Kingdom of Light and Shadow

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/43361668.

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Mature

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra)

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Blood and Gore, Violence, Explicit Sexual Content

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Part 5 of Tapestry of Time

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by Faded_Glory

Summary

As the hidden threat of Eternia's infiltration into all corner's of Etherian society comes to light. Adora must unravel the past and uncover all the secrets Light Hope had kept hidden from her. About Mara, about She-Ra and the real reason the First Ones had wired the planet. While Catra goes on a quest deep inside Mystacor, retracing Light Spinner's own journey towards the dark power that led to her downfall.

Notes

Thank you for tuning into another part of the story. I love to read comments and appreciate all the kudo's.
Bitzy Bee: I hope this arc is what you have been looking forward too.
Oddbodkin: Thank you, I am glad you liked the last chapter of Kingdom of Dreams
Pink Storm: I am glad you liked the last chapter also, I hope to take you on another crazy ride in this arc.

Return to the Beginning

It took three days of long travel across Thaymor. To reach the outer growth of the ancient forest.Known as the Whispering Woods. A massive woodland that covered all of Bright Moon Kingdom and most of the smaller, neighboring kingdom of Plumeria. Stretching further north into the highlands all the way up to the Barrier Mountain range that bordered the frozen tundra of the far north. Off the coast, lay many glacier's and islands. Above the arctic sea at the very top of the world, lay the larger landmass of the Northern Reach.

Given that name a long,long time ago, when magic was only being discovered by the First Ones .Many tales and myths about the trees have persisted even to this day. That the forest was haunted, possessed by chaotic spirits intent on causing confusion and mayhem. Some believe that it is in fact a sentient creature created by the magic of Etheria. Neither good nor evil, but rather mischievous and enigmatic in nature. Compelled by its whims, calling out to unwanted travelers and drawing them deeper, never to be seen again. Or guiding those who are chosen to untold treasures and safe harbor in the hidden villages that thrived inside its green embrace.

During the war, many Horde Battalion's had gotten lost trying to navigate through the endless trees. It seemed that the woods had sided with the rebellion and sought to protect the people and the Kingdom of Bright Moon. Merchants and travelers who knew how to stay safe in the shifting landscape. Kept to the well worn paths and roads that led to villages and towns. As they made their way north to Bright Moon Castle.

Adora no longer feared the woods, as she did as a child of the Horde. The trees had been a stalwart alley to the rebellion and saved her and her friends many times over the years. She led her group confidently along a well worn trail, heading northwest, crossing the Wailing River once more and onwards towards Crystal Castle. Traveling ever deeper into the immortal green wood.

Which wore the red and copper cloak of the cool season. Etheria was changing and it was startling for Adora to see. The Whispering Woods in the last thousand years had stayed vibrant and alive no matter the season. But the air was chilled, ice crystals were heavy in the morning dew and she noticed for the first time. The trees were shedding their leaves, some branches already bare. The dried litter amassed around the trunks. It was startling to see.

In the last few weeks the forest seemed to finally feel its age. It was tired and preparing for a long sleep, knowing that when the warm season returned. It would also come back to life, reborn with the ancient magic unleashed from the Heart. At least that's what Adora hypothesized in her mind. To soothe the fear of seeing the wood dying and alleviate the burden she felt upon her heart at yet another one of her choices causing harm to someone else.

They stopped briefly in the forest towns and villages scattered along the way. While the east side of the Wailing River held many settlements of mostly deer hybrids, who were known for their outdoor festivals during the warm and hot season. The west side of the river was closer to Elboron and thus the villages had mostly Moth hybrids. Who were far more inclined to host grand feasts inside their great halls. Known for their amazing hospitality towards travelers, the leader's felt they had to live up to those expectations, even at the cost to their own people.

As She-Ra, Adora felt it was her duty to check in and see how the inhabitants were faring with the coming cold season setting in. They had been welcomed each time with a revered excitement of hosting the Hero of Etheria. Adora would smile but would not accept any token of gratitude or allow any feasts. The villager's needed all the food and supplies to survive the coming cold that they had never had to deal with before. She merely took stock of what they had and what they might still need. Relaying their needs back to King Micah in Bright Moon, so they could be included in the aid coming from Scorpania. Sharing what she could of their own provisions and supplies.

Selfless and humble, she would never take any offerings of repayment. The villager's awe or praise or gratitude was reciprocated with only a small, warm, smile that was genuine and pure of heart. They had felt no pressure to argue or refuse her wishes. So they conceded every time to her eagerness to help in any way she could. Compelled to make sure each village was prepared for the coming snow.

She would stop for a single day in each village or town. Use her magic to heal the sick and injured. Spend many hours helping cut and haul firewood, along with Liam. Promising that aid was coming from Bright Moon to help repair the damage done to their homes and communal buildings by the war.

She was the epitome of a hero, swooping in at the break of day. Going above and beyond to help the people then disappearing back into the woods at dusk.

Kronis took note how the vitality drained from her, day by day. Yet she refused to give into her compounding exhaustion. As she aided one village after another along their route deeper into the forest. A steel determination came into her eyes, as she gave all of herself to every task. Never faltering, never wavering in her sense of duty to her people's well being. Pushing herself beyond all rational limits, as if she was a machine made of flesh and bone. Yet she could not conceal the physical ramifications of what she was doing to herself. The dark circles under her eyes, the sickly gray pallor to her skin. As she refused to acknowledge the limitations of her human body.

Liam took on the responsibility of setting up and tearing down their camp between villages. Giving Adora respite from the daily chores. She had refused at first, stating she could pull her own weight. Mulishly storming off to gather firewood, from a dead grove a few miles west of their camp. Spirit had accompanied her, the horse never left her side when they were out in the wilderness. When she didn't return after dark. Liam set off to find her and Kronis followed at a discrete distance to observe. The young man had ascended a small rise and spotted Spirit coming

out of the trees into a grove half way back to camp. Adora was slumped over his neck, fast asleep. With several bundles of wood, lashed to his hind quarters. Liam had shook his head in disbelief.

"Stubborn…woman…" He had muttered, as he led Spirit back to camp. His frustration and worry getting the better of him. She was disregarding her own health and working herself far too hard. Which resulted in a heated debate,when she woke up the next morning. That Liam had chastised her about not taking proper care of herself. That she was already pulling her weight, taking care of the villages. That he was not lazy or incompetent and she needed to rest and allow him to take care of simple chores around their campsite.

She had cringed and quickly looked near tears, as her gaze fell on Spirit who was hovering behind Liam. The horse wore a very hard, disapproving look in their eyes . A solidarity with Liam, very evident in the horse's close posture to the young man. As if Spirit was speaking to Adora as well as Liam. Reluctantly, she then agreed to allow him to take on the bulk of the duties in regards to their camp so she could rest. It had been a strange and sudden acquiescence. Kronis was intrigued by it, that silent communication she had with Spirit. That was so similar to Adam's communion with Cringer?

Adora's stubborn demeanor of strength and resilience never changed until they left the last village behind them. Traveling into the very heart of the Whispering Woods. Where the ancient growth towered over them. The thick roots clogged the forest floor, leaving only a narrow foot path to guide them. The canopy covered the sky overhead in a cloak of many colors, the leaves dried and dead but refusing to fall.

Finally her shoulder's began to droop, her head bowing in submission to the complete and utter exhaustion. Emphatically, they could all feel the weight of her struggle to stay awake. She was quickly losing that battle and would be unconscious again shortly.

The clones who had remained ambivalent to her suffering over the last few days.

Watching her with the same curiosity and silent awe as Kronis. Reached out in the only way they knew. They were fellow soldier's, seeing that her duty was done and in need of aid. They stopped the cart and quickly made a bed inside of all their blankets.

As Spirit turned around, trotting gently back towards the cart. Liam dismounted and quickly jogged up to Spirit. Reaching up and tenderly drawing Adora down off his back.

She groaned indignantly at his large hands, eased her off Spirit's back. Curling instinctively against his chest, as he carried her the short ways to the cart. Tucking her face under his chin with a plaintive moan.

"Catra…you smell weird…" She mumbled.

The once tender smile upon Liam's face faded into confusion.

"Who's Catra?" He muttered, as he climbed inside the cart and gently set her down upon the nest of blankets.

Kronis was the first to see the slight shifting of the trees. It was slight and easily dismissed. Like the slow drip of water from a tap. That became simple white noise, but was there nonetheless.

"What's going on?" Liam questioned as he emerged from the cart, finding Kronis glaring suspiciously at the trees. Glancing around the old growth and wild, overgrown underbrush curiously. Trying to ascertain what had spooked the old Maker.

Kronis sat a bit straighter on the back of his horse, narrowing his eyes at the barely noticable change to the forest surrounding them. It was disconcerting, how their location shifted, yet the landscape remained pretty much the same.

“Let's just keep moving…” He advised, guiding his horse forward around the cart and leading them into the trees ahead. He didn’t know if this forest was friend or foe. So he would remain as vigilant as he could until proven which side these trees were on.

The clones climbed back up to the bench, oblivious to the change in the forest or Kronis’s growing apprehension. The first clone snapped the reign’s to get the mule plodding again. While Liam mounted up on his roan with Spirit trotting behind. They made slow, cautious progress deeper into the forest. As the path wound downward into a deep ravine. Pine trees loomed along the edge, leaving a mat of needles that crunched under the horses hooves. The sunlight scattered around them in brilliant flashes as they trudged along.

Kronis kept a watchful eye on their surroundings, trying to see the shift. Made even more difficult since he had no connection to magic.

The path became more winding as they climbed out of the ravine. Kronis had no idea where they were going, the forest offered no other path but the one they were on. He had to trust that they were going the right way. The day moved ever onward, the sun crossing the sky as slowly as their plodding horses. As Adora slept.

Coming to the top of a rise, Kronis scanned the endless sea of trees below for any other paths, forks, smoke from other villages…the only thing he saw was trees and more trees. With a resigned grunt, he snapped the reins to urge his horse to walk onward. There was no other choice but to follow the path the forest had offered them.

The shadow’s grew long as evening began to descend upon the deep forest. The light of day was fading, when slowly a large clearing appeared before them. A soft, iridescent glow hovering just behind the tree line.

Kronis stopped them upon the path, scanning to the west as the sun fell below the horizon. What lay before them within the glade was breathtaking to behold. A massive structure, rising up to the heaven's. Glowing from within, as if powered by magic itself. Crumbling ruins surrounded the elegant tower, long covered by moss and long dead vines.

"Is this Crystal Castle?" Liam gasped in awe. Snapping the reigns of his Roan to get her to move forward into the ruins. The young man had no fear or suspicions about the forest's allegiance or the danger these First Ones Ruins might pose towards him.

"Hold!" Kronis shouted, guiding his horse to block Liam's. "This is not a place to charge forward recklessly."

Liam was shocked and more than a little confused. Adora had explained the purpose of the temple as they traveled the Whispering Woods. He didn't understand why they would need to be wary of a place built to service She-Ra's needs, to train her?

"What does a Maker know about First Ones ruins?" Liam challenged.

Kronis groaned, "I am decades more experienced at life than you, boy. I've learned the hard way not to go charging into places, I may not be welcome."

"It's alright…" Adora's soft, groggy voice floated to them from the back of the cart.

"I destroyed the operating system inside, it no longer has any way to defend it self….the temple is dead."

Kronis huffed and then nodded. "Looks like you haven't quite finished your story." Sending Adora a sharp, accusing look that she was with holding information. He was not trusting enough to believe it was not on purpose.

Liam had never even thought that First Ones Temples had defenses of any kind. He thought they were just dead hunks of

mortar and stone. His ignorance and arrogance could have proven fatal. He took a moment to let that sink in, suddenly far more cautious of his surroundings. He mentally slapped himself, he wasn't on the farm anymore. He needed to get his head on straight…the world out here could be deadly.

As Adora crawled out of the cart and slowly walked towards them. Spirit was quick to come alongside her and offer her his bulk to lean against. Adora gave him a thankful, if tired smile leaning against his flank.

She stood on weak, trembling legs as she gazed at the ruins ahead.

"It's safe to set up camp in the courtyard out front. I think I might need a bit more rest before we go inside." She moved past them, with Spirit alongside. Silently leading them into the open glade. Her bold, unwary approach into the ruins proved to them that it was safe.

Late afternoon was fading into evening, by the time Castaspella arrived at the Master's library. Glimmer crossed the library, when she noticed her Aunt slipping inside through the massive, ornately carved double doors. The Master's library was a cavernous two story room. With tall arching windows dominating the back wall, with large cushions tossed here and there against the glass. So one might have a thoughtful view of the tranquil garden that stretched towards the horizon below. The elegant windows ascended all the way up to the balcony that ringed the huge room. Rows upon rows of bookcases filled with spell books, written by the past Elemental Masters filled the main area below. While the balcony above was a more secluded area, with soft benches and desks and chairs to study at. The roof was domed in a similar manner as the Basilica, the skylight inlaid with stained glass instead of crystal. In the warm season when the sun shone

much brighter and was not dimmed by the heavy clouds of the cool seasons. The light would shine through the glass in million's of fractures motes of color that bathed the library in a rainbow haze.

Passing her Aunt near the huge oak double doors, Casta reached out and grasped Glimmer's arm, halting her exit.

"Let me show you the way?" Casta offered, as Glimmer crossed her path knowing exactly why her niece was abandoning her own research for the day.

She had been gone all day. Having guided Catra to Light Spinner's study that morning. She didn't need to oversee the princesses as much since they were now under the tutelage of their respective elemental Guild Master's. Who had been helping them research and training them. So she was able to attend to her duties as Head Sorcerer once again.

"No need, Aunt Casta. I'll just teleport to her." Glimmer answered, giving her a curt wave before departing. Holding her own spell book close to her chest. She had been spending a lot of time with Catra over the last few days. Investigating the city and the many mystical tower's floating on the smaller islands around Mystacor. It had been a fun, pleasant distraction. As their closer friendship made Catra less guarded and more playful. Glimmer had teased and joked with her, as they explored. Enjoying each day in her company, which alleviated some of the loneliness she felt. As Bow was unintentionally pulling away, completely engrossed in perfecting his new weapon and helping Brojee and his crew. Retrofit the Horde Drones to track the Seeker Drones spying on Etheria. She had barely seen him all week.

Glimmer was seeing a whole new side to the magicat, one she figured Adora knew well. She was driven to find her own answers, scouring every inch of the ancient places within Mystacor. Writing and drawing every rune she found. She worked tirelessly from sun up to sun down, with Glimmer barely able to keep up. Staying up to all hours of the night, reading Light Spinner's journals and

deciphering the runes in her spell books. It was admirable and she understood bitterly. That this passion and commitment to something she cared about. Was the reason she had been winning the war.

Catra barely spent time in the libraries and had yet to speak to her own tutor in fire magic on the High Council. She stubbornly believed that all her answers lay outside of the Citadel walls. Glimmer had tried to convince her that maybe, her Tutor, Master Cyrus might be able to help. That he may not know how to conjure fire in the ancient ways, but he understood how fire magic worked. That he had something to offer. Catra was so engrossed in her research, in doing things her way. Glimmer wondered if her advice had even been heard.

Today, Light Spinner's study had finally been unsealed. Glimmer had wanted to give the magicat some time alone. To deal with whatever strong emotions being in that room might invoke. But she also wanted to make sure the hybrid knew that Glimmer was there for her in any way she might need. That she would never have to fight her demon's alone again.

So now Glimmer slowly made her way down to the lower halls of the Sorcerers wing, teleporting far enough away to enjoy a short walk. Winding her way down the opulent white corridor's of the Master's Studies. She took a moment outside the simple oak door to Light Spinner's study, taking a deep breath and settling her own nerves before lightly pushing the door open.

She also did not have the best of memories concerning Shadow Weaver. She couldn't help the shiver of disgust that ran down her spine, at entering the woman's private study. Where she had groomed and manipulated her father into dark magic. Leaving him with ugly scars both physically and mentally. Misunderstood or scared, what ever the reason. Ultimately, Light Spinner had not been a very good person. She had wanted power at all costs and sought to obtain it by any means necessary.

In her mind the ends justifies the means, which was morally reprehensible. She had sought to teach the Queen that philosophy. Guiding her towards the pursuit of power as a means to win, when Glimmer had been the most isolated, the most vulnerable and ultimately the most desperate. The Etherian Horde was days away from winning and she felt she had no choice but to seek out the magic at the heart. It had been her greatest sin and had endangered everyone,nearly destroying the planet. If it hadn't been for Adora…Etheria would be dust right now.

The room was barely lit, the overhead light crystals dangling from the ceiling barely had a charge left in them. Casting the crypt-like room in an eerie blue hue, that was both melancholy and sinister. Since the room had been abandoned for well over two decades. Only dust and spider webs remained. Since Light Spinner's mastery was in channeling and conjuring light magic. Using spells, incantations and potions to harness the lesser elemental magic. Her study reflected such,with a now dried up waterfall style fountain against the back wall she may have used for a scrying pool. A cold, dusty forge at the back for melting down metals for amulets, small weapons or jewelry. Bookshelves that once housed her many spell books, now empty and full of cobwebs. Various crystal pillars for magic storage guarded each corner dull and lifeless. The tips of the crystal column's jagged and chipped from being harvested decades ago. A long table sat in the center of the room once used for spellcraft. The dark lavender sheen of the table top, now dull from a heavy layer of dust. Catra's woolen satchel lay tucked in one corner of the table, a small mound hiding within emitting a brilliant red glow. Melog was all curled up tight inside, resembling a burning ember more than a kitten.

Glimmer slowly finished scanning the gloomy room, finding a long dark tail lashing beneath the long table. She knew by Melog's hue that Catra was fuming underneath.

"Find anything?" She inquired with an amused smirk, resting a hand on the table as she peered beneath it.

Catra was growling low in her throat, a hint of an angry purr rumbling into the silence. She had been left all day alone, to scour an empty room that held only dust and cobwebs.

“What is this powder?” Catra asked, scratching the slate floor with a claw. Drawing a thin line through the pink and lavender dirt staining the floor under the table.

“Looks like ground up storage crystal’s from one of the Lunar chamber’s.” Glimmer answered. “It’s perfectly normal magic… nothing nefarious.”

Catra grunted and crawled out. Prowling over to the cold forge and pulling the door open to peer inside. The hinges screamed in protest at being moved, the yellow aged glass on the door window cracking. Catra huffed with resignation, at finding the fire box cold. The inner iron plates black from use, long decayed coals lining the bottom.

When Catra had finished organizing the journals and spell books Casta had given her a couple days back. Finding out that not a single one had any dark magic research in them. She had confronted the mage about it. Casta had merely shrugged and stated when she was ready and trained enough to understand the forbidden research then she could look at them.

The Head Sorcerer knew she wasn’t going to her tutor, or had even stepped foot in their libraries. It was just an excuse, bait to get her to go to her tutor. To learn magic their way…finding Light Spinner’s study completely gutted only infuriated her more.

“Casta won’t let me read Light Spinner’s spell books on dark magic.” Catra stated flippantly, her tone thick with disappointment and ire.

“Well, dark magic is forbidden, I bet those books are off limits to everyone. Catra. You’re just a novice mage right now like the rest of us.” Glimmer shrugged.

“Throwing my ignorance in magic, in my face, is not going to make me go see, Master Cyrus.” Catra shot back.

“You are falling behind the rest of us, Catra.” Glimmer huffed, crossing her arms.

“The princesses are all going to their tutor’s and they are learning how to harness their elements better.”

“I don’t care. Learning First Ones magic is a dead end…I’m trying to figure out the ancient ways…of how to harness the magic of Etheria from a thousand years ago…” Catra snarled, as she started to pace in front of the forge. “It’s in all the runes,” Catra mused, “I just don’t know how they work yet.”

“I get that Catra, but you can’t learn to draw glyphs from thin air… you need a tutor.” Glimmer declared.

“These runes are not glyphs…they are more than that…they form knots…connections…threads…” Catra couldn’t explain, her memories of a thousand years ago watching her mother perform fire magic was foggy at best.

“Oroboros has not tried to reach out to you in weeks, Catra. Who is going to teach you but Cyrus? Please, go see him. Hear him out for one session, if you feel he has nothing to offer then fine. I’ll drop it.” Glimmer grasped Catra’s shoulders, her gentle, indigo eyes pleading.

Catra snarled, her tail lashing more aggressively behind her. Then it slowed and hung low, curling timidly around her ankle as she rolled her eyes, “Fine.” Catra conceded, she knew she had to play their game to get what she wanted. So she’d play…but the rules would be her own.

Glimmer made a triumphant sound and hopped on her toes for a second.

“You're gloating.” Catra smirked with dry amusement.

“I’m not gloating, I’m…congratulating myself on finally convincing you. You stubborn brat!” Glimmer explained with a wiry half smile.

“You're gloating.” Catra countered, turning her back on the Queen to continue investigation of the empty room. Her expectations of finding some kind of clues to the Nameless One was once more dashed. This search had been fruitless and her irritation was bubbling to the surface, molten and angry. This was why she used to never let herself hope!

“Maybe just a little.” Glimmer giggled with a triumphant gleam in her eyes. Keeping her distance, she cautiously gauged the level of rage simmering inside of Catra. As the Magicat prowled near the bookshelf.

A bitter, mirthless laugh escaped the magicats mouth as she craned her head back.

“They completely cleaned this place out, everything is locked away in the vault. I need permission to see every little thing…this is so frustrating!” Catra pulled at her short hair behind her ears. “What was the point of even unsealing this place!” Catra kicked the ceramic bricks under the forge, before storming away to glare furiously at the empty bookshelf.

Glimmer had gotten used to Catra’s bursts of rage when things didn't go her way. She wasn’t alarmed like she once was, but still wary. She understood the frustration and fear of not being in control. Of other people, more powerful people who held what you wanted away from your reach. She had butted heads with own mother enough times during the early part of forming the Princess Alliance. She could empathize with what the magicat was going through.

“Catra…” Glimmer moved towards her cautiously. “I know you're upset, but…” Her voice faltered as her gaze was drawn to some loosened bricks that were slightly askew from the rest.

“Catra…Look..” Glimmer beckoned.

Catra glowered over her shoulder, finding Glimmer crouched at the back corner of the forge. Her fingers digging insistently at the crack between the bricks. She slowly wedged the brick free, revealing a tiny hidden compartment behind.

“It’s so dark…” Glimmer grumbled, moving aside as she knew Catra had better eyesight. She was wary of flicking a light orb inside, not wanting to trigger any magical traps that might lay within.

Catra crawled up to where Glimmer once was and squinted into the tiny compartment. She was about to reach in, when Glimmer snatched her hand.

“Don’t just reach in there…Light Spinner might have trapped it.” Glimmer warned.

Catra’s ears pinned back in fear, after Adora stepped on a magical trap and nearly set herself ablaze. Catra knew to be cautious.

“Ok, go get your Aunt. I’ll wait here.” Catra sat down before the forge, as if guarding the hole.

Glimmer nodded and blinked away.

Only to reappear a moment later with a very confused Castaspella.

“What is going on?” She commanded indignantly.

“Auntie, we found a hidden compartment.” Glimmer pointed to the brick pedestal the forge was on.

Casta quickly moved to crouch beside Catra, who moved aside to give her room.

“I thought we found all the forbidden items in here and locked them away?” Casta mused.

“Yeah, well thanks for wasting my time!” Catra sniped, she had spent hours scouring this empty room. Only to have everything of real value out of reach yet again. But it was fine, she had to fight tooth and claw before to get what she wanted she could do it again.

Casta and Catra shared a cold, hard look between them. Catra was silently accusing Casta of hiding the truth from her, keeping her away from her answers.

She was a part of the problem, part of the ones in power holding her back. Because they were scared or didn’t trust her…or felt she wasn’t strong enough to have the knowledge she sought. In the end she would have to prove her worth.

She was used it…

Casta sighed then merely turned her back on the hybrid. Focusing on the hole, she moved her hands in an intricate pattern. Casting a magic detection spell. Then moving her hands in a counter clockwise pattern to disarm the magical trap. There was a flash of light and then sparkles exploded out of the hole.

Then she reached inside, pulling out a small, ornate black vial filled with luminescent blue dust.

“That looks like the vial Shadow Weaver used when she teleported us to the Heart?” Catra exclaimed.

“This dust is nothing like the crystal’s here in the Citadel…” Casta inspected the vial closely, “Come, we must go to Master Elys.” Casta quickly stood up and dashed from the room with Glimmer and Catra close behind.

Coiling the threads

Chapter Notes

Ok, so I needed a few extra days to polish this chapter up a bit. So enjoy!
Also thank you, EvaWolf, PinkStorm and BitzyBee for your comments and all those who have left Kudo's.

Dusk was settling over the woods, the soft rustle of small animals. Scavenging beneath the leaf litter whispered in the air. The cold evenings this time of year were normal, but the smell of coming snow. Had the animals of the Whispering Woods confused and anxious. Causing them to become more active, as they sought to prepare themselves for the frigid temperatures ahead.

A thin, gray mist began to move silently between the trees. Hovering on the outskirts of the temple grounds never encroaching upon the glade but merely cloaking it from the outside world. Its murky presence, hovering in the periphery of the courtyard. Was foreboding, leaving everyone in camp unsettled by it. Adora was keeping a close eye on the mist, from her perch upon a crumbled chunk of stone near the temple. Alert and anxious herself. As the fog reminded her far too much of the dark magic. The Husks had used in the lowland marshes. To weaken and subdue her.

Soon after entering the temple grounds, Spirit had gone into the woods in search of apples, sending Adora a quick sensation of hunger as he left. Followed by a feeling of worry and foreboding disappointment. That the apples in the nearby groves may have already gone rotten or frozen?

Then they spent the remainder of the afternoon. Setting up camp within the ruins, three tents were now pitched and a small fire crackled a few feet away. Small boulder’s, that were crumbled remains of ancient structures. Were dragged around the fire so they had somewhere to sit. The alien, crystalline stone within the

courtyard, was glowing an eerily ghostly blue hue in the faint twilight.

Kronis was hunched near the campfire, his back rigid, shoulder's tense. Casting the fog, strange, wary looks. Trying to ignore the warning instincts now firing inside of him, that he was in danger. Ever since losing his duel with Skeletor, he had a strong fear of magic. This forest was magic in its purest most deadly form. It was wild and untamed, having no master to control it. Which made him question his choices once more, was capturing the long lost daughter of Randor and Marlene worth inciting the wrath of this primordial magic.

A magic he knew from previous reports of Etheria. That as She-Ra, Adora was linked to. From this moment on he now had placed himself in a very dangerous situation and would have to strategize every move he made from now on. Cunning and guile would be what got him out of here alive, with his prize.. Which was something he had in spades. Kronis grunted, pretending to focus on his task. Instructing the clones how to mount the cooking pot on its pole.

Adora had been hunched over a crumbled stone slab since late that afternoon, on the far side of the courtyard. Refusing to look at the beacon glowing behind her. Her focus divided upon her whittling or the billowing mists lurking beyond camp. Working on a piece of pine she had taken from the firewood, the two Clones had gathered a few days back. She was hesitant to even acknowledge the temple's presence, lest it start to call out to her. She was loath to admit it, but being too tired to enter the Crystal Castle that afternoon had been just an excuse. She was stalling, honestly. Because she was scared about going inside. She had nothing but bad memories attached to that place.

The fear and grief she had carried into the temple last time, as she headed towards the heart. Still seemed to haunt this place, a bleak gloom clinging to everything. This made the ruins feel eerie like an ancient tomb…which in many ways it was. Both Light Hope and Shadow Weaver had died within its walls.

The beacon had never held its punches. Forcing Adora to confront everything that lay in the very depths of her own soul. In truth her last trial within the Temple had been brutal, leaving her shaken and terrified about what she might encounter this time.

The visions of Catra and all the incarnations of her she had known. Her mind spinning with both warm nostalgia and heartache. How lovingly Catra had greeted her…cupping her cheek so sweetly, as they pressed their foreheads together. The tender affection and happiness that washed over her, was everything she truly wanted.

Catra….she loved…Catra…

The temple had candidly forced her to confront. What she wanted most, her heart breaking with the understanding. That her destiny did not allow her to have this. Making her doubt, making her regret.

Then on that vision's heels came Mara, who's words carried so much weight. That Adora was left humbled by her sacrifice yet again and trembling at the truth she struggled to come to terms with even to this day. That she was worth more than what she could do for others, that she deserved love too.

Then Prime, taunting and smug. Shook her fragile confidence that she might have a chance to prevail, to survive this. Leaving her shaken and struggling to find the resolve to keep going alone.

She was so scared and so conflicted…

As the temple security system delivered the final blow. Her own people had betrayed her…destroyed her…she would no longer be coming out of this alive.

Infected and in immense amounts of pain she sank to the floor on her knees, Clutching her side as raw agony ripped through her. Then Catra had come to her rescue. Leaping upon the monster, claws out, screaming in fury. As Shadow Weaver had come to her aid. Catra had stayed to fight the Monster, once again putting her

own life on the line to give Adora a chance to save the world. But at the gateway to the heart, hearing Catra's screams of pain.

She made a choice!

She was dead anyway…she had failed…but she would never… never leave Catra to fight alone again! She had run back…if she was going to die…then she was going to die fighting along with Catra…the only person she had ever loved!

If it hadn't been for Shadow Weaver…they would have never made it to the heart. Having to watch yet another mother figure sacrifice themselves to save her, to give her a future…it tore her apart. But the tears she shed for Shadow Weaver were different than the tears she had shed for Angella. Who had shown her nothing but compassion, kindness and affections that did not need to be earned.

Her tears in the depths of the temple for Shadow Weaver. Were bitter and tainted with acidic undertones of confusion and shame. At the sudden sense of freedom, the relief she felt in her passing. To no longer have her judgmental, condescending shadow lurking over her. She was still struggling to find a resolution as to why Shadow Weaver had denied herself the power at the heart. When Adora had left her every opportunity to just take it for herself, when she had chose to go back for Catra. It was right there in her grasp…yet she chose to protect her 'daughters' instead. In the end she did that one good thing…so that everyone on Etheria could have a future.

It made no sense?

If it hadn't been for Catra…being far braver than she could ever be. By being vulnerable, for opening her heart and confessing her love. She would be dead today. Everyone had supported her, protected her, died for her… they did so much, suffered so much. Just so she could reach the heart.

She was supposed to be the hero, the strongest, bravest and most powerful warrior on the planet. Yet in the end, she had done nothing heroic, nothing brave or strong. She was just the mule, the beast of burden sent to cart the Failsafe to the Heart.

She was nothing…she was just the sacrifice.

All of those memories were still haunting her and she needed some time to rebuild her mental defenses. Before she entered its hallowed halls again, knowing that at its core lay ghost's from not only her past but every She-Ra before her. All those demon's were her's to slay. The trail she was about to enter, would easily shred her heart again.

So she sat at the very edge of the firelight as twilight fell around her. Most of her light, that she was using to whittle by. Comes from the haunting glow of the temple behind her. The greater moon's were slowly ascending above the looming tree line bordering the outer courtyard. The star's shimmering like ice as the chill of evening sets in.

"You should really come closer to the fire." Liam offered, as she no longer had her marron cloak. Dressed now in only her gray pants, brown traveling boots and white long sleeve shirt. He was worried she was getting cold, so he draped a dull gray, heavy woolen blanket over her back. Before sitting down beside her.

His presence was not unwelcomed, but also was barely acknowledged.

"I will in a bit." Adora muttered, her tongue sticking out slightly at the corner of her lips. As she lightly shaved away a tiny chunk at the base of the wood.

Liam sat silently, undeterred by her aloofness. Watching her whittle away tiny pieces of wood. Her carving didn't look like much yet, she was still working on its general shape. But he could now see what looked like a sharply angled face and the pointed ears of a cat.

“What is it?” He asked, lightly scratching at the scruff of a beard growing in along his square jaw.

“Melog.” Adora responded, scrutinizing the square chunk now encircling the head.

“What’s a Melog?” Liam questioned.

“They’re a friend. We met them on a planet called Krytis.” Adora sighed, sadly. She wanted to get their likeness perfect. This was her first attempt so her hopes were not very high. But she wasn’t going to give up either, if it took her a hundred or more carvings to get them to look just right. Then so be it. This was going to be a gift for Catra, so the carving needed to be perfect.

Liam sat quietly hoping she would continue to explain. He was once again in awe, that she had been off planet going on adventures among the stars. She had told many tales about her time on Etheria, but he had yet to hear any about her time in space.

When she didn’t elaborate, putting her all into her work as always. He sighed with disappointment, then pushed on with another question. That had been bothering him all day.

“Who’s Catra?” He asked, softly, a reluctant hesitance in his voice. She had spoken that name with such devotion, such reverence. He was unsure if he truly wanted her to answer.

“She-Ra!. You have finally returned.” A bright, elderly voice erupted from the tree line on the other side of the campfire. Then a few moments later, Madame Razz shuffled into the ruins, carrying her broom.

Liam’s gaze shot up in alarm. While Adora looked up, with a rueful half smile pulling on her lips.

“Razz….I can’t transform anymore….I’m just Adora. ” Adora sighed with fond amusement, as the old woman hobbled across the courtyard towards her.

“Pah…silly girl…you are always She-Ra!” She declared with a playful sternness. As if Adora should already know this. Crossing the courtyard, Razz’s owlish dark eyes cut towards the clones and Kronis for a moment at the fire. The clones were fussing with setting up a hanging iron pot over the flames, with Kronis’s guidance. So they could start to prepare their evening meal. For the last few days they had been rationing their provisions. Now that they were settled, the clones had hoped to learn to cook with Kronis’s instruction. It was a skill they felt would make them more favorable to the rest of Etheria. If they could cook, then they would be useful. If they were useful they would be able to make a place for themselves in this society. If they were able to make a place for themselves, they would no longer be shunned or persecuted. So far their journey to be accepted on Etheria had been rather unsatisfactory. They had a long way to go and were eager to prove themselves as competent individuals. Who could take care of themselves and others.

Razz tutted and shook her head, in mild disapproval. Promptly ignoring the three once again. As she continued towards the crumbled stones, Adora was sitting on.

She stopped and assessed Liam for a moment. Her eyes narrowed in elderly scrutiny, lightly tossing the handle of her broom from hand to hand. Silently debating if she needs to smack the young man and knock some sense into him. In the very same way she had to for Adora years ago.

So similar they were…driven, stubborn and completely obtuse to so many things.

In the end Razz huffed and focused on her current charge. Who still needed a bit more guidance. She was still unbalanced, still struggling to let go.

“Of course, of course…” She tapped Adora’s shoulder with a slender, wrinkled finger. “Come more training.” She beckoned, heading towards the forest behind the crumbled debris of the statue Adora was sitting on.

Adora nodded, stuffing her small carving into the side pocket of her gray pants as she stood up, offering Liam the blanket. Before dashing after the old woman, who as always was not waiting for her to catch up, merely expecting her to keep up.

Liam watched Adora go. As she dutifully follows the strange, old woman out of the ruins and back into the misty concealment of the forest.

"I see you have made new friends. " Razz noted, ducking under a bare branch in the fading twilight. As the darker tones of night were falling around them, obscuring their surroundings even more. Adora quickly leaned down narrowly avoiding the same branch. With only the gentle light of the Greater Moon's to guide them, Adora needed to keep up.

"Yes, Liam…He's the young man you met just now. He wants to become a Stonemason. So he is traveling with me back to Mystacor. When I'm done at the Crystal Castle." Adora nodded, "Then there were those two clones. They kinda imprinted on me back in Thaymor…" she sighed heavily. "I guess they are kinda my responsibility now." Adora scratched her head, mulling over what may lay ahead for the two clones as they sought to claim their own individuality. It had been a long and sometimes emotionally turbulent journey for Wrong Hordak. "Then there's Kronis…" Adora shrugged. "I have no idea why he's tagging along, he's part of the Maker community, An engineer I met on a Farm, that Liam had grown up on."

Razz clicked her tongue several times on the top of her mouth, sending Adora a firm, warning look over her shoulder. As she skipped over some fallen logs covered in slick moss and dried bramble.

"Watch your step dearie. The path ahead is tricky, it could trip you up." She cautioned.

Adora nodded, mounting the loose logs and watching her feet. As she lightly stepped over the fallen branches and dead shrubbery that littered the top of the logs. Not catching the second meaning behind Razz's warning.

"Where are we going, Razz?' Adora questioned a few minutes later. Glancing around the unfamiliar trees. As the Whispering Woods seemed to swallow the both of them, taking them off to somewhere completely different.

"We must gather the proper materials if we wish to weave." Razz explained, as if it was common sense. "The best place to gather what you need is never far, 'when' you know 'where' to look for it." Her cryptic answer as always left Adora, confused yet curious as to her words true meaning. She had accented two words "When' and 'Where'. Adora mused over her words for a time. Razz had come first at dawn to train her and then now, at dusk. That was definitely the when. The 'where', she guessed she would find out soon.

It was gradual, but soon Adora started to recognize the woods surrounding them.

The ancient oaks and elms blackened and scared from battle and the massive fire that had engulfed them. The grass still scorched down to the top soil, the cold weather holding off the once resilient plants ability to heal.

"Razz, Where are we going?" She called out again. Her voice was urgent, now that they were wandering into the devastation. The Laser Bears had inflicted upon this part of the forest.

"I must show you where to gather the 'threads for weaving, Adora." Razz tutted, her small legs moving swiftly over the dried bramble.

"Now, stop sightseeing, silly. Nothing can be done for right now and you need to keep up!" Razz chastised sharply. As she was

quickly gaining ground away from Adora. Trotting out of view, as she rounded a bend in the trail far ahead. Forcing the blonde to stop gawking at the burnt landscape around her and focus on keeping up.

"Razz!...Wait up!" She called her voice high pitched with exasperation. Sprinting up the path. Then leaping over twisting roots, that had grown over the path. As she scrambled desperately to catch up.

Soon they left the devastation behind, climbing up a small hill towards a lone Willow that stood guard over the valley. Adora looked over her shoulder to the woods below and then up to the lush curtain of leaves of the willow. She recognized this place…it was where she and Catra had spent the first half of the night during their journey back to Bright Moon. Before all of this craziness had begun.

"Razz…" Adora called softly, ascending the last of the way to stand before the majesty of the grand willow. This was the first Willow that had crossed her path during her journey's through Etheria. She had camped beside another one, with her Squad in another valley during their trip to Scorpion Hills. She had passed yet another in the highlands of Bright Moon during a very poignant dream. Where she had met Sheana and Despara for the first time and then traveled to Addie's cabin…the very first She-Ra.

She had never paid much attention to the ancient trees until now. The Willow was majestic, crowning the top of the hill. That overlooked the blackened devastation of the small valley below. Its trunk was rough, the bark a pale white almost silver. With vivid green leaves that hung in a glorious curtain. From long, elegant branches that hovered over her head.

The old woman merely smiled in that warm, all knowing way. As she approached the base of the tree, moving between the bent and twisted roots that had sprawled across the ground. Winding and knotting deep into the earth.

“This is the Whispering Willow. “ Razz bowed her head in reverence for a moment, pressing a wrinkled hand against the tree’s rough bark. Adora stood in silence, bowing her own head respectively towards the tree. As she sensed Razz was invoking some sacred communion with the Willow. It was thanks to her time in Plumeria, learning about the sanctity of the forest. That she understood how the people of the forest paid their respects to the trees.

“She and all her sister’s are the oldest beings upon Etheria. Their roots have formed connections over time and have bound the planet together for eon’s. ” Razz explained, folding her hands together and weaving her fingering together meaningfully. Then spreading them apart and raising a hand above her head, as she cast a ball of light into the air. The softly glowing ball of magic floated up into the lush green canopy of the tree before exploding into a fine layer of sparkling dust. That coated the many slender branches that fanned out over their heads. Making the leaves shimmer as if the curtain of foliage that now surrounded them was coated in pure starlight. The soft incandescent glow illuminates the ground around the Willow. As suddenly thousands of willow branches could be seen littering the grass all around them.

“How many Willow’s are there?” Adora questioned as she watched Razz begin to bend down and start picking up the soft, slender branches. That lay beneath the tree.

“As many as are needed?” Razz grinned gently, as she handed a bundle of branches to Adora. The blonde stared down at the sticks now cradled in her arms. They were all different colors, length and thickness. There was no way all these branches came from the same Willow Tree? Razz could see the slow revelation alighting in Adora’s eyes, her thoughtful expressions twisting from confusion to sudden clarity. As she began to understand each Willow's significance. To the threads of magic woven into the very essence of Etheria.

Soon Adora was sitting under the willow's green canopy, sorting out the branches, deep in thought. While Razz sat in a bough above her head, swinging her short, wrinkled legs. Humming a merry tune.

"What am I weaving?" Adora called up into the tree.

"Depends on what you wish to create?" Razz responded, lightly. "I taught you the basics, now you must learn how to shape the threads. I shall teach you how to coil, how to plait and how to twine the threads. What you will create is up to you?" So much went unsaid, as Razz's voice faded away. The old woman's attention was drawn to some distant point beyond the trees.

"Connections…can take many shapes. " Razz sighed, her eyes focused inward. Mulling over long ago memories, "Some threads are gentle, weaving together because there is no other way for them to exist and become stronger together. While some threads become knotted, by design or perhaps fated to become so. Those connections can be powerful…but also complex…forming an unending pattern. They can become something elegantly beautiful, or unwieldy grotesque…or even a mixture of the two… depending on their creator. Others may not be as resilient and fray and slowly disconnect over time."

Adora nodded, so focused on her task. She never looked up to notice the lonely forlorn, sadness in the old woman's eyes. Razz gave her head a shake, clearing her thoughts lest they draw her away from this time. As her awareness returned she merely hoped down from the branch. Landing on light feet just before the wicker piles, that shifted and fanned out upon her bare feet's sudden disturbance upon the grass.

With a grunt and groan, Razz settled her old bones before Adora and began to instruct her once more. Elaborating on her weaving techniques, as Adora worked with nimble fingers. The weaving was like carving, it was a physical form of mediation. Allowing her mind to wander easily, down one path to another. As she coiled the pliant branches into a spiraling base. Her thoughts falling upon

Mara, upon her less than ideal heritage as a First One. Fretting about what more terrible things she was going to uncover, the harsh truths she had yet to face about what happened a thousand years ago. That lay waiting for her inside the temple.

She sucked in a startled breath, when she suddenly saw eight guiding branches jutting out of her coiled base. That looked just like the eight sided star that graced She-Ra's chest. Snapping her eyes up, finding Razz's owlish gaze fixed upon the weaving with a proud smile spreading over her wrinkled face.

"Very good, Adora..your coiling is tight. The guiding threads are strong. We will keep going another day." The old woman encouraged her, gently reaching down and taking the base out of her hands. Tucking it away in the many folds of her pink dress. She cocked her head towards the forest. The sharp peak of the beacon that protruded just above the forest. Was glowing more brightly amid the multi-colored canopy of the woods that lay beyond the valley. It shone against the black backdrop of the night sky, like a falling star.

"I believe you are being summoned my dear." Razz stated.

Adora stood, staring down at the shining peak of the Crystal Castle. Her body shivered, as every muscle was electrified by a magical force. Unable to fight the incredible pull of magic, as she was drawn away from Razz. Her eyes shone with divine light. As the blue runestone on the golden bracer began to pulse. She walked away from the old woman, back down the hill and disappeared into the blackened trees. Heading back towards the First Ones ruins and her destiny, once more.

Master Elys grunted, as he observed the glowing blue dust scattered inside a small glass dish on his desk. He once again had his magnifying headband on, the column of lenses protruding out from his right eye. As he hunched over the dish, having poured

some of the contents from Light Spinner's hidden vial to study. Nimbly picking up a tiny piece of broken crystal with metal tweezers. Lifting it up to the lenses and then grunting again.

Casta stood behind him, arms folded as she scowled down at the dark metal vial sitting on the old man's desk. A taunting reminder of how dangerous and reckless Light Spinner had been. How her vile machinations were still capable of causing misery and ruin, even after her death.

Glimmer sat in one of Master Elys's armchairs by the fire, casting the roaring flames nervous glances. As Catra prowled by the tall windows, with Melog's satchel hanging off a shoulder. Their ember red glow within, flickered and flared like the roaring fire.

They had been waiting for nearly two hours on pins and needles for Master Elys to confirm what the dust inside the vial was.

"I need to see Light Spinner's forbidden spell books…to be certain" Master Elys muttered.

Casta's eyes flew wide.

"What are you thinking, Elys?" She gasped. A dreadful heaviness of impending doom, clamping onto her chest and holding firm.

"This conjuring dust…I have to confirm its origin..but I believe that Light Spinner has harvested it from the Crystal of Kaydak." Elys flipped up his many lenes, his expression dark and determined.

"I knew it!" Catra spat, when Shadow Weaver had teleported them to the Heart to save Adora. She had felt that same, cold desolation envelop her as it did in the portal reality. When she had offered herself to the Nameless One. The scent of timeless decay had assaulted her as they blinked through that void and back into existence inside the Crystal Castle. The same unsavory taint that had also lingered around Prime and Shadow Weaver.

“I noticed that the shard was chipped…when I had it in my possession.” Master Elys stated, setting down his headband on the desk with dull clatter.

“How the hell did Light Spinner get her hands on a dark relic so powerful?” Glimmer groaned, standing up.

“She explored the hidden catacombs beneath Mystacor…perhaps she found it down there.” Casta offered.

“Ok….then if you won’t let me see her spell books on dark magic, then perhaps my answers lay down there.” Catra’s snarky insolence was scathing, her contempt towards Casta clear in her heated scowl. As she promptly headed for the door, her tail high and lashing behind her.

“You can’t go down there, it's too dangerous!” Casta shouted out, as the magicat stormed out of the study. Worry and concern etched deeply upon the Head Sorceress's face as she watched the fuming Magicat leave.

“I’ll keep her safe, Auntie.” Glimmer promised, as she chased after Catra out the door. Glimmer’s assurances did not ease any of Casta’s anxiety…with a determined frown she also left Elys’s study. Intent on making sure that no other calamity would befall Mystacor, due to another mages reckless and impulsive behavior.

Glimmer had silently endured the last few days as Catra and Casta argued and butted heads over Light Spinner’s research. Their relationship mirroring that of her and her mother far too close for comfort. Casta just wanted to protect Catra. Keep her safe, from her own stubborn need to barrel ahead into magic that could be dangerous and deadly in a novice's hands.

Glimmer easily caught up to Catra further down the hallway. The magicat was moving at a brisk pace, low growls rumbling in warning from her throat. As she glared down at her feet. The other mages coming up the corridor were quick to duck into side

halls. Not willing to even pass by the fuming hybrid. The waves of wrath and fury coming off of her aura was like a dark ominous cloud. Driving everyone away.

Except Glimmer, who understood Catra's frustrations and wanted only to help.

She chuckled softly as she came astride, calling her magical staff into her hand in a cloud of sparkles.

"When are we heading out then?" She inquired cheerfully.

Catra stopped suddenly and turned to her with an incredulous look.

"You don't have to come with me."

Glimmer rolled her eyes. "Yes, I do…and I want to. The Best Friend Squad sticks together…we don't let anyone go into danger alone…and we are great at quests!"

Catra grunted and shook her head, crossing her arms over her chest as she gave Glimmer a knowing smirk. "We barely survived most of the 'Quests' we got into during our trip home, remember?"

Glimmer groaned, remembering the many dangerous and near death experiences they had all had, hoping from planet to moon, to asteroid, to derelict space stations. Trying to keep Darla repaired and space worthy during the journey home. Then quickly offered Catra a bright, confident smile. "Yes…but we survived..key point. If we sucked at the quests…we'd all be dead by now." She shrugged, tossing her staff from hand to hand smugly.

Catra's sour look slowly softened. " Fine." She grumbled, striding away with Glimmer keeping pace beside her.

When DT returned to the Adepts Dorm. He found Catra, moving urgently around the room. Navigating amid a maelstrom of books, clothes and provisions all scattered over the bed and the floor. He stood for a moment in the doorway, in the guise of the Thaymorian deer hybrid. Just taking all the controlled chaos in.

Catra was standing in front of the bed, flipping through a journal then setting it down. Picking up another book from the ones strewn all over her four poster bed.

Her half packed backpack opened and slumped on the floor against a corner wooden bedpost. She stood before the malestorn of books, thumbing through one then another. Muttering and growling, her tail lashing violently behind her.

DT still had not heard anything from Peekablue and they had to admit they were getting nervous. Finding Catra preparing to take off again and not being able to report her whereabouts to the Seer was not good either. So they nodded and headed towards their bedroll. Without a word they tucked their own spell book, baby blanket and wool blanket on the thin mattress before rolling it up tight and lashing the bundle together with hide cords. So they could carry it easily across their shoulders.

“What are you doing?” Catra inquired, when she noticed Finn rolling up his bedroll.

“Going with you.” Finn responded in a bold statement.

“Uh….no.” Catra responded, folding her arms over her chest. “Where I’m going is far too dangerous for a little kid.”

“So…then where are you going?” Finn prodded, folding his own arms over his chest stubbornly.

“I can’t tell you, cause I know you would just follow me.” Catra smirked, this impertinent banter was very Finn.

Finn huffed and rolled his eyes, hurt and disappointment twisting his features. DT knew Catra’s weaknesses and they would exploit

them to get their way.

“Fine, I’m used to being left behind, everyone leaves me eventually. Why did I get my hopes up that this time it would be different!” His downcast eyes were suddenly wet with unshed tears. “I thought I’d found my family…I thought you guys wanted me around but I’m just a nuisance…aren’t I… you're just too nice to tell me to go away. " He whined, as he turned away from her. Sniffling loudly, a sly smile played upon his lips when they knew Catra could not see. As he reached down to sling his bedroll over a small shoulder.

“Finn…I…no…come on…it’s not like that! ” Catra stuttered, quickly striding across the room to repair the damage she had done. Reaching for the little Thaymorian as they trudged despondently towards the open front door.

“Yes it is!” Finn roared, spinning around to glare up at Catra. The fear and devastation of being rejected once again burns in their wet, blue eyes. “You guys already left me behind once…and Momm…urgh…Adora didn’t come back!” He shouted, refusing to call her Momma again. DT was laying on the drama, real thick. Driving in one emotional nail after another, reopening all of Catra’s old wounds of being abandoned, being neglected, being unloved.

“I don’t want you getting hurt and where I’m going is very dangerous!” Catra shouted in desperation, clearing the distance again and bending down to hold Finn in place by the shoulder’s. She was only trying to protect him, why couldn’t he see that!

“I’ve been on my own for years! I can take care of myself!” He shouted in her face, rolling his shoulder to dislodge her hands. Rejecting her comfort, harshly.

Catra cast her head to the side and growled…”If you get hurt…” She snarled.

She was breaking…this was too easy!

“I won’t!” Finn declared, brushing away his tears angrily with his hands hiding his small, proud grin.

“ugh….Fine” Catra groaned, throwing her head back and staring in futile regret at the gray cloud’s hanging in the sky outside the open door.

“The more the merrier…” She ground out as two full packs fell from the balcony above and struck the flag stones just behind Finn.

Finn jumped, startled by the heavy thud.

“Good to hear, WildCat!” Scorpia’s exuberant voice echoed from above, followed by her heavy footsteps upon the stairs. Catra turned and found both Perfuma and the Scorpioni heading towards the packs and slinging them on their backs. They were both dressed for travel. Scorpia had her heavy coat from the Northern Reach on, while Perfuma was now wearing a long, woolen green coat instead of her shawl.

“What’s going on?” Catra questioned, completely bewildered as to what was occurring around her.

“We are going with you.” Frosta stated, her tone matter of fact and slightly amused. As she strode down the colonnade towards them, once more dressed in her heavy parka with the fur lined hood and a heavy pack on her back.

“Ready to go, Horde Scum..” Glimmer closed her door lightly, shouldering her own pack. Dressed once again her dark violet pants, with her heavy lavender jacket with fur lined hood and white gloves. Her backpack was slung over one shoulder with her staff jutting out the side of the top flap.

Catra stood motionless in her doorway, swallowing hard. She was overwhelmed by their friendship. With tears in her eyes, she cleared her throat, quickly averting her gaze to conceal how emotional she was getting.

Then merely nodded and ducked back into her room. Quickly throwing on her leather coat. Gathering up Melog from the fireplace mantel and tucking them into their satchel. Then dashing back to her bed, shoving a few of Light Spinner's journals into her backpack. When she returned, both Netossa and Spinneralla had joined the group, also dressed for colder weather and ready to depart. Catra squared her shoulders, turned and marched down the colonnade to the outer courtyard. As the group of princesses passed the Cathedral, both Emily and Mermista's bots. That had been sitting near the stairs, rose up and joined their ranks. Catra glanced behind briefly, before quickly averting her eyes back to the orchard ahead. Stubbornly keeping her expression impassive, even though her heart was bursting with joy. She had been a part of their group for nearly half a year now, never feeling like she truly belonged. But this time she felt truly like one of them…the pride she felt at finally earning her place among the princesses was overwhelming.

The comforting warmth, of being accepted, being cared about. That was spreading through her was the most welcoming feeling. She never wanted to hurt or disappoint any of them. She would protect them, always. This must have been what Adora had felt in their company back in Bright Moon after she left the Horde. The hope to always pull through whatever the odds and that unwavering loyalty they had to each other was amazing and she was a part of that bond. A silent tear trailed down her cheek, but she kept her head up proudly. Knowing she would not have to face adversity alone ever again.

Kingdom of Light

Chapter Summary

> From this point on the arc will be broken up into two storylines. The first will be Kingdom of Light, that focuses on Adora and Mara. That leads into Kingdom of Shadow that focuses on Catra and Light Spinner.

Chapter Notes

> Thank you OddBodkin, EvaWolf, BitzyBee and PinkStorm for your comments and all the Kudos. This will be the last instalment for a few weeks, happy holidays and see you all in the new year.

"I never wanted to be a hero, I won't be remembered as one." -Mara, She-Ra of Etheria

Night had fallen completely, during the time Adora traveled to the Whispering Willow. Now the star's twinkled overhead, sparkling within the cracks of the barren branches of the trees. As the greater Moon's and their smaller counterparts had taken to the dark sky. Hovering overhead like stalwart companion's to Adora's trek back to the Crystal Castle. She moved silently among the blackened husks of dead trees in the valley below. Her boots left imprints upon the soft, loose soil. As fat flakes of ash floated around her. The gusts of cold wind, sending the burnt remains of the forest into the air. Causing it to drift and swirl around Adora, like falling snow.

As Adora slowly made her way deeper into the forest once more. Following a golden spirit, she had come to trust. The ethereal presence of the Goddess of Life was comforting, warm and serene.

(Your time with Mara was cut far too short, thanks to Primes meddling. We shall remedy that, now.) Sheana's gentle voice hummed in Adora 's mind.

Adora walked into camp, her eyes glowing with divine light. Her focus upon the central tower at the back of the ruins. Locked into a trance, she moved with a single minded purpose towards the temple. Following the golden glow of Sheana, who sought to push her gently to confront the many fears. She has harbored towards the Crystal Castle. Ever since her last trial within its halls.

Liam never noticed at first. Quick to dash to Adora's side as she crossed behind the campfire. Like a moth to a flame, Liam was always drawn to Adora whenever she was around.

"Adora…I wanted to show you something. I was working on some improvements to Spirit's barding while you were gone." The young man's boastful rambling fell silent, as Adora completely ignored him.

Kronis noticed the strange, distant look in her eyes and jumped up as well. Moving swiftly from the fire and clasping Liam's arm in warning.

"Let her go, lad. She's under thrall." He hissed.

"What the hell does that mean?" Liam snapped back, watching in confusion as Adora approached the temple.

Spirit knickered from nearby and quickly trotted to her side. Sheana nodded in acceptance towards Spirit as the horse approached.

(Take your trusted steed with you, his presence will fortify your magic, as you seek your answers.) Her voice was soft, full of tender adoration towards Spirit.

Adora’s hand seemed to float up from her side and press against the stallion’s neck. Guiding him silently with her towards the temple. Following Sheana’s golden glow hovering across the courtyard, compelled to keep up to her guide.

(The temple is powering down, since you severed the link between my essence and the Relic. But my magic is still bonded to the Crystal Core. I need you to recharge the temple with my magic. So that you may speak to Mara again.) Sheana commanded, as she led Adora and Spirit towards the central tower at the back of the ruins.

“Can you hear the humming brother?” The first clone muttered, still hunched over the fire stirring the cooking pot. That was now full of a hearty stew of vegetables and salted meat.

“Yes, brother.” The second agreed, closing his eyes as his long pointed ears twitched. “It is like the whispers of the Hive Mind….” He whimpered, his voice shaking slightly with loss.

A low rumble vibrated in the air, followed by the ground trembling under their feet. Then a ramp appeared at the base of the tower and Adora and Spirit descended into the interior of the temple. The ramp ascended a moment later, sealing them up inside and then disappeared.

Liam looked on in both wonder and concern, while Kronis narrowed his eyes in disgust. Nothing good ever came from messing around with ancient First Ones fortresses. Bile rose in his throat, to burn the back of his mouth. As brutal memories of assaulting Castle Grayskull on Skeletor’s orders years earlier, rose in his mind. It had been a fruitless battle, the Castle was impenetrable and guarded by an Immortal Sorceress. The magic defenses had laid waste to his troops before they even made it to the front gates.

It had been a blood bath…

Lord Skeletor’s true plans that day would not be laid bare until after the slaughter.

The lives of his soldier’s…his people…had been a distraction. To keep the Sorceress busy, while Lynn and Beastman snuck into Castle Grayskull to steal some ancient relic.

He was wary of the First Ones, the power that lay dormant within their ruins here on Etheria…must be just as devastating as Castle Grayskull upon Eternia.

Adora walked down a long hallway, with Spirit at her side. The hollow sounds of her boots and the horses' hooves echoed in a solemn procession. As they moved deeper into the dimly lit temple.

She was resolute on her mission, the golden glow of Sheana floating ahead. Beckoning her to continue, a ethereal essence she followed unerringly towards her destiny.

The First one writing upon the walls glowed faintly with the last remnants of power, a low resonating hum whispering around them. Destroying the A.I who governed that Temple. Caused the Crystal Castle to now function much like a body without a brain….but over the last year all the systems were starting to shut down. It was just a technological shell, still capable of wondrous things as long as it had the power to do so. Except it no longer had a way to communicate with Adora. Without Light Hope, the temple was silent, an ancient machine without a soul to guide it.

(I was enslaved to the Sword…here. Sealed and forced to carry out the First Ones bidding by their puppet.) Sheana’s voice held no heat, just mute acceptance. She had no grudge against Mara, if anything after getting to know her kind and compassionate soul. Sharing her memories here on Etheria. She found the woman to be noble and brave and did not deserve her tragic end.

Adora's eyes still glowing under Sheana's magic, filled with tears. Her once blank expression, crumpling with grief at the pain and suffering the Goddess had endured. By being sealed within the Sword of Protections, sharing in Mara's heartache over what her people were doing to the planet, to its people. While Despara's bracer vibrated with a need for vengeance.

Sheana also had empathy and remorse for how Mara had also been manipulated and controlled by those in power.

(Mara was conflicted…she struggled to find balance and was unable to let go. The First Ones used her… as they used me.) Sheana sighed heavily, as she led Adora deeper into the temple. (I regret killing her…) The goddess finished, in a lowly whisper.

Adora felt for her, she understood all too well the heavy guilt of having no other choice but to take a life. She would always struggle with having killed Light Hope.

In time, they moved into a large cavernous room, filled with crystal pillars. Six more narrow, crystalline pillar's surrounded a raised dais. The pale pink facets were cracked and broken. Perhaps the damage was done by Mara, when she rebelled against the First Ones and sought to destroy their hold on Etheria. Many of the structures and statues that littered the grounds had scars from the Sword of Protection. Or perhaps it was merely time slowly causing them to crumble into ruin. Now that Adora knew a bit more about stonecraft, thanks to Liam. She understood that these crystal pillars stored magic, that she guessed powered complex systems here in the temple.

A central dias dominated the center, with a ramp, etched with First Ones writing. Sheana's spirit floated up the ramp to hover upon the emitter platform at the end. She waited for only a moment before raising her arm and pointing at the large, glass like pillar that rose up at the back of the room.

(I will recharge the Crystal Castle) Sheana hovered upon the platform.

Adora could not hold back her worry that perhaps this was a bad idea. She felt unsteady and nervous. Reluctant to give this cursed device the power to control her, manipulate her…kill her…once again.

(**Do not fret. Both Despara and I will be with you until the end. As long as we are together, nothing can harm you. You are stronger than the First Ones machinations.) Sheana offered, with a warm, reassuring smile. Despara's affirmed that statement, her deeper, husky voice echoing in Adora's mind. (You can do this, your soul is strong, your will indomitable and because of that. The First Ones would never be able to control you again. We believe in you, Adora…you must learn to believe in yourself.)**

Adora nodded, her expression firm, resolved to see this through. She walked up the ramp and across the dias to stand before the smaller platform at the back. Facing the back wall where a pale, glowing column stood. The base was etched in First Ones glyphs, as the control pillar ascended up and out of view high above.

Spirit had never entered this room before, he never really came into the Crystal Castle all that often. He tossed his head back and forth, finding several more dark archways branching out of either side of the room.

He sent a concerned inquiry through their link. Adora merely smiled reassuringly over her shoulder, her eyes glowing like living stars. Then turned back towards the control pillar, raising her right arm, summoning Sheana's shield. The blue gem in the middle flared. As the manifestation of the goddess of Life appeared in Adora's grasp. The gem flashed a beam of divine light towards the control pillar and it came alive as well. Thousands of First Ones

glyphs charging, appearing across its length. As the very depths of the Crystal Castle began to hum louder.

A blinding flash of light, ignited within the base of the pillar. The beam of light cascading across the floor to illuminate the platform upon the dais.

Adora's eyes cleared, the divine light fading away from her eyes. As she completed her mission. Returning them to her natural soft blue.

The strange, abstract hologram that acted like an interface to the temple appeared. Hovering above the platform, hands clasped before her waiting patiently.

"Welcome Administrator…what is your query?" She inquired with a synthetic smile.

"Uh…" Adora was just coming out of her trance, glancing around the room in awe. Finding Spirit standing at the end of the ramp, snorting and shaking his head anxiously.

"Hi…again." She muttered, as Sheana's bracer reappeared upon her wrist. She had never seen the Castle walls look so vibrant, the crystal pillars glowing so brightly. They illuminated the room in an electric pink glow. Even the floors were shimmering a brilliant blue. It was like she was surrounded by the vivid colors of sunset. Suddenly her heart lurched, she really missed Catra. It had been a week since she had seen her.

Then she yelped, clamping her hands over her mouth as if that might stop the temple from reading the yearning in her heart.

"Hey, Adora." Suddenly Catra's sultry voice echoed from deep inside the chamber. Calling to her in that same taunting, lilt that she loved.

"No!....no,no,no…" Adora clamped her eyes shut, refusing to allow the Temple to comfort her with some cheap copy of Catra, all because she missed her so badly.

“I want to talk to…Light…Urgh…” Adora groaned, as guilt slugged her hard in the chest. She couldn’t talk to Light Hope…she was dead…but who was in charge now? It took her a second to get back on track. “Uh….I want to talk to the Planetary Facilitator…I want to talk to Hordak!”

She demanded, refusing to open her eyes until she heard the cool, emotionless base of Hordak’s voice.

“Welcome, She-Ra. How may I serve you?”

Adora snapped open her eyes and sighed with relief. When she saw the transparent hologram of Hordak. Once more dressed in the lighter, more refined armor that Entrapta had designed for him. Before he downloaded his consciousness into the First Ones, Supercomputer.

“Ok…good…uh, Sheana brought me here to talk to Mara.” Adora nodded towards Hordak. Who merely stood unmoving upon the platform, his soft yellow eyes staring patiently at her.

It took Adora another second to realize he needed more than a statement of intent. He needed a Query.

“I want to know everything…about Mara the Last She-Ra of Etheria. ” She declared. It was a broad question but she hoped Hordak would prove to be more useful than Light Hope was. He wasn’t trying to control and manipulate her. So perhaps he would access all the information in the Crystal Castles data banks she wanted.

“Processing…” Hordak’s focus drew inward, his gaze became unfocused and distant as he tapped into the vast amount of data stored in the Temple.

“Shall we start from the beginning?” Hordak asked, when he had finished downloading the information.

“Yes…that would be great.” Adora was ecstatic at how easy it was to get what she wanted from Hordak. Pushing aside how

unnerving it was to have a person she once feared in her youth, now catering to her like she was a superior.

“Very, well then. Come with me.” Hordak walked past her and headed down the ramp, passing Spirit who made a disgruntled sniffing sound. Casting Adora, a wave of confusion about seeing Holo-Hordak through their bond.

“It’s a long story, Spirit. But it’s alright, Hordak’s on our side now.” Adora gave him a reassuring pat on the cheek as she passed him. Following Hordak across the vast crystal chamber towards a dimly lit triangle shaped archway.

“How are things going on Beast Island?’ Adora offered polite conversation as they walked across the chamber.

“Entrapta’s research and our retrofits to the First Ones technological infrastructure to the planet is proceeding on schedule.” Hordak offered.

“That's good.” Adora nodded. “I ran into a couple of your brother’s out at the border of Scorpania. I caught them assembling Sentinel's and selling one to a local farmer.”

“That was an unfortunate situation that Entrapta and I have now rectified. Some of my brother’s have yet to rejoin the fold. I hope the lost ones will return to my side soon. I will need their strength in the coming months, I fear I can not keep Etheria functioning without them.” Hordak explained, his words were vague but held an urgency that made Adora anxious.

“The Sky Tree is currently hovering over the island, so that we can transport clones and equipment more rapidly.” Hordak commented, continuing his report in a very humble, military fashion. As if addressing a superior officer.

They passed through the archway, moving into a dark corridor. That was lit only by the First Ones glyphs along the walls. The

temple shifted as a large triangle shaped door rushed towards them. A soft tingle against her skin, that mimicked the effects of teleportation washed over both Adora and Spirit. As the door passed over them, another chamber appeared. It was similar to the first room, with seven crystal pillars rising up out of the floor in a semicircle and a huge mural of She-Ra on a simple platform on the back wall.

Adora recognized this room, it was the central chamber to a First Ones ruin a little further north west of Crystal Castle. It was the ruin that she, Bow and Glimmer had sought refuge in when being chased by that ferocious, elemental that was protecting the Sword of Protection. A huge spider-beetle, monster, that nearly killed them. Light Hope had taken her to this room as well, during their first meeting. When she had come to her for help to learn how to heal.

The room was now filled with crates, half packed in straw with First Ones relics. Tarps strung up on poles protecting tables, filled with archaeological tools used for excavation. Bow had spoken to her briefly before heading to the Heart a couple months ago. About his father's exploring a ruin in the woods to hide from Primes forces. This must have been that ruin. Adora wondered briefly if George and Lance were still coming back here, hoping to uncover more of the ancient past.

"She-Ra…is Etheria's Champion…" Hordak waved a hand towards the crystal mural. As Adora refocused on Hordak, her heart sank. Worried he was going to start the same 'Chosen One spiel' Light Hope had years ago.

"But she is not alone. For there are three other champion's who share the same destiny. He-Ro…the champion of Primus and He-Man the champion of Eternia and Zie-Thy the champion of Krytis. The four central worlds of our universe. " Hordak continued, hovering away from the mural to a more empty portion of the vast room as Adora followed him. Finally taking a breath, already he was being far more forthright than Light Hope ever was. The image of four people formed before her. One she recognized as

Mara, two were blonde twins. The last was a tall, flowing figure that resembled Melog's first appearance on Krytis. Adora was drawn back to the twins. The very same young men that were walking beside the cart. In her dream of Mara she had while meditating with Perfuma back on Mystacor.

"Who were they?" Adora mused…under her breath.

"As She-Ra, you are to protect and maintain Etheria's connection with the other four Primal Worlds in the Tri-Solar system…." Hordak ignored her question or simply did not hear her since she had spoken so softly. A glowing three dimensional triangle formed between the four figures. That reminded Adora very much of a symbol she had once seen as part of the matrix of the Heart of Etheria. She cringed at the memory of that horrific contraption. That had hovered over her and Catra. Howling and threatening to destroy them. As it was charged with a thousand years worth of magic, glowing green as it was infected by Primes virus. Sparking and shooting lightning over their heads. Capable of killing them in one strike, if not for She-Ra.

The four warrior's faded leaving only the three dimensional triangle that represented the Tri-solar system. Then hundreds upon thousands of other galaxies began to spark into existence, scattering out from the points of the triangles, in swirling arcs. Held within two cubes, one bigger than the other. Points of lights glowed at the four corners of each cube, with planets hovering in first ones glyphs beside them. The star map was a perfect replica of the Heart of Etheria? The infinite map that hovered before her. A three dimensional representation of the wider universe. Beyond those worlds lay a blank void, the unfathomable expanse of deep space.

Adora was instantly overwhelmed by the endless universe now stretching out before her. The sheer size and depths of the cosmos was a daunting concept to take in. Her heart was beating fast, as she breathed in both awe and wonder and perhaps a good dose of fear.

“He-Man as the conduit of Power, She-Ra as the conduit of Protection and He-Ro as the conduit of Unity and lastly Zie-Thy the conduit of Harmony. When the four vessels of primordial magic are in connection, all magic in the universe is in balance.” Hordak instructed, waving a hand over the star map making it disappear.

“Ok…no big deal…I can do that…” Adora muttered as even more responsibility was piled on her shoulders, as she was now expected to not only maintain the magical balance of the planet but of the universe as well.

“Sadly, Zie-Thy was destroyed over a thousand years ago. Krytis is a dead world and no longer has magic. Due to the First Ones arrogance and reckless actions. So Balance can never be obtained again. The Universe is doomed to spiral out of control until it inevitably destroys itself. ” Hordak stated, folding his gloved hands together in finality.

Adora stood dumbstruck at Hordak’s bleak statement and the dire consequences in their future.

“I can fix that…” Adora promised, it was just another impossible quest. But this was a chance to heal the damage her people had done. “I’ll figure out how to bring magic back to Krytis. I’ll balance the universe again.” She vowed, her eyes were fierce. Determined to right yet another terrible wrong inflicted upon the universe by her ancestors.

“You have proven already, how powerful you can be. I trust that you can do the impossible.” Hordak’s smile was reserved. His words express full confidence in her ability to succeed, no matter the odds.

Adora smiled back, his praise fortifying her resolve to do just that.

“Everything on Etheria is connected. A thousand years ago, the elemental magics were controlled by the Rune Bearer’s.” Hordak

continued, as once again Adora was surrounded by glowing silhouettes. But these were not the same ones she had been shown before…these were not the current princesses.

She was surrounded by hybrids, some she recognized like Catra's mother Aoi and the rest of the Greater Elemental Rune Bearer's. She had seen back at the Basilica. All of the hybrids were different colors, just like the princesses were in Light Hope representation. Adora understood now, from being in the true heart of Etheria that the colors represented the threads of magic for each element.

But there was no Queen Angella, in her place was another Magicat…much taller than Aoi. Her silhouette shimmered like the moonlight. Wearing what looked like light plate armor, by the sharp angles of pauldrons on her shoulders, the elegant chest plate that molded to her slender feline body. Heavy leather gauntlets and greaves upon her wrists and shins. Her tail was fluffy, hanging low. The upper part near her butt was sheathed in leather with chainmail over top. She had a long mane, tied up in a ponytail, her bangs were parting down either side of her face like waterfalls. Her ears were pointed upward, showing how alert she was. But the most shocking was the mask she wore upon her brow…it was Catra's mask!

"Who is this?" Adora moved swiftly in front of the powerful silhouette.

"That was C'yra, the Rune Bearer of Light." Hordak answered.

"Did Queen Angella know her…what happened to her?" Adora spun to face Hordak. Back at the Basilica it was a statue of Angela as the Rune Bearer of Light. Why was this Magicat erased from history?

"I have not retrieved any data on Queen Angella…from that time. Do you still wish to activate Mara's memories now or shall I download the files the Firsts Ones kept on the Immortal, Angela?" Hordak inquired.

“Yes…I want to know about Mara, first.” Adora agreed, casting Spirit a nervous look. As the room shifted again, Hordak transported them away into an even smaller room.

It was pitch black, except for a central platform that looked strangely like a bed. With the same array of various glowing pink and blue crystals embedded around the perimeter of the room and upon the border of the platform.

Adora had been in this room before too. It was the room Light Hope had used to place her into stasis. So that she would let go of all her attachments and begin her training.

Adora swallowed hard. “I am not getting on that thing again.” She stated pointedly.

“That is merely an M.R.I” Hordak began, “A memory, retrieval, initializer.” He finished, addressing the strange bed with First Ones writing glowing along its surface. “It is the fastest, most efficient method to view Mara's life and any of the other lives. Of the previous She-Ra’s that you might want to learn from.” Hordak explained. Not understanding her trepidation over a simple machine.

Adora groaned and rolled her eyes in distaste. She had been completely immobilized last time, it had taken Glimmer’s frantic, terrified voice calling to her to wake her up!

She really did not want to submit herself to the Crystal Castle again.

“Couldn’t you just create illusions of her memories…I mean this whole place can recreate anything…” Adora hedged.

“Yes, but it would take time to download every one of Mara’s memories into my data banks and then project them…I am afraid this is the most efficient way.” Hordak admitted, his tone firm.

Spirit huffed, his hot breath blowing in a sudden gust against the back of Adora’s neck. Causing her ponytail to flutter up. Letting

her know he was here and that he would watch over her and if she needed him. He would come to her aid, just like last time when he led Glimmer and Bow to her side. When Light Hope had put her consciousness into that machine. She could trust in him to wake her up.

Adora turned and pressed her forehead against his nose. As his strong protective feelings rushed over their bond.

"How long?" She sighed, with resignation.

"However long it takes for you to find the answers that you seek." Hordak shrugged.

Adora turned, giving Hordak a dispassionate look of distaste. As anxiety and fear rolled inside of her as she slowly approached the bed and laid down. Feeling once again, forced to acquiesce to something she did not want to do…for the greater good.

"Spirit." She reached out for him, as he trotted forward pressing his nose into the palm of her hand. As her desperate need to be connected to someone outside of the dream rushed through their link.

(I got you…I am right here…always.) Spirit thought, sending confidence through their bond. Soothing Adora's panic as her eye lids slowly closed. As the sedative effects of the machine began to take hold, the low hum vibrating all around her. Drawing her consciousness away.

Chapter Two

Chapter Notes

Alright I am back! This is a long chapter, I hope you all enjoy. Thank you Pink Storm for the comments, I love reading them.

"I don't know what they told you, but it wasn't all bad at first. We were the first ones to settle Etheria, to really study this planet's magic. How could it have gone so wrong?"

Mara, She-Ra of Etheria

Adora had been sealed inside the temple. Liam had not been worried at first. Keeping himself busy, the next morning by tending to their campsite. At dawn he had gone hunting for a few small animals for their meals that day. Harvesting berries and herbs from the forest this time of year was pointless, so they would have to use their supplies to add substance and flavor to the meat and stews. Which meant he would have to go to a nearby village for more when they ran low. He spent the rest of the morning, gathering and stacking a good amount of firewood. By the afternoon, Kronis and the clones had pulled out the heavy tarps and hides that were rolled up in the cart. As Liam chopped down thicker more sturdy branches from the nearby trees. As supports to lash the tarps and hides too. It took the rest of the day but by dusk they had built a yurt style shelter that could keep them warm during the cold months again. Covering the cold ground in thick woven mats and then placing their sleeping mats on top, adding heavy furred blankets. The campfire was built in the center of the shelter, the roof flap pulled aside to vent the smoke.

Liam had spent the next night sitting by the open doorway, glaring at the beacon.

As the monolith stood silent, glowing softly in the moonlight, uncaring about how worried he was becoming.

Kronis watched him with a calculating eye, having been observing Liam the whole trip. It was obvious the young man had feelings for Adora. The whole time they had traveled the young man hardly gave the woman space to breathe. Always taking care of her, as she seemed to neglect her health and well being quite often. Now the 'mother hen' was adrift with no one to care for. Stuck fretting about his charge and unable to care for her.

Kronis glanced down at his data pad, he had walked around the perimeter of the ruin. Taking readings of its energy levels, attempting to pin down the power nodes and junctions so he could start and probe its defenses. His ultimate goal was to covertly hack into its data banks first so he could learn as much as possible about this Crystal Castle. From there he could devise a plan to nullify the beacon's defenses.

The best way to conquer the unknown is knowledge…

Adora found herself, once more standing upon the rugged outlook deep in the Whispering Woods. A river wound threw the lush landscape below. Weaving like a shimmering ribbon among the trees and granite cliffs of the canyon. That jutted out along the edges of the vibrant, sprawling valley below.

Adora did not appear as She-Ra, but as she was now. In just her white compression shirt and gray pants with knee length leather traveling boots. Her two bracer's adorned each wrist, the red and blue stones glowing softly. Her blonde hair was still tied back in a ponytail, but it had loosened. Her poof that once kept her bangs out of her face had pulled free. Allowing her long bangs to cascade down either side of her face.

The long days of travel had worn down her resolve to care about her appearance. She no longer had the energy to maintain control

over frivolous things, like her bangs. If her hair became a nuisance, she might just cut it short. It would be easier to take care of anyway. She had far too many other worries that were taking prominence in her mind.

She looked haggard and worn, from giving her all in the service to the villager's. To help them prepare for the cold season ahead. This would be the beginning of the first year in this new Etheria. So many unknowns lay ahead, as they navigated this new world.

A warm breeze danced over her, tossing her hair playfully as it disappeared into the trees behind her. Adora closed her eyes, as a small pleased smile spread upon her lips. Basking in the gentle caress of the wind. Sighing softly in delight, as the air was heavy with the sweet scent of flowers. She slowly opened her eyes, that had once been clouded with exhaustion. Where once more clear blue and sparkling with new vigor. Her gaze was lost to the wondrous landscape before her. Admiring the radiant, open sky that stretched out to the horizon. Which was alive and vibrant with color, frozen in that magical transition of either twilight or dawn. The greater Moons and their companion's shone in the starlit sky. As a timeless serenity surrounded her, quieting her mind, lulling her soul into a much needed tranquility.

Adora hummed with contentment as the rush of life and magic surged across her skin, her eyes flashed with divine light. She had been here before…this was where she finally was able to meet Mara. At least the memory of her that lived inside the Crystal Castle's data banks.

"Looks like you survived?" Mara smirked knowingly, as she once again joined Adora at the edge of the outlook. This time she did not appear as She-Ra, but just Mara. Wearing a soft blue tunic and half skirt, with darker leggings. The common attire Adora had first seen her in. When she had viewed Mara's last transmission upon Darla, before the ship crashed in the desert.

"Yeah, " Adora agreed with a sigh. "What you told me last time…it saved me…love." She finished, her cheeks flushing at the tender

memory of her first kiss.

Mara laughed merrily, clapping her on the shoulder.
"Good for you, you deserve it!" She declared, turning towards the spectacular views that stretched out before them. Before continuing, in a more subdued tone.

"This was my favorite spot to retreat to…when I was in the Whispering Woods. I felt the most at peace here. I could come here and just breathe. Take my time to work out my thoughts." She sighed, clasping her hands before her demurely.

"I had one of those…a platform high above the Fright Zone… actually it was Catra's hideout first. Then it kinda became our special spot." Adora admitted, as she stood companionably beside Mara. Relishing finally having all the time she wanted to connect with the previous She-ra…her mentor…her hero. Appreciating these moments shared between them. Of all the people on the planet…Mara understood the pressure of being She-Ra. With a grunt, Adora pushed aside all the stress and anxiety that weighed upon her in the real world.

She would have never been able to do that a few years back, so caught up in the war and the crushing responsibility that was She-Ra. Even now, she had so many threats bearing down upon her. But she refused to give those unknowns any control over her. She had learned to be selfish at least a little, since the war ended. She would not taint this time with Mara, by rushing it or being distracted by her anxieties over what tomorrow may bring.

She was here to find her answers…however long it took, however painful the truth might be. She was resolved to see this journey through to its end.

"I guess we should start from the beginning then?" Mara reasoned, as she waved a hand over the landscape. It instantly fades to black, leaving them both in the void.

“I was born on the planet Primus…a colony world of Eternia. The Tri-Solar system was not the First Ones home. But a refuge our ancestors had retreated too to escape the Horde. It was thousands of years later, before our deep space Watch Tower”s. Began to transmit warnings of Horde ships approaching. The escalating threat of the Galactic Horde encroaching on the edge of our new galaxy. That was to be our sanctuary… It drove our Galactic council to seek new sources of energy, to try and figure out how to weaponize our magic. To explore beyond the two planets we first colonized, desperate to find more ways…to protect our people. We increased our exploration, seeking out new resources, new sources of magic…Finding Krytis and then Etheria.”

The memory began, shortly after Adora had left the last time. Her invisible spirit floating within this vision from Mara’s past. As the young brunette guided the cart, pulled by the leathery beast down a small hill towards the lush valley below. Sitting on the bench at the front of the cart, wearing a simple tan tunic and dark beige pants and leather boots. With the dusty blonde twins walking and bantering on either side of the cart. Wearing the same simple style of tunics and dark pants and boots.

The warm blue of the afternoon sky slowly turned into the brilliant glow of sunset. Just as the three approached a farmstead, nestled at the bend of the wide river that ran through the valley. Traveling down a narrow carriage path, lined with trees. That gently curved towards a large farmyard. That was surrounded by miles and miles of green grass and freshly tilled fields. The sunset was brilliant on the horizon beyond the flat fields. The wide open sky looked as if it was set on fire.

Farmhands were finishing up the daily chores. Laughing and joking as they were tending the livestock. Feeding pigs in the

pens around a large two story, wooden barn. Or herding the chickens into the little hen house for the night.

As they entered the farmyard. The plaintiff baying and angry snorts, or indignant clucks floating through the air.

It was a pleasant, comforting sound to Mara, she closed her eyes briefly, a small nostalgic smile pulled upon her lips. As Adora glanced over to her, with a soft, tender smile of her own. Adora had sat her spirit down upon the bench beside Mara earlier that day. Sharing the warm embrace of the afternoon sun and peaceful ride through the valley. As her soul blended with Mara's slowly becoming one. Living these moments with as much clarity as her predecessor.

Mara guided the cart up towards the large two story farmhouse with a wide wrap around porch. She couldn't help but heave a sigh of relief. It had been many days of travel, for them to go all the way to the Capital City of Onnor. Then back to the province of Terra. Mara did not find the journey unpleasant, since she was accompanied by her two cousin's. Dare and Vikor, who were good company usually. Yet with them, trouble was also a steady companion. Journey's were never uneventful and definitely not boring, that's for sure. They had not lingered in the interstellar market long, gathering the tech components for repairing the machinery and the general supplies the farm needed for the growing season ahead. Then headed out within a day. They only got sidetracked briefly, in a well known tavern on the way out. A somewhat rowdy den of merchants, mercenaries and adventurers. It also had a wide selection of entertainment as well. Ranging from Bards and Minstrels within the main banquet room. To smaller rooms filled with various games of chance. Or one could retreat to the rooms on the floor above. Where one could pay for more carnal games.

Mara glanced sideways at Dare, giving him a rueful smile. He was easy on the eyes and he knew it, also a huge flirt. Which usually got him into trouble when alcohol was involved. With a heavy sigh, she turned to regard his brother Vikor. Now sporting a black

eye and a small cut above his right eyebrow, from the brawl they got involved in. Thanks to Dare's insufferable charm.

"Mara, Dare, Vikor…it is good you have arrived!" A middle aged woman, in a simple tan sundress and apron. With long dark hair, streaked with gray. Running down her back in a thick braid, similar to Mara's. Quickly stood from a wicker bench on the wrap around porch of the farm house, when they reached the end of the carriage path.

"Mother?" Mara was quick to hop down from the cart bench and mount the steps. Catching the urgency in her mother's voice.

"Come, come….we have a visitor." She beckoned, opening the screen door and rushing inside.

Mara paused on the last step before the porch and looked over her shoulder at her cousins with concern. Dare merely shrugged, walking past her. While Vikor gave her an affirming pat on the shoulder before following his brother inside. Mara was the last to enter the house. They never got visitor's? Strangers in the valley were a bad omen. She heaved another great sigh, her eyes hardening with resolve as the screen door closed behind her with a soft creak.

Adora was quickly enamored by the rustic charm of the farm house. The main living room was not very large, with the front wall taken up by a large window. The other walls are decorated with framed pictures of Mara, Dare and Vikor growing up. The twin's had joined the family as small children, after the death of their mother. Their father had died before they had even been born. They were only a year older then Mara, but had always treated her like their little sister. Always acting like they were in charge and seeking to protect her, as if she was incapable of it! It was a sibling dynamic Mara found frustrating because most the time, she had to take charge and care for both of them! Since she

possessed the more level head and was not swayed by passion or fury like her cousins.

A large field stone fireplace took up one wall, the mantle built from the twisting horns of some large animal. With a plush green couch and matching armchairs. A squat oval coffee table,of polished mahogany. Decorated with a large white doily sat in front of the furniture. With a vase of brightly colored flowers, the elegant wide petal's shimmer in the pale light of evening. As if the dew that was still upon them were powered by magic.

A quaint staircase led upward, with a highly polished banister. A long red carpet ran up the stairs, worn down to threads from years of use.

Adora followed Mara and her family across the living room and through a large archway into the kitchen at the back. Which was just as charming as Addie's cottage. With wooden countertops and a stone carved sink. A darker wood accentuated the many cupboards. A black iron stove nestled in a small alcove just to the side of the cupboards next to a simple door. That must lead down to the farmhouse's root cellar. The house had a cozy atmosphere. Adora could feel the warmth and love…those rich feelings had been in such abundance they had seeped into the foundation of this home.

Another large window took up the back wall. With a large banquet style table sitting, with at least six hard wood chairs. Mara was startled to find a Galactic Guard from Eternia sitting at the table. His long power staff leaning against the back wall and an energy blaster attached to his belt. Dressed in the streamlined designed, pale white armor of the space fleet. His mirrored visored helmet sitting on the table top. With the elite crest of Grayskull etched upon the side in smokey gray.

As they approached, he stood up. He was at least as old as her parents, perhaps older? He had a deep blue eye, like the color of a stormy ocean. The other eye was covered by a black leather eye patch. He wore the heavy scowl of a warrior, who had already

survived far too much bloodshed. His square jaw was covered in a bristly blonde beard, peppered with gray. Pale blonde hair that was close to platinum was tied back into a ponytail with twin braids that hung on either side of his thick neck, curving across massive shoulders. At least six feet tall, with broad shoulders and a barrel chest. A huge man by Primus standards, of well packed muscle. Which made him obviously an Eternian.

"Remember last spring, when the Galactic Council decreed. All children over the age of sixteen had to submit to a blood test?" Mara's mother began sourly.

Mara and the twins turned back to her with reserved frowns. As the front screen door slammed. Followed by the crescendo of heavy boots. As Mara's father came thundering into the small kitchen at the back of the house.

"I refuse to give them my daughter!" He shouted, his dark brown eyes burning with fury. He was a burly man, with a bald head. Dressed in a tan button down shirt with the long sleeves rolled up tight, revealing his huge arms. Thick black suspenders were holding up his pants and his heavy boots were crusted with mud from the animal pen's. Mara's mother glanced down at the tracks he had made throughout the house with silent disapproval.

As Mara's silver eyes widened in alarm, she had no idea what the blood test had been about but her parents were not given a choice in the matter. She had not been given a choice. It was either obey the council's order's or suffer the consequences. The Galactic council had already made an example of the Western continent of Primus, known as Opal. When their people refused to accept the mandates to test their young adults last year. By imprisoning the leader's of the rebellion on one of the First Ones' prison moons. Then sending several battalions of Galactic Guards to ensure the populace's compliance. Snuffing out any kind of resistance before it could even begin to grow. So the rest of the planet had meekly obeyed.

“What’s going on?” Mara was scared, her heart was beating hard in her chest.

“I have been sent to escort Mara to the Galactic Council. ” The Guard stated.

“What…Why?” Dare spat, standing taller with a challenging glare towards the guard.

“You’re not taking Mara, anywhere!” Vikor took a threatening step forward, blocking Mara slightly.

“I am not at liberty to say.” The Guard shot back, towards Dare. Quickly losing his patience as he now felt threatened. His left hand strayed to the hilt of his blaster, keeping a close eye on Vikor.

“Hold! We are a peaceful people!” Mara’s father interceded, pushing himself between the Guard and his nephews.

“Eternia has no jurisdiction here!” Mara’s mother shouted, indignantly. “Primus is an independent colony, and has been for over a hundred years!”

“The galactic horde is growing more powerful every year…it has been conquering the outer planets and their armada is moving inward as we speak! If you want to remain free, then you need to fight!” The Guard declared, “Your daughter will be coming with me either peacefully or by force. The choice is up to you?” The soldier moved with purpose then, reaching for his power staff and spinning it towards them. The ends glowed a vengeful red as a threatening hum began to vibrate throughout the room.

“Ok…ok…ok..” Dare pushed in front of his brother who had his fists up, arms coiled to strike. “Let's all settle down…you can’t tell us why. Then where are you taking her?” He inquired, his radiantly charming smile firmly in place.

“To the Enos moonbase…for military training… then she is to take a transport to Etheria.” He answered, unable to resist Dare’s

unthreatening, easy charisma.

Dare glanced over his shoulder, giving Mara's parents and his brother a firm look to back down and let him handle this diplomatically.

Vikor growled and lowered his fists, while Mara's parents wilted slightly. They could not fight a decree from the Galactic Council… they were just simple farmers they had no power…

"Etheria?" Mara's father muttered, he had never heard of that planet. Mara's mother had gone pale and her eyes filled with tears. Their only child was going to be stolen from them and they would never see her again.

The Guard groaned and rolled his eyes. He was not a cruel person and this mission was closer to kidnapping than anything.

"Your daughter was chosen…to become Etheria's Champion…she will help protect us all from Prime." The Guard answered, his gaze was unwavering towards Mara. Full of awe and respect. Seeking to soothe her parent's worry with the truth.

Mara's mother nodded and ushered Mara out of the kitchen and up the stairs to her bedroom to pack. Mara looked scared, but refused to break down in front of her mother. Her eyes had slowly hardened with a firm resolve… as she helped her mother pack her bags. Whatever awaited her on Enos…on Etheria she would meet head on. Her parents had raised her to be resourceful, resilient and above all compassionate. Little did she know that those traits would serve her well in the hard years ahead.

"She will be able to send communication's home anytime." The Guard offered with a slowly wilting smile towards Mara's father.

Who wore a very disgruntled scowl, growling in acknowledgment as he folded his arms over his chest.

The vision turned black. Adora stood within that timeless void she had come to know so well. A soft golden glow, hummed before her as Mara took shape. Dressed in her common clothes. Of soft blue pants with a powder blue tunic and white leather skirt and leather pauldrons. The purple leather neckband and matching gold and brown leather cone atop her head that held her braid and the golden bulb adorning the bottom. Along with the golden headpiece, so similar to Scorpia's. This was the Mara she knew, many years older now. Her eyes are no longer innocent and pure, but fierce and determined. She had endured far too many years as a living weapon for Eternia's War Machine. Bearing witness the brutality and needless bloodshed upon Etheria's soil. As the First Ones sought to control the masses and harness the magic for themselves.

"I was presented before the Galactic Council…" An image of several faceless shadows sat on throne like chairs, upon a high dais. The starscape as a timeless backdrop behind them. Adora could feel Mara's fear as the Galactic Guard ushered her before the Council, as if she was a prized animal before inspection. "Then I was taken from the Council chambers on the Enos Moonbase, to the communication center. Where I was introduced to the four Senator's who governed our colony worlds." Mara continued, as an image of her standing in a large sterile command room before a wall of monitors. Where the stern faces of three old men and one woman stared back at her. They were all dressed in fine clothes, all wearing similar suits of state. "Senator Keldor was my superior, he was the Planetary Facilitator of Etheria until Light Hope came online." Mara finished, as her year of grueling, military training began to scroll past. The harsh, unyielding days of being conditioned to be a soldier. As they broke her down, instilled a sense of duty, of purpose to the First Ones cause. Rebuilt her to obey and not question order's. It was hard for Adora to witness, as that same merciless conditioning had been her childhood.

But it wasn't all bad, Mara also made close friendships with several of the other cadets. As they shared in both their achievements and failures, as the year of training progressed. During that time she had also gotten close to the old Guard who

had taken custody of her. Dekker was also currently stationed on Enos. As the Commander of the Primus unit of Grayskull Squadron. A company of elite tactical teams, stationed on all four of the core planets. He sought to mentor Mara and took care of her in all the ways a father would. She grew to care for him, her friends in the barracks and also the member's of Grayskull Squadron stationed on Enos. Who were all older, battle hardened Soldiers at the time. Who saw her like a little sister, always looking out for her, teaching her how to be a better soldier.

Adora smiled fondly as the memories passed. Also having a deep understanding of the sibling bond when living in the barracks and sharing both hardships and victories with your bunkmates. Her easy, caring relationship with Dekker, made her kind of jealous. But she quickly pushed those negative emotions aside, her issues with her upbringing in regards to Shadow Weaver would not taint Mara's memories.

"Within a few months, my cousin's Dare and Vikor would be 'honored' as well. Becoming the Champion's of both Eternia and Primus….It would take me several more years to uncover the truth of what we really were…and Champion's we were not." Mara glowered down at her hands, her eyes haunted by the blood she could still see upon them.

"I was taken to Arxia for Planetary Orientation. Where I was introduced to Etheria's operating system, Light Hope." Mara began, as the memory of her younger self, standing before a command deck similar to Darla's, on Arxia. Came to life around them. She was dressed in common clothes of a gray tunic and dark pants. With simple leather shoes and a coin pouch latched around her waist.

A small lavender communication orb hovered over the silver panel. As a different soldier in similar light infantry armor. Stood beside Mara's younger self, hands poised over the controls.

"She was in the first stages of development back then, as we had yet to hard wire the planet to the Super Computer. It would take

many more months for her to come fully online as the Planetary Facilitator. " Mara stated, as the memory shifted. To one of her standing before the three crystal pillar's that will one day hold the FailSafe.

"I was also bonded to the Sword of Protection." Mara released a slow, painful breath as a shiver of disgust ran over her. Finding it hard to relive this memory, so filled with shame and regret that she had just blindly followed her order's. Not comprehending that she had signed her death note that day.

A group of technicians and a single scientist in a white lab coat. Where hovering before the pillars, glancing at data pads. As Mara mounted the steps, staring nervously at what lay within. The Sword of Protection was embedded in the middle of the dais between the three crystals. Adora could feel Mara's fear and excitement warring inside of her as she cautiously entered the pillars.

"You will touch the sword, so that you can sync your DNA with the Rune Stone. Then choose an activation phrase to instruct the Rune Stone to infuse your body with its magic." The head Scientist instructed.

Mara nodded, took a deep breath, then thinned her lips with resolve. Her hand was shaking as she reached out and touched the tip of her fingers to the end of the hilt. The hilt flashed, a biting sensation exploded through her fingers, then the sudden weakness of being drained of blood as if she had just been wounded. Adora cringed, remembering the same painful sensation when she first touched the sword. But this time, Adora was witnessing the bonding first hand. She flinched in horror as she watched thin streams of blood. Trickling down from Mara's fingertips, spiraling down the curving golden hilt towards the crossguards. Until her blood touched the blue gemstone in the center, coating it red. Mara's mouth hung slack, eyes glowing an electric blue as she was entranced by the magic. Adora remembered how the sword had spoken to her in Light Hope's

voice…she wondered if it was the same for Mara? Wondered what vision's she had been shown?

Suddenly Mara screamed as the Control Pillar's began to glow with First Ones glyphs. Her hand instinctively grasped the hilt and held tight. As divine lighting crackled and arced all around her. Her body ascended into the air, as she held the ornate, golden hilt of the Sword of Protection. Carrying the sword up with her, holding it with both hands against her chest. The Portable Rune Stone embedded in the cross guard was humming, the glow deep inside the stone intensified as her eyes began to glow a solid white. As Sheana's magic was shackled to her soul.

Adora cringed in pain and averted her eyes, as Mara's screams of agony echoed over the cavernous chamber. She understood the unbearable pain Mara was going through and struggled to be witness to it again. Absorbing the Fail Safe code into every cell in her body, had felt like being flayed alive! As if her skin was being shredded to allow the code to enter her body. It had been the most excruciating pain, like thousands of needles striking her all at once all over her body.

"For the Honor of Grayskull!" Mara shouted to the heaven's, thrusting the sword above her head. The whole room went white, as her first transformation took form. Massive waves of magical power, crashed outward from inside the pillars. As the technicians and the Scientist cried out in alarm and shielded their eyes.

Adora grinned, finally understanding why she had to call out that phrase to activate She-Ra. Mara had always strove to honor Dekker and the good friends, who always had her back. The found family she held so dear.

"But when I first arrived, I was also met by …Senator Keldor. At the time he was the Planetary Facilitator. Over seeing all our military bases, scientific laboratories and our civilian settlements. As the First Ones expanded all over the planet. Harvesting all manner of resources, from mining star seeds and metal ore for powering and building our ships and tech. To grains and livestock

to feed our other planetary colonies. Our scientists had been studying how Magic worked here for more than a decade, in an isolated laboratory. Far from the mainland on the Growling Sea. "

Adora shuddered knowing exactly what nightmare place she was talking about. Mara grimaced and nodded. "The scientists' work had not started out that way. They had the best intentions at first, but their research became weaponized as the threat of Horde Prime became more urgent. Their research subjects got out of control…and had to be abandoned. In time the island became a dumping ground for hazardous materials and corrupted tech. " Mara sighed heavily.

"Becoming Beast Island." Adora finished, as Mara nodded sadly.

"I want you to tell me about Omega Prime." Adora demanded, her stern expression softening. As she watched silent tears of regret fall down Mara's cheeks,as her eyes became distant and haunted.

"I will show you…in time…Adora…it is one of my biggest mistakes." She answered in a broken whisper, barely able to maintain control and not break down.

Adora reached out and drew her in, comforting her in a gentle hug. Giving her mentor the moment she needed to gather herself. It took Mara only a few minutes to calm down and begin her tale again. Slowly, drawing away. She offered Adora a small, grateful smile.

"So Keldor took me under his wing, taught me all about Etheria. I would eventually be stationed in the Whispering Woods at the Beacon, known now as Crystal Castle. To be trained…and secretly controlled by Light Hope. But first Keldor paraded me about the planet. Professing to the Etherians that I was their savior, their champion. That only I could protect them from the threat of the Galactic Horde."

Adora took a moment to take in the memory of Mara's first meeting with Senator Keldor. As he shook Mara's hand, within a vast shuttle bay. The bay doors were open, the hum of transports flying outside vibrating through the cavernous room. Several bulky supply cruisers were already parked inside, being unloaded by military personnel. Wearing the space armor of the Eternia Space fleet. Senator Keldor on the other hand was in a fine tailored suit, with a black leather cape. Pinned to the shoulders of his purple suit jacket with silver goat skull pendants. An older, tall, well built Gar. His skin had a grayish blue hue. He was very muscular, with broad shoulders and thick legs and arms. With a head of dark hair, that hung low over his pointed ears, that was slightly peppered with gray at the ends. He had heavy brows and shaded, dark blue eyes. That quickly took in Mara's plain appearance. Dressed as she was in her Primarian commoner clothes. His disappointment, hidden behind a polite smile. His sharp jawline and square face was accented by a small dark mustache and goatee. He had a walking staff with a silver goat's skull as a hand hold, clutched in his right gloved hand. His long, elegant fingers coiled over the goats twisting horns.

"You must be Mara, A bit underdressed aren't we?" He acknowledged with a curt nod and stiff smile. Turning on his heel and walking across the bay. Not waiting for Mara to step in line behind him. His boots make sharp clicking sounds as he strode swiftly over the open expanse of the bay towards the massive sliding doors that led into the Arxia Starbase.

Mara frowned and glanced down at her clothes in dismay, regretting not dressing in her uniform this morning. But meeting Senator Keldor had not been on her itinerary today. So she figured she could get away with common clothes and have time to get settled here in the Star Base. Now she had to dart forward to keep up to him. Feeling foolish and unprofessional.

"Yes…I am." She admitted with a blush, "Sorry, Senator…I just got off the transport and my belongings have not arrived yet from the Elidor Moonbase."

Senator Keldor nodded and sighed. ‘Very well, then let's get you acquainted with your new home. Shall we.”

The older Mara waved her hand over the empty void, casting her memories as if it was a video screen. Another year passed before Adora’s eyes, as Mara traveled over the planet as She-Ra. Visiting every kingdom and people in turn. Some welcomed her with open arms and kindness, like the Plumerian’s. Who were Fox hybrid’s who made their home deep in the heart of the Whispering Woods. Their Rune Bearer was more than happy to help the First Ones and do their part to protect Etheria. Agreeing to bond to the Rune Stone…’The Heart Blossom’ to amplify their magic. The Guardian of Earth Magic had remained hidden the whole time Mara had visited and she was a bit disappointed. But the Rune Bearer had assured her that they were merely shy and next time she visited perhaps they would show themselves.

While the Royal Houses of Scorpania. Offering diplomatic hospitality, with hidden agendas behind warm smiles. Some houses were impressed by She-Ra, more than eager to praise and prostrate themselves before the Champion of Etheria. To improve their house's honor and political standing on the grander interstellar stage. While other houses sought to curry favor with Senator Keldor. In the hopes of better trade deals for both exports of Etherian goods and off world imports. Wanting to use him as liaison to the Galactic Council on their behalf. So that they could avoid taxes and tariffs wanting only to further fill their personal coffers. In the end the installation of the “Black Garnet’ was voted upon by all House Leader’s and unanimously approved. So the Rune Bearer and the Guardian of Dream had no choice but to acquiesce to the governing body of the Scorpiania Kingdom.

Senator Keldor did not need She-Ra’s help to convince the Sea Elves of Salineas. A bribe of installing a SeaGate to protect the Archipelago was good enough to secure their loyalty to the Heart Project. The Rune Bearer was willing to bond to the ‘Pearl’ when it was installed. The Guardian of Water was absent, either hiding,

like in Plumeria or silently protesting the First Ones. Mara did not know, but it seemed the Water Serpent's opinion really didn't matter to the Rune Bearer or the Salinean Elves.

Securing the Northern tundra of "Snows" proved to be more difficult. As She-Ra had to prove herself, by dominating the Alpha Wolf which was also their Rune Bearer, in single combat. It had been a long, grueling and bloody fight within an arena, created by the massive icy coils of the Guardian of Ice. Who's cold, frozen countenance loomed over the combatants as they fought. Hidden up in a barren heath at the very peak of the Barrier Mountains. Senator Keldor had watched the vicious battle, of sword, tooth and claw with a hawk-like vigilance. As he stood on the upper crag with the Alpha's two Beta mates. As the rest of the Omega's crowded over the rocky edges of the health, howling and barking their excitement. As both She-Ra's and the Pack Leader's blood soaked into the dry, cold ground. In the end the Alpha Wolf Hybrid had been defeated, a feast was held in the warmth of the wolves' communal caves deep in the bowels of the upper reaches of the mountains. The 'Fractal Flake' would be installed into a Rune Chamber near the Alpha's Den.

While others like the Magicat Prides of the Serenia Savannah and the Temple of the Sky. Were wary of Senator Keldor's "Heart Project". The Pride leader's were far too cautious about trusting outsider's. It didn't help that both Rune Bearer's Aoi and C'yra disregarded Keldor outright. Refusing to even sit down with him to talk about the future benefits of the "Sun and Moon Stone." Which was frustrating for Senator Keldor. He had already started to erect Rune Stones in every other territory but Serenia and Sky Dancer Mountain. The magicat prides were becoming a thorn that needed to be pulled.

Adora lingered within the memory of Mara's first visit to the Northern Pride of Serenia. Knowing from her long talks with Catra, this was her people.

The heat on the wide savannah was sweltering. The sun beat down upon the tall grass in the wide open field that She-Ra stood in. She had just been dropped off by an Eternian transport craft, the rear lights still glowing in the distance. As it headed back to the First Ones Beacon, nestled in the Oasis behind the rock monolith of the Sunna Stone.

Baobab tree's clustered in the distance, a strange silhouette of twisting branches on the far off horizon. As She-Ra scanned the grass with keen eyes, knowing that the Magicat hunters would be meeting her here to guide her back to their village. She had never met a magicat before. But Light Hope had been instructing her for weeks about their Pride Leader's and social hierarchy. She felt prepared, at least to not offend them. But their Rune Bearer, Aoi… had refused an audience with Senator Keldor on many occasions over the last few months. Leaving him to speak only with the Elder's, which proved to be a futile effort. They would not accept the First Ones offer of protection if Aoi did not agree to the Heart Project. The other Rune Bearer, C'yra from the Lunari Pride, was also giving Senator Keldor the cold shoulder.

Mara was under a lot of pressure to make the Magicats see reason. Senator Keldor's patience was not infinite and the War with Prime was escalating rapidly. So many outer worlds had fallen already. It would not be long before the Horde threatened the core worlds. They needed to be ready to defend themselves! They needed to charge the Heart…that limitless energy source only the Rune Bearer's could create. With the aid of the First Ones and their Rune Stones. This was her last chance to win them over, if she could get the Sunna on their side then naturally their cousin's the Lunari would follow. If She-Ra could fulfill her purpose, she would be ready to defend the planet.

The cool season was wearing on and they were running out of time to erect the Rune Stones. The Great Conjunction…a rare astrological event that only happens every thousand years. Was going to occur within this next year. When all the moon's of Etheria, the planet and Aldarion would all align. All thirteen sources of magic could be channeled into the Rune Stones, the

energy would be unbelievable! Then the Rune Bearer's could sync their magic with the artificial Heart of the planet…creating a limitless power source. They would be able to do so much good with all that magic…She would be strong enough to defend the planet if Prime ever attacked. Perhaps she would be able to defeat him, send his Horde back into the void where they came from.

They would be safe…they would finally be free…it was this hope that kept her steadfast on her goals to win over the Magicats.

She-Ra's eyes narrowed, as a long wooden pole jutted up out of the tall grass a few meters ahead. It was wrapped in stripes of hide, with an animal's skull fixed atop it. Sunstones were shining in the hollow eye sockets, refracting the light of the sun like two blinding stars. Shiny beads and feathers decorated the weathered bone. Dangling in long, dancing chains from the lower mandible. Creating an odd, hypnotizing rhythm that had She-Ra's full attention for a time. As she watched the pole bob up and down. As whoever held it slowly approached her.

Then the sharp warning of her soldier's instincts kicked in, knowing she had been distracted. As adrenaline charged her muscles, her hand twitched, instinctively wanting to unsheath her sword from her hip. As she slowly scanned the grasslands. Wanting to see the hunters approach, to prove to them that she was a powerful warrior as well. Then suddenly four magicats sprang up around her, grinning triumphantly. At startling her, causing her to jump back and unsheath her sword. They were wearing the typical hide clothing of their people, with sunstone beads patterned into their tunics. They had been slinking so low to the ground, they practically slithered up to her! The pole turned out to be a long spear, with a bone blade at one end, counterbalanced with the skull on the other. It had been a diversion, now the hunter who owned it stood before her grinning smugly. He was a fit, wiry male. With a rusty brown coat of fur and a wild, dark mane. His golden eyes danced with amusement as his dark ears twitched, giving her a wide toothy grin that showed off his sharp canines.

“Strength to the She-Ra.” he offered.

“Uh….” Mara huffed, not knowing his name to offer a greeting.

He merely laughed, “Come, come…I wish to return to the feast before my brother eats all the good meat.” He waved her forward, as the other four hunter’s surrounded her. Herding her towards the village.

Adora walked alongside Mara, an invisible ghost to the past. As the hunting party of magicats, led her through the village. The village was large, at least as big as Erelandia. All set up in interlocking circles. The outermost battlements looked out over the wide plains. Constructed of simple wooden guard towers with grass thatched roofs and swinging bridges. Cats in full leather armor walked the battlements keeping a close eye on the grassland.

The next circle was made up of forges, tailor’s and other merchants shops. The buildings were multi leveled structures, of wood, molded clay and woven grass roofs. Each with a unique design to house what lay within. The innermost circle was made up of baked clay and thatch family homes and in the center of the village was the community Square.

Chicken’s scattered under their feet, as the small group of leather armored magicats. Led Mara who was in full She-Ra form towering over the shorter Magicat hunters. Into the large open courtyard nestled in the very center of the village.

Women herded small children threw the square. While older women sat under squat structures made only of grass and long wooden poles, along the sides of the courtyard. Young male and female magicats were busy preparing the feast on either side of the square. A sweet smelling smoke of spiced meat rose from fire pits. The savory scent was heavy in the air.

Children and adolescence crowded around them as they entered the center of the courtyard. The children were offering She-Ra bribes, such as beads or shiny stones for stories, but none dared reach out and touch her. They merely danced around her eager and excited. While the adolescence who stood aloof nearby, were whispering in awe and preening to be seen by Etheria's Champion.

"So good of you to come, Mara." Senator Keldor cooed, moving next to She-Ra through the crowd as smoothly as a serpent.

"Not at all, Senator Keldor. It is my duty as She-Ra to protect these people. They must join the Heart of Etheria project if they are to survive. Every day our people are losing ground against the Galactic Horde. We can't afford doubts or stalling any longer." Mara advised, following the Hunter's as they parted the throng of villager's, headed towards a semi- circle of wooden poles and grass structure. Set atop a carved stone dais in the middle of the square.

Four elders sat upon dried woven grass matts under the structure, waiting for the hunting party to bring them the Eternian's. They wore simple hide pants and were bare chested, except for one female who wore a leather halter top. It had tiny, black wool tassels accenting the bra line. The eldest of them, whose coat was mostly gray, had a hide and wool cloak wrapped over bent shoulders. While the other two males, who were a bit younger, had various necklaces of orange crystal beads hanging low around their necks. Each had grim faces, worn and weathered from age. Their ears drooped and tails curled around their crossed legs. Their various fur coats were peppered with gray.

The children stayed a good distance away, as the hunting party led the two Eternian's to the dais.

The magicats halted their work. As they all fell silent to listen, the children settled onto the dirt before the dais. Eager to find out what the future would hold for their people.

The memory faded, leaving only Adora and the older Mara in the void once more.

"I was completely invested in the Heart project, then. I completely believed all the propaganda I was being fed by my superior's. That I was created to save Etheria…that what we were proposing….with connecting our tech to the planet, to the Rune Stones would enhance the Rune Bearer's magic…so they could charge the "Heart" that in turn. I could use that limitless power source to protect Etheria. I was disappointed and perhaps a bit angry. That the Sunna's Rune Bearer refused to come to the banquet in my honor…but it didn't deter me from my mission. I was still too proud, too stubborn to see the truth. So after the banquet I left the village, refusing to accept that I was being snubbed by Aoi. If she wouldn't come to me then I would go to her and make her see reason. Prove to her that the First Ones were here only to help. That we needed to be a team. That I needed the Rune Bearer's to play their part. So that I could protect the planet…so that we could all protect Etheria together. " Mara explained, her voice was strained with regret and humility. Embarrassed at how pompous and arrogant she had been back then. Her people had placed her on a pedestal, made her a champion and a goddess. Driven by her ego and a divine purpose to confront Aoi at the Sunna Stone. It had been a futile and sobering encounter.

The memory shifted She-Ra stood upon the very peak of the Sunna Stone. Her body glowing with divine light, as the warm night wind howled up from the hidden Oasis below. Tossing her long silver hair behind like a war banner. She knew Aoi would sense her presence and come. She would at least get Ouroboros's attention. She had already spoken to some of the Elemental Wyrm's of the other territories. She felt confident she had been able to befriend at least a few of them, other's had accepted her only because their Rune Bearer had. She had never met the magicat's Guardian's. She hoped Ouroboros would see this bold confrontation atop his scared home as a show of strength. Give her something to start a monologue between them.

It was the piercing wail of a baby that spun her around in shock and confusion. Two Magicats stood on the other side of the stone. The taller male was in a heavy tunic and the hide pants of a hunter. The shorter female, in a long hide dress with wide sleeves and fur lined hood that was pulled up. An infant was tied to her hip in a large kanga cloth. She quickly pulled out a kitten swaddled in a blue hide blanket, out of the makeshift pouch. Handing the baby to her companion.

Adora gasped, as she caught sight of the mismatched eyes of the baby.

"Catra…" She whispered, her spirit which was now linked to Mara's soul. Filled with joy and then melancholy for the tragic future that lay ahead for that baby. Her heart ached for her true love. Who would lose everything and everyone she had ever known…

"Aoi?" She-Ra greeted the magicat as she moved to stand before her. She studied the Magicats face. But Aoi's expression was unreadable, as placid and firm as the stone beneath her feet.. Mara could feel the stone beneath her feet heating up. Which was a sure sign the Oroborous knew she was there and was not pleased at all!

Aoi merely grunted, folding her hands into the wide sleeves of her hide dress. Tucking her chin, against the cold wind howling up from the Oasis. Staring out over dark Savannah beyond the gleaming peek of the metal beacon ascending out of the canopy of the baobab trees below.

"You did not come to the feast…Elder Tyr told me where to find you." She-Ra offered, "So I decided to come to you so that we may speak and you would know that my intentions are pure."

Aoi raised an eyebrow in disbelief and took a deep breath, rolling her shoulders before speaking. "I am sure you believe you are our savior. Destined to balance the planet and protect us from the Evil Horde. But I can not accept that your intentions are pure or your words could ever be sincere. Because you are just a part of their

machine. Do you not ever question the greater authority that guides your hand. You and your people are outsider's, highly intelligent and powerful…yes…but also dangerous…because you can not control magic…magic simply is. "

She-Ra unsheathed the Sword of Protection, a pained stare of confliction in her eyes as she gazed down at the blue stone in the hilt. She had heard the crazy old woman say the same thing. Razz had been coming to the Beacon for several months now and their relationship was the first meaningful friendship she had made here on Etheria. Razz had begun to open her eyes about the magic of Etheria and her teachings went against Light Hope's training, everything her superior's had ever instructed her about wielding magic.

So who was right?

"You are like a child…eager to please and unconditionally trusting. But it is time for you to grow up. To become strong and wise and think for yourself. I will never agree to Senator Keldor's plan…so you are wasting your time." Aoi never gave She-Ra the time to respond, turning on her heel and striding back to the other magicat and the baby. Who was still crying out for her mother, her voice was shrill and desperate. Her wails echoed mournfully into the night. As if terrified, her mother would not return. Adora's heart was breaking, at the misery in Catra's cries. That mirrored the broken, grieving sounds she had made as she wept for her mother. When Aoi had faded into the dawning light, back in their shared dream.

The baby cries only quieting down once in Aoi's embrace and soothed by her comforting purr. All of Mara's counter points evaporated as Aoi merely walked away into the night. Leaving her thoughts heavy with doubt and plagued by uncertainty about what her people were doing…forced to acknowledge for the first time that she had just been going along with the Galactic council's plan not questioning any of it.

Aoi had planted the seed of doubt that would one day grow into the ‘Great Unrest’, Mara’s rebellion against the First Ones.

Chapter Three

Chapter Notes

Thank you Pink Storm and Bitzy Bee for your comments and all those who left Kudos'. I really appreciate it!
Things are going to get crazy...so stay tuned.

"I love Etheria. I love how old, and weird, and beautiful it is. I'm sworn to protect it as She-Ra, just as I'm sworn to serve my people, but…I know we're doing something to the planet. The Heart of Etheria Project…I don't know all the details, but I know it's big. They say we're the heroes, but…I don't know if it's right." Mara, She-Ra of Etheria

Kronis was way over his head. He was sitting cross legged in front of an open panel at the back of the massive, central building in the ruin. Various tools were scattered all around his knees. He had his leather apron on, with a fat utility belt with pouches bursting with components and even more tools. He just sat there, staring at the ancient tech inside the panel…blinking and sighing as his confidence slowly withered away. The crystalline hardware inside this panel was taunting him. Every other panel he had pried open over the last few days was all the same. It was so layered, so intricate…it was baffling. It had taken him a couple days to build a map of the Crystal Castle's technological architecture.He had managed to pull off almost every control panel and power node on the outside. Revealing thousands upon thousands of crystal power cores, multi-faceted signal processors, memory systems so embedded he had no idea how to extract them. Sub-system upon sub-systems, upon sub-system, so inter-connected he had no idea where to begin to dismantle them. The more he looked at the networking layer inside the panel, the more disheartened he became. This ruin was not a simple First Ones beacon, it was as elaborate and complex as Castle Grayskull itself! He was a weapon's smith by trade back on Eternia. Having enough

knowledge and skill to be able to fake being a Tech Master here, in this backwater world for the last year. But he was nowhere near the tech genius Tri-clops was. He had been the only one to ever hack into Grayskull…Kronis was loathed to bring him into the loop. Evelynn had forbidden him from pursuing Adora…only because she was not a part of Lord Skeletor's agenda…at least not yet. But Tri-Clops was just as obsessed with her. So maybe he wouldn't rat him out to Evelynn or Lord Skeletor. His mission was to infiltrate the Tech Master Guild, ascertain their threat and dispose of anyone who might pose a problem to obtaining their goals on Etheria. Such as Entrapta…But he had abandoned his mission… and if that got back to Skeletor

Kronis squeezed his eyes shut, cowering slightly at the horrific memory of dueling Skeletor. How utterly without mercy that Necromancer was, as he had torn his body apart. The skeleton king's high pitched cackle of glee as he watched his dark magic, maliciously rip Kronis apart. It was as easy as a child , tearing the wings off a fly.

Dropping his dismembered body to the barren dirt at the peak of Snake Mountain. Leaving him to bleed out, until Tri-clops had found him and on Skeletor's order's. Rebuilt his body and gave him back his life, on the condition he would serve Lord Skeletor. With his body broken and his rebel soldiers slaughtered, he had no choice if he wanted to live; but to enslave himself to this demon.

Kronis growled, once again he had no choice. If he wanted to control the magic of this place…then he would need Tri-clop's help. But perhaps for now he could keep his questions vague enough not to arouse suspicion.

With a heavy sigh, he pulled out his communicator and pushed it into the heavily scarred hole on the side of his head. That was all that was left of his ear. Activated the device with a couple taps and pulled out his communication pad, from a large pocket at the hip of his utility belt.

“What are you doing?” Liam’s inquiring voice, jolted Kronis out of his bitter thoughts. He immediately double tapped the communicator to shut it off.

Snapping his head to the side to find the young man crouching beside him. Inspecting the open panel with avid curiosity., along with the two clones.

“I was attempting to gain access to the Beacon.” Kronis responded. “It’s been days and now I am even getting worried about Adora.” He lied smoothly, playing the empathy card to appear caring.

“That’s great! Can I help?” Liam was more than eager now. Pushing his face up against the open compartment, as if he could glean anything useful out of the alien tech he was looking at if he got up close and personal with it.

Kronis grit his teeth and crawled away in irritation. As both clones now crowded around the panel as well. As all three of them began ducking their heads in and out of the open compartment as if they were chicken’s pecking as seeds.

“It is full of …different types of cut crystals.?” Liam hummed, pulling a magnifying glass out his pants pocket to help him get a closer look. “The crystal’s have etching embedded in them…” He mused.

“This is very ancient…” The First Clone stated, after he got his first look.

“It’s First Ones tech, brother.” The second declared. “Look at the crystal processors embedded into the signal matrix.”

Liam glanced over at the second clone in surprise.

“Does that mean that they can hold a magic charge…like Spirit’s horn?” Liam gasped.

“Ahh, yes..I see…so rudimentary…” The first one responded.

“What are you trying to do…exactly?” The Second turned to Kronis with a simple curiosity. Neither of the clones or even Liam suspected anything nefarious.

“I was just trying to figure out how to open the ramp, or a door… even.” Kronis huffed, crossing his arms over his chest. The thick leather gloves he always wore made a shuffling sound. “If we can get inside, then we can look for Adora and find out if she is alright?”

“Ahhh…well this is a communication processing unit…you need to find a control panel with access to the operating system.” The second clone nodded, tapping his chin.

“No….this signal access network can work, Brother.” The first clone argued. “We just need to bypass the external drivers…here” He pointed to a data crystal, and then another. “ and here.”

“Ahhh…I see…Then we can route a control program through the communication sub-system here to gain control of the entrance and exit points on the outside of the structure.” The Second nodded in agreement.

Liam stood nearby, bewildered by the conversation. While Kronis' dark eyes gleamed slyly. He had no need of Tri-Clops! It seemed these two clones could hack into the Beacon for him. While Liam could decipher what kind of magic those data crystal’s held. He had three very willing, very eager ‘hero’s’. Who would do whatever he asked of them, all in the name of rescuing Adora.

“Ok, then! Let's do this!” Kronis cheered, tossing the clones some of his tools.

“Right! We’re coming to get you, Adora!” Liam declared, thrusting a fist into the air. As the clones gave Kronis enthusiastic grin’s and nodded then got to work.

The season’s changed, growing colder, then warmer again. As Mara divided her time between training with Light Hope and protecting the First Ones settlements around Etheria. The Rune Bearer’s protected their own people and would be offended if she stepped in to fight their battles. Mara was given a ship and a crew of her own. To aid her in responding faster to the threats of monster attacks all over Etheria. Keldor did not give any more details than what she needed to contain or kill the various creatures. But as the weeks wore on the variety of monsters and the frequency of their attacks were starting to overwhelm her crew’s ability to respond in time.

Recently, the villagers in the First Ones settlement of Alwyn had mysteriously disappeared…the village was untouched, but the bodies were simply gone without a trace…Strange black vines had sprung from the earth and strangled all the trees, webbing over the village buildings…by the time Mara and her crew had arrived the vines had shriveled up and blended into the dead landscape. Scientists from the Galius lab were sent to do an investigation… but the documents were classified. Leaving Mara unsettled by Keldor’s lack of disclosure.

Adora found her spirit on the command deck of Darla. As Mara sat in the captain’s chair, tapping a finger upon an armrest nervously. Keldor had set up a contingency plan for the Rune Bearer’s, as the attacks grew more violent and far more frequent. Installing a distress beacon near every Rune Stone pillar that they could use to call for She-Ra’s help. The beacon in Plumeria had gone off just over an hour ago. Mara and her crew had been up at the Northern Reach, patrolling the icy seas for a pod of Razor Fin’s that had destroyed a fleet of fishing boats.

They could not have been further away!

Several crew member’s stood at the forward control panels. Each one dressed in the streamlined armor of the Eternia Space Fleet. Adora had flown Darla long enough to know, the panel in the middle was navigation. The one to the left was tactical and the one to the right was communication. All of those functions could

be controlled in the Captain's chair as well. The forward window showed it was the middle of the night, the moons were high. But their gentle light could not penetrate through the thick blanket of smoke that had enshrouded the Whispering Woods for miles. As Darla flew deep into the heart of Plumeria, to the primeval tree city of Dain.

The crystal pillar with the red strobing distress beacon hung high over the canopy of ancient trees. A target Mara's crew was heading for, they would be right above the 'Heart Blossom'.

"We are closing in on the 'Heart Blossom', Commander." The communication officer declared.

"Alright, can you give me a visual?" Mara commanded, crisply. Turning to the officer on the right.

"I'm sorry, Commander…the smoke is too thick." Was the reply.

"Fine…I'll go in blind then. Get me over the beacon." Mara stood up and briskly left the command deck.

Adora watched as She-Ra charged down Darla's ramp, leaping into the wall of smoke below. The acrid fumes burned She-Ra's eyes, forcing her to squint as she passed through the murky haze. The intensity of the heat slammed into her as she descended. It felt like falling into an oven.

She-Ra landed hard, indenting the burnt, crack ground. Slowly rising up, she took in the devastation with horror. The mighty legacy trees of oaks and adler's were engulfed in flames. The round wicker treehouses, that were one nestled high up in the branches lay smashed upon the forest floor. Fox hybrids lay slaughtered amid the ruins of their homes. Their broken bodies, riddles with holes as if a thousand spears had rained down upon them. She-Ra stood amid the carnage, reviled by the sight and shaken to her core.

The Whispering Woods had become a horrorscape of flame and ash. Screams of panic echoed from within the inferno. As the

villager's who had survived the attack had attempted to escape only to be lost in the forest. To suffocate and burn along with the trees. She-Ra was quick to ascertain the situation, holding the Sword of Protection before her. Scanning the raging fire for any kind of movement. Valiantly trying to listen through the screams and crackling flames for threats or survivor's. As a Fox hybrid rushed towards her out of the flames, dressed in living armor made of bark, thorny vines were twisted around her wrists and held tight in her hands. A living whip, the Rune Bearer of Earth used as a weapon. Her long rusty red mane that she usually wore free down her back. Was now braided tight to the scalp, hanging low down her back. Her fluffy ear's pinned back against her head, her braid snapping in a counter rhythm to her tail, as she leaped and dashed across the rubble. Her sage green eyes glowed in the dim, half light of the flames, burning with fear and fury. The gentle beauty of her face now hidden under soot and ash.

"Run!" She screamed, as an unearthly roar exploded from behind the wall of smoke.

She-Ra had no time to react, as the Fox was struck from behind with a mortal blow. The Champion of Etheria, could only stand there in shocked horror. As a spear-like stinger protruded out of the Rune Bearer's stomach and she was lifted into the air. Her expression was that of shocked surprise, as blood pooled and dribbled from the corner of her lips.

"Fera!" She-Ra screamed, charging towards the Fox. Sheathing the sword at her hip as she ignited her palms with healing magic. But it was too late, the segmented tail snapped violently. Sending the Rune Bearer's limp corpse into the air, to crash out of view into the inferno behind She-Ra.

She-Ra watched in terror as Fera disappeared into the smoke. Then she heard the low rumble that sounded like the roots of the forest were pulling themselves up and moving. Followed by the powerful tremor of the earth, vibrating below her feet. Aion…the Guardian of Earth was somewhere in that smoke, headed towards their Rune Bearer at breakneck speed.

Then Mara snarled in fury, as she unsheathed the Sword of Protection once more. Her eyes glowing with divine power, as she charged into the unknown beyond the smoke. To confront the demon who had laid waste to this settlement, massacred these peaceful people…and had just killed Fera….right in front of her.

She-Ra's rage evaporated into complete disbelief as she was forced to swallow her rising gorge. Overwhelmed by disgust and sorrow at the demonic abomination that stood before her. A truly horrific conglomerate of beast, insect and man. It had a scorpion's tail, the sharp pincher's of a mantis, the body of a huge cat and the face of a human with goat horns. It looked like a mutated mixture of Etherian hybrids, Andreenids and human D.N.A…

She-Ra gasped, as she recognized the face the beast wore. It was a lab assistant she met on Galius. A young man who had been eager to prove himself to his superiors. The isolated lab was set up on an island far out on the Growling Sea. To study this planet's magic…it now looked like those scientists were studying more than just magic? What they were doing was abhorrent and appalling…

She stared up into the young man's eyes, with both pity and shame. His stare was wild, pupils blown wide as if two dark voids now inhabited his eye sockets. Whatever humanity he once had was gone. The change had been so violent, so unfathomably painful he had lost his sanity along the way.

"What have they done…" She-Ra breathed in horror, but had no time to weigh the morality of what to do. As the beast's tail snapped towards her, intent on piercing her through the heart. She swung her blade, leaping backwards to avoid the strike. The tip connected with the stinger, the crystal blade ringing harshly at the contact. Whatever this beast's tail was made from, it was far harder than the chiton the Scorpani had.

The beast was much faster and far more agile than she could predict, whipping its tail back and rearing up on his hind quarters. Swiping at her gut with the razor sharp claws of its front paw. The

low throaty, guttural howl it unleashed was otherworldly, practically demonic in origin. She-ra clamped her teeth and groaned in pain, as the howl was close to bursting her ear drums. Then she was forced to duck another swipe from the other paw. Before giving up her position and back flipping away to get out of range of its tail once again.

Panting and cursing as she ran behind the scattered debris of several treehouses. That had all crashed to the earth at the same time, entombing the occupants still trapped within. Their lifeless eyes gazed up from the darkness, beneath the cracks of the broken branches of their homes. They stared up at their failed hero, silently blaming her for their deaths. As Mara felt hot tear's fall unchecked from her eyes, leaving wet trails down her cheeks through the dirt and soot now caked upon her face. She took a moment to grieve Fera and all the innocent Plumberian's that had lost their homes and their lives tonight.

All those strange, vicious monster's she had been fighting… killing…over the last few weeks. Must be escaped test subjects…or experiments from Galius. She raised her eyes to the heaven's begging forgiveness for what she had been forced to do. All the lives she had taken with her sword. All the innocent civilians who had perished because of her people's arrogance and complete disregard for life.

How could they do this? How did they figure out how to create monster's like this? She-Ra's eyes darted back and forth in slowly rising panic. As the cruel, unforgiving pieces were falling into place now…and her heart shattered under the weight of her regret…as this was all her fault.

Heaving a calming breath, she squared her shoulders and charged out of cover. Resolved to what she had to do. Just as a fireteam in full space armor emerged from the smoke. The beast snapped its head towards them and snarled. As they leveled their energy blasters and released a devastating volley of laser fire. The beast reared again as the beams tore into its flesh. It howled in agony, writhing and twitching upon the ground. As it bled out slowly from

dozens of wounds, left whimpering and staring blankly up at the stars above. Trapped in the misery of a slow death.

She-Ra passed the fire team, shooting them a furious glare at how poorly they had dispatched the beast. Marching towards the bloody mess they made, now laying upon the blackened ground. The beast was riddled with holes and none of them had proved lethal. She barely paid the beast a glance, focusing on the point of her sword needing to end this. She smoothly thrust the blade into the side of the monster's neck severing the jugular vein. What was left of the young man's face grew slack as he bled out in an instant.

Then she spun on her heel, her transformation fading. Leaving Mara, storming towards the fire team. Her gray eyes were livid, hands balled into fists.

"Not a single one of you is skilled enough to fire a center of mass shot!" She thundered. Most of the team cringed and cowered slightly at the wrath in her voice. While one walked forward, confronting her before she could get close.

The soldier pulled off their helmet, which had the pale gray insignia of a Skull. Revealing a young blonde woman, piercing ice blue eyes and strikingly beautiful features. That left Mara in her tracks.

"Force Captain, Cereyn. Grayskull Squadron, Elidor unit." She introduced herself. "We were not sent in to kill the Mantisaur, but maim it enough to regain control and cage it. So it can be shipped back to Galius for further study. " She sighed in dismay, sliding her eyes to the beast. Then snapped them back upon Mara, her posture stiff and at attention in the presence of a commanding officer.

Adora gasped, she recognized that voice. It was the woman on the recording, Bow's dad's, found in the ruin just north of Crystal Castle. She had been part of the rebels who downloaded the FailSafe into Arxia. She had no idea what happened to those brave

souls, who had helped Mara so long ago? But this must be 'Rebel Squadron Grayskull…at least a part of the team stationed here on Etheria.

The scene turned black once more, as Adora stood before a now bowed and broken version of Mara. She sat on the floor, knees pulled up tight to her chest as she wept into them.

"That would be the beginning of the end for us." She muttered.

As the world around them came to life, Adora bore witness to Mara's life once more.

Watching the ship dock at Arxia to be resupplied with soldiers, scientists and equipment. As they sought to contain the beasts now plaguing every corner of Etheria. Her current flight crew would disembark for some much needed downtime. Allowing her twenty four hours of leave, as a fresh crew came on board. She would spend that limited time to send a communication home to Primus and reconnect with the friends she had made in the Eternian Space Fleet. Where she would ask small, easily dismissed questions about what was going on with the military operations on the planets they were assigned to. Seek to gather as much intel as she could to get a broader sense of what the Galactic Council's intentions were with the four core planets.

The Galactic Guard who had escorted her to Enos, was the Commander of the Elite Squadron Grayskull, on Enos. His name was Dekker and he had become like her second father...her military version. Always willing to listen to her worries about what they were doing on Etheria. She had yet to push the boundary from curiosity to outright treason. But in their last transmission, he had mentioned that what they were doing to Etheria, rerouting the magic, siphoning it, and collecting it into the planet's core. They were also doing to Eternia, Krytis and Primus…building artificial Hearts on all the core planets in the Tri-solar System. It sent a cold terror through her like she had never felt before. The need to know the truth of what the Heart Project truly was now burned inside of her.

She had to make a choice…

Adora returned to the void, finding Mara once more curled up onto herself on the ground.

"Months earlier, just before I went to Serenia on my diplomatic mission to the Sunna. When Etheria was still rather peaceful. Razz had taken me deep into the Whispering Wood one afternoon. Said that there was someone who wanted to meet me. Mara raised her head then, a bitterness in the furrow of her brow and loathing in her eyes. Her voice trembled with remorse and shame.

Adora faded into the memory, as the ancient forest surrounded her. Quickly following after Mara as she scrambled over logs and twisting roots to keep up to the uncanny agility of old Razz. They had been walking for most of the day, headed north, following the banks of the Wailing River up into the highlands of Bright Moon. All the way up into the foothills of the Barrier mountains. Adora recognized the old growth of this forest; she had walked the very same paths during the dream in which she had met Sheana and Despara…

Slowly navigating up the rocky steppes the foothill became at the threshold of those mountains. The dried scrub grass and mossy rocks did not hinder the old woman's bare feet. As she cackled and danced up the steep hills, casting Mara broad smiles and gleeful looks over her boney shoulder. As she led her unerringly up into the steep, rocky crags of the mountains.

"Come! Come! Mara keep up!." She commanded, raising the brush of her broom skyward as if she was a general leading an army to war. Before resuming to use her broom as a walking stick, as they hiked up the barely visible trail deeper into the mountains.

Mara was confused, casting her eyes upward in the slowly fading light of day. As they traveled up a narrow trail, leaving the forest far beneath them. Headed towards a barren heath at the very peak of the mountain. There was a beauty and serenity here so

high up on the granite face of the mountain, it defied the desolate, lifeless surroundings.

Razz led her through a narrow crevice, down into a hidden valley tucked away from sight. Mara stared in wonder, following the gentle creek that crawled amid the forest below all the way to a small woodland lake. That dominated the center of the massive valley. Its crystal clear waters were calm, reflecting the lush trees that surrounded it. As they entered the valley, the dark green embrace of the woodland quickly enveloped them. Mara closed her eyes basking in the timeless serenity that surrounded her. That seemed more lush and vibrant than before, as if this place had changed seasons. Mara stopped dead in her tracks, as she noticed the now warm sunshine splintering through the branches. It was morning…again?

"Razz…what's going on?" Mara called nervously into the forest ahead. Scanning the leaves overhead. That looked fresh, unfurling from their branches eagerly towards the bright sunshine. The sky was a warm blue with barely a cloud to be seen. She snapped her gaze back down when there was no response. Finding the forest completely devoid of crazy old ladies. The forest was quiet, the stillness broken briefly by sudden bird song and the trickling sound of the creek.

"Razz!" Mara shouted, breaking into a jog as she dashed through a thicket fresh with blossoming flowers. The buds that blanketed the ground, in pastel hues. The stem's rising prominently out of the grass, petals fully extended and still glistening with dew.

By the look of them, this was the very beginning of the warm season. But that made no sense! Etheria was midway through the cool season? The leaves were fresh and shimmering with moisture as if a rain had just ended. The air was damp but softly fragrant with the various flowers in full bloom around her. The light and life that surrounded her, seeped into her very soul. Making her gray eyes shine with wonder and a sense of awe at the delicate beauty of this ancient forest. Mara took a long, calming breath. Unable to appreciate the purity of the renewal she

was surrounded in. Her tactical mind was screaming in warning that she had been tricked..perhaps trapped in some crazy Etherian magic she would never escape from!

Having no choice but to wander. The woods slowly shifted, from the robust pines replaced by more thirsty types of trees, as the creek widened into a river. Fat oaks curved themselves over the stream, along with spruce, standing tall behind their counterparts. She passed a huge, willow tree, the lush curtain of leaves dipping into the stream. Mara couldn't say if she was still in the valley, she couldn't place where she was at all anymore. So she kept to the only constant landmark she had, the river. Adora was awestruck. She had followed this same river…in the very same dream…This was where she had met two serpents, one white, one black. That had swam beneath the surface of these waters and greeted Razz's hand as eagerly as two children.

Mara, kept glancing into the clear water, watching the silvery scales of fish glinting beneath the surface. As they raced the current over the kaleidoscope of shiny stones of the river bed. The branches overhead tossed in the sudden gust of wind. Mara stopped, as a gentle voice whispered faintly from the lush tree line on the other side of the stream. Turning towards the other side of the bank, she searched the line of tall, ancient trees and thick river weed. That grew on the other side, for the voice. Her gaze fell on the rough bark of a massive oak tree. A thick bow had twisted over the river, creating a natural bridge. Its many delicate branches dip into the cool water, breaking its surface in thousands of tiny ripples. But there was no sign of anyone.

Mara stood there on the bank of the river, listening to her own heart beat instead. Seeking to calm her mind and temper the panic rising inside of her. Once she had reclaimed her peace and set her resolve to find her way out on her own. Mara set off once more following the river towards the lake and then walked around the perimeter.

Stopping once again when she caught sight of a small cave, set in the hollow of a hillside. A narrow stream flowed from the mouth

of the cave, descending down rocky steps to the lake behind her. The cave was not very large, but she could feel familiar vibrations of magic power emanating out of it. It made her shiver. She had been around a few Elemental Wyrms over the last year. The feeling of timelessness that washed over her was the same. She followed the barely visible foot path up the hill towards the cave. Once more hearing the soft whisper upon the air, but when she stopped to listen she was met with only silence. Once more replaced by the gentle rustle of the wind through the branches.

She had the unnerving feeling of being watched. It did not deter her. When she stood at the mouth of the cave, a warm gust of wind washed over her.

"You are not like the other invader's?" The whisper floated out of the cave. Making all the hairs on her bare arms stand up. Mara held her breath, unable to determine if she had heard words or if she had merely felt them?

"Come in, Child." The whisper beckoned.

Mara took a deep breath and then walked forward, brushing her hand along the rough cave wall as complete darkness surrounded her. A gentle vibration tingled against her fingertips as she descended further. As if the walls themselves were infused with magic.

The narrow tunnel slowly widened, becoming damp as the walls glistened with moisture. A glowing light pulsed deep within the depths. Casting the walls in dancing shadows. Mara noted gold lichen, clinging to blue crystal's that reminded her of the gem stone embedded into the Sword of Protection. As the tunnel twisted around into a vast opening to a huge cavern.

"Hello?" Mara called softly, cringing as her voice wavered with fear. As she approached the bottom of the cavern floor. She came to a sudden halt as her boots splashed into a body of water. Glancing down she found herself now standing knee deep in an underground lake. The water had an electric blue luminescence,

the surface shimmering as if glazed in tiny jewels. The pulsing glow that she had followed began to grow larger. As something floated upward towards the surface.

Mara took several steps back, as a great pearl white serpent rose out of the water. It had no eyes, but a central blue orb upon its broad forehead. Adora gasped in shock, she recognized that Serpent as the one Razz had shown her in the creek during her dream. The central orb glowed with a prismatic light that was breathtakingly beautiful. Both Adora and Mara were instantly enraptured by it, unwilling to break eye contact. Willing to live the rest of her life gazing into it, when a sudden strike of a broom handle struck the back of their head. Feeling rather dizzy, reeling at the sudden assault. Mara reluctantly dragged her eyes away, her soul screaming in protest. To find Razz once again standing at her side, scowling up at her in disapproval.

“Adora! It is rude to stare!” Razz tutted, shaking her head.

Mara groaned in discomfort and rubbed her head. Razz had been mistaking her for this Adora person frequently. She wondered once again how senile the old woman may be.

The Serpent was not very large, perhaps as big as a horse. Nowhere near the size of the other Elemental Guardian’s she had the honor to meet so far.

“Vasuki, wanted to meet you.” Razz inclined the snake. Who merely dipped its head in greeting.

“Pleased to meet you.” Mara slowly raised her hand, like Razz had taught her with the boar. To show that she meant no harm and that she could feel the Serpent’s magic and share her magic with Vasuki.

The Serpent recoiled at the offer, raising its head out of reach. Mara lowered her arm at the serpent's rejection and looked to Razz for advice.

“Vasuki, is the Guardian of Life, Dearie. “ Razz sighed, “They are curious about you and how you possess the magic of their Rune Bearer… but do not trust you.”

Mara nodded and unsheathed the Sword of Protection from her hip. She didn’t know what had happened to the Rune Bearer at the time and was oblivious about how callous and cruel showing Vasuki the sword would be.

“My people gave me this sword, the Rune Stone is imbued with Divine Magic.” Mara explained.

Vasuki lowered their head again, sniffing the cross guard then hissed and drew back even more swiftly. Revolted by the sight of the Rune Stone.

Mara was growing nervous and insecure, she was trying to be friendly and open with Vasuki. But she seemed to only be offending them. She looked to Razz for instruction, finding the old woman looking mournfully at the sword instead.

“I don’t understand?” Mara spoke softly, turning back to Vasuki. “I’m sorry, I don’t know what made you both so upset?”

“It’s not your fault dearie.” Razz gave her elbow a reassuring pat. ”All things in due time.” She nodded, turning to comfort Vasuki, she made to walk forward and give them a pat on the head.

But Vasuki huffed, their lips vibrating with irritation against their purple gums. Briefly showing a maw of small sharp teeth. Then dove back into the luminescent pool, disappearing quickly into the it’s depths. The whisper Mara felt in her mind, was a bleak mournful dirge. She suddenly felt like crying herself and did not understand why? Then a flash, like the twinkle of a star shone amid the ripples of the water. When Vasuki had made a sudden departure.

Mara reached down and deftly picked up a tiny, silver white scale…

The scene turned black once more, Adora found herself before the older Mara again. She stood before her, glaring down at her empty hands.
"I was still so trusting….so stupid." She growled out in shame. "I didn't know what they were doing on Galius…but the scale." Her voice trembled, so distraught by her sin. " I knew from touching the Boar it held magic…and I wanted to help my people…so I gave them Vasuki's scale to study. That was my worst mistake! " Her voice grew loud, as she spat out her crime. "I will never forgive myself…Aoi was right…I needed to grow up and after I fought the Mantisaur…I did." When she raised her head, her expression was twisted into a fierce scowl. Her eyes burning with hate, at her superiors. Who had abused their powers, causing nothing but pain and suffering to the Etherians. All in the name of 'peace'… By the time she found out the tragic repercussions of her blind faith. Mara had made her choice…

Chapter Four

Chapter Notes

> Thank you Pink Storm and Bitzy Bee for your comments. I had to go back and change one thing, the Temple of Bright Moon was suppose to be the Temple of the Sky. Just to explain better, the Elemental Guardian in last chapter was Fera's, Elemental Serpent. Perhaps I will go back and work on that explanation better. Also thank you to all who left Kudo's.

"I saw what they would do, the deaths that would follow. I couldn't stop them before, but I can now! "

Mara, She-Ra of Etheria

[**Unauthorized program detected! Firewall protocol activated! Unable to comply…Mainframe compromised!**]

The monotone voice of the Crystal Castle's interface hologram echoed throughout the cavernous chamber. Both Clones were hunched over an open panel, at the base of the control pillar. Each one had plugged in a data pad and was typing furiously upon the keypad. One clone was trying to stay ahead of the network's communication functions. Rerouting the interfaces attempts to block their entry to the computer core,While the other bypasses the operating system's. While installing their own operating program, with override protocols into the Beacon's core processor, seeking to take over all primary functions. First Ones tech at least ones as ancient as this one was simple for the two clones to hack into. Working as a team they were able to quickly subdue the operating system.

Kronis stood nearby with his arms crossed, eyes darting around the room nervously. As the walls strobed with a piercing red light. Liam was behind him, prying data crystal's out of their housing

with a dagger, out of the crystal formations around the dias. Pocketing them in a leather pouch as he went. Dismantling the beacon's ability to function, one power conduit at a time.

[Unauthorized presence detected! Security protocol activated!...Communication network offline...Power grid failing...sensor's offline...unable to comply...]

The operating system was struggling to salvage control, the monotone female voice sounded almost desperate at this point.

Kronis metal jaw prevented him from smiling, allowing him to always have an immaculate poker face. But his eyes were dancing with triumph,it had taken only a day for his minion's to seize control of the beacon. It no longer posed any kind of threat and he could investigate this First Ones ruin without any opposition. He was eager to gut every treasure he could find out of the labyrinth, horde what he could away from Skeletor's greedy eyes and perhaps one day kill the heartless tyrant. The necromancer's death would be slow and agonizing. Kronis sighed, allowing himself a moment to relish in his victory here and the promise of true power that lay within these halls. Soon….Skeletor would learn to fear him instead!

The next few weeks past in a whirlwind. Galius was soon nicknamed Beast Island, as the monster attacks were traced back to the Lab. Arxia was forced to disabled the island's communication network to the Watch Tower as the computer system had somehow become corrupted. Resulting in the island becoming overrun by all the living weapon's they had created. The scientists were ultimately trapped with no way to escape the death sentence they had created for themselves. But had enough morality left to enable a signal that kept the monster's contained on the island. Their sacrifice saved countless lives at least for a little while.

Senator Keldor redesignated the island as a H.W.D.S. Hazard. Waste. Disposal. Site. Concealing the secret projects that had been in development there, by making the area even more inhospitable to life as a dumping ground and far too dangerous for anyone to ever set foot on the island again.

It was when Mara visited the Temple of the Sky, for the second time. That was when Adora bid her to slow down the memories… Mara merely nodded, fading away. As the ancient halls of the strong hold that would one day become Castle Bright Moon. Washed over Adora as she entered the memory. The majesty of the outer structure stood unchanged from Adora's time. Yet, it wasn't a castle…it was a Temple. Inhabited by magicat monks, dressed in gray leather jerkins and dark lavender, short cloth pants. Hide wraps adorned their hands and feet and each one carried a long staff of pure silver that looked remarkably like Micah's lunar staff…that Glimmer used. Adora's spirit moved through the halls, in Mara's body. As Mara was guided towards her destination by an old monk. He was a weathered and bent cat, with pale white fur and silver ears and an overly fluffy tail. His dark ebony mane was a wild mess, with long silver tufts that resembled scraggly sideburns. That hung seamlessly into the long beard growing beneath his chin. A heavy gray woolen cloak hung off his boney shoulder's to keep him warm. As his long toe claws clicked and scratched the floor as he shuffled along. Adora was completely focused on the familiar yet more humble architecture. As the cavernous walls that were once etched in extravagant motifs remained simple and plain. The window casing once decorated with gold and jeweled accents were simply framed in endless Runic knots. The clear ornately paned glass that once hung in the arching windows of the outer corridors that overlooked the lake. Were open to the elements, the clear mist of the water below was left to waft into the hall. Making the marble floors damp and somewhat slippery.

The old monk led Mara up a winding stone staircase to the upper halls within the forward keep. Taking her down another long corridor. Adora recognized that would lead them towards the throne room. He pushed open one of the heavy double doors and

then left. Continuing on his way down the hall, returning to his daily routines without a single word.

Mara entered the room, impatient to see the occupant that awaited her within. Mara crossed the massive chamber that would one day become the throne room. It was exactly the same except where Angella's throne should be floating, was empty space. Just an open outlook of carved stone that surveyed the garden's far below.

Standing at the edge of the open platform, was the pale, silver coated Magicat with the long raven mane. She was strikingly beautiful, with sharply angled, high cheekbones and a delicately pointed chin. Her bluish-gray eyes were soft, like moonlight. Her eyelids curved in a very exotic way, that was enthralling to behold. Her tall, slender body was enrobed in a pale, almost sheer gown of shimmering moonlight. That fabric reminded Adora of the shimmering cape Queen Angella always wore. Curving leather pauldrons that resembled crescent moon's covered the magicats shoulders and Catra's Mask, sat atop her elegant brow as she surveyed the garden's below. It was made of the purest silver, gleaming in the late afternoon sun. By the time Catra gained possession of it, a thousand years later. It would become tarnished with age, turning a rusty red.

"What brings the False She-Ra to darken my doorstep yet again?" C'yra quipped, sarcastically, as she glanced over her shoulder. Noting that Mara did not come pompously as She-Ra, like last time. Nearly a year ago, Mara had gone with Senator Keldor to the Temple after her trip to Serenia. Her last stop was to petition the Lunari Pride to join the Heart Project. She had gone as She-Ra. Expecting to get the same adoring reception as the savior of the planet, that she had received so far.

"I have come to petition your aid…not as a First One, not as She-Ra but as Mara…we…we have a-lot to talk about." Mara stated softly. Her heart was beating fast, so many more secrets had been uncovered about the Heart Project. Since she had reached out to Dekker and asked him to find out the truth. Within the last few

months, the various members of Squadron Grayskull stationed on the moons of every core planet had become traitors. Leading the movements of rebel factions planetside throughout the Tri-Solar System. That were becoming united under Mara's banner…their secret transmission's encoded with the passcode. "Friend of Mara." As Rebel Squadron Grayskull fought to dismantle the Hearts of the Tri-Solar system.

Krytis had been destroyed by Prime nearly a year ago. There had been no survivors. Eternia was currently at war with Prime, the planet was trapped behind a blockade of Horde Ships. So the rebel factions there were on their own to survive extermination. For the last year, Primus had been rebelling. Their people had gone to war against the Galactic Council. In the end, the Rebel Grayskull Squadron on Enos, had banished the Council member's stationed on Primus, who survived the war. To the cold expanse of space. The Primarian's unfortunately had exhausted their ability to defend themselves. But the free people of Primus had chosen to take their chances when Prime set his sights on their planet..Mara was already mourning the death of her parents and her cousin Dare. Primus was in a no win situation and she wasn't optimistic to think they would survive.

But Etheria still had a chance…she needed to save Etheria before it was too late!

Another Magicat dashed into the room through a side archway. They were wearing the full plate and chain link armor of a Lunari Warrior. Their sharply angled helmet covering their face, the dark lavender tassel fluttering aggressively as they charged for C'yra. The armor was dented and covered in a fine layer of ash.

Mara was shocked at the sight of it…she was a soldier and had seen her fair share of battles. So what was going on? Where had he been fighting?

Since Light Hope had taken over as the Planetary Facilitator, two years ago. Senator Keldor had been able to focus solely on the Heart Project. He was completely invested in making sure the

Project was a success. With so much to keep on track with manufacturing and building multiple Rune Stones all over the planet. He had been far too busy to keep in constant contact with Mara. Which suited her just fine. It gave her plenty of breathing room to plan and execute rebel mission's to slowly dismantle Keldor's precious project. The rest of the Tri-solar system had been in complete disarray, with rebellion attacks and slowly crumbling power structures on both Primus and Eternia. The Galactic Council slowly had lost their control of the core planets. Etheria was in the throes of a quiet insurrection, her rebellion forces here were mostly seen as insurgence carrying out small scale terrorist attacks. To slow down the installations of the remaining Rune Stones. There were also a few skirmishes here and there as people sought to leave the planet. Deluded in thinking that they might find refuge on fringe planets not currently under threat from the Galactic Horde. The First Ones were running out of time and Etheria was still not balanced. Both the Sun and MoonStone had yet to be constructed? With the fall of Krytis tensions had been high in Etheria. Prime's forces were looming, already the Horde had begun to destroy Eternia. In the last week there were rumor's of a Horde invasion force landing on Primus. As the planet's crumbling governing power's made them weak and disorganized and easily conquered. It was only a matter of time before his armada was upon Etheria.

Mara narrowed her eyes, the damage to the Magicat's armor was caused by fire? She knew Senator Keldor was frustrated with the Magicats…with the threat of Prime so close. What had he done? She had been so focused on her own missions to stall the Rune Stones construction for the last few months she had not checked in with him or her rebel forces in Serenia? Cold dread wrapped around Mara's heart and held firm.

C'yra turned to meet the Warrior's charge, eyes narrowed in scrutiny. He was scared, pupil's thinned to sliver's. She had sent a battalion to Serenia, to keep the peace. As the Sunna were becoming agitated as their people were starting to disappear. Soon the four prides would be at each other's throats because

they were scared and angry and did not know who to blame, who to fight.

“What is going on!” C’yra demanded.

The Warrior glanced over to Mara, his eyes wary. Then bid C’yra to the side of the room. Where they spoke softly. The hushed tones of their conversation were sharp and highly charged.

Mara remained polite and waited, but she understood the warrior’s rigid body language and C’yra lashing tail. Whatever the news the Warrior was giving her it wasn’t good.

With a huff, C’yra squared her shoulders and bid the Warrior farewell. Then returned to the outlook, her demeanor was stiff, charged with restrained animosity towards Mara.

Mara took note of how extended C’yra’s claws were, how her tail snapped back and forth aggressively under the layered hem of her dress. She was fighting to remain calm.

“A’ngella..” C’yra called, her voice was deep and echoed with authority.

A moment later a young girl, barely into her teens, with shimmering dove white wings. Flew up from the garden’s below to land before the Magicat. She had long pink hair that shimmered like starlight, fluttering in the wind as she landed. Her face was round with a cherubic innocence. With three teardrop jewels accenting her angelic features, two earrings and one hanging on a thin silver chain, just below her hairline in the center of her forehead. Wearing pale lavender leggings and a darker purple sleeveless tunic. Showing off her flawless soft lilac skin. A leather belt pouch was hanging against her hip, full to bulging with whatever she had been harvesting down in the gardens. Her feet were bare, striking the marble floor with a smart slap.

“You called, Mother.” She inquired, sweetly.

Adora gasped, in shock, as she heard the refined tones of Angella's voice. Sounding so much younger and care free than she had ever heard before. Glimmer's mother was just a child and… the Rune Bearer of Light was her mother!

"I wish for you to show our guest to the dining hall." C'yra inclined Mara with an absent wave of her arm.

A'ngella turned with a tolerant smile towards Mara, knowing she was a First One.That she had come a year ago to petition her mother to join the "Heart of Etheria Project and did not get past the bridge. She knew very little about the politics between the Temple of the Sky and the First's Ones. Only that the Lunari were wary of outsider's and these colonists from beyond the stars were definitely outsider's.

"C'yra…we really need to talk!" Mara demanded, taking several rushed steps towards the Rune Bearer of Light. Who confronted her with such a cold, ferocious glare. Mara was forced to halt her advance lest the Magicat unleash her claws upon her. Taking note of how violently C'yra's tail was lashing and how her ears had pinned themselves back against her head. Mara had been on the receiving end of the C'yra's temper before.

The Magicats did not like the First Ones, unlike the rest of the planet. C'yra had put Mara in her place pretty quickly, when she tried to reason with her a year ago. The magicat had no fear of She-ra, stalking right up to her. Dressed for battle in her light chainmail and plate armor, holding a long morning star flail in her right hand. Her predatory stare, beneath the cowl of her mask holding Mara in her place upon the long bridge that spanned Half Moon Lake to the shores of the Temple. She remembered how a cold fear had swept down her spine under the Rune Bearer's unblinking glare. As C'yra got right up into her face, completely unaffected by the fact that She-Ra towered over her. Arching her head upward to hiss inches from She-Ra's left ear. Snarling that she was a false She-Ra, revealing that the Sword was not some ancient relic of Etherian origin. But a construct of the First Ones. Than promptly turned her back, striding only a few feet away and

blocked the bridge in a battle stance. Silently, kicking her and Senator Keldor out of her temple before they even crossed the bridge to the island.

Mara had left humbled and with even more questions than before. She had once again sought out her answers. Because thanks to Aoi and then C'yra's candid discourse. She began to seek out her own truths. Coming to realize that her superior's had been lying to her from the very beginning. The Sword of Protection was never native to Etheria…it was a device used to enslave the magic and bond it to whomever they wished. To make a willing puppet, who would do their bidding. The true She-ra had been murdered years ago…releasing the magic back into the Cosmos. So that the First Ones could seal it into the Portable Rune Stone embedded in the cross guard of the sword. Which finally explained why, the Guardian of Life had been so revolted and saddened in her presence. She promised that after she figured out how to free the magic she would return to Vasuki and plead for forgiveness.

It had been a long few months of uncovering the truth…after that. Thanks to a friend in what was now known as "Rebel Squadron Grayskull." Who had hacked into top secret files in the Galactic Command back on Eternia. Transmitting secret military reports to Mara, that made her blood run cold. Many decades earlier, during the first wave of colonists. An elite team of assassins had been dispatched to Etheria, to deal with the She-Ra. They had poisoned the tips of their energy bolts with a virus. That the Eternian scientists had developed to subdue not only She-Ra's magic but the connection to every other Champion on the other core worlds. In essence it would block the magic entering its vessel. Weaken the Champion, by forcing them to turn back into their mortal bodies. Making it easy for another assassin to kill them. So the naturally chosen champion's on all the core worlds had been eliminated before the first Colonists had even set foot on the core world's. This plan to control the planets had been set into motion, thousands of years prior. A slow, methodical enslavement of the universal magic on all four of the core planets. First on Eternia

and then Primus..Kyrtis and finally Etheria. Mara did not know who the She-Ra had been. But she mourned her, as guilt and rage began to consume her. She would stop the First Ones…She would free the magic…she would do everything she needed to to redeem herself in the eyes of the Etherian's.

The documentation from the scientists about the development and sealing of both the Goddesses, Sheana into the Sword of Protection and Despara into the Disc of Destruction. Was difficult to read, it had her in tears, knowing that for the last few years. She had been using the Goddess of Life's magic against her will. Another report offered proof as to the real reason for the blood test. She really was a fake savior, the same as her cousin's. Her blood…activated the Portable RuneStone, bonded the enslaved magic to her soul. She had refused to touch the sword, or train since then and Light Hope was getting suspicious. Their friendship was becoming strained…Light Hope had evolved beyond her programming. She had become sentient and Mara had grown to love her. She was stern and logical, yet sweet and rather goofy at times. As she sought to understand humans and their emotions. They had shared so many wonderful moments here at the beacon. Mara trusted her with her life, but had yet to divulge the truth. That she had become one of the rebel's fighting against the First Ones…along with thousands of others who did not agree with what they were doing to the core planets. Rebel's throughout the galaxy who used code names based on the constellations of threatened planets and secret transmissions that bore the password, 'Friends of Mara'. She wondered if Light Hope was capable of being loyal to her over her own programming? Over the last year the Operating system had deleted many conversations she had with Razz and many other situations that had gone against her mission protocols. Valuing her friendship, over logging events that would result in disciplinary action. Keeping Mara's secrets. Perhaps Light Hope could be trusted?

Mara had to come to terms that she was a pawn in some grand plan to control the magic of Etheria. For what purpose she didn't fully know…her superiors told her she would be able to protect the planet. Now she wasn't too sure….she needed to protect Etheria

on her own terms. Which is why she had come to the Temple, to seek C'yra's aid. The Rune Bearer of Light was the mightiest warrior on Etheria, Second only to She-Ra. She also had the largest standing army on the planet. If Mara wanted to go to war with the First Ones, with Senator Keldor she would need C'yra's army to drive the Eternia's military off world. So she was here as Mara now…the Chosen She-Ra of Etheria and no longer a puppet of the First Ones.

A month ago, Razz had returned to the ship to hunt down more sugar for a pie, as Mara had promised to bake with her that day. Again as before the old woman had reminded her that Etheria had chosen her. That she would never have been able to feel the magic, or heal the forest without the sword otherwise. That she did not need that silly device to summon the magic, that the magic was hers to wield.

Mara had found new confidence then, a new purpose to prove to the Etherian's that she was their She-Ra. She could feel the power echoing deep inside of her every time she touched a tree or the ground. She had no idea how to transform without the sword but it didn't matter. She would no longer wear the armor of the First Ones She-Ra. For the first time she felt worthy. Etheria had chosen her and she would never pick up that sword again!

"I have duties to attend to, you can understand that." C'yra inclined with a nod towards the massive double doors at the end of the room. "We shall speak at the evening meal, Mara." Her voice was clipped and thick with authority.

An'gella led Mara out of the room. As C'yra quickly disappeared down an archway, practically running.

Evening was falling over the Temple of the Sky. The setting sun had turned the clear sky a molten red. Mara was anxious, unable to sit down and wait calmly for C'yra. She paced along the length of the table. That sat at the back of the huge, communal dining hall. The hall was on a lower level of the temple, nestled in a domed keep near the shore of the lake. Constructed of mud brick from the lake bed, it was rather rustic compared to the carved stone of the main temple. The narrow windows along the outer wall, allowed enough of the evening light to cascade in fiery beams over the large dining room. The soft, subdued atmosphere of the room did nothing to calm Mara down.

The soft rumble of voices and the sharp clinking of utensils filled the air. As several monks were sitting at nearby tables. Mara was staring at her boots, as they marched over the wooden floor. Hands clasped behind her back and her mind raced from one conflicting thought after another. She wanted to protect her people, the innocent colonists. Who were just trying to carve out a better life here on Etheria. But her superior's had ulterior motives, Senator Keldor was keeping secrets and the members of the Galactic Council stationed up on Elidor, could not be trusted. So she had betrayed her mission. She knew now that the First Ones were hurting the Etherian's. She was She-Ra…she had to protect them! The First Ones colonies beyond Etheria were already falling to the Horde? Would Etheria's magic even be enough to save them?

An'gella was leaning against the wall near the windows, watching her pace. Glancing absently out of the window's from time to time. Her gaze focused on something out beyond the lake near the edge of the Whispering Woods.

The creak of armor alerted Mara of Lunari Warrior's coming down the outer hall beyond the dining room. She snapped her head up, as C'yra entered the dining room dressed in her full armor.

“What’s going on?” Mara rushed towards C’yra with An’gella at her heels.

C’yra’s eyes were fierce beneath the cowl of her Silver Mask.

“I should have heeded the Seer of Fate, weeks ago. When he offered me counsel.” She growled, “Now I fear it is too late for Etheria.”

Mara swallowed hard, her eyes welling with tears. As C’yra continued.

“Serenia is burning…the Sunna have been massacred…and Ouroboros is dead. Your beacon and your Rune Stone have been reduced to ash… I must protect the future.” C’yra released a heavy sigh, turning to An’gella. “Come with me child, we have much to discuss.”

An’gella nodded and rushed after C’yra as she left the doorway. Mara was in shock for only a moment before she raced after them. But both C’yra and An’gella were gone. Leaving her heaving for breath and choking on her anguish.

She had failed to protect the Sunna…

The Temple of the Sky faded into darkness, leaving only Adora in a timeless void. She stood stunned at first, listening to the pounding beat of her heart as it slammed against her ribcage. As the silence dragged on, she glanced around nervously. Swallowing hard as she tried to stay calm and not give into the panic. That the Crystal Castle had glitched yet and again and she was now trapped in this limbo.

“It took me nearly a thousand years to confront the past. I went to the beacon in the Whispering Woods to speak with Light Hope.” Angella’s matured, refined voice echoed from the black expanse before her. It sounded sad, resigned to the consequences. Her

somber tone was reminiscent of how her voice had sounded while talking about Micah, when she had believed he had been killed… and that his death was her fault.

Slowly, Queen Angella wavered into view, as if she was a mirage. Standing before Adora with a ghost of a smile.

"I allowed her to scan my memories, to store them here in the Castle. I wanted her to see what she had taken from me! I did not want the Lunari to be forgotten and I wanted Light Hope to be held accountable for what she did to Etheria." Angella stated, waving a hand towards the darkness. As her own memories came to life. The somber depths of Sky Dancer Mountain surrounded her. As Adora was thrust back into the ancient past.

She remembered this tunnel…it was the route she had taken with Glimmer during her coronation. During the Quest of Queen's that would lead them down to the Chamber of Queens. The air was damp and cool, the walls glistening with moisture. She could hear the dull roar of the waterfall, thundering in the distance. As C'yra walked ahead, her eyes sharp and glowing in the half light. Created by the luminous shine of the crystal formations that jutted out of the walls. A deep lavender lichen grew around the base of the crystal formations. Giving off the heavy scent of lilacs. C'yra's toe claws clicked against the wet stone, as she guided An'gella. Who's smaller, bare feet were far less stable on the damp, slippery rocks.

Adora felt a sense of awe and amazement, sharing An'gella's emotions in these first moments. As they descended deeper into the mountain, her young eyes wide and full of wonder. As she took in the soft luminous crystals that surrounded them. As they entered a massive cavern that was at the very core of Skydancer mountain. Having to step carefully down loose stones of an embankment. An'gella gasped, her mouth opened in amazement and eyes wide like saucers as she took in the crystalline lake spreading out below. Her dove white wing's fluttered, as she heard the roar of a mighty waterfall, crashing on the far side of the water. Her head in constant motion, as she scanned the

gleaming crystal stalactites and stalagmites that sprang from the roof and jutted out of the lake.

“Where have you taken me?” An’gella asked, her voice soft and breathless. As C’yra offered her a hand, helping down the last few rocks to the sparkling sand of the shores of this underground grotto.

“You have been walking in the footsteps of all the Rune Bearer’s who have come before us? I have brought you before Ophion, the Guardian of Light. So that you can be judged worthy of that power. ” C'yra began.

“But I can’t be a Rune Bearer…I’m not…” An’gella tried to argue. But C’rya quieted her with a stern look.

“You came to me, thirteen years ago. As a star, I watched fall from the heaven’s into the lake beyond the temple.” C’yra smiled fondly down at An’gella, holding her smaller hand in hers. As An’gella starred out over the clear, still water. That looked as if it was made of liquid silver, lapping gently at her toes. A timeless energy was humming beneath the surface. Drawing her deeper into a trance, as she began to sense an ancient magic within the buried depths of this underground grotto.

She moaned in both exhilaration and dread. Her heart was aching and beating fast in her small chest, sensing an inevitable farewell.

“I took you in, named you, raised you…you are not of my blood… but a daughter, born from the love I carry for you in my heart.” C’yra knelt down before An’gella then. Gripping both of her hands and gazing up at her beseechingly. Needing to make An’gella understand and hopefully one day forgive her for what she had to do.

“I wish we had more time together. But I must leave you, my darling. I know you will be alright. I have faith that you are strong enough to go on without me. “ C’yra began.

“When will you be back?” An’gella interrupted feigning ignorance. As she valiantly held back painful tears. Forcing a hopeful smile, that this wasn’t goodbye.

C’yra paid her a tender smile, her eyes shining with pride. “I have done my best to prepare you. I need you to lead our people in my absence. When the Great Conjunction begins, bring our people here so that they will be safe. Protect our magic, protect our home.”

An’gella could sense that C’yra was keeping secrets, but she would not understand how painful and lonely her life would become until she fulfilled her mother’s wishes.

An’gella stood frozen under C’yra’s now fierce gaze, her soft lavender eyes searching her mother’s for reasurrance. That she would see her again…when she found only silence. Tears finally began to fall from her eyes, streaming down the sides of her face. Her chest felt heavy as if a weight had settled upon her heart. She couldn’t breathe, stunned and unable to respond. Swallowing her fear, swallowing her grief…she blinked to clear her eyes.

“Promise me, Starlight?” C’yra clasped her shoulders and gave her a gentle shake.

Hearing her name of endearment shook An’gella out of her misery and she nodded. Her eyes hardened with resolve to live up to her mother’s expectations of her.

“I need you to be strong…to be brave…and always remember that I love you. “ C’yra turned and knelt before the mystical lake. Her eyes flashed with magic, as she dipped both arms into the water. The heavy leather gauntlets that wrapped around her wrists, darkening as they became wet.

“Dip your hands into the water, Starlight.” C’yra commanded.

An’gella nodded and crouched down beside her mother. She held no fear, as she thrust both bare arms into the cold water. Far below the surface, a single glowing blue eye stared up at her from

the depths. The water shimmered, as if moonlight shone just beneath the surface.

An’gella was entranced by the magical illumination once again, her eyes mirroring the moonlight shining upon the water. As Ophion linked her soul to the Rune of Light…she would share this connection to the magic with C’yra until her death.

Then An’gella would be given the full power of the Rune…

The scene shifted, like a ripple upon the water. When it cleared, Adora found herself standing upon the far shores of Half Moon Lake. An’gella stood beside her, her eyes firm and resolute with her mothers impending departure. The edge of the Whispering Woods grew at the top of the shoreline. The old growth of ancient oaks guarded the shores. Adora and An’gella were scanning the thick trunks of trees slowly. As they found a man hidden in the shadows of a massive oak. A heavy dusk colored cloak shrouded his body. As he leaned against the rough bark, arms crossed over his chest waiting.

C’yra strode without looking back, towards that man. As the Magicat closed in, a cloud of sparkles shimmered low near the base of the tree.

The man jumped back, his hood falling backward. Revealing a moth hybrid, with a stern looking face and penetrating eyes.

C’yra reached for the dark, polished wooden pole of her Morning Star at her hip. As An’gella yelped in fright. A small creature stood, peeking timidly behind the trunk of the oak. He had a cute round face, wild deep blue hair that was pinned down under a white helmet that bore the emblem of a gray skull. His long pointed ear's twitched nervously, the tips hidden within the mass of hair. That fluffed out beneath the bottom of the helmet. He stared up at them with wide, innocent brown eyes. Dressed in simple red overalls with a heavy pack strapped to his back,

clutched an equally fluffy striped tail to his chest with his right hand. His left hand was hidden in the left pocket of his overalls.

“A pixie?” C’yra sighed, clutching her heart instead of attacking and shaking her head ruefully.

“Loo-Kee…I told you to stay at the hut with Salidin and Aoi.” The moth hybrid moaned, pinching his nose in frustration.

“I…I…I… couldn’t…Alistor…” Loo-Kee stammered, “I have a mission too.” he finished, scampering up to C’yra. Pulling his left hand out of the pocket of his overalls. Revealing a strange, murky blue crystal shard. Thrusting it up for C’yra to take.

Who’s eyebrows drew up and furrowed in distaste. She hissed and her tail bristled to twice it’s size as she recoiled from the Pixie. His left hand had turned dark purple and sickly purple veins were starting to creep up his arm.

“Take that cursed stone away me and my daughter!” C’yra snarled, backing up to guard An’gella. Unsheathing her claws and baring her fangs.

“I…I…I…don’t want it…anymore. ” Loo-Kee whimpered. “It whispers…to me…I don’t want to listen anymore! ” he cringed and danced on his large furry feet in agitation.

“How did you come into possession of such a thing?” Alistor moved forward, pulling a crystal ball out of his cloak.

“My village in the Oasis…was swept up in the inferno…when Ouroboros attacked the First Ones stronghold. I barely made it out…but I found the wreck of a First One’s space fighter during my escape. The pilot was hurt real bad…she…she…she gave me this. Told me that I needed to protect Etheria…that I had to run as far away as I could, keep it hidden…keep it safe.” Loo-Kee cringed, as if in pain. His fingers clenching around the shard. He wanted to drop it, but was too scared that it might taint the Whispering Woods as it had been doing to him. He just wanted to be rid of the vile thing.

“I am not strong…I can’t protect this evil thing…I need you to take it!” He wailed desperately at C’yra as he rushed for her again.

C’yra unsheathed her flail, swinging the spiked ball and chain downward. Intending to smash the pixie’s wrist and force him to drop the shard, before he got too close and then end the poor tainted creature.

“Mother! “ An’gella shouted in horror, coming to Loo-Kee's aid by shooting sparkles from her hands. Into C’yra’s face as she darted in front of the Magicat, to shield Loo-Kee with her body. Grinning down at her hands in both shock and awe to see her elemental magic appear for the first time.

“An’gella…he is tainted by dark magic…there is no mercy to be given…but death.” C’yra attempted to reason with her daughter, who’s heart had always be far larger and more compassionate than her own.

“We are the Rune Bearer’s of Light…it is our duty to lead those trapped in darkness towards the light.” An’gella beseeched her mother, her eyes welling with empathy for the Pixie. Who had been burdened with such a grim task, one far greater than they could accomplish. Forced to endure the agony of cursed magic, as it tainted their body and soul.

Alistor’s eyes were cold, calculating as he snatched the shard from Loo-Kee’s hand. Tossing it up into the air before it could taint him, as he turned his palm that was holding the crystal ball and channeling his magic into it. Making the ball hover in the air over his head just below the now slowing falling shard.

“Charge the Scrying ball with light..” He instructed at C’yra. “We will bind the deep magic.”

C’yra’s eye’s burst into shimmering moonlight, as she raised her hands. Casting a beam of pure light at the ball. It flashed, becoming translucent as the shard then past threw the ball and

was held within the sphere of moonlight. As the shard past threw the bottom of the ball, it had become clear the depths of the shard still glowed a pale, icy blue.

Alistor snatched the shard out of the air with one hand, as his scrying ball hovered into his other outstretched palm.

"I will take this shard into the labyrinth of the Dark Edge where it will be lost forever in the shifting canyons." Alistor advised.

Loo-Kee starred in both wonder and relief, as Alistor pocketed the shard inside his heavy cloak. The moth's hybrid's long, fuzzy ears twitched with interest, as he crouched down before the Pixie. Grasping, Loo-Kee's tainted hand tenderly. His eyes were soft, as he lightly turned the small Pixies hand. Surveying the damage in dismay.

"I can not heal this…" He sighed, offering Loo-Kee a small apologetic glance as he released his tiny hand.

"You will be forever scared by this magic, I am afraid. " He noted, before releasing Loo-Kee's hand. "You have much to explain, Little One." He stood up, the warmth in his gaze turning stern.

Loo-Kee nodded and shoved his scarred hand into his pocket, not wanting to look at it any longer.

C'yra had already said her goodbyes, so she merely wrapped An'gella up in one more loving embrace. Before she followed Alistor and Loo-Kee into the forest.

An'gella watched them go, until she could no longer see them. Before squaring her shoulders and returning across the long bridge to the Temple.

The scene faded away, leaving Adora once more with Mara. Standing in the void. Struggling to make sense of the needless death and devastation that had just transpired in the Savannah.

“My people…The First Ones were on a crash course for destruction…” Mara laughed bitterly. “I couldn’t save them…so I chose to save Etheria instead.” She turned to Adora, with a thin smile of acceptance.

Chapter Five

Chapter Notes

> This is the last chapter of this Arc. Thank you Eva Wolf, Pink Storm and Bitzy Bee for your comments and all those who have left kudos.

“But at what cost, I never wanted to die. I sacrificed myself, so you would never have too.” Mara, She-Ra of Etheria

“Brother, our control program has overwrote the cache.” The first clone declared, his finger’s typing furiously on the virtual keyboard upon his data pad’s screen.

“Installing the trojan driver’s, now. ” The second Clone responded.

“Virtual memory syncing.” The First Clone nodded.

“We hit a firewall!” The Second grumbled.

“How far do we want to go?” The First asked, finally glancing up from his screen to take in the cavernous room. That was now barely lit, the First Ones glyphs on the walls flickering weakly. As the Beacon had been reduced to functioning on auxiliary power. His pale face was cast in an eerie, red tinted half light, as he took

in the aftermath of their meddling. He was having second thoughts, he didn't want to breach the Firewall…he didn't want to delve any deeper, did they really need full control of this ancient ruin? Whatever lay behind in the Mainframe's core memory could be left alone…right?

"Kronis says Adora's in danger. First Ones tech can't be trusted, we know this. By the Light of Prime. It has always been so. She has been gone too long and we need to save her. We need full control of the Beacon, It is the only way to force it to let her go." The Second responded, his voice far more animated and emotional then the First Clone had ever heard before.

"The light of Prime was a lie?" The First clone shot back with a snarl.

"We need to save Adora…" The Second responded, he was resolute that they follow Kronis's plan to the very end.

"Alright." The First clone conceded with a groan. "Cracking the firewall…" he typed a few keystrokes on his pad in resignation.

"As soon as we get entry to the core memory, we can use the Beacon's sensor grid to track for life signs…we can lead Kronis and Liam to her…" The Second Clone nodded, confident they were doing the right thing. As he returned his attention to his screen.

The scene faded to black and Adora was once more standing in the void with Mara. Who looked exhausted and incredibly sad.

"I had made my choice…" Mara's voice was barely a whisper and it trembled with unbelievable grief. Knowing that in the following weeks, she would lose everything…her family, her friends, her… life.

"In the months that followed, Senator Keldor and the survivor's of Ouroboros' attack on the Beacon in Serenia were relocated to Arxia. I already had soldier's who were loyal to me, former crew members of my ship who had seen first hand the atrocities that we were committing all over Etheria. They were keeping close tabs on Keldor and the order's coming in from the member's of the Galactic Council up on the Elidor Moonbase. While C'yra had disappeared… An'gella had taken over the temple and allowed the Moonstone to be constructed….but with the Sun Stone destroyed and so many of the other Rune stones in various stages of construction. The planet could never be balanced. So it honestly made no sense for her to comply with Keldor's plan? When I confronted her about it…she just said that she was doing it to save the future….I never understood what she meant. Until the Heart fired and reality shattered….as I transported the planet into Despondos and we met for the first time. I was given a glimpse of what the future of Etheria would look like…without the Rune Stones to store a portion of the elemental magic away from the Heart during Etheria's time trapped in Despondos. Without the Rune Stones the princess would never have had the power to fight Hordak and hold the Horde at bay. The first Princess Alliance would never stand a chance…Hordak conquered Etheria…and… " Mara's voice faltered as she looked up, her silver eyes shining with a bleak understanding of a nightmare world that could have easily come to pass, if it wasn't for An'gella's intervention. Adora nodded with a grim expression of her own, remembering that brief moment inside the portal reality where she had seen Mara standing in front of the Crystal Castle. As she struggled to survive a chaotic and twisted version of her own reality, that was currently imploding all around her.

“It all started at Beast Island.” Mara began, as Adora was thrown into her memories once more.

Mara and her crew had taken matters into their own hands. As the Beast of Beast Island, began to threaten all life on the planet. Black tendrils had erupted out of the ground all over Etheria, strangling the life out of every living thing. From the trees of the Whispering Woods, to the animals who roamed within. The inhabitants of Hybrid and First Ones settlements were disappearing every day. They were disobeying orders, as Senator Keldor had wanted them to focus on helping the other combat teams eradicate the tendrils. But she couldn’t do that, it was a futile effort. She needed to contain or destroy the source of those tendrils.

She had confided in Light Hope soon after leaving the Temple of the Sky, many weeks ago. They had had a long heartfelt conversation, in which Mara had told her everything. About the First Ones meddling with the magic of the other core planets, the biological weapons they unintentionally released upon Etheria. The murder of the original She-Ra, the enslavement of the goddess of life…Sheana within the Sword of Protection. She confessed so many things to her. From being a rebel, to how much her friendship meant to her, how she trusted her completely….how she had come to… love her. Light Hope had been relieved to find out the real reason that Mara had pulled away. That she trusted her, confessing that even though her emotional programming was limited. She cared deeply for Mara as well….and perhaps she loved her too. She promised that she would alway look out for her.

Light Hope had been covering for the rebels for weeks, now. The effort for her to fight against her programming was monumental but she did it. Never telling Mara or the other rebels how difficult it was. She believed in Mara, and the good she and her crew were doing to help Etheria. She had become so much more than just an operating system. She was their friend. Mara and her crew trusted her to always have their back. Light Hope would protect them… she would protect Mara.

Mara once again sat in the command chair, dressed in the light, military armor of a Galactic Guard. With Light Hope hovering at her side. A power staff was leaning against the back of the chair. Mara glanced down at the utility belt she now wore with an energy pistol magnetic locked to its holster. She adjusted the angle of the grip as she stood up, to make sure it would be quick to release when she would inevitably need it. Lightly tapping the containment collar hooked on the other side of her belt. She had not idea what they were going to find, but she knew enough that it was going to be some mutant creature. Its genetics, weaponized to kill…on a massive scale. She was going into this battle blind, but she had two options…kill it or contain it…she would make her decision when they found it.

"We will be over Beast Island in a few moments." An officer standing at the communication panels stated.

Mara nodded and turned expectantly to Light Hope.

[I have masked our tracking signal, tagged it to another tactical cruiser. As far as the Arxia command knows. We are currently in transit to the northern coastline of Selineas.] The hologram reported, her glowing eyes distant as she dealt with the constant data coming into her mainframe.

"Good…Thanks Hope!" Mara stood up. "That should keep Keldor off our trail…at least for a little while." She sighed, heavily. Approaching the tactical station and giving her fully armored crewmember a firm pat on the shoulder.

"I need you to scan the island and lay down pinpoint laser fire, I will lead a Fire Team through the jungle and up to the Lab. We do not want to have to deal with too many of those predatory vines." Mara declared.

"I'm on it commander." The young soldier nodded, he turned his head with a nod. The mirrored visor was down on his helmet, with

a holographic display glowing behind.

Mara turned and walked with a quicker stride back up to Light Hope.

“Keep us hidden, ok…Keldor still thinks I’m loyal and I need to keep it that way till Cereyn gets back from Primus, with the Fail Safe code….then I can end this.” Mara declared. Her eyes were intense. A fearsome determination and resolve burning their depths.

Light Hope merely nodded, as she watched Mara stride with purpose out of the command deck.

The gory memories of the battles through the jungle as Mara led her team towards the summit were brutal to see. Her ship was able to keep the hunting tendrils in check, but could not save them from the deadly monster’s who had made Beast Island their home. Most of her fire team had been slaughtered by those various monster’s along the way. By the time they reached the sealed doors to the lab, she only had two member’s left. Their armor was dented and scratched, splattered with blood from the constant attacks. Daylight was fading around them as the gray tones of evening set in. It had been highly dangerous to be outside during the day, with night approaching if they didn’t get inside before full dark. Their death would be inevitable.

“Hope…how are we doing at cracking the passcode to get in?” Mara spoke, taping the communication pod in her ear.

[Accessing…I have bypassed the security protocols and I am attempting to sync myself to Galius's internal network…] Hope strained, voice filtered out into the bloated silence just outside the main doors to the Lab.

The two remaining soldier’s, held their power staves across their chest in a defensive manner. The ends of the staves glowing a piercing red, as they had them charged to a lethal setting.

Strange calling sounds echoed from the corrupted jungle of melted tech and twisted vegetation surrounding them. It was the sound of a pack of agile predator's that had been hunting them for the last half of the day, picking them off one by one. The soldier's turned, keeping watch on the jungle. Refusing to give into the fear gnawing at their resolve.

"Hope!...I need you to hurry up!" Mara exclaimed, her eyes darting anxiously into the eerie canopy of branches for the deadly beasts…that had looked so cute at first. But turned out to be lethal predators that hunted in packs. They were quickly being surrounded!

[I'm on it…] Hope responded….[Go…go…go!] She shouted a second later as the heavy metal doors began to creak open. Just as several black creatures with a single glowing red eye leaped from the branches. They were incredibly fast and agile. Their massive jaw's opened like a snake. To reveal four poison's tipped, incisors and razor sharp teeth. Their bite was strong enough to break their amour and tear their prey apart. Mara had witnessed these creature's over taking member's of her fire team, leaping upon their back as they ran through the jungle. She couldn't save them, getting to the lab had been paramount. So they had to keep running, leaving them to be savaged and consumed.

Mara and her two team member's slipped inside the crack in the doors. As several monster's charged for them. Hope resealed the door as quickly as they got inside. The angry howls and chittering calls of the predator's echoed from outside. As Mara and her remaining team member's disappear into the depths of the Beacon.

The corridor's inside the beacon were dark and foreboding. The smell of decay was cloying, hanging in the musty air of what had become a tomb. Mara led her last remaining soldier's below the lab. Following Hope's instructions towards the core…in which the largest life sign resided.

(So….hungry…)

Mara stopped abruptly, as the whisper of emotion exploded in her mind.

"Commander?" A soldier questioned, as he slammed into Mara's back when she stopped suddenly.

"Nothing.." Mara muttered, shaking her head and clear the alien feelings that had surged inside of her. Before continuing down the earthen tunnel that had slowly replaced the metal corridor they had been walking down. The walls of the tunnel were damp, smooth and deathly pale. Mottled with a sunless green hue. Dark, bruise colored, bulbous knots, jutted downward towards them from the roof. Disappearing into the gloom of the shaft ahead, was a canopy of fine, fibrous roots. That glowed faintly with sickly hues of yellow, green and pale white. They looked very similar to the dark vines that webbed across the island above and most of Etheria right now.

[The energy signature is only a couple more miles down.] Hope ground out, as if she was in pain.

"Hope…are you alright?' Mara questioned in concern.

[I am fine…Mara…nothing I can't handle.] Hope responded, masking her pain now with a confident voice.

As they entered the two mile mark the tunnel suddenly expanded into a massive cave. The cave became more damp, the air thick with the stale scent of mold and mildew. The clumps of flesh that had merged with the earthen walls gave off a faint, eerie green glow so they were not in complete darkness. The unsettling and crypt-like atmosphere of being so deep underground. Put them all on edge.

Mara kept a close eye on the vines spider webbed all around them, as they twitched and throbbed.

"We're getting close…" Mara muttered, her hand reaching for the stasis collar locked on the other side of her utility belt. The ring of metal was warm to the touch, fully charged and ready to be deployed as soon as they got a visual on the Beast.

(Hello….?) The eerie childish whisper invaded her mind once again.

Mara stopped again, confused. Adora swallowed hard, fighting back her tears. Sharing in Omega Primes confusion and child-like worry at sensing Mara and her team's approach. Mara quickly halted once more as the cave widened into a vast cavern. Its walls stretched out of view. Disappearing into the gloom. The ceiling is so high above them, to be nonexistent. She gauged the rapid, sharp decline in the floor. The angle was so steep and severe it could have easily been the edge of a cliff.

"Commander, why did you stop again?" A soldier asked, their voice wavering with fear.

(So….hungry…) The creature was consumed by an endless hunger it could never quench. They had no time to react as a dozen black tendril's shot out of the hole towards them.

Mara leaped backwards, spinning her power staff defensively to knock the tendrils away. Her two soldiers were not as fast and were wrapped up in the vines. Their screams of agony pierced the air, echoing sickeningly off the cavern walls.

Mara could only watch in horror, as the corrosive mucus covering the vines melted their armor. The vines quickly constricted upon the flesh beneath, as the tendril devoured the soldier's alive in a matter of seconds! Their empty armor clattered to the depths of the hole below.

[Kill it!] Hope exclaimed through Mara's earpiece, as several more tendrils shot towards her.

Mara had no way to escape, trapped on the ledge of the cliff. The vines were quick to wrap around her waist and over her left shoulder hauling her off her feet and over the hole.

Mara screamed in agony as the acid began to burn through her armor, biting into her flesh and melting her skin beneath.

[Kill it!] Hope screamed again.

Mara writhed in the grip of the black tendril, staring in horror down into the depths of the hole. Gasping in both disbelief and revolution at the ghastly macabre creature that lay within. A giant wym was curled up in the middle of the hole that had been its cradle since birth. It had a strange elongated face and pointed ears of a Horde clone. It's two larger eyes glowing a brilliant green. Just like Horde Prime…

While it also resembled Vasuki in so many ways, with its silver white scales. The smaller eyes that framed the left eye glowed a divine blue. The very same as the Elemental Wyrms single orb that lay upon its forehead. Millions of black tendrils extended from its body, like fine hairs. Snapping and writhing like the hair of the mythical snake demon medusa.

[Kill it!] Hope demanded.

(Pain….hunger…pain…) The plaintive whisper moaned in her head.

Mara cringed and writhed in the mutant wyrm's grip.

"I can't!" She screamed, consumed by guilt and regret for giving those scientist's Vasuki's scale. She couldn't kill something…that was just a baby…but it was born against its will…the cruel scientists who had given it life…had condemned it to nothing but pain and suffering.

But it was killing her! She had no choice…she couldn't save it as she was now…there was no magic here on Beast Island for her to channel that wasn't dark and corrupted! Mara screamed in misery, as her flesh began to be consumed by the tendril. In a snap judgment fuelled by pity and remorse. She decided to contain it, in the hopes that one day it could be saved. So she grasped the containment collar and tossed it at the creature below. As the metal ring bounced off the top of the mutant wyrm's smooth head she called out the activation word.

"Eternia!" She screamed, with a roaring thrum the collar expanded into a bubble that quickly encompassed the wyrm.

It cried out in alarm then went silent, as it was now frozen in stasis within the bubble.

Adora stood behind Mara, as she knelt at the edge of the cliff. Struggling to take in enough air. As she wailed in anguish, crushed by her guilt…her failure as Etheria Protector. Her armor was dissolved around her waist and across her left shoulder. The flesh beneath was melted and blistered by the monster's acid. Blood and puss began to ooze in the angry wounds. Mara hissed and sobbed, relishing the pain as penance for being so naive and foolish.

“I will fix this…” Adora crouched down beside her. “I promise.”

Kronis and Liam had left the Clones' side as the Crystal Castle began to power down. Their mission was to track down Adora and free her from whatever prison the Beacon had put her in. They had walked down one long, empty corridor after another. Until Kronis heaved a frustrated breath turning to Liam. Finding themselves in a massive room. The corridor they left was one of seven other’s that flanked the wall on either side. Liam was quick to glance into each entryway, finding identical corridor’s heading off in different directions. A giant hole dominated the center of this cavernous room, with three stone pillar’s. Two jutting downward on the other side of the hole and one in the middle, pushed over the chasm. Creating a bridge to the other side. Kronis noted that there were five entrances on the other side of the hole…making thirteen halls in total.

“I think we should split up, kid.” Kronis advised.

“I think we stick together…” Liam countered, as he walked carefully across the makeshift bridge. Reluctant to go off by himself, after Kronis’s dire warnings when they arrived about the dangers of First Ones magic tech, he felt it would be prudent to stick together.

“We can cover more ground if we split up, we have way more corridor’s to search and not a-lot of time. Stars! Liam, we don’t know what this place is doing to her! ” Kronis had been using Liam’s fear for Adora’s well being as leverage to get what he wanted. It worked like a charm as always.

As Liam’s eyes went wide, a new resolve and commitment to save Adora steeling his once nervous expression.

“After our crash course outside, you know as much about First Ones tech as I do. Trust your instincts, your smart and I believe you can navigate around here just fine. If you find her, notify me over the com’s, ok.” Kronis gave Liam his vote of confidence before forcing his command by heading down the nearest corridor. Leaving the young man standing halfway across the chasm, debating his own route on the other side of the hole.

Glad to be free of the young man, Kronis could now explore the Beacon on his own terms. Hoping to pocket First Ones tech he could adapt into a weapon powerful enough to kill anyone who got in his way. Fantasies of power and conquest filled his thoughts along with vengeful images of forcing Skeletor to kneel before him.

Broken, bloodied and vanquished.

His eyes gleamed with malicious glee, he would have his revenge!

Now Kroinis found himself in the depths of the beacon, in a large barren room. The walls and floor were scorched by a massive blast. Chunks of blackened goo clung to the walls and were smeared across the floor. Whatever it had been, it had been vaporized. Kronis bent down, swiping a gloved finger through the goo finding it had a dull green tint.

“Strange?” He huffed, pulling out a glass tube that was filled with small metal bolts. He quickly unscrewed the top and poured the bolts out in his pocket. Then smearing the goo on his index finger into the vial before he closed it back up. Tucking it away into the same pocket of his storage belt he had retrieved it from. Before continuing his investigation of the room, finding a broken mask a few paces away from the blast. He crouched down and picked up the two pieces, his eyes squinting curiously at the empty runestone socket in the middle of the mask. That resembled the same housing the Crystal Castle used for power and data crystals?

The tech inside the housing wasn't salvageable, having melted into an unrecognizable shape. So he dropped the mask and continued down the long corridor ahead. As his hope of finding powerful tech started to fade. Finding the corridor beyond the room was as empty as all the other's.

The scene turned black for only a moment before Adora was once more enveloped by Mara's last few weeks of life.

Mara had made it back to the ship on her own, it had been a harrowing journey and she had barely made it. Not much was left of her armor, dented, melted and scorched beyond recognition. The medic on board peeled off what remained in the infirmary on the ship. Then tended to her many burns as the ship returned to the Whispering Woods. Now she had a bandage wrapped around her waist and shoulder as her wounds healed.

Ever since Beast Island, Light Hope had been acting off. Mara could no longer trust her. She had changed…it was subtle at first. She didn't respond to their banter with the same light hearted curiosity she once had. It was as if the love and commitment to her that once shone in her eyes was gone? Light Hope was constantly inquiring about what she was doing, where she was going? Mara was immediately wary of the changes in her personality and kept her plans hidden. Pretending to act normal as best she could, assuring Hope that she was still on mission. Keeping her command logs vague, she knew Hope was sending back to Arxia.

Mara had no time to investigate what happened to Light Hope, or even grieve for the loved one she had just lost. Mara was in the end game now, she sent her crew away. Those from Eternia or Primus, that wanted to leave Etheria. Where smuggled off world on allied freighters. Hoping against all odds, their families back

home had survived Prime’s assaults. While those from Etheria returned to their villages. They had left reluctantly, but agreed that with Prime’s vanguard of ships poised to attack the planet in a matter of days. they should spend what time they had with their loved ones.

“I couldn’t wait any longer for word from Cereyn but I gave them time. I went to Arxia and forced an evacuation. So that the rebel carrying the Fail Safe code would have no opposition to the Control Pillars. While I was in the Starbase, I destroyed Light Hope's interplanetary systems by severing her link to the Watch Tower. So she could not send the firing signal to Eternia or Primus…so that their Hearts could never be activated. Hoping that when I returned a week later that the Failsafe would have been downloaded into the control pillar’s by then. ” Mara explained, as Adora watched. As Mara tapped into the planet's magic by touching the ground and then thrust her hand over her head. Her eyes were glowing with divine light so bright and powerful it was as if she became a goddess herself. Sending a beam of magic so wide and explosive from the palm of her hand it engulfed the Outpost of Arxia hovering high above the clouds. Turning it into a living island, floating high above. Burying the space port beneath miles of earth, rock and vegitation.

“I wasn’t able to stop Light Hope from activating the Heart of Etheria..but I could still stop it!” Mara declared, Adora cried out in alarm as her soul was catapulted into the chaos of Mara’s last hours of life.

Mara was running down a dark corridor, warning klaxon were sounding as piercing red light strobed above her head. She looked haggard, her hair was wild and loosened from her braid. She was still wrapped up in the bandages from her battle on Beast Island. The golden bauble she wore at the end was dented and scuffed. She clutched her left side with her right hand and dragged the

Sword of Protection behind her. Blood was trickling down her arms from several deep gashes near her shoulder's. (Heart of Etheria… Malfunction…Planet wide evacuation…required…all units return to Eternia.) Light Hope's voice echoed over the speaker's. As Mara stumbled, slamming her shoulder hard, into the wall of the corridor. Her skin was tingling with magic, she could feel the Heart starting to awaken. But she could not let it fire…she finally got her answers about the Heart Project. It was a weapon…and she was the trigger! Rebel Squadron Grayskull was to have smuggled a failsafe code into the data banks, here on Arxia. She would take the Portable Rune Stone into the control pillars and shunt the code directly into its Runic Core. She would destroy the weapon in the very same place it had been created.

A week ago, she had used the magic of Etheria to turn Arxia into a floating island. Burying the starbase under several tons of rock and vegetation. The Eternian personnel had been forced to evacuate. Leaving the Starbase empty, so she would not have to deal with fighting her own people to reach the Control Pillars.

She had hoped to end it, before any more innocent people were killed. But the Seer of Fate had been waiting for her in the chamber.

"I can not let you use the Failsafe." He declared, raising a crossbow, as he shrugged his heavy cloak to the ground. A Moth Hybrid, of pale, dusk colored fur stood before the dais, in plain leather armor. His chest piece was studded with thousands of metal studs. That glint in the half light cast by the control pillars, like tiny stars. He wore matching leather pants with tall traveling boots that were close to thread bare. A wide hide belt with many large pouches was strapped around his waist. He had stern pointed features and wise deep set eyes.That seemed to see far beyond the veil of reality staring straight through her. His expression was fearless, determined and very intimidating.

"Why are you stopping me? This is the only way to stop the Heart from firing…Light Hope has already sent the signal…I…can't stop it!" Mara never got the chance to explain, as the hybrid charged

screaming his war cry. Firing a bolt at her legs, as he dove to the side. Tucking himself into a forward roll, only to turn on a knee and fire at her again.

Mara had no choice, she raised the Sword of Protection to defend herself. Fighting it's pull to transform her as they had fought. He had managed to wound her in the leg before she took his life. Cleaving him through the belly, as he sought higher ground up the steps to the control pillars.

Mara held him as he died, "I'm sorry…but it has to end here."

His final words…had penetrated her resolve like a dagger to the heart.

"You are the beginning…not the end…Adora…you must protect Adora." He breathed, blood gurgled out of the corner of his mouth as life faded from his eyes.

Now Mara was jogging down the corridor, retracing her steps out of the buried StarBase…leaving the Fail Safe behind.

She had made her choice…

Razz constantly mistook her for this Adora…complaining about how her memories always got muddled..between the future and the past. Her and Adora…They were connected somehow? The old woman was ancient; mystical. She understood the magic of Etheria more intimately than anyone she had ever met. She needed to find her…perhaps she would know how to stop the magic from destroying the planet.

Mara stood on the edge of the island. Staring forlorn, up to the starlit sky, taking a moment to reflect. Finding the once dark backdrop filled with glowing streaks of light. As thousands of interstellar ships took off, headed for home. She continued her descent from the southern peak of the Barrier Mountains, taking to a narrow trail that would lead her down into the eastern groves

of the Whispering Woods. Razz's hut was never hard to find, when she focused upon it. The magic of the woods was kind and compassionate, always guiding her to the old woman when she needed her most.

Entrapta was humming to herself, as she sat upon a thick ponytail of her lavender hair. Hovering in front of the control pillar, as she typed animatedly on a virtual keyboard hovering just in front of the main screen. She had spent the last few weeks retrofitting the beacon with all her own tech. Now there were several screen's mounted along the sides of the pillar, displaying columns of data. The main screen in front of her had countless lines of code scrolling across it. A small window was in the far right hand corner, displaying Litha's frowning face.

As the young girl was busy coding on a data pad, while sitting in the command chair on Darla.

"So far the boys and Bow have gotten a half dozen old surveillance Horde drones functional again. Our tracking program is working, which is good…" Litha hedged, " We have managed to locate several dozen seeker drones…all over the planet. But the defense systems in those Horde drones..is…well… It sucks actually. Those seeker drones have a more streamlined design, more versatile set of weapon's and a more advanced offense sub routine. They have already blown three of our drones to smithereens. So I am sure the Eternian's have intel on our attempts to track their drones by now. " Litha explained sourly.

"So we got to upgrade our remaining drone's with an adaptive A.I that can learn to out maneuver and counter those Seeker drones attacks." Entrapta nodded.

[Entrapta] Holo-Hordak called urgently from the emitter dais off to the side of the pillar.

Entrapta squealed in delight, she had not been able to access Hordak's interface since he had been recalled to the Crystal Castle. Whatever program Adora had been having him access, it had taken all of his processing power to run it.

[I require your assistance, I have lost contact with the Crystal Castle…It's core processors have been rerouted and I have been forcibly taken off line.] His deep voice sounded dire.

Entrapta gave him a perplexed look for only a second before rising up on her hair once more.

"I'm going to have to reschedule our lab time, Litha. I am sure you can handle the rest of the coding on your own." Entrapta cut the call, before the little girl could argue.

"Alright Hordak, let's see what's going on?" Entrapta took a deep breath before diving into the network. She and the clones had patched the First Ones ancient network to Primes communication spires. She attempted to ping the beacon, just to get an idea as to what was happening. When she got rerouted back to the Spire network. A cold ball of dread settled into her stomach.

"The Crystal Castles being hacked!" She declared, her amber eyes cooling into a firm determination.

[Entrapta….I am being corrupted…] Hordak choked out, as his hologram glitched and phased out of existence.

"Hordak!" Entrapta cried out in alarm. Her lips twisted into a snarl, as her fingers flew over her keyboard.

"I am not losing you again!" She breathed, tapping the communication device in her left ear. "Wrong Hordak, we got a breach in the Etherian network. I need higher processing speed…" She began to call out her order's into thin air.

"On it, I will take Clone pod's D through K off data management and reroute them to core processing support. If you need more let me know." Wrong Hordak responded.

"I need to get ahead of the hack…if I need more clone's I'll let you know. For now let's put pod's K through Q on stand by. The rest can resume their normal functions…we still gotta keep Etheria's First Ones tech online as well." Entrapta instructed.

"Should I send a squad out to investigate?" Wrong Hordak inquired.

"Yes, that would be prudent. The breach was at the Crystal Castle." Entrapta informed him, as she cracked her knuckles and got to work.

Mara stumbled through the entrance of Razz's hut. Leaning heavily upon the stone frame. Razz was startled at first, her eyes distant as time swung her consciousness back into the past.

Etheria was screaming, crying out in pain as the magic was siphoned away from its heart. As the planet was weakening, the magic was bleeding out of everywhere. Stolen and contained within the Artificial Heart deep inside the planet. Charging the Rune Stone in the Sword of Protection with a massive amount of magic. Mara was struggling to keep the sword's control over her in check. Her body felt like it was being torn apart as she refused to release the magic.

"Razz…" Mara spoke, her voice strained and breathless. The pull of the sword was becoming unbearable. Setting every nerve on fire. The night sky outside was alive with magic, howling in a vortex of power as the Heart siphoned it away.

"Mara, Dearie!" Razz cried happily, turning to greet her with a warm smile.

“I can’t stay long, Razz…I need to know…Adora…will she be the She-Ra in the future?”

Razz was perplexed for a moment, her mind clearing slowly at the question.

“Adora…yes..yes…Adora will be there…” She answered softly.

“Okay…” Mara nodded, her eyes hardening with resolve to see her new plan through to the end.

Her tortured memories swept past Adora once more, as she told Razz about what her people were doing to the planet, that she was a weapon and she refused to be a part of their machine. Running away into the forest as the power of the Heart intensified. With Razz calling out to her, as the stricken old woman sought to follow.

The Heart was drawing more and more magic from the planet, from the Whispering Woods. Mara stumbled when the pain got to be too much, thrusting the sword deep into the ground in some hidden grove. Falling to her knees in agony as the First Ones glyphs came alive upon her skin, her eyes glowing white with the magnitude of the magic entering her.

Adora moaned and squeezed her eyes shut, her whole body trembling as she remembered the raw agony that had torn through her own body. When Light Hope had set off the Heart in the future. It had felt like the magic was ripping her apart from the inside.

Then Mara had stumbled to her feet and walked onward, leaving the sword behind, heading deeper into the forest towards her ship that she had hidden a few miles away from the Crystal Castle.

Adora barely kept her tears in check as she witnessed the heart breaking confrontation between Mara and Light Hope. As Mara told her that she wasn’t Light Hope! Finally admitting what she had been dreading for the last few weeks, that Hope had been

reprogrammed. So she would set off the weapon which was her prime directive.

The whole time the combined magic of the heart was tearing her fragile, mortal body apart. Molecule by molecule, as she could not heal herself without being She-ra. She had never learned how to summon She-Ra, but only how to channel the magic of the planet through physical contact. So she understood that her death was imminent.

Yet she stubbornly refused to die, not yet. She used the Ship's transdimensional drive to expand a portal beyond its safety parameters to encompass the planet. Then she pulled Etheria into the Shadow Dimension of Despondos. That was when reality fractured.

Mara stood before the beacon, having just returned from the Temple of the Sky for the second time. When reality shifted, she spun in shock and confusion to find a young woman, with a blonde ponytail and red jacket standing behind her. Then just as suddenly she was back aboard her ship, the aftermath of shattering reality haunting her. She was quick to plot a course for Serenia, glancing sideways down at the cloud of sparkles near her feet. That hovered just in front of the forward control panel. Mara turned away from the front view screen, shuffling to her command seat. Her body ached with bone deep weariness. Her eyes held a grim acceptance to her fate. As she sat herself down in the command chair, tapping on the arm to activate her log so she could make her last recording. She had gotten a glimpse of this Adora during her brief time skipping between realities during the shift to Despondos. She knew without a doubt Adora was real. That she had made the right choice…for once…the only choice. She activated the ship's data logs and spoke to Adora, bearing her heart, her guilt and her regret. Before her ship crashed into the Oasis behind the divided remains of the Sunna Stone.

Kingdom of Shadow

Chapter Notes

> Thank you for the comment Bitzy Bee. I have a lot to unpack with Shadow Weaver, but it will be spread out over many more arc's though. So here we go!!

“I was hard on you…I won't deny it and I won't apologize. I wanted to prepare you for the world, I wanted you to be strong." Shadow Weaver, Commander of the Etherian Horde.

Lonnie swallowed hard, staring down at the stack of field reports waiting off to the side of her desk. That she had yet to read through. She had only been back a few days and already the workload to keep the ex-Horde on track for rebuilding and the deployment of aid across Etheria was immense. Lonnie groaned and leaned back in her chair, pinching the bridge of her nose. In a vain attempt to stay focused. It was barely dawn and the steaming mug of coffee, in a tin cup. That sat in front of her was the only sustenance she had consumed in nearly twelve hours.

“Lonnie?” Kyle’s soft, insistent voice floated from just outside the slightly open flap to her command tent. Then Imp flew inside, carrying a metal tray. He had no doubt stolen from the mess hall. It had a plate of eggs on toast and a bowl of oatmeal. The Horde no longer lived off just ration bars. Trading with the farmer’s on the border near Thaymor, in exchange for the Fright Zones metal scrap and busted tech. That the tech master’s used to fix the machinery. Their food stores for the coming cold season were beginning to grow, not enough to get them through the cold season, though. But thankfully the ration bar production facilities had survived the war. So while fresh food was in supply. They would only use those tasteless bricks of protein and vitamins for a source of food as emergency rations. Scorpania soldiers that were

out in the field, used them more frequently as they were easier to transport and lasted forever!
"Imp…you are a lifesaver." Lonnie smiled gratefully, as the little mutant clone landed upon the corner of the desk and offered her the tray of food.

"Family….takes care of each other." Imp opened his mouth, Lonnie's stern, yet caring voice invading the quiet of the tent.

Lonnie gave him a tender pat on the head, before pushing her reports aside to allow room for the tray of food. When she and the boys had gotten back to the base with Levi and Max. Imp had been in the infirmary recovering from poison. The medic was amazed at how quickly the little mutant clone could flush the toxin out of his body without any kind of pharmaceuticals to aid in its breakdown. Whatever genetic cocktail Hordak had used to create Imp. Was some pretty highly evolved stuff. Imp had a high metabolism and coud out eat any of them, his cells regenerated almost instantly making him able to heal from wounds faster and now I guess he was impervious to poison as well.

"Force Captain." Lazlo pushed into the tent, with two young squad leader's trailing behind.

Lonnie had a folded piece of toast with dripping egg poised before her mouth as her old Staff Sergeant barged into her breakfast break. With a stubborn grunt, she shoved half the toast into her mouth in one bite refusing to wait any longer. Knowing that the old mutant would rant about something for a good five minutes. Giving her enough time to chew and swallow that bite.

"The senior cadets have been monitoring the Eternian communication feed and I have a full report for you. My soldier's have logged the names and various locations the Eternian insurgency has infiltrated, based on the landmarks spoken of during their com broadcasts." Lazo slapped a stack of folders on her desk.

“Wonderful…” Lonnie nodded, as yet another stack of reports lay before her to work through. Max and Levi had come rushing back into their campsite at Scorpion Hills just over a week ago. Tossing Lonnie a tiny com earpiece and telling her to listen. Lonnie was alarmed at first as she heard the chatter of Eternian infiltrator's. Then she had smirked, as this stolen piece of tech would become an irreplaceable tool to take down all the spy’s all over Etheria.

Currently Grizlor was leading a strike team. Consisting of Max, Levi, Rogelio and Kyle out in the Crimson Waste to extract Prince Peekablue from the Eternian’s who had captured them. The Strike team she had sent into the Dark Edge had gone silent about a week back. Scorpia had left intel with the Force Captain’s that they would need Peekablue to guide the rescue team into the canyon’s. So time was not on their side right now, the team had enough field ration’s for about a week, two if they conserved them. They needed to get into the canyon’s asap.

“I will give a report to Queen Scorpia later today. I want you to report back here before sundown so we can figure out how we are going to apprehend these guys without showing our hand.” Lonnie commanded.

“I don’t see how…we don’t have enough soldiers to commit to that many extractions. Read my reports, Commander. “ Lazlo tapped the stack of folders urgently.

Lonnie raised a curious eyebrow, shoving the tray aside and leaned forward to grab the first report.

Imp sat patiently on the edge of the desk, watching with concern as Lonnie read through one report after another. Her face slowly went pale and her determined expression wilted into a hopeless frown.
“…fuck…” She muttered, closing her eyes and thumping the back of her head against her chair as she slapped the last report down on her desk angrily.

When they reached the Hall of Master's, Castaspella was waiting for them, along with one other member of the Magic High Council. The Head Sorceress stood at the end of the line of statues. In front of the fresco that concealed the entrance to the catacombs.

With a very tall man with broad shoulders. Clean shaven, with a very bold, squared jaw. He had a head of soft brown hair that was thick and wavy, hanging low down his neck. That was going gray along the sides, flaring in that same wild way as Ely's over his ears. With thick eyebrows that shaded intense brown eyes, that smoldered like the dying embers of a fire. He held a long bronze staff in one hand, with an ornate crown that looked remarkably like a molten ball of flame.

Catra recognized him instantly as Cyrus. He was no longer in his pale gray and orange robes but now in common clothes. Of a simple woolen button up shirt and dark pants, with leather traveling boots. He had a full pack slung over one shoulder, greeting the troop of princesses marching towards him with a warm smile.

"Auntie…what?" Glimmer jogged ahead, questioning the newest and uninvited member to their expedition.

"I don't need a babysitter." Catra snapped, as she marched up behind Glimmer. Knowing full well, Casta did not trust her. Shooting both Casta and Cyrus a scathing glare.

Cyrus merely offered the magicat a wiry grin, raising his hands in a placating manner.
"That I believe is still undecided. " He stated sagely, the arrogant superiority thick in the undertones of those words.

Catra gave him a somewhat disgusted scowl before shaking her head in disregard. Biting the inside of her cheek to silence the furious retort that wanted to explode from her mouth.

“Cyrus was kind enough to offer his services as a guide. He has also explored the ancient tunnels under Mystacor. He did not go as deep as Light Spinner, mind you. But he has had enough experience inside them to help you avoid traps and what not…” Casta huffed, twirling her wrist dramatically.

“We don’t need him, I have Light Spinner’s journal.” Catra countered, unwilling to allow anyone she didn't know into such close quarters as the tunnels. There were enough danger’s down there to deal with. She knew her thinking was flawed, that this was merely her Horde upbringing…having grown up in such a combative environment breeds a natural distrust of strangers. The other and more pertinent reason was she just didn’t like him.

“Nonsense…I will not allow you all to go wandering down into the most dangerous part of the Citadel blindly. Adora nearly died down there!” Casta snapped back.

Catra huffed, crossing her arms stubbornly unable to refute her point.

“Fine…” she grumbled a moment later.

Casta nodded, making a satisfied noise before turning to the fresco.

“Alright Cyrus, like we practiced. It takes two mages to unseal the lock on the door.” Cyrus nodded, taking his place beside Casta. Mimicking her movements as she spun her arms, incanting the spell that would grant them entry into the catacombs.

Double Trouble had been curious as to where they were going, skipping along after the troop of princesses in the guise of the Thaymorian deer hybrid. Their fake excitement about going on an adventure, turning into a silent scream of panic. When the true destination presented itself. Now they were huddled in the flickering firelight, from Catra’s left palm. Pretending not to care about what was happening, drawing in the dirt on the slate floor.

Scheming as to how they were going to keep the Princess away from their hideout.

As Catra walked slowly down the corridor set just behind the secret entrance. With Glimmer taking numerous pictures with her communication pad, cataloging the images to be visually dissected later. They had been working together for the last few days, investigating all the ancient places around Mystacor. So they had easily fallen into their roles, like two historian's uncovering the past. Glimmer cringed, as the thought brought an image of Bow in her mind. They had barely seen each other in the last week. She was really missing him…as he rarely left the confines of Darla's workshop lately. She had gone to the ship just last night, when once again he had not come back to their room to sleep. Finding him hunched over a cluttered work table, fast asleep. Drooling on his new weapon schematic….a more compact kind of crossbow. He had attempted to explain it to her days' earlier, all hyped up and excited about his breakthroughs converting First Ones tech into the trigger. She had retreated to their old bunkroom then returned to the workshop with a blanket, covering him up. She pressed a sweet kiss to his temple, before leaving.

Her thoughts skipped to another matter not wanting to dwell on her insecurities regarding her relationship with Bow. Brojee and the boys were going to launch the retrofitted Horde drones this morning…she wondered how that went? That thought lasted about a second before ricocheting back to Bow. He was so caught up in his invention, he had been unintentionally avoiding her? She hoped that was the case. Her anxieties over losing Bow's affection had been nattering in her ear. Fueling her fear that perhaps she had done something wrong, or perhaps he was bored of her, or perhaps…realized she wasn't worth the effort. Glimmer sighed, refusing to wallow in what ifs. Tapping the screen to see if Bow had responded to her message. She had let him know where she and the rest of the princesses were going a couple hours ago. She wasn't surprised to find no response. Bow just didn't seem to have time for her right now, she was feeling rather bitter about it. But logically she understood that they were in crisis right now and they all had important tasks, they were all working together to

keep Etheria safe. But they were also working apart…so her thoughts naturally fell on Adora.

"How is Adora?" Glimmer asked, pulling the pad away from her face after her last picture. Catra was standing a few feet away, slowly dragging her gaze across the expansive image of various panels that took up the entire hallway.

"We have been talking before bed all week. Last night she was in Elboron, I guess they tried to throw her some kind of party?" Catra chuckled. When Adora saw the Great Hall all decked out and the feast. She refused to allow them to waste their food and got into an argument with the Leader of Elberon. Who was a kind, yet stubborn moth hybrid who just loved any excuse to throw a party of any kind.

"Yeah, I wouldn't know. I missed the last party." Glimmer shrugged, her tone feigning ambivalence but Catra could hear the jealous undertones.

She arched an inquiring eyebrow, silently hoping Glimmer would explain.

"It doesn't matter." She quickly responded, clapping Catra on the bicep. With a warm smile. Refusing to explain, not wanting to sour the mood. That she had missed the party because she had just started her reign as Queen of Bright Moon. She didn't blame Catra, but she knew the Magicat still harbored guilty feelings about the Portal and Queen Angella.

Catra nodded, quickly realizing that she did not want to talk about it. So she let it go.

Turning back to the murals.

"What does it all mean?" Frosta inquired, brushing her hand down the dusty wall.

"To study the past, one may yet define the future." Cyrus mused, taking in each mural in turn as he marched down the corridor.

Frosta gave him a befuddled look, at his cryptic response. Bowing her head as she contemplated the meaning.

Catra rolled her eyes, she may have not gone to Cyrus for training last week. But that doesn't mean she hadn't spied upon him. As he trained younger apprentices in fire magic. So far she was not impressed, he had come off as a pompous blowhard. Giving commands and correcting the children under his tutelage with a condescending, superior air that grated on her last nerve. His philosophical answer was a lame attempt to look highly intelligent in front of the Princesses.

Which was just one more reason she had been avoiding him, knowing it would be very difficult for her to remain polite, when all she wanted to do was take him down a peg or two.

"We've taken pictures of other places on Mystacor with similar images." Glimmer explained, ignoring Cyrus's comment.

"Light Spinner, had theories in her journal's about these murals." Catra continued, placing down her pack and rummaging for a certain journal inside. Pulling it free with a triumphant sound.

Cyrus smiled with pride at the mention of Light Spinner, crossing his arms over his chest to listen to the late Sorceress theories.

"They were drawn by the survivors of the Great Unrest…during the Forgotten Age. By both hybrid and human's…Who had migrated up to the island to rebuild. The two murals are the duality of magic…the light and the shadow." Catra shrugged, flipping through the page until she got the entry. Then pointing to the center of the mural before she started reading.

"It had taken far longer than I had anticipated to figure out the glyph arrangement to unlock the seal to the catacombs. But with Micah now aiding in my research. Who is so naturally gifted in the art of glyph work it took us no time to get inside. The boy has so far exceeded my expectations, he is exceptional. But I am not a fool and will not go forward recklessly, even though Etheria is on

the brink of war. The secrets to the deep magic lay within these walls I am certain of it!" Catra finished then just began skimming the page.

Glimmer scowled at the mention of how Light Spinner had manipulated her father as a child. Teaching him dark magic, leaving him scarred both physically and mentally from it. Glancing up to find Frosta tapping her foot impatiently.

Glimmer chuckled, "Light Spinner was rather long winded…give her a moment."

Cyrus nodded, his eyes growing distant with fond memories of Beatrix. She had a brilliant mind and an indomitable spirit.

'Ok..ok. So…" Catra pointed to the center again of the first mural. "The big half circle taking up the bottom of the picture is Etheria. The symbol in the middle is the Heart of Ethera…the three triangles that surround it…are the Crystal of Arxia that held the Fail Safe…the star-like thing shooting out of it…is magic…"

"That's a Rune Stone….maybe the Black Garnet?" Frosta pointed to the left, cutting Catra off. Scorpia was intrigued and approached the mural for a closer look. Tapping a claw on the cracked paint of the mural.
"Could be…could be…not exactly like the Garnet…though…" She advised shortly, about to go into more detail before getting interrupted.

"Then a full moon, then a half moon, a star…then the sun." Netossa added.

"Catra's source of magic is the Sun." Spinnerella turned to Catra for confirmation. The magicat merely nodded.

"Mine is the Greater Moon Elidor." Glimmer added.

"So these must be the sources of Magic in the Universe." Netossa observed.

“But the RuneStones were not natural…they were artificial?” Catra countered, which had everyone confused as to why it was depicted in the mural.

“Then perhaps, that is a Star Seed.” Cyrus nodded towards the crystal image knowingly.

Everyone began to nod in understanding, while Catra refocused on the journal in her hand.

“Who are those two guys in robes at the top?” Perfuma asked.

“There are six more robed guys at the bottom on either side of the big circle blob in the middle.” Frosta added, “Three on the left and three on the right..” She finished slowly.

Cyrus raised a finger about to respond, since he had been the sole audience for Beatrix’s theories so very long ago. Their debates about the First Ones had been very heated and could get rather loud. Lasting into the evening, until they both got kicked out of the Citadel’s libraries for misconduct. Retreating to his or her dorm room to continue said debates, long into the night.

“Where the hell are we!” Mermista’s shrill voice exploded from the back of the crowd musing over the fresco’s.

Everyone turned to find the blue horde bot, projecting a very, flustered and confused Sea Princess. Who was now looking around the gloomy, musty corridor in mild confusion.

“Currently we are just beyond the entrance to the catacombs.” Entrapta offered, calmly as her hologram came online at the back of the group.

“I thought…I was going to be training today? Guess not. ” Mermista huffed while rolling her eyes and crossing her arms over her chest. In a display of indignation and reluctant acceptance at having her plans changed without notice.

“Do any of you understand First Ones writing…or is it just an Adora thing?” Scorpia inquired hopefully from the edge of the group.

“I noticed that writing too.I have an algorithm running to decipher them. The First Ones writing is complicated…so it takes time.” Entrapta explained, as rapid clicks of her accessing her data invaded the bloated silence that followed. As the group continued to survey the many components of the various murals. Her hologram quickly dissolved, as she disconnected from Emily. The princesses were used to Entrapta coming and going by now and paid little attention to it.

“I could leave too, you know?...If I wanted to.” Mermista muttered, feeling overshadowed by the murals. Disgruntled by not getting a heads up about the change of plan today. Bitter and frustrated that she really had nothing else to do, but wait for Sea Hawk to return. She had sent him to the Valley of the Lost to enlist a pirate crew willing to smuggle aid supplies from Sea Worthy down to the struggling villages along the southern coast of Salineas. It had been days and he had yet to return and she was getting worried.

“Well, there are three sets of First Ones writing…Two on the upper right and one on the left…” Catra commented, engrossed in the journal searching for answers.

“Bow’s dad’s said that it was based on the constellations of the past.” Glimmer offered.

“The pattern is circular…” she finished in slow measured contemplation.

“Planets are circles…” Frosta muttered, “Could they be planets”

“A star chart…” Cyrus added…”Of our universe perhaps?”

“Light Spinner…wrote about how the mural’s meanings are layered.” Catra was back scanning the texts in the book. Squinting her eyes, which were still quite sharp in the flickering half light of

the fire in her palm. But Light Spinner's writing was tiny and the letter's tended to bleed into one another.

"Let me help." Glimmer offered, sending a ball of light to illuminate the entire hallway.

Catra grunted in acknowledgement, moving forward to tap the center of the mural again.

"So this is the heart, then the Crystal of Arixia, then the magic, the next layer of pattern is…"
"It looks like an eyeball!" Frosta interrupted again, pointing to all the black squiggles coming off of the larger square.

Finn groaned and trudged over to the other side of the hallway and slid down to the ground. This was going to take a while and he was absolutely bored.

"Light Spinner had gone to the Crystal of Arxia before…but she chose to invoke the Spell of Obtainment instead…Why?" Catra mused, as they wound down the stairway back to the lower hall that housed the Chamber that held the Control Crystals.

"Well…She didn't want to die…obviously." Mermista shrugged, she had heard all about their adventure to Mystacor to retrieve the Failsafe. The creak and clack of her bot's legs, echoing down the staircase.

"Obviously…but where did she get the information that those Crystals could kill her? " Catra smirked at Mermista's hologram, as the dark blue bot stomped beside her down the empty hallway that was once lit by flames on either side. The Sea Princess merely shrugged.

"She was studying dark magic…So obviously she felt the spell of obtainment as a greater chance of success. " Cyrus offered, as he trailed behind them.

Catra grunted to mask the grim humor of that statement. Light Spinner did not survive that spell…she had yet to prove it. But she was certain that she had become a husk, just like those undead magic users from Eternia.

"Another mystery to solve. Where did she get the Shard of Kaydak?" Glimmer groaned, "This place is empty…except for the Crystal." She ranted, raising her hands up in frustration as she walked ahead of Catra.

Emily led the way, stomping far ahead. Her central core, scanning the hallway in one continuous violet beam.

Finn kept glancing at Cyrus as they walked down one empty hall after another, after leaving the Crystal of Arxia far behind. Castaspella had stated he had explored down here…yet he had offered nothing so far. There was no way that they were just strolling down these dark, barely lit halls without setting off at least one trap? The princesses were just marching along like a bunch of carefree, sightseeing tourists so what the hell?

Cyrus wasn't shy or perhaps was he lying about being down here before? Because Double Trouble had watched them pass several room's already. With Arxia powered down to auxiliary systems only. There was little to no light, the First Ones glyphs hummed along the smooth walls like faint ghostly outlines. So the seams of the doors were not invisible but hard to see if you didn't know what you were looking for. Double Trouble fought with themself for a few moments about helping…trying to figure out how they could do it without breaking their cover. They really did not want Kitten to come all the way down here, only to have her time wasted and not have anything to show for her effort.

"This is supposed to be an ancient First Ones Starbase…so where is all the tech…or doors even?" Netossa complained.

As if on cue, Finn stumbled and crashed into a wall and suddenly a door whooshed open in front of him. To which he promptly

squeaked and fell face first into the room. In a perfectly executed display of physical comedy.

“There's your door.” Frosta smirked, inclining the door with a hand before dashing into the room, stepping over Finn’s sprawled body in the process. She stood frozen just beyond the threshold. As Glimmer tossed a ball of light inside. They all slowly took in the tiny room from the doorway. It held nothing but a smooth, curved desk along one wall with a cracked screen. A moldy cot along the other wall, with a tattered balled up blanket in the center. The molded desk chair was sideways on the floor. Strange ancient objects were scattered all over the floor and set on molded shelves on the back wall.

“Crew quarters…” Cyrus offered, as he came up behind Frosta. Moving past her to the desk and activating the keypad, with a few taps along its smooth, dusty surface.

Catra and Glimmer entered behind him, as the rest of the princesses crowded around the doorway. Focused upon scanning the dusty contents of the room, ignoring the Thaymorian completely. Finn picked himself up off the floor with a disgruntled pout. He had hoped to receive some laughter for his performance or maybe some concern from their momma cat. But nothing…

Now they were leaning against the far wall of the room with their arms crossed. Cutting Cyrus a curious eye, as the old mage seemed to know his way around First Ones tech pretty well. As he had the forward screen illuminated now and the last program activated in the terminal was still running.

The face of a blonde human, barely into adulthood, was frozen on the screen. He was dressed in white and gray combat fatigues, sitting at the very same desk Cyrus was currently fiddling with.

“That image was part of one of the communication’s I downloaded from the database.” Entrapta offered, as her hologram walked through the wall beside the doorway and into the room. Emily was standing tall at the back of the group outside

in the hall, so that the bot could project Entrapta into the room. "On a side note, the Drones are airborne and we should have results shortly." She finished with an eager smile.

"Play it." Catra paid her nod of acknowledgement before turning back to Cyrus.

Cyrus hit a button and the image of the young man began to move, his voice was garbled and degraded. The static and droning hum of the recording pierced savagely against everyone's ears. Frosta cringed and pressed her palms against her ears, leaving the room.

"KIll, it…Kill it!" Glimmer demanded, as Cyrus was quick to pause the screaming recording.

"There are thousands of these recordings, I've filtered and decoded what I could. I sent them all to Adora before, I could send them to you too?' Entrapta offered.

"Yes…that would be less painful." Catra ground out, rubbing her ringing ears as she also left the room.

After a long day of exploring, the troop made camp in a cavernous shuttle bay. Setting up a fire glyph between a couple of walls of stacked metal crates and circling their bedrolls around it. The ambient glow from the circle was slowly lulling everyone's mood as they shared a simple dinner of roasted meats, bread and cheese. Catra and Glimmer shared a duet of dulcet tones, in the far recesses of the massive storage room. As Adarion set and Elidor took it's reign over the sky outside. The princesses sat around the glyph watching them sing, basking in the ambient echo of their shared voices. As both Catra and Glimmer began to glow with their source of magic. Catra's body flared with the ancient fire of her people, as Glimmer glowed softly in the silver sheen of Moonlight.

After the shared communion with their magic. They returned to the fire glyph, to awed looks and smiles from their friends. The princesses' conversations that followed were soft and warm, echoing throughout the somber chamber.

In time Catra took her leave, needing some time alone to collect her thoughts. It had been a long day. Pulling out her com pad from her pack, checking to see if Adora had sent her any messages. It wasn't even close to bedtime, so she never expected a call yet.

Catra sat against a far wall, slightly hidden in a large alcove that may have been used to park a small transport. Contentedly biting into an apple that was serving as her dessert. As she reviewed the pictures Glimmer had taken on her com pad. Lightly brushing away stray strands of her mane that kept getting into her eyes.

"Your hair is getting longer." Glimmer commented, taking note that her brunette mane was now brushing low near her shoulders. Passing Catra an elastic band.

Catra chuckled ruefully. "Those things don't work, Sparkles. My hair's as wild and untamed as me." She quipped, passing Glimmer a coy smile that revealed one fang over the corner of her lower lip. She quickly snatched the elastic and shot it off her fingers towards the far corner of the room. A startled yelp erupted from the gloom beyond a wall of crates.

Catra cast Glimmer a strange look before dashing towards the sound. Glimmer was quick to follow. Finding Cyrus just behind the wall of crates, rubbing the middle of forehead ruefully. That now sported a red welt.

"What are you doing back here?" Catra questioned, glancing down at the floor that now had several burn marks.

"Training….something you should have been doing with me for the last week." Cyrus pointed out with a taunting smirk, planting the butt of his staff on the ground and leaning against it. Paying Catra

an encouraging grin, “Care to join me? Rune Bearer?” he invited smugly with a spinning flourish of his staff. Catra narrowed her eyes as she scrutinized his technique or lack thereof. It wasn’t anything fancy, just a simple spin over his head. Stopping the spin by grabbing the pole with a jerky clasp with both hands and then planting the pole rather stiffly upon the floor. His movements were awkward, almost stilted as if he was just learning to use the staff?

Catra arched an eyebrow at Glimmer. Who merely gave her a noncommittal shrug.

Finn sat high atop the metal boxes, their yellow reptilian eyes locked on Cyrus as they had been watching this so-called Master of Fire Magic, bumble about with the staff for the last hour casting various fire spells. While the Princesses had their evening meal.

“Uhm…ok…sure.” Catra responded with uncertainty. She could feel her rage boiling under the surface, the pressure to hold it in check. Was like a feral thing fighting to be set free from its cage. All resentment and hate, she felt towards the elite of Mystcor and how she felt they were mistreating her, holding her back from reaching her potential. It wasn’t just Casta, she knew the rest of the High Counsel did not trust her either, didn’t believe in her… wanted to control her…wanted to control all the Rune Bearer’s. For power or out of fear was yet to be determined.

Double Trouble, bit down hard on their cheek to stop the cheer that wished to break free. But mentally, they shouted. (Go get’em Tiger!)

“Now, I will not go easy on you.” Cyrus taunted, arrogantly.

“I don’t expect you to.” Catra countered, as the pressure of her anger built. She handed Glimmer, Melog’s Pouch. The Queen glanced up at Catra, who was seething silently. Her mismatched eye flashing with pent up fury, pupils turned to pin pricks. Glimmer gasped, then she peeked into the flap for a quick look. Finding Melog curled up inside, a pale blue with a maroon flare for

a mane. They blinked upward at Glimmer with large glowing blue eyes and then promptly yawned. Showing off their fangs as their mouth widened larger than their little head.

They looked so cute and unthreatening, Glimmer nodded and flipped the flap closed. Confident Catra was in control of her rage. Before clutching the pouch to her chest to watch Catra and Cyrus spar, certain the Magicat wasn't about to kill the pompous mage.

Catra snapped her hands open, claws extended as she prowled towards Cyrus. Flames ignited in her palms, the fire staining the dark leather of her coat sleeves a brilliant orange. Flickering menacingly across her determined scowl, her unblinking, predatory glare calculating every twitch of muscle the human made. She was going to prove herself, right here and now. That she could handle her magic! That she was more powerful and capable then they gave her credit for!

"You wanted to teach me…then teach me!" Catra yelled, dashing forward in a low charge as her whole body ignited. The ferocity of her charge was so sudden and so terrifying.

Melog flared like the sun inside the pouch, as Catra unleashed her magic. Glimmer yelped and dropped the bag as it was instantly consumed in flame. Melog released a low, growling snarl as the cloth turned to ash. Like a phoenix emerging from the ashes, Melog stalked out of the flames. Much larger now and far more imposing. With their body now dark as pitch, with glowing crack's of lava flowing over tightly packed muscle. Their mane and tail flaring like the mighty sun itself.

"Stand down, Melog!" Catra snapped her eyes towards her companion. The thirst for violence, the need to protect was exploding across their link. She knew if she didn't control her companion they would rip Cyrus to shreds.

Melog whined and laid down, the fire inside of them dimming. As their mane and tail reduced to a warm flicker.

Cyrus was standing a few feet away, eye's now wide in terror. The smug, confident smile he once wore had fallen into shock and awe. At the raw fury and immense power now thrumming off Catra in waves of barely contained magic. That could easily devastate everything in its path if unleashed.

"Well…now…perhaps we could start off with just theory first." He cleared his throat, all fight gone from his frame as he practically cowered before her.

"Seriously!" Catra scoffed, she had been looking forward to a fight. The inferno her body had become instantly snuffed out in disappointment.

Finn roared with laughter from his perch, falling backwards off the crates.

Double Trouble swore Kitten had made that old wind bag piss himself.

Catra had lingered, when Glimmer gave her an appalled, reprimanding look before leaving to head back to the fire glyph. Reminding her silently to play nice and that she had promised to give Cyrus a chance. So with a disgruntled groan Catra turned to regard her magic trainer. Offering him a patient smile, smothering the last of her anger with a long, drawn out sigh.

"Ah…well…you can't fault me for backing down. I've only been at this for a year?" Cyrus shrugged.
"You have got to be kidding me." Catra grumbled, shaking her head in disbelief. As Cyrus just proved to her, that she was wasting her time.

"I thought you were a Master of Fire Magic?" She complained.

"Not everyone on the High Council is a Master, I am not even a part of the Sorcerer's Guild. I'm a Historian…of Fire Magic. " Cyrus chuckled.

Catra merely blinked completely bewildered as all her assumptions about the man had been thoroughly obliterated.

“Honestly, with Fire magic extinct for the last thousand years. I only had techniques and theory to work with. “ Cyrus shrugged, sitting down on the floor and placing his staff across his lap. “It is so thrilling to be able to actually conjure fire now!” He exclaimed, eye’s burning with unbridled excitement.

Catra watched him for a moment longer before joining him on the floor. Wanting to make sure they were on even ground and she wasn’t unintentionally intimidating him.

“Without Adarion…to replenish the magic…the Heart absorbed it all.” Catra nodded, remembering what Ouroboros had told her.

Cyrus merely nodded, “Fire Magic began to weaken during the Forgotten Age and then it just disappeared. Until Etheria returned to the Universe….and the sun returned. Since She-Ra released all the magic stored in the Heart it’s even more powerful.“ Cyrus explained, silence reigned for a while before he spoke again. “You're really scary…” He muttered ruefully.

“Sorry…” Catra apologized, ducking her head and clutching one arm across her chest regretfully. She honestly had gone overboard…and he didn’t deserve to be intimidated like that. She had to admit once again she allowed her anger to get the better of her.

“Well, let’s just talk…I think that’s all I have the energy for right now.” Cyrus chuckled, relaxing back on his elbows on the floor.

“Do you have any questions about fire magic I might be able to answer?” He added a moment later.

Catra thought about it then shook her head. She may have lots of questions but being put on the spot like this her mind was blank.

“Well, ok..well..Fire Magic is a combative magic, it is offensive in nature.” Cyrus began.

“No, It’s not. It’s my magic…I will determine what it is used for.” Catra countered, not liking how simply Cyrus was explaining it. She did not like her magic being referred to as some kind of weapon. She is no longer that violent, rage filled monster…yet… the way she had just acted when she felt provoked proved otherwise.

Ugh….she needed to talk to Perfuma again.

Cyrus frowned…she wasn’t getting it.

“Every element has a catalyst?” Cyrus pushed on. “I mean, I guess, it has been adapted to be more versatile nowadays. But for example Light is defensive, Water is offensive, so on and so forth.”

“What does that mean?” Catra huffed in confusion. .

“Well, do you know the tenets of magic?” Cyrus asked.

“No, but I know one.” Catra countered.

Cyrus waited for her answer.

“Magic is fueled by emotion and driven by intention.” Catra answered.

‘Yes, that is one.” Cyrus regarded her. “So what emotions fuel your magic.”

Catra stared at him for a long moment reluctant to answer.

“Anger.” She finally admitted lowly.

“Anger…is a negative emotion, it is combative in nature. It is an offensive feeling, seeking action.” Cyrus smiled, knowingly.

“Fire is offensive magic…it’s combative in nature…got it.” Catra smirked back.

“Alright then, what intention drive’s your magic.” He offered.
“I want to protect…” Catra answered, cautiously. Not wanting to give away too much about who she wanted to protect.

“Ah, ha!” Cyrus raised a finger in a eureka gesture. “Which leads us to the next Tenent.

Control is Focus, Power is Emotion. You must learn to focus your intentions and control your emotions less your magic turns wild or destructive in nature. “

Catra’s eye widened in sudden clarity. Shadow Weaver's less than ideal methods to teach her control over her anger had served a purpose? The old woman had seen her rage as a strength as long she learned to temper it, focus it…control it…Always warning her that her rage when out of control was a weakness…that it would blind her, distract her from her true goals. It was all making so much more sense now.

Catra scrubbed her hands up and down her face to clear away the bitterness at those memories. Melog padded to her, settling down against her hip. Now the size of a large dog with fully developed features once more. Resembling the cat they once were, but slightly different. Their violet body was tinted a dark maroon, their shape thicker and more robust, with a barrel chest and larger paws. Their cheeks are more round, with a wider nose and strong jaw. Glowing blue eyes set in regal features, resembling a lion now more than a panther. Their mane no longer has an iridescent flowing halo around their head but a glowing orange cowl wrapped around their thick neck like a warm bonfire with a flickering tail to match.

Catra had noticed small changes in her companion over the course of their transformation. As they acclimated to her magic. But their form now, that their transformation was complete. It was more than obvious that their magic was Fire.

Catra wondered idly what element of Krytian magic they had been adapted to before?

She reached out and began to pet them down their broad back as Cyrus continued their instructions into Magic theory.

"You are so much like her." Cyrus was sprawled on his back, staring up at the empty ceiling above. As Catra lounged against Melog a few feet away. Their conversation had lasted long into the evening. She could hear the soft sounds of the princesses talking on the other side of the wall of metal crates.

"Who?" Catra asked, softly. She was close to falling asleep, as she was so relaxed.

"Beatrix." Cyrus answered.

"Who?" Catra, chuckled.

"Light Spinner." He explained.

"That is not a compliment if that's what you were thinking it was." Catra growled back, suddenly not so relaxed anymore.

Cyrus laughed softly, nodding in acceptance. Beatrix had been a complicated person, one not many people liked. She never really tried to be liked, finding most people boring and pedantic in nature. More interested in unraveling the mysteries of magic and the secrets of the First Ones, then making friends. That was a passion they both shared and the cornerstone of their friendship. Honestly, he may have been the only person she tolerated on Mystacor. He still to this day did not really know if she had even considered him a friend? Perhaps a rival? At least a like minded colleague in the magic arts. She never allowed anyone to get too close. A lone wolf until the very end.

"Light Spinner…was the name she had earned when she was initiated into the Sorcerer's Guild and received her badge. I grew up with Beatrix, we were both apprentices in the Maker Guild at first. Norwyn had found her in a village at the steppes of the Barrier Mountains, at the very edge of Bright Moon. The old goat

wasn’t the Head Sorcerer yet, not even a Master. Just a simple teacher of Light Magic. Mystacor had sent him to investigate allegations of monsters terrorizing the local’s. What he found was a filthy, half starved, little Gar, barely ten years old. Able to conjure very frightening, very real illusion’s that she used to scare off villager’s so she could sneak into their homes. Stealing food, jewelry, anything really that she could eat or sell. Beatrix was very bold and cunning even then, I guess it was how she learned to survive. Being a Gar, she would not have been welcome in the village. Her race has been persecuted and shunned by the rest of Etheria since the Forgotten Age. They had been banished to live in the Northern Tundra beyond the Barrier Mountains. It’s a harsh, unforgiving land. Not good for crops, or herding even. Hunting and scavenging is the only way to survive up there. Norwyn, I don’t know, maybe. He thought she had potential, maybe it was, pity. Since she was so young and alone in the world. Either way, he brought her back to Mystacor.” Cyrus began, delving into tales of his youth with a much younger, much more hopeful and far less bitter version of her Senior Officer…the broken, twisted creature she had known as a Mother.

Chapter Two

Chapter Notes

> Thankyou Bitzy Bee and Pink Storm for your comments. I love to read what people think of my story, I am really trying hard to develop a whole universe so to speak. Thank you all who left Kudo's as well.

“I do not suffer mediocrity…not even in myself.” Beatrix, Stone Mason apprentice, Mystacor

The Scorpania Strike Team had been tracking the Eternian’s across the Savannah and now the desert for the last couple days. Finally finding them at the edge of the sandstone canyon's, in the early morning hours. The enemy had parked their hover sleds just outside of camp. Which consisted of several smaller tents surrounding a larger command tent in the center. The rigid military formation of the tents is very familiar to the ex-horde soldiers, currently spying from the caves high up upon the canyon wall. The Valley of the Lost was a few miles southwest of this location and a solitary lizard-kin had set off from the camp couple hours earlier. He wasn't their objective, so they made a log of his departure as part of their intel. Maintaining their post and observing the camp as morning drew on towards midday. The Leader of the Eternian's was a huge, furry beast of a man that oddly resembles Grizzlor. He had prowled the camp, barking orders at his underlings and disappearing inside the command tent afterward. Only to reappear hours later covered in fresh blood.

Kyle's tracker pad had picked up a life signal inside that command tent that never left. They had quickly discerned that it must be Peekablue. The fact that the Beast came out of the tent later that

day covered in blood had been a pretty good indication that the Prince was being interrogated rather violently. Max had been on watch at that time, he was a hardened soldier so the sight of blood didn’t turn his stomach as it once did. When he had been fresh on the field, as part of a strike team after graduation. The fact that he was now desensitized to it, did bother him though. Levi was quick to replace him, as she noticed how upset he was. They had grown up together in the barracks and she knew all his tells. They had bonded early as first year cadets and had become best friends. She knew Max better then she knew herself. They had survived the war together. Left the Horde, together, built a new home in the highlands of Bright Moon, together....and in the end. Returned to service under Princess Scorpia's new banner together...to continue the good fight, to protect the planet they both loved, to protect the people they cherished back in that village...together.

Levi touched his shoulder lightly, as she crawled up next to him on the edge of the outcropping. Max had been tapping his finger's against the binocular's as he kept watch, his agitation rather obvious to Levi. He sighed heavily as he passed her the binocular's.

"Want to talk about it?" She offered, taking the equipment from him with a small, sympathetic smile.

Max thumped his forehead down upon his crossed arms on the ground, shielding his tears away from her. He felt dead inside, numb....witnessing bloodshed should invoke something...right? His chest felt tight and his stomach churned with guilt. He didn't want to be here, he wanted to go home...but he could never leave Levi...would never leave her. They had survived everything together and they would survive this new war too. Then perhaps when she got it all out of her system, this thirst for heroics, for fighting the good fight, they could finally return home and perhaps she would find peace in their simple life. Perhaps this time, she could be happy...perhaps just being with him could be enough for her?

"Not right now." He mumbled, turning away from her as he crawled away back down the embankment and into the cave they were hiding in.

Levi watched him go, eyes full of confusion. But quickly nodded in acceptance, whatever was bothering him he would tell her soon.

Afternoon passed quietly. Soon the rays of the setting sun, reflecting off the rolling hills of sand. That surrounded the Eternian campsite, created a disorientating, shimmer that hovered just above the ground. Making Levi feel rather dizzy as she stared through the Horde issue binoculars, as she monitored the soldier's activity below. Or lack there of...everyone had retreated into their tents just after mid-day and she had not seen anyone since.

Levi was on watch as night approached, laying flat at the mouth of a sandstone cave at least a mile away from the camp. While the rest of the strike team was hidden away behind her, deeper in the cave. This massive canyon held a huge bandit city known as The Valley of the Lost, it was several miles just south of this location. Rogelio and Kyle were right at home here in the waste, having spent a good part of last year living in that city and fighting for freedom against the Galactic Horde. Rogelio had led them to this cave early this morning. While Kyle had retreated deeper underground down some narrow branch of the cave system with his new golems hovering over each shoulder. The rebels had hidden supplies in the caves, using these underground systems to evade Primes' forces and mount gorilla attacks on his spires throughout the canyon. He returned hours later with his arms full of dried wood, his two companions had a larger pile hovering between them in a tractor beam.

Levi never questioned and Max as always just rolled with it. Force Captain Grizzlor on the other hand was less than thrilled at the prospect of building a fire. They were supposed to be on a stealth mission and lighting a fire tonight might compromise that.

Levi was awestruck by how Kyle had nervously, but purposefully argued that the nights got really cold in the Waste this time of

year and that they needed a fire. While Rogelio merely started to build one when evening set in, setting the wood alight before Grizzlor could continue to protest again. Grizzlor was still their commanding officer. In the old days of the Horde both Kyle and Rogelio would be written up of insubordination and be facing some serious punishments when they got back to base. Now it seemed, as the newly minted Scorpania Forces, rank and punishments were less absolute. The soldier's had some power to voice their opinions without repercussions.

"If those Eternian see us and this mission goes to shit." Grizzlor threatened, shaking a fist at the still small fire. Before stalking toward Levi, who was laying flat on the ground just beyond the mouth of the cave at the edge of a barren outcropping. Watching the lackluster argument over her shoulder. Resuming her sentry duty, immediately when Grizzlor caught her eavesdropping. Turning back to canyon below to keep watch with the binoculars. Grizzlor crouched low beside her and took the binoculars from her. Raising the device to his beady eyes, silently commanding her off watch duty for the night. His sensitive nose was not going to appreciate the smoke and he needed to be close to fresh air.

Levi grunted and got to her feet, retreating into the cave to stay warm by the fire as the sun fell behind the canyon walls. The shadow's grew long and the temperature dropped several degrees in a matter of minutes. By the time the Moon's rose and the stars blanketed the sky above it was just below freezing.

It didn't affect Grizzlor much, with his heavy fur coat. But the three humans and lizard-kin were soon huddling around the small bonfire for warmth.

"The nights are usually cool, but this close to the cold season it's going to get frosty."

Kyle sighed, warming his hands in front of the fire.

"Alright, so we are going to hit them, fast and hard, just before dawn. " Max nodded, scratching the last of the markers into the

dirt floor beside the fire with a sharpened stick.

“It’s a simple extraction, we are not supposed to engage with the enemy.” Levi reiterated. Glancing pointedly at Kyle.

“I got it!” Kyle crossed his arms over his chest indignantly. “Yin and Yang promised not to fire on them, just buzz the command tent to draw out the guards and that Big Beasty guy!” He promised, grinding his teeth as he absorbed his golem’s seething rage at not being able to lay waste to the camp. They were free now, after decades of slavery to these vile Eternian’s they wanted revenge!

(What about those machines they drive?) Rogelio grunted, tapping a claw on a simple square markers on the map that represents the War Sleds.

Max patted a bulging pouch on the side of his utility belt. “I will be planting thermal detonators under the chassis, while your golem keeps them distracted. The second they activate whatever powers those things…BOOM!” Max exclaimed, spreading his arms wide with a beaming smile. “They won’t be going anywhere. Then we can call for the prisoner’s transport to swoop in and take them all into custody.”

“While Grizzlor, Rogelio and I sneak into the back of the command tent and release Peekablue.” Levi tapped the larger triangle in the cluster of other triangles on the map.

“Sounds simple enough.” Kyle shrugged.

“Even though Norwyn vouched for her, natural skill at the magic arts. The Head Sorcerer would not allow Beatrix to be an apprentice to the Magic Guild. She had not done anything to warrant such prejudice and distrust, but being a Gar. Her people

had been cast out over a thousand years ago and they still struggle to this day to be treated equally with the rest of Etherian Society.” Cyrus shook his head slowly in disappointment, at Beatrix's unearned mistreatment when she was just a child.

“There were many Gar in the Ehterian Horde.” Catra commented.

“I don’t doubt it, they are treated like outcasts through out Etheria They probably flocked to Hordak’s banner, as a means to better their lives. Perhaps exact some vengeance upon the kingdoms who keep them downtrodden and staving up on that frozen wasteland they were forced to call home. “ Cyrus remarked in a bitter, sour tone.

“Why? What happened?” Catra asked, scratching a claw absently against the metal flooring. She already had an idea, but she needed it verified. Since she had already been put into that stasis pod and had no memories of the aftermath of Mara’s rebellion.

“I don’t really know, the Gar were blamed for Etheria being banished to Depsondos. So they were punished, exiled and sent to either survive or die as far away from the rest of Etheria as possible. “ Cyrus shrugged, “I am still searching for the truth in the research Beatrix left behind.”

“Can I read it?” Catra instantly perked up, Casta had not offered this but Cyrus had access to it and she hoped her own questions could be answered in the journals he possessed.

“I have them in my pack, at least the ones that could prove useful down here in the catacombs.” Cyrus nodded, “But we have time for that later, back to my story.”

Catra nodded, reclining back against Melog, genuinely interested in Shadow Weaver’s time at Mystacor.

“She wasn’t happy about being forced to apprentice in the Maker Guild and not even be given a chance to prove herself as a magic user. But she accepted that she had to earn the trust of the

Citadel. One sorcerer at a time.” Cyrus offered Catra a small, half smile.

“So she chose to learn to be a Stone Mason?” Catra asked, bewildered that Light Spinner would just acquiesce without a fight. That wasn’t the woman she had known. Shadow Weaver was always driven by her own wants and strove to achieve her own goals relentlessly. With or without approval.

“Yes, but only because it’s knowledge was useful to her own goals. She was obsessed with Rune Stones and the myths of the First Ones. She was able to appease those in charge. While she studied magic in secret, sneaking into the Sorcerer libraries and hiding magic journal’s all over the lower bastion’s of the citadel. Beatrix never did exactly as she was told." Cyrus smirked. Her incredible magic abilities were honed by hard work, and a tireless determination to always be the best. She inspired him to strive for more than just being in the Maker guild. She made him believe that he was capable of achieving his dreams. That even though he came from a less affluent family on Mystacor. That did not mean he was less than any other higher class apprentice in the citadel. That if he aspired to be more, then he could achieve it…no matter how many obstacles stood before him.

Catra groaned and rolled her eyes. It was aggravating to be reminded about the traits they shared. When a strange echoing tone sounded from the other side of the wall of crates. Catra’s ears flicked at the sudden familiarity.

“That’s the Andromeda Frequency?” She muttered, scrambling to her feet and dashing back to the Fire glyph. Melog trotted behind her and Cyrus followed curiously.

Glimmer had propped her communication pad on a crate near the fire glyph. While the princesses were sitting around the glyph, relaxing on their bed rolls and listening to the broadcast attentively.

Catra settled down beside Glimmer, casting her an inquiring look.

“Litha, installed the universal com’s on my pad. When one of their allies broadcasts, my pad will pick up the stream.” Glimmer answered.

“How many frequencies have they broadcast?” Catra asked.

‘This is the first one to stream since Beast Island.” Glimmer shrugged. “I guess their allies out there in the universe don’t communicate that frequently.”

Frosta was hunched over her knees between Netossa and Spinnerella on the other side of the fire glyph. She wore a very sour, unimpressed expression. Refusing to even look up from scowling at her boots. Netossa passed her partner a concerned look. They knew how suspicious and anxious Frosta was about the universe beyond Etheria. This sudden communication from some unknown source out beyond their stars was triggering poor Frosta’s anxieties.

Spinnerella was rubbing the young princesses back, trying to soothe her. Responding to Netossa's concern with a knowing look of her own. They had been privy to Frosta’s growing frustration with Glimmer’s lack of common sense. As the Princess of Snows put it. In regards to befriending the four new outsider’s to their ranks. The young ruler of the Snows was not quick to trust and she was scared, now that the rest of the universe knew Etheria was back. She was not embracing being a part of a universal community as enthusiastically as Glimmer.

“This is the Andromeda Frequency. She’s the leader of a Freedom Fighter sect, called Andromeda’s children. I guess these guys were fighting against Prime long before our rebellion took him down.” Glimmer offered, settling more comfortably on her bed roll. “She plays songs, reads stories and talks about what is happening around the Tri-Solar System. It’s her way to spread unity, understanding and friendship across the stars. “ Glimmer smiled in welcome, as Catra adjusted herself into a more comfortable position on her bedroll beside Glimmer’s. Leaning back against Melog, as they laid down behind her.

The tones shifted into a slow beat, slowly turning into soft music. With a graceful melody of strings and the light airy sounds of flutes. In moments a gentle voice began to sing.

(Do you still have faith in me...Do you believe I can save….what's left of us...

Don't give up, Don't give in…

Open your heart...Take the moments as they come…Hold love close.

Don't lose hope, Don't lose yourself …

Do you still have faith in me...Do you believe I can save...what's left of us…)

The soft, melancholy beat faded, as the voice grew silent. A few moments passed before an elegant, gentle baritone echoed from Glimmer's pad.

"Hello, my cosmic children. Andromeda Stardust here, speaking to you from the depths of the void once again. To offer you respite from your struggle. Sit back, relax and enjoy these moments for what they are. Know that you are not alone out there. I am here for you, to give you strength, to give you hope. That the reality that surrounds you is not as dark and cold as you have come to believe."

"I have a special treat for you all. Tuck in with some of your favorite snacks. We are going to watch something called a movie. It's a very ancient, long lost entertainment from a planet called Earth. If it still exists, it is somewhere far, far beyond our stars. In the Milky way galaxy. No one has ventured to that part of space in a millennia. I was lucky to come across this gem and I paid handsomely for it! So enjoy!" Her voice faded, as the starlight upon the pad flashed. Replaced by a grainy image of a strange world. Full of blocky buildings, molded from cement that rose high into the clouds. Moving machines of metal and glass that rolled

incredibly fast on rubber wheels and everyone on the screen was a human….everyone was a First One!

Catra was enthralled by the intense images scrolling across the screen. The bright neon lights that glowed in the city at night. The sparkling river that ran through the city, with an elegant red metal and cable bridge. The varying character's, the drama, the action… she even laughed at the funny parts along with the other princesses. In time Melog adjusted themselves. Allowing both Glimmer and Catra to relax against them as if they were a huge pillow. Finn crawled between them and curled himself up with his blanket. His eyes were wide with wonder and awe, completely enthralled by the movie. Glimmer rubbed a hand down his arm briefly in greeting, while Catra patted his head. As the movie played, Glimmer started to snuggle against Catra's side. Wrapping her arms around Magicats bicep as she rested her head against Catra's shoulder. The Magicats leather jacket creaked softly as Glimmer rubbed her cheek against it as she got comfortable. Catra didn't even think about it, she nestled her head against the top of Glimmer's. Basking in the Queen's now calming scent, that she found soft and sweet. Humming contentedly as she kept her purr quiet. She finally had what she truly wanted, what she had craved secretly for her whole life. Strong bonds, full of caring and understanding. From friends she could count on, friends she could trust with her life. She had found…a family.

The time flew by and soon the end credits were rolling.

"Well, that was truly worth the thulite!" Andromeda commented, her deep voice was breathy and sounded a little choked up. "Got some shout outs from the Tri- Solar System for anyone willing to lend a hand. A supply freighter "Hecati" out near Quadrant R-7 has picked up a distress signal coming from Dactis. The planet was abandoned hundreds of Telks ago, after Prime eradicated the inhabitants. So that's strange. But my children do not ignore a call for help. So the freighter has changed course to investigate. I will continue to monitor Hecati's engine output and life signs in case this turns out to be a trap. Mutant ships have been sighted in the quadrant so be careful out there, my children."

Scorpia huffed and clacked a pincer anxiously, the other rubbing the back of her neck . Perfuma, who had been cuddling up to her during the movie, was quick to calm her down. Suddenly sitting upright and rubbing Scorpia's back, speaking softly. Catra glanced over to Scorpia for a moment, knowing the woman was very ardent about protecting Etheria for outside threats. The mention of Prime got her heart rate racing as well, sliding her gaze she found Spinnerella rolling her shoulder's nervously and rubbing her neck, glaring down at the floor. While Netossa whispered affirming words into her ear, seeking to calm her down.

Then Catra realized that she was also rubbing the back of her neck. She quickly snapped her hand away, confronting Glimmer's concerned frown.

"Are you alright?" She asked gently.

"Yeah…ugh…Prime kinda sets us all off, ya, know." Catra confided with a growl.

Glimmer nodded, turning to find even Mermista's hologram that had been sitting across the fire glyph relaxed and half asleep in her hammock back on the island. Was now pacing and rubbing her neck in the confines of her small cabana. Glimmer hated what Prime had done to her friends. Wished she could set them free of those noxious feelings that made them all so unsettled every time his name was mentioned. It was so unfair that Prime still had such a hold on them. Glimmer clenched her fists, frustrated by how so helpless she felt.

"Planet Rintor, is once again sending invites for challenger's for 'The Games' To all competitor's galaxy wide to compete for amazing prizes and of course bragging rights of being the Mightiest Warriors in the Tri-Solar system!" Andromeda's voice was excited. " I will be streaming the games, so, all my children. Who are too far out in the depths of space to attend can still enjoy the show!"

Frosta perked up with interest, her brooding forgotten.

“Alright before I sign off, I want to talk about Eternia. The planet has been struggling to survive for a thousand years. But everyone is accountable for their choices. Eternia chose to prey upon other planets to stay alive. Harvesting their resources and their people. It has made many enemies because of that. Andromeda’s children will always fight tyranny and injustice all over the galaxy. So I have a final request for you all.” Andromeda began, her tone was soft, beseeching her children. “Our long lost sister planet, Etheria. Has reached out to me. Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon has petitioned for all planets, all asteroids and all starbases to keep a lookout. For any of her people who had been recently harvested by Eternia and who may be being sold on the galactic slave markets. To please return them home. All those who bring Etherian’s home will be compensated, so keep your eyes peeled, ear’s clear and hearts open. Let's get these people home. ” Her ethereal voice pleaded to the cosmos.

Glimmer eyes flew wide, a few days ago she had been on Darla just hanging out in the workshop with Bow. While Brojee helped him tinker with his new weapon, Caz and Drissi were rewiring a couple drones. Litha had been there, lounging on a large pink, fluffy pillow with her Data pad. They were all sharing stories about growing up on Omega-4 and Etheria. The conversation had grown from light hearted banter to the more serious atrocities that had happened in their lives. Brojee talked about the mutant invasion and their people's enslavement on the ice moon, while Glimmer told them about how Eternia had been harvested. How her people had been stolen off world and that they were lost somewhere out in the cosmos. Litha had offered to send Andromeda a plea for aid and she had agreed.

“Remember, my children, stay safe out there and look out for one another. This has been Andromeda Stardust, signing off.” Andromeda finished, her voice faded away into that eternally lonely tone of deep space.

“WHAT! “ Frosta jumped to her feet, screeching at Glimmer.

Catra's ears pinned back as the young princesses voice was piercing. As Glimmer spun to confront a furious Frosta. Who was now stalking towards her with ice fists.

"What are you thinking!" She shouted, then rolled her eyes. "Right…you're not thinking." She growls sarcastically. "Stupid, reckless…idiot!"

"Calm down, Frosta." Netossa scrambled to her feet, reaching for the young teen.

"Frosta." Glimmer shot to her feet, raising her hands in defense as Frosta closed in.

Catra moved swiftly between them, blocking Frosta from Glimmer. The queen of Bright moon was a formidable warrior, but Frosta looked ready to kill.

"It's going to be ok." Catra advised, internally groaning at how she suddenly sounded exactly like Adora. She hated when the blonde affirmed that everything was going to work out, always an optimist. When her whole world was unraveling around her and she did not feel safe or in control. Which was exactly how Frosta felt right now!

Frosta snarled, refusing to look at Catra as she seethed towards her boots. Anger and betrayal coursed through her like acid, of all the princesses. She had counted on Catra to be on her side.

"Look, I know it's a bit of a shock and yeah, I did it on the spur of the moment. But…if you would just listen. " Glimmer confronted the rest of the Princesses. Who were staring at her with a mixture of concern and bewilderment.

"You have no right to make these decisions without consulting the rest of us!...You just put a huge target on our planet…who knows what kind of threats are going to come our way now!" Frosta shouted, shouldering Catra out of her way to get to Glimmer.

“She’s got a point, there.” Scorpia nodded. “We got enough to deal with right now, is calling out to the Galaxy for aid a good idea…I mean…you offered compensation…Etheria’s hasn’t anything to offer? I mean…we are just starting to rebuild everything.” The Scorpion was on her feet as well now, pincher’s clicking anxiously. Perfuma was hovering a few inches away, wary of her now wildly swinging tail.

“I know, I know…Litha and I were just talking and I threw it out there. I never expected her to go ahead with it.” Glimmer's heart was racing now and a part of her regretted the impetuousness of it. But a bigger part of her honestly believed that they needed to reach out, to trust that Brojee’s allies out there would look out for her people and bring them home.

“You got all high and mighty on Catra and Adora about telling you about the Eternian invasion…and now you go do this?” Frosta snapped. As Glimmer was backing away from Frosta who was stalking towards her now, fist raised high to slug her one upside the head. While Catra sought to intervene, knowing exactly how painful getting an ice fist to the face was.

“I should have said something…but I never thought Litha took me seriously…but I’m glad she did! We can’t just not help our people! We have to get them home…we have to try!” Glimmer shouted back defensively, palms sparking with light magic.

“Well, what’s done is done. I don’t know why we are making a such a big deal out of it.” Mermista shrugged.

“It is kinda a big deal though.” Netossa added, “The whole Galaxy now knows we’re back.”

“Oh, the Tri-Solar System has known we were back for at least a year.” Entrapta’s voice invaded the tense standoff between Frosta and Glimmer. Frosta spun back to the lavender haired scientist who had just reappeared again after a long absence. Frosta’s round face was even more pale than normal. Dark blue eyes shimmering with rising dread.

“I finally got our long range sensor’s online…and well…we got all kinds of starship traffic moving all around us. Some are passing through our star system, one big, weird looking ship is hiding behind Elidor…It could be Eternian…It could be the Mutants, it could be anyone really. There are thousands upon thousands of planets out there. It is truly fascinating, there's even a starbase up on Elidor…I so…want to go up there and investigate…” Entraptra started to ramble, as Frosta became more and more terrified. Before tears could escape, she bolted out of the docking bay and back into the dark corridor beyond.

Emily was quick to scuttle after her, their long legs clacking swiftly across the open bay. “Wait! Frosta!” Entrapta shouted in alarm.

“Frosta!” Spinnerella yelled, chasing after the young princess with Netossa close behind. It took only moments until the sound of both women’s horrified screams echoed from somewhere beyond the shuttle bay.

Catra and Glimmer were in motion seconds before the rest of the Princesses charged across the shuttle bay and into the dark hall. Finn cast Cyrus a look, as this would be the perfect time for the old man to show his expertise. Yet he remained rooted to his bedroll, pretending to be engrossed in whatever book he was reading.

“Fine…” Double Trouble growled low, trotting after the other’s. “Where did they go?” Perfuma’s frantic voice called from the back of the group. Catra sniffed the air for only a second, before Glimmer grabbed her arm and teleported them away. Unwilling to wait even a moment to track the three princesses down. Catra yelped in fright as her contact with the floor disappeared, followed by the sickening disorientation of passing through solid space. As the distance between them and Frosta was instantly traversed. Reappearing in a small dark room several feet away from the bay, in a flash of light.

It took Catra a moment for her eyes to adjust from the flash of brilliance from Glimmer teleport to the sudden darkness once

more. Glimmer floundered for her hand, unable to see. As Catra guided her forward cautiously. She could just make out the more solid shapes. Emily, Netossa and Spinnerella a few feet ahead and to the left. This room was small, with several alcoves on either side of the short aisle they were walking down. A central, rounded podium sat in the middle of the room.

"What is this place?" Glimmer asked, her voice soft, nervous.

"I don't know…" Catra's pupils dilated larger to bring in as much of the meager light as they could. She noticed hard,metal benches jutting out of the side of the alcoves, with vague shapes curled up at the back in a few of them. "I think, perhaps, those are cells?" She answered slowly, still uncertain about the shapes inside. But as they drew closer to Netossa and Spinnerella she was certain that they were cells. Glimmer cast a ball of light into the air, illuminating the room and the grizzly remains that lay within.

"Oh…Stars.." Glimmer gasped, releasing Catra's hand to clasp her mouth in horror.

Both Netossa and Spinnerella were standing, frozen in shock in front of them. As Catra swallowed hard, needing to contain the bile that wished to rise up her throat at the grotesque sight that lay within the cell and the raw horror at what had befallen poor Frosta.

The young princess was curled up against the back wall of the alcove, her mouth opened in a silent scream. A green forcefield buzzing over her body, like a second skin. Snapping violently with the raw voltage now coursing over her body. Right in front of her lay the shriveled, leathery remains of a mummified prisoner. Their hollow, long dead eyes staring at the young teen. Hands and legs, tucked and locked in a rigamortis fetal position. As their remains had been entombed inside their cell for a thousand years. Trapped in the very same pose as Frosta.

Chapter Three

Chapter Notes

Once again, Thank you Bitzy Bee and Pink Storm for your comments. I enjoy reading them and all those who gave Kudos.

"Because you remind me of myself. You always have. Nothing was ever easy for me either. I wasn't born to power like Adora and the others. I had to earn my power, fight for it. Why should it be any different for you?"

Shadow Weaver, Horde Prisoner

By the time the first light of dawn began to warm the sky, the Eternian camp was set ablaze. Chaos and panic reigned, as Yin and Yang howled over the tents. Laying down cover fire, as Levi and Grizzlor guided a battered and bloody, Peekablue out a tear in the back of the command tent. Rogelio slipped out behind them, quarter staff in hand and poised to protect them as they retreated. It hadn't mattered how much they had planned, the mission had gone south anyway. In the end there was no way to account for the unexpected. So now they were all just improvising and praying to make it out of this hell storm alive.

Rapid concussive blasts erupted from the edge of the camp, followed by the deafening roar of a savage beast. Levi and Grizzlor never broke stride, moving as swiftly as they could with the deadweight of a badly wounded and delirious Peekablue. While Rogelio covers their backs, jogging through the smoke and raining debris.

Kyle was laying low just beyond the camp, at the summit of a sand dune. Using his transformation magic to conceal his body, by turning his skin to sand. An energy rifle braced against his

shoulder. Staring down the sights, towards the cluster of War Sleds. Keeping a close eye on Max as he rolled out from beneath the last machine a smug self satisfied smile on his face. As a massive explosion bloomed behind him, a couple Snakemen had mounted a war sled he had booby trapped earlier. Trying to escape the death trap inferno the camp had become.

Max ducked and wrapped his arms over his head, as metal debris rained down over him. His ears were ringing from being too close to the blast, he had no way to react fast enough to avoid the charging Beast man. Now exploding from the fire and smoke directly at him. The malice and rage burning in his eyes froze Max in terror. As the hulking monster was at least seven feet tall, covered in a thick mat of dark brown fur that hid a massive body of tightly packed muscle. He barely wore any armor, just a simple leather pauldron on his right shoulder, strapped in place with a thin belt that ran across his huge chest. His groin was protected only by a leather and chainmail loincloth. The only piece of adornment he wore was a necklace made of tiger teeth.

His face was broad, with a large protruding jaw and long tusks, jutting out of the sides of his mouth. His eyes were cowled under a thick forehead. A set of dark horn's ran down the center of his shorn head, with a thick dark ponytail at the back. That whipped back and forth as he moved, like a war banner. His large wolf-like ears were pinned flat to his head.

The beast man closed in fast, his power and speed unmatched. With his massive paws raised, savage claws unsheathed and poised to strike. As Max cowered before him, all his Horde training was forgotten. Petrified by the hulking predator bearing down upon him, unable to think straight enough to move.

"Max!" Kyle screamed, his finger compressing on the trigger several times on instinct. The energy bolts flared at the end of the long mussel, then shot like angry starlight towards the War Sled hovering right in front of Max. Just as the Beast man closed in. The shots landed upon the curved hood, as the snarling monster

swiped at Max with massive hands, savage claws prepared to gut him.

The sled exploded right beside the beast, the flash of fire blinding him for a moment. As the smoke and debris gave Max cover to escape. When the smoke cleared enough for Kyle’s vision down the scope to see again. Max wasn't moving, he had crumpled to the ground? Kyle swallowed hard, at Max’s prone body laying face first on the sand. A crimson pool forming underneath him.

He hadn’t been fast enough to prevent the fatal attack…Kyle’s heart sank and guilt fell over him like a suffocating blanket.

“Ro! We got a man down! I need you to break formation and head to those hover sleds. I got you in my sights, and Yin and Yang are keeping those Eternian’s busy. So your route should be clear, but the Beasty guy just took Max out!” Kyle shouted to the strike team over the com’s.

Levi’s stride faltered at Kyles word’s nearly dropping Peekablue, who was being supported between her and Grizzlor.

Rogelio snarled and turned on his heel, charging away into the smoke before Levi could intervene. Her eyes grew wet, a painful, stricken expression twisting her features. As she watched the Lizard-kin disappear, before grinding her teeth and resuming her mission. Grizzlor, shook his head. Moving to take Peekablue’s full weight. Easing the seer's arm from around Levi’s shoulder and leaning his prone body over his fuzzy shoulder in a fireman’s carry.

“I got him, go make sure those two make it back to the cave in one piece.” He growled. Shuffling off with Peekablue, his beady eyes alert to the billowing smoke around him. His pace increased as he got used to Peekablues added weight. Rapidly, disappearing into the wall of smoke ahead.

Levi nodded, turning on her heel and unsheathing her quarter staff as she charged after Rogelio.

(Master…what is wrong?") The soft, gentle voice of Yin echoed in Kyle's turbulent mind, with concern.

Kyle took a deep breath, he got used to hearing his new friends in his mind over the last week. But their sudden invasion into his thoughts was still unnerving at times, especially now. When he was under severe stress and worry.

"Max is hurt…like really hurt bad." Kyle whispered, keeping a close eye on Max through the scope of his rifle. Gasping in both surprise and hope as he watches both Rogelio and Levi charge out of the smoke towards the Beast guy. Flanking him on either side.

(We come to help!) Yang's deep voice echoed next, earnest and full of fury.

Kyle grit his teeth, yes, he would really like them to come help to make sure Rogelio and Levi survived this battle. But Grizzlor needed back up too…

"NO! Stay on Grizzlor, maintain cover fire until he is safe inside the canyon's caves." Kyle commanded, bracing his shoulder more firmly on the butt of his rifle. As he laid down strafing fire at the Beast guy's feet, forcing him to leap backwards and right into Rogelio's grasp. The lizard-kin was at least a head shorter but he had bulk and brute strength to take this beast on hand to hand.

Levi came in hard and fast, swinging for the Beast's knees to trip him up. Between the three of them they quickly put the monster on the defensive.

With a howl of frustration and rage, the beast turned tail and ran. Disappearing into the smoking remains of his camp.

"Alright Kyle send up the flare, so the transport can come in and lock down the camp." Levi ordered through the com.

Kyle nodded and stood up, his transformation fell away as he unlatched the bulky flare gun from his utility belt and fired it skyward. The flare screamed up into the bright blue sky, exploding into a cloud of green smoke. Kyle never watched to make sure it had gone off, he was already sliding down the sand dune. Breaking into a sprint as soon as he got on level ground. Moving at top speed towards Max's limp body laying next to the smoldering remains of the hover sleds.

As he reached Max's body, Levi had already turned him over and had his head braced in her lap. Rogelio was crouched low on his haunches, growling, his long slender tail lashing behind him. Kyle understood his lover's display of impotent rage and helplessness. He felt the very same way.
"I got this buddy…" Kyle slid on the sand next to Max, shrugging off his utility vest. Unzipping the largest pocket at the back and pulling out a modest med kit and quickly began to ascertain Max's wounds. Swallowing hard and fighting back tears, as he took in the deep, ugly gashes across his chest. What was left of his poncho and shirt was shredded and hung off his shoulder in tattered rag's. There was so much blood! Kyle was reluctant to look further down, but he did. Finding all his hope fleeing as he saw the massive damage to Max's stomach. The Beast had literally gutted him, his entrails were hanging from the wound, dangling over his side and onto the ground. The internal damage was so extensive, that whatever he might have in his field medical kit was completely useless.

"He's not breathing." Levi wailed, tears flowing down her face. As she cupped Max's cheeks, he was so pale and cold.

Rogelio howled low in his throat, as he pressed the side of his head against Max's chest. He couldn't hear a heartbeat either.

Max was dead…

Kyle grit his teeth, he wasn't going to give up. He may not be able to help but he had been brought back from death's door. So he knew what to do.

“We need Adora!” Kyle commanded, taping his com in his ear to call Lonnie.

“Is she alive?” Netossa questioned, her voice breathless with panic. As she knelt in front of Frosta. Her trembling fingers inches away from brushing the forcefield, that was pulsing maliciously around the young teen’s body.

“I don’t know…” Catra crouched beside her. “I can’t get close enough to tell…she looks frozen.”

“The Forcefield has contracted around her like a cocoon.” Entrapta’s voice responded, the clacking of Emily’s legs upon the metal floor echoing behind them.

“Is she dead?” Glimmer turned beseeching the hologram scientist.

“I don’t know, at this point all I have is data or the lack thereof. For right now we can deduce that she is neither alive nor is she dead. We can not determine that until we free her from the forcefield.” Entrapta sighed, as Emily clanked over to the access panel beside the alcove. Several automated tool’s shot out of small compartments, attached to Emily’s hull. The robot quickly detached the panel, giving Entrapta access to look at the wiring and crystal matrix within. Then a thick cord with an adaptor shot out from just beneath Emily’s energy core, plugging into a docking port inside the panel.

“It looks like this forcefield is glitching...it is programmed to hold a life sign inside the cell. Instead the force fields are sealing the life sign in an energy cocoon.” Entrapta advised. “The force field activated when the rooms sensor’s picked up Frosta's life sign in the alcove…it will not disengage until the life sign fades.” Her voice was slow and concerned. “So technically since the forcefield is still active, she is still alive…for now.” Entrapta offered them a

small encouraging smile, her focus still completely on her monitor's.

"So she trapped unless she die's." Spinnerella exclaimed, her voice high and tight with stress.

"Deactivate it!" Catra commanded, pointing at the access panel with a claw.

"I don't know how…" Entrapta muttered…"Yet" She clarified, as rapid clicks of her keyboard amplifying the tension in the small room.

"I know some people who may be able to help." Glimmer blinked away in a flash. Reappearing with both Caz and Drissi, still dressed in their pj's. Caz was in a white t-shirt and pair of red and black plaid sleep pants. Drissi's more robust frame was in a fuzzy dark blue onesie, with a bear hood hanging low around his broad shoulders.

"What's going on?' Caz questioned, groggily. Rubbing a fist into his eye as he struggled to wake up.

Drissi was able to become alert much faster, when he realized they had been teleported into strange surroundings.

"Frosta's trapped, we need your help?' Glimmer pointed towards the open access panel. Emily detached her connection cord and stomped away, allowing the boys to take a look inside.

"I need my tools." Drissi muttered, focusing on tracking the course of the wiring of the power grid. Already mapping the various crystal diodes embedded inside.

"On it!" Glimmer exclaimed, blinking away in a flash of light only to reappear a second later realizing she had no idea what tools he needed or what they even looked like, snatching Caz. "I have no idea what they look like." She commented, as Caz yelped in fright as she teleported them away.

“This is ancient…” Drissi muttered, tapping his chin with his index finger.

“It’s First Ones tech.” Entrapta’s hologram offered pedantically, as Emily scanned the doorframe of the cell. Attempting to trace the forefield emitters, in the hopes of shutting them down.

Drissi cringed, then nodded, rubbing a hand down his face. As his once bleak stare became hard with determination and resolve.

“Is that a bad thing?” Catra inquired, sliding up to him to stare over his shoulder. As if she might have any clue as to what he was trying to figure out and be able to help.

“It’s not great…” Drissi mumbled. “First Ones tech is…tricky…”

Catra started to nibble on her lower lip anxiously, as the seconds ticked by.

“It’s powered by crystals…which makes it volatile. ” Entrapta offered, as Emily finished her scan. Clunking away to the side of the doorway, with a sad beep to relay her data back to Entrapta. The emitters were so deeply embedded into the door frame they would have to dismantle it to reach them and that would take too long.

Catra cast Entrapta a strained look the scientist knew well. Her frayed nerves showing in her twitching eye and her patience thinning, she hated feeling so useless.

“Remember on Darla. How, I had to synchronize the energy output between the crystals of the ship and Arxia?” Entratpat began to explain as plainly as she could.

“Yes.” Catra answered, crisply.

“Crystal’s are easy to blow up.” Drissi answered bluntly, cutting off Entrapta’s long explanation.

“Exactly.” Entrapta nodded.

“So basically, if you screw up we’re all dead?” Netossa snapped from inside the cell. Even worse was since they were so deep underground if they blew up Arxia even just a part of the outpost. Mystcor would suffer damage as well, resulting in more civilian casualties topside.

“Basically.” Drissi shrugged.

Catra groaned and stormed away needing a minute to absorb the grim outcome of the situation. Struggling to tamp down on her growing rage at herself, for bringing everyone down here and putting them all in danger. She had been so happy to have the princesses supporting her, wanting to be with her during this expedition. But it had been selfish and reckless and she loathed that she had allowed herself to be so weak.

“Oh, Wow…you guys were hard to find.” Scorpia’s voice rang out from the main doors of the brig.

“How can we help?” Perfuma offered, watching Catra pace and brush down her short hair as she struggled to maintain her composure. She was irritated at Frosta for storming off and getting herself ‘killed’. Frustrated at Glimmer…for setting Frosta off, with her impulsiveness. Angry at herself for being so stupid and happy that all her friends wanted to come along and had not assessed the risks at all. She deserved the crushing guilt consuming her. Struggling to take in a good breath. Overwhelmed by how scared she was, that they might all be in a no win scenario and it was all her fault!

“Wild Cat?” Scorpia had seen Catra, stressed and spirally many times. She could see the signs of a coming emotional explosion.

“Just give me a moment.” Catra snarled back, swallowing the seething fury that wanted to erupt. Her claws extended with the need to shred something…anything. Just to release the violence boiling inside of her.

“Alright, then we need a contingency plan.” Spinnerella took charge, giving Netossa’s shoulder a reassuring squeeze before leaving the cell.

“If this place is going to explode, then how will it explode?” The lilac haired princess demanded, arms crossed over her buxom chest.

Finn trotted from behind Scorpia, glancing around the room nervously.

“Go back to the cargo bay Finn.” Catra pointed out of the door, commanding the little boy to leave.

“But…” Finn started to argue.

Catra would have none of it, he did not need to see the long dead corpses or Frosta. That was very potent nightmare fuel and as his ‘Mother’, she would protect him from that kind of trauma.

“I will take him back, but here I think these notes may come in handy.” Cyrus walked into the room, holding out a black, leather bound journal. It was open to a certain page and tagged with a silk royal blue bookmark, towards Catra.

“What is this?” Catra took the book, scanning the page with interest. It was written in Shadow Weaver’s tiny scrawl, with several intricate drawn diagrams.

“Light Spinner used her knowledge of Stone Masonry to map the crystal matrix of Arixia. It was the basis of her first endeavors in recreated Rune Stones within amulets.” Cyrus offered with a shrug.

“We mapped the catacombs, as we explored it. Most of the Magic traps are contained around the Crystal of Arxia. Which have since been dispelled. The further you go down the less they are, usually set off by setting foot inside the glyphs. But Arxia has other danger’s, it’s security system for example. I was curious as to why you guys were not setting off any of sensor’s as we went deeper

past the Crystal of Arxia. But I soon realized that your bot over there was disrupting the sensor's embedded into the walls and floors. That's why it was walking ahead, why it didn't want Frosta to leave the bay without it. " Cyrus smiled softly, then placed a hand on Finn's shoulder and forcefully guided him back out. Finn was staring up at him with confusion and reluctant respect, leaving without any further argument.

Better late than never, Double Trouble grumbled in their mind.

Catra threw her head back and laughed, the high pitched cackle was jagged and sharp. "How could I have been so careless…I saw Emily scanning ahead of us." She snarled, stalking towards Emily. "I just took for granted that since I didn't see any glyphs on the floor that there just weren't any traps. I didn't even think about the starbases security system." She quickly got control of her bitter laughter then spun upon Entrapta, her eyes burning with barely contained fury. " Why didn't you say anything?" Catra accused Entrapta, stalking toward Emily. Claws unsheathed and muscles coiling to strike.

Entrapta merely blinked in confusion. "You were already inside the catacombs when I came online, I assumed you knew? How do you think I managed to get down to the Arxia Crystal all by myself earlier? I programmed Emily to set off the magic glyphs so I could disable them and scramble the sensor's so the Security System couldn't pick up my life signs as we explored deeper. "

"How would I have known!" Catra snapped back, "Stop, assuming everyone is as smart as you are!"

"Cyrus figured it out…" Entrapta pouted. "Regardless, what happened to Frosta wasn't a trap…nor was it part of the Security System. It's a degradation of the program for the force fields, here in this room." She defended, turning away from Catra and ignoring the angry Magicat outright. Focusing on her work instead, ignoring Catra's fuming glare.

“Calm down, Wild Cat.” Scorpia moved towards her, pincher’s raised to hold Catra back as she looked ready to shred Emily right then and there. As retaliation for Entrapta’s lack of communication skills.

Catra snapped her heated glare towards Scorpia who cringed and shrank instantly. The Scorpioni’s obvious discomfort and nervous gesture to defend herself was enough to douse Catra in a cold realization. She was under so much stress and guilt she was reverting back to her old, toxic coping behavior. Of getting mad, blaming others and lashing out.

“Fuck…” Catra growled, closing her eyes and taking a deep breath to try and calm down. When she opened her eyes, she found Perfuma had closed in. Now standing right in front of her, blocking her from the others. Staring at her with stern yet compassionate eyes.

Her words, from the river echoing like a reprimand in Catra memory.

(That's your mind, Catra! It is so full of negative thoughts, they howl and rage against your peace of mind. How can you throw your stone? You can't see what kind of ripples it will make...how your actions will affect your world.. until it's too late? You have trapped yourself in a loop of reaction and regret...I want to help you break free of it...if you will let me.”)

“I”m trying…I’m trying…” Catra hissed, her voice hoarse and wavering.

“Good.” Perfuma nodded, waiting for Catra to regain control of her temper.

“I’m sorry…Scorp…Trap…I’m really upset about Frosta…and I’m scared…I will try harder not to lash out at you…you don’t deserve it.” Catra moaned, as she admitted her weakness, ducking her head in remorse. Keeping her heart open, finding the courage to be vulnerable, to trust.

“This couldn’t have been prevented.” Netossa commented. “Frosta knew how dangerous this place was. She was also upset and did not think her actions through. Right now we all have to focus on what we can do to help her survive.”

“Right.” Perfuma spun and nodded, marching towards the cell to see if her magic could help. Scorpia offered Catra a weak smile, accepting her apology and then turns to follow Perfuma.

Entrapa’s hologram hovered near the cell, with her mask pulled down. Working diligently to crack the code to the Force Field. She was hiding, unable to cope with Catra’s angry tirade, or to accept her apology. As the ugly scars from Catra’s betrayal so long ago flared and choked her ability to speak, or to deal with any more stimuli.

Catra felt horrible, with a pitiful moan, she pressed the open book to her chest as if it was a shield to protect her from Entrapta’s disregard. Once again forgiveness was not instantly given and she was struggling to cope. She moved as far as she could away from everyone and slipped to the floor. With her knees tucked under her chin, tail wrapped tight around her ankles. The weight of her remorse, her guilt at failing to protect Frosta crushing her.

(Do not allow your shadow’s to consume you, there is always hope.) Melog’s deep, rumbling voice echoed in her mind. Catra turned her gaze behind her, finding the glowing flame of Melog’s mane illuminating the darkness. The warm light cast from their body washing over her. As they strode proudly into the room and settled down beside her. With a nod and a sigh, Catra set the book down beside her. Reading its contents in a valiant attempt to find anything useful.

Glimmer reappeared in a flash of light with Caz once more, toting a large, clunky, gray metal tool box and a smaller red medi pack. Glimmer immediately noticed Catra’s defeated pose, upon the floor. Sitting aloof and bowed in the far side of the room with Melog. Reading a book in her lap by the firelight of her right palm.

Glimmer moved swiftly to her side and crouched beside her, a gentle, reassuring presence.

“Light Spinner was a Stone Mason before she was part of the Sorcerer guild. She was obsessed with Rune Stones and First Ones tech. ” Catra began, “She mapped both the power and data crystals inside Arxia…” Catra tapped the diagrams with a claw, lightly.

“That’s great! That should help…let's get that over to Drissi and Caz.” Glimmer snatched the book away from her and dashed over to the boys.

Drissi had his tools out, small, slender picks that he was tapping inside the panel. Sparks and crackling erupted from the wires that were still active with energy. While Entrapta hovered beside him, offering him advice and any knowledge she had gained about First Ones tech. The young man was nodding, but focused on his task.

While Caz was standing inside the cell, licking his bottom lip nervously.

“Would one of you guys mind getting that dead guy out of there? I need room to move in this broom closet.” He grumbled, backing out.

Scorpia merely nodded and moved into the cell, clasping the corpse's feet by the ankles with her pincers and dragging it out. The body's dry brittle bones crunched under the slight pressure of her claws and the moldy, decayed clothes rustled like dried leaves as she dragged it out. Perfuma cringed at the creepy sounds, giving Scorpia lots of room to drag the body out of sight and into the shadows, further into the room.

“I got a schematic of the crystal cores inside that panel.” Glimmer offered, setting the book down beside Entrapta.

“Perfect! We do not want to overload the matrix.” The Princess of Dryl exclaimed, quickly crouching down to trace the old sketch

with her finger. Instructing Drissi as to what crystal was which, so he could start to disassemble the matrix.

It only took a few minutes for the two boys and Entrapta to deactivate the forcefield. It fizzled out with a pop, allowing Frosta's twisted limbs to relax and fall limply to the floor.

Caz had been kneeling beside her as the forcefield dropped with the crew's med kit. He quickly got to work, laying his head down upon Frosta's chest to check to see if she was still breathing or if her heart had stopped.

"Please don't hurt me Ice Queen when you wake up." he muttered his sassy nickname for her. That he used just to piss her off, cause he was a natural shit disturber and struggled to act nice and polite when he knew someone hated him. Every encounter he had had with the Princess of Snows had been blunt and full of animosity. He was sure she wanted to punch him, but had been valiantly restraining herself.

"Her heart is still beating faintly but she is not breathing." Caz moaned, squeezing his eyes shut tight. "She is sooooo going to hurt…me." He whimpered, as he began C.P.R. Pressing his lips over Frosta's and pushing air into her lungs, as he started chest compressions. Repeating the process, as the rest of the Princesses hovered around the cell anxiously.

"Come on…Ice Queen…" Caz growled, as he pressed his lips over Frosta's once more before doing more chest compressions.

Spinnerella moaned, ducking her head into Netossa's shoulder as she wept.

Glimmer stood with her hands clenched tight into fists, willing Frosta to live by the determination in her stare. Perfuma stood beside Scorpia, her eyes wet with unshed tears. Scorpia glanced over her shoulder as Entrapta's hologram flickered out as she cut her connection to Emily. She had done all she could to help and could not bear to witness the outcome.

Catra never moved from her spot apart from the other's, her expression was hard, detached, her eyes staring at some distant view.

"Dammit!" Caz snarled, unzipping the med kit and pulling out a strange device with a flip screen, wires and a pair of paddles. He quickly unzipped Frosta's jacket and then with a pair of scissor's cut open her t-shirt beneath.

"What are you doing!" Glimmer demanded, as Drissi moved in front of her and held her back with a raised hand.

"That is a defibrillator, her heart's stopped." Drissi stated, sadly. "It will send an electrical shock to her heart to get it going again."

"We need She-Ra!" Perfuma exclaimed.

Catra was in action, pulling out her com pad and sending a call to Adora. She waited, holding her breath as the call went through with no response.

"She's not picking up!" Catra scrambled to her feet and dashed for Glimmer, her face pale and full of fear.

"If she is inside the Crystal Castle, it's a total dead zone. Her pad would not pick up a signal." Glimmer sighed, she knew from experience. The Best Friend Squad had spent months when Adora first got her power's trying to navigate inside the Beacon and the other set of ruins further north. Getting lost and unable to communicate to anyone outside of the structure. Thankfully they made it out in one piece, the security system inside pretty much ignored them cause they never made it very far and they never touched anything.

"What do we do?" Catra breathed, her voice trembling with dread.

"Fuck! Drissi, when was the last time we charged this piece of crap!" Caz shouted in dismay.

“How would I know!” Drissi shouted back.

“It’s dead.” Caz snarled, throwing the paddles to the ground in defeat.

Perfuma turned to Scorpia, eyes wide in sudden clarity.

“Scorpia can do it!” She offered.

“I can…” Scorpia stuttered.

“Use your lightning to shock her heart.” Perfuma nodded, pointing to Frosta.

“You're the only one who can save her.” Catra was in action, dashing across the room and pulling on Scorpia’s pincher’s. Forcing the taller woman’s frozen feet to shuffle forward. Perfuma’s smile as Scorpia moved off was proud, yet sad. Catra’s positive action and encouraging words. Was exactly what Scorpia needed, yet she couldn’t help but feel jealous. Of how Scorpia still turned to the Magicat for affirmation. She so wanted to be the woman Scorpia turned to for love and support. Perhaps in time, Perfuma may be soft spoken and naturally kind, but she was also patient. She also wanted Scorpia to realize her own self worth and stop looking to other’s for affirmation and praise.

“You can do this, Scorp.” Catra whispered ardently, her eyes were wide and pleading, her voice was strong, confident. So certain in Scorpia’s abilities that she had complete faith in her.

Catra’s unwavering reassurance emboldened Scorpia, she smiled softly down at the magicat and nodded.

“I can do this…I can do this…” Scorpia muttered, as she kneeled down next to Caz.

Who took her pincher’s and set them where they needed to be on Frosta’s bear chest. Scorpia closed her eyes and focused upon her magic…manifesting her pure intentions, by visualizing the

outcome she wished to invoke upon the real world. Just like Njouron had taught her.

The point of each of the pincher's flared a brilliant crimson and a spark of lightning shocked Frosta. Her small chest jumped as the electric charge coursed through her.

"Again!" Caz shouted, as he rose up from listening to Frosta's chest. He had no other way to monitor for a heart beat, since their equipment was dead. It was so frustrating.

Scorpia charged her pincher's and jolted Frosta again. Her chest jumped off the ground and then settled back down with a dull slap.

"We got a heartbeat!" Caz shouted, moving off her chest and checking if she was breathing. "She's breathing…we're in the clear." he offered Scorpia a beaming smile. "That was Awesome!" he shook his head in awe and disbelief.

Scorpia chuckled and stood up, shuffling away with her face beat red and proud tears streaming down her face.

"What happened…" Frosta moaned, slowly pushing herself up off the ground.

Caz was quick to scramble out of the cell and out of ice fist range. As Frosta suddenly noticed that her jacket was open and her shirt was cut open revealing her bare, modest breasts. She squawked indignantly, but her voice was cut off as both Netossa and Spinnerella enveloped her in a tight hug.

"We almost lost you…" Spinerella advised softly.

"Scorpia saved you." Netossa kissed Frosta cheek, "So did Drissi, Caz and Entrapta."

Frosta was alarmed, her mouth dropping open in disbelief. As her blue eyes grew moist with gratitude. It had all happened too fast,

she had been crying and trying to find a hiding place to calm down. Then nothing, just darkness…

"We were so scared…" Glimmer cried, as she dove in and hugged the young teen as well.

Frosta was now completely smothered between three women.

"Well breathing is becoming an issue again…guys…" Frosta squealed, in a muffled slightly strangled voice.

The three women were quick to detach.

Frosta took in several deep breaths, casting them each a rueful look.

"Glad you're still with us, Snowflake." Catra grinned down at her, tears finally breaking free to fall down her cheeks.

Frosta had never seen Catra cry before. The feline was becoming more open and genuine with showing her emotions around others. Her once sharp edges have softened, her once hard impenetrable walls shattered. As she was now surrounded by people who cared about her. Allowing herself to care about them in return.

"I'm glad too." Frosta admitted with a genuine smile of gratitude.

Kingdom of Light and Shadow

Chapter Notes

> Thank you once again to Bitzy Bee and Pink Storm for your comments. We are now on the final part of this Arc, things are going to get intense.

"Those are daisies. I find them cheerful." Shadow Weaver, Traitor to the Horde

-Catra-

The expedition was canceled, at least for a large group. Glimmer had teleported everyone back out. After Frosta's near death accident. Then Casta had declared the catacombs off limits. So for the next three days Catra trained with Cyrus out beyond the Citadel within the Tranquil Garden's. Seeking out all of Beatrix's old hiding spots around the lower bastion's with him. That she had used to hide stolen journal's before joining the ranks of the Sorcerer's Guild. Uncovering a dark magic book the High Council had not found. Written by a Dark Mage, long before Mara's time called Gorta. Catra quickly discovered that Gorta's research at its core was on the Duality of Magic. With regards to the Sanctuary Spell, which was depicted in the stained glass in the atrium back at the Elemental Basilica and another spell…a spell of his own creation, the spell of Obtainment. His journal was complex and difficult to read; she made slow but steady progress with the help of Beatrix's many, many cliff notes that she had scrawled in the corners and along the edges of each page. By the worn out look of the journal and how much Beatrix had defaced the pages she thoroughly erased Gorta's research and made it her own. She had no intention of ever taking that journal back into the Master Library or wherever she might have found it.

Catra was also exploring deeper into Arxia with Cyrus in secret. Unwilling to risk her friends again. Using Light Spinner's journals, Cyrus had in his possession to navigate safely into the very depths of the outpost. Listening to stories of his youth with Beatrix. Finding her Guardian in the Horde, was more than just the cruel, manipulative, power hungry tyrant she would one day become. She had been a child, an adolescent struggling to prove herself, to be seen, to be heard, to be trusted and respected by a society that despised her on sight, just because of her heritage.

With the communications Entrapta had decrypted on her pad. She had also spent many hours scouring through the mundane, detritus. Of the long dead First Ones who manned Arxia, personal logs. She had managed to single out only a few communications that held real clues as to what happened a thousand years ago and it wasn't a surprise that those logs belonged to Senator Keldor. It seemed the Heart of Etheria, had been classified as a Power Source. That it's capabilities were limitless, to be used to finally end the war with Prime. But Catra had a feeling it was more than just that, the fact that there were three other's built on the four core planets. That She-Ra had been a part of some super weapon? Ultimately it was part of a greater plan, a secret initiative? That only this Galactic Council and perhaps the Senator's who rule the core planets knew the truth about. Now her and Cyrus had a clear mission inside Arxia. She wanted to find Keldor's old quarter's, His true plans for Etheria so long ago would lay there. She was certain of that. She had a clear mission and was focused on a goal.

In regards to her elemental magic training with Cyrus. She finally felt she had made breakthroughs in both her magic wielding and with her own research into Hybrid Magic at least in regards to her own element. It was a modest step forward, but it made her feel a sense of accomplishment.

-Adora-

An endless sky of pale slate blue flowed over her head. It seemed to go on forever, unblemished by a single cloud. She had been laying here since well before the day moon rose. Watching as the light struggled to bring forth a new day. The world still hung in that tranquil state of half-light, sluggish to transition between night to day.

The soft smell of flowers surrounded her. Adora turned her head, finding the dainty, fragile stems and delicate petals of daisies. The air was crisp and a bit thin, making Adora slightly light headed. She knew she was in another memory, that was not her own. But it wasn't Mara's and it wasn't Angella's then who's? Alien feelings that were not her own began to overwhelm Adora, as her soul bonded to these memories. This was her favorite place, where she felt hidden within the blanket of flowers, safe and able to relax enough. That she could become lost to her fantasies. Her mind at ease, able to conjure the grand things that she desperately yearned for, that lay far beyond her bleak surroundings. Able to retreat at least for a while and not be burdened by constant strife in her real life.

The daisies offered color and sweet scents that allowed her to retreat into whimsy and focus on a more positive outlook upon her life. That perhaps one day she could escape, one day she would be truly happy?

She found them…cheerful.
"Trixie!" A strong, firm voice called out to her, carried by the cold wind.

Adora turned and slowly, reluctantly rolled off her back and knelt upon the frozen earth. Revealing herself above the blanket of flowers. She glanced around the flat heath covered in daisies. Her eyes scanned the endless tundra that stretched beyond the flower's, towards a cluster of sickly looking pine and spruce trees. That were struggling to grow, their trunks thin and twisted in the hard packed earth. The needles were pale and sparse upon the

spindle like branches. More trees clung behind the young growth, more robust and darker in tone. Crawling up the foothills and steppes of the rugged mountains looming behind the forest.

“Nana?” Adora called, back. In a tender, soft voice she did not recognize. Scrambling up to her feet and running towards the tree line. Her eyes darted at every shadow and rustle within the underbrush. Always alert and wary of what might lay in wait to ambush her as she moved deeper into the forest. It wasn’t just wild animal’s that may be a threat, but bandits as well. Her Nana’s had just chased off a small band of would-be robber's just a couple days back and a few of the stragglers that had survived, may still be lurking in the forest that surrounded their home. The constant uncertainty she lived everyday, ate at her. She worried everyday about many things. If she would get anything to eat, if her Nana would get sick or hurt fighting off whatever predator’s or stranger’s managed to stumble upon their secluded home. If she would die…

She was all she had left…her father had been murdered, when she was just an infant in a raid on their village. Her mother had taken her to the forest to live with her grandmother from then on. Hoping that the seclusion and ambiguity of her Grandmother's hidden cottage would allow her to grow up safely. But her mother had succumbed to sickness last cold season.

Here on the tundra beyond the Barrier mountains. Where little to nothing grew and the herd animals moved through only during the cool season as they migrated down towards better grazing on the other side of the mountains. Food and resources were in short supply for most of the year. Those banished upon this frozen waste land, had to fight for what little they could lay claim to. So she had grown up fast and hard, as only the strong survived here.

She traveled down a narrow trail, hopping from stone to stone. Her shoes had worn thin and the soles were little to no protection against the thistles that crawled along the scrub grass. Moving deeper into the dark wood, as the trees began to loom over her.

The stones were slippery with lichen and moss, but her movements were well practiced and her balance was precise at every skip and hop. As she made her way home.

She smelled the sweet, earthy musk of wood smoke first. The stillness in the air was not uncommon but not welcome either. Usually, the sharp calls of birds would be in the air early in the morning. Unless predator's had spooked them into the air at dawn and they were miles away. Naturally her heart began to pound with anxiety. She was small and weak and could not hold her own in a fight, but she was fast and wily which was her best and only defense.

In time she came to a clay and log house that blended in with the woods so well it was almost invisible. A specter of wood smoke, curled from a stone chimney. The walls were weathered and worn, matching the faded colors of its surroundings. It was as if the house was growing out of the earth itself. With trees towering around it, as if forming a protective barrier wall from the rest of the world. The slanted roof was woven with thatch and held down by field stones. It had a porch, barely large enough for two people to stand on with a heavy oak door. There was only one small, square paned window just off from the porch. It had no curtains, the glass was stained yellow from age and withstanding many storm's over the years.

Upon the porch, standing in the open doorway was a tall woman. She wore simple tan woolen pants and a heavy, gray, woven long sleeve shirt. A coarse weave, shawl hung around her bent shoulder's to ward off the chill in the air.

Her dark hair was fine and straight, graying on the temples. Chopped straight along her strong jaw. Her features seemed cut from regal stone, with high cheekbones and exotic eyes that slant upward, her pupils were faded, nearly white. Blinded by cataracts. Her pale lavender skin was weathered from age, her slender pointed ears wrinkled and drooping at the tips. As she leaned upon a crudely carved walking staff, harvested from the forest itself.

“Trixie, you know better than to wander so far from home, when there are stranger’s about.” The elderly woman chastised, as the little girl dashed through the door. Not fast enough though to evade the stick, striking the back of her head.

The dull thwap was earned, but worth it. As she rushed to the stone fireplace at the back of the single room home, warming herself by the fire. Catching sight of herself, upon the warped iron pot hanging within the flame.

Finding a small waif of a girl, dirty and starving staring back. With sharp, emerald green eyes that held an iron will, Adora recognized. With long dark hair, hanging wild and dirty down her back, with grass, twigs and leaves collected from her time laying upon the ground. Pale, dusk colored skin and sharp pointed ears that cut like blades through her dark hair along her slender, elvish face. Wearing nothing but rags upon her boney frame. Her pants were gray and thread bare, the knees long worn through. With a woven, tan long sleeve shirt that hung two sizes too big off her shoulder, with a darker gray wool sweater thrown over top that hung low near her knees.

Adora recognized the child looking back at her…she had spent her youth being molded and shaped by her adult self. Into some ruthless, cutthroat soldier, a weapon that she had hoped to wield against all those who opposed her. In her endless coupe for more power.

(Shadow Weaver?) Adora’s spirit gasped.

“Beatrix, quickly gather our trinkets and meet me outside. I want to be down at Skara by noon and home by dark.” The elder woman commanded, gathering a couple cloaks and two half veils from a set of hooks near the door.

A thrill of excitement churned in her belly, this would be the first time Nana took her to Skara and didn’t leave her behind in the forest. She had spent her childhood, hidden up in the mountains, unable to explore very far beyond the glade of daisies. The sense

of adventure and the unknown, made her skin hum with anticipation.

Adora felt herself nod, as she slowly took in the one room cabin. That spoke of a grim squalor and the savagery of survival here on the Tundra. There was a small round table with two straight back chairs near the single window. A tiny counter that held only the basic items needed for cooking. A wooden basin, a block of knives, dried herbs crumbled into bowls tucked at the back of the cutting board. A single hay mattress pushed tight against the back wall next to the hearth with a large wooden wardrobe and stool. The most unnerving thing about the tiny cabin. The walls were covered in bones. Standing out in pale relief against the dark log walls, all hanging in a manner of importance as if on display. Proud racks of antlers covered in chalk drawn symbols and long rib bones, with runes carved along their length that looked more like art pieces than decoration. The plain wooden mantle above the fireplace was a series of bleached skulls. Some were the elongated shape of prey animals, other's held the sharp teeth of predator's, some were very apparently human or hybrid in nature.

Another table was set near the fire, where some of the smaller bones were assembled into bracelets, necklaces or earrings. Some adorned objects of purpose, such as quills, brushes and hair pins. All decorated more ornately with beads and feathers. There were stacks of bones in the far corner that seemed like discarded refuse from crafting.

Adora quickly jogged to the crafting table and began to gather the items, tucking them into a hide sack that had been sitting beneath the table. Then slinging the sack over her shoulder by its single hemp rope strap. She knew she had to move quickly and efficiently lest she get struck by her Nana's stick again.

It took half a day to travel by foot down the mountain to their closest city, a settlement known as Skara. Hidden in the Highlands

of Bright Moon at the very base of the Barrier Mountains. They passed through several smaller villages that surrounded Skara. That were scattered along their route. Consisting of squat, wattle and daub walled houses, sheathed in flagstone. That was sunk into the ground, sitting clustered within the shelter of the hills. As they drew closer to Skara, Beatrix could see the massive wall that enclosed the city; what lay within was still a mystery.

Her grandmother had walked unerringly down the foot trail's from the mountain's, and then down the dusty roads when they reached the foothills. It was uncanny how the old woman who was no doubt blind. Could still navigate almost effortlessly through the labyrinth of forests and now down the busy dirt road that led to the city.

As they crested the last hill, Beatrix saw the tall timber enclosing wall. That protected the settlement from the harsh weather that battered the buildings during the cold season and also provided a barrier keeping bandits out.

As they got close, her grandmother quickly put on her cloak and veil and made Beatrix do the same.

"Stay hidden, while we are within those walls. Child." she advised, her eyes grew cold and piercing. Demanding that her rather impulsive and impertinent grandchild obey her.

"I hate covering my face, I can't breathe." Beatrix grumbled, as she clasped her dark brown cloak around her shoulders and pulled up her hood. Tucking the bone carved hooks on the side of her pale blue veil over the tops of her pointed ears.

"You are too young to understand. But as a Gar, you must hide your identity when among Etherians. If you take off your veil for any reason, I shall punish you right then and there. " the old woman advised with a cluck, brandishing her stick threateningly towards Beatrix's face.

Beatrix cringed and shrank away from her, nodding that she would obey. Her grandmother was stern and her expectations were clear. She did not put up with obstinance or misbehavior and her punishments were always swift and often rather severe.

“Why do they hate us?” She whimpered, her excitement now tempered by fear.

Her grandmother scowled down at her. “We are the bloodline of the Betrayer, our ancestor nearly destroyed this planet. So we have had to pay the price for his failures.”

Beatrix frowned pensively at her feet as she plodded forward. Her bitter thoughts were quickly derailed by the smell of fresh vegetables.

As they walked past a huge vegetable field, the worker’s already bent and moving briskly to harvest the fully grown plants. Beatrix’s mouth watered at the sight of the many vegetables just out of arm's reach. She was so very hungry…glancing sideways at her Nana, debating if she could veer a little closer to the carrots near the road and pick a few? Her courage quickly wilted under Nana's calculating scowl. She could smell the vegetables and knew her granddaughter had little to no will power.

“Are your hands worth losing for a full belly right now? Or do you possess the fortitude to endure your hunger pains just a little longer. After we sell our goods, I will have coin enough to buy food. Child.” She warned.

Once again, Beatrix steeled her resolve. Scowling down at her hands, wondering if all the horror stories her grandmother told her about Etherian’s were true? Would they really chop off her hands if she stole just a couple carrots? Honestly, she was smart and cunning enough not to get caught anyway. Either way she sought to overcome her weakness and prove to her grandmother that she had mental fortitude. Capable of controlling herself. So she refused to look at the garden, keeping her eyes straight ahead and focused on the timber enclosure.

Skara was one of the oldest cities on the Highlands, settled by the First Fleet of colonists. Made up mostly of soldier's and scientists. Sent to colonize and tame the wild's of Etheria. Which resulted in a fortress mentality to the construction of the community. The outer walls were thick and high, built to withstand attack and harsh weather. Time and seclusion from the Greater Galaxy had eased the military feel. Now occupied by both Hybrid and human alike. Full of commoners, tradesmen and merchants all seeking to create a life for themselves and their families. The first to lay to rest the hundreds of years of grudges against the hybrids who had denied the colonists their endless power source, their Rune Stone.

Beatrix was so busy gawking at the massive wall of timber, she had to suddenly dance out of the way of an enormous moving cart filled with baskets. That smelled awful, like rotting fish. Squawking indignantly and shaking her tiny fist at the oblivious old goat driving it. Now she was standing with her grandmother outside the entrance gates to Skara. A sea of Etherian's swirled around the city walls, their chatter a ceaseless hum that she had heard miles away. Beatrix was wary and on edge, never being surrounded by so many others before. Her grandmother stood in front of her, resting against her walking stick. Feigning a begin pose, as her eyes shifted on high alert to the stranger's milling around them. Beatrix gripped the rope of her sack more tightly, as nervous energy surged through her small frame. Her sweaty palm, coating the rope and making it slick. There was an edgy excitement in the air, sharp and tense. This was the last refuge of civilization before the wilderness beyond. The Etherian's were anxious to get inside to the safety of the city.

Beatrix took note how her grandmother would snap her eyes up, giving the surging crowds of hybrids and human's a brief, surly glower before meekly averting her eyes to the ground. She did not like coming to Skara, but selling their wares once a month and buying what they could for provisions helped them survive.

Soon they passed under the gate, moving with the flow of traffic that consisted of carts and animals all headed towards the city's

green space where the market would be set up. As they walked deeper, towards the market. Beatrix's breath was taken by how amazing it was inside. It was quite honestly a huge city, sprawling over the hillsides. With all manner of buildings, in all shapes and sizes. Much more elegant and sturdy than the villages they had passed through. Built with more than just local material's. The wonder and beauty of the cobblestone streets was inspiring. With the grand iron hanging lamps and boxed flowers along the sidewalks.

As they moved deeper into Skara, passing through the residential area. Beatrix was transfixed by a sprawling homestead that took up at least several blocks. Curtained by a stone wall covered in ivy, with a grand manor house behind. Full of towering keeps filled with sparkling windows and lush garden's that went on forever.

"What is this place?" She inquired.

"That is the royal manor, the Lord and Lady of Skara live there. They have just had a daughter recently, Princess Spinerella." her grandmother explained, "It is best we do not hang about here, Trixie. Let's get our wares sold and get back where we belong." There was genuine fear in her grandmother's tone and it was unsettling to Beatrix. Her grandmother was not scared of anything or anyone…at least not until today.

Beatrix swallowed and trotted after the old woman now that she had picked up her pace. Where before, the memories would pick up their pace and allow Adora to live the life of the bearer. This time it was as if she was being blocked and only allowed a glimpse of Shadow Weaver's childhood. She wasn't surprised, the woman had always been guarded, keeping her secrets, to use when she saw fit.

Darkness descended as it always did, after Adora re-lived a memory. Yet this last one had left her confused and unsettled.

The void surrounding her this time was not benign at all. It hovered around her like a lurking predator laying in wait.

The ominous feeling of malicious intent vibrated against her soul, like a million needles poised to strike.

Suddenly she felt a small hand grip her own. Adora shot her gaze downward. Finding the little girl, now a few years older. Standing before her, still dressed in little more than rags. Wearing a dull gray cloak with the hood pulled up and a sheer, lilac veil over her mouth. Her keen emerald eyes, regarding Adora with a calculating air that she recognized. She had a heavy backpack strapped to her back and no shoes. Her feet were cut, bruised and filthy. The soles hardened with thick calluses.

"Beatrix…" Adora breathed.

"Trixie, I prefer Trixie…" She scowled, then pulled on Adora's arm. "We must run!" She commanded.

Adora obeyed as if on instinct, allowing the young girl to guide her deeper into the darkness.

-Scorpia-

For the last few day's Scorpia, Glimmer and Lonnie had been working out the details of a joint operation between Scorpiana and Bright Moon's military to apprehend the many spies all over Etheria. Lonnie had enlisted Jitsu's aid, to identify the insurgence. He had been more than eager to offer his help, stating he looked forward to being able to prove his loyalty to Princess Adora. He practically jumped at the chance to read over the reports and give detailed descriptions of every agent that had been sent undercover. It would only be a matter of days before the prison's were overflowing with more Eternian's.

This was the first time in days Scorpia got a day off from planning and wanted to make the most of it. So she had taken Perfuma into the merchant quarter to fulfill a promise.

Scorpia stepped out into the street, in front of the potter shop she had taken Perfuma to. The merchant quarter was coming alive again, many of the shops, taverns and cafe's were repaired and those that had burnt to the ground were already well underway to be rebuilt.

Perfuma's delightful humming sang behind her, Scorpia smiled happily and stepped aside. Allowing the Plumerian Princess to walk out behind her. The gleeful smile and warm blush upon her freckled cheeks was the greatest gift. As she clutched a small box to her chest. That held her new tea cup, it had taken her most of the morning to pick it out. But Scorpia didn't mind the wait, she enjoyed every moment with Perfuma.

"Shall we?" Scorpia offered her, her elbow chivalrously.

"We Shall." Perfuma beamed, taking her elbow graciously.

Scorpia had a whole day planned of shopping and grabbing lunch at this quaint little cafe she had found. But it wasn't a date…at least she didn't know if it was…she was just happy to spend time with Perfuma. She was far too nervous to ask if Perfuma thought this was a date. So she was just going to enjoy the day for what it was.

They made it only a few blocks before her communicator pad began to twitter with an incoming call. Scorpia's smile wilted, she had not set up any meetings with her Force Captains today and had asked not to be disturbed unless it was an emergency. So her anxiety spiked big time at the sound of her pad.

"I gotta take this." She apologized, unlatching the pad from her belt.

Perfuma pulled away and nodded in understanding.

Scorpia quickly clasped the thin pad in one pincher and activated the call with the other.

Lonnie's alarmed face exploded onto the screen.

"We need Adora!" She shouted.

"What…wait…what's going on?" Scorpia sputtered.

"There's been a casualty on the Strike Team out in the Waste." Lonnie began.

"Oh, goodness…Kyle!" Scorpia gasped, assuming it was the blundering blonde.

"No…Max…a really nasty Beast-Man…" Lonnie swallowed the bile that was thick at the back of her throat. Just thinking of the carnage inflicted upon poor Max.

"Adora's not here…she's in the Crystal Castle." Scorpia advised. Her expression twisted with both sympathy and worry.

"No time….he's…there's no time!" Lonnie screamed in fright, clutching her head as grief and desperate terror consumed her.

"I'll get Glimmer and we will get to him as quickly as we can!" Scorpia advised, cutting the call.

Perfuma was staring up at her with concern. As they both broke into a sprint in unison back to the Citadel, Glimmer was currently in the Master's Library.

-Adora-

Adora found herself alone, standing in a lone corridor. She peered down the long hallway, feeling self-conscious and out of sorts. The hall looked familiar, it had a robust earthy smell of mold, the air

thick with the scent of oil and ash. The halls were rough and natural. Carved from the earth itself. Not knowing how or why she was here she began to wander down the narrow, earthen halls. Finding each one she navigated were empty, yet she could hear the ringing of tools, the faint clip of footsteps and soft conversations all around her? A door opened just ahead and Adora froze.

"Trixie…you are an absolute menace! You know that!" An exasperated voice, whined inside the open room and soon a young boy stomped out. He had a strong face with a square jaw and thick wavy brown hair. His eyes were a molten brown, fierce and piercing. He wore the heavy leather apron of a Maker Apprentice over top of his simple cotton shirt and dark pants. His hair was standing up and singed, with black soot smeared over his face. He looked like he had just survived an explosion.

"Bye, Bye, Cy…you coward, I don't need you…anyway…I don't need anybody." The shrill, angry voice called out to him from inside the room.

"Stubborn, obstinate, brat…would it kill you to apologize when you screw up." he growled, balling his hands into fists and storming away.

Adora instantly knew where she was, she was in the lower bastion of the Citadel on Mystacor. Where the workshops and the Maker's Guild were located.

She tentatively entered the room, lurking in the doorway. Nervously scanning the dimly lit room, curious about the occupant but also certain as to who she was going to find.

"Come in Adora." An older version of the little girl answered. But her voice was distant, not entirely focused on her visitor.

Adora was shocked that she sensed her, but took it in stride and walked into the room. Her form shimmering into view like a ripple on a pond. Finding a workshop with many long, wooden tables

filled with various strange tools. Pieces of metal and stone shards were scattered among the tools. On the far side was a fireplace, the ember's in the hearth crackling low the log fuel inside nearly spent. The walls around the fireplace were covered in black soot, recently experiencing an explosion from the firebox.

She found Trixie, hunched over a work table at the very back of the room. Hidden slightly in the shadows cast from the dying fire, she was hard at work on something. Dressed similar to the boy who just left, in a heavy leather apron, dark pants and a cotton long sleeve shirt she had rolled up to past her elbows. A strange contraption for magnification was wrapped around her head. Her straight, jet black hair hangs in two loose braids down her back. A matching leather veil hid her mouth, no doubt thinned into a determined frown. The pale lilac skin of her face was covered in black soot. Her piercing emerald eyes totally focused on the silver amulet she was working on. Slender picks in either hand, working deftly to mount tiny fragments of crystals into holder's in a very intricate pattern.

Adora closed in curiously looking over the girl's shoulder, the amulet was beautiful. In the shape of an exotic flower she did not recognise, but she really didn't know a-lot about flowers. Tiny shards of crystal of various types were already set in housing along the edges of the amulet.

"What are you working on?" Adora inquired.

Adora glanced down again to have a closer look at the amulet. The shard's formed a pattern, one she recognizes as a constellation…an ancient one…Serenia…

"The future…I'm always working on the future." Beatrix muttered, then snapped her head up in alarm.

A stench invaded the workshop, it was thick and vile. Coiling in the air like a specter of something truly unsavory, as if death and decay had been made flesh and it was stalking towards them. The

looming sense of doom enveloped both of them, as wrath and hatred seemed to seep from the very walls.

"You must hide!" Beatrix spun on her, climbing off the tall stool she had been sitting on and ushering Adora to the far side of the room. By gripping her arm tightly and dragging her into the heavier shadows beyond the meager firelight.

"What…where?" Adora sputtered, she was never one to just cower and hide. She wanted to face this foe head on and defend both Beatrix and herself. She was a warrior…not a coward.

"Trixie…I don't want to hide." She complained, yet was strangely unable to assert herself and pull away. The young girl seemed to have inhuman strength…even if she was a Gar…she forced Adora into a tool closet and slammed the door closed. Leaving her once more in that impenetrable darkness. Adora heard the frantic scuffle of feet and then a retreating cadence of bare feet fading down the hall.

The darkness faded as it always did, replaced by the warmth of a new day.

"Doddering, old fools! They refuse to approve my expedition to the Crimson Waste! " Light Spinner's enraged voice rang out. Shaking Adora free of the void in one sudden and frighteningly familiar jolt of alarm and fear. Pain always followed after that woman's temper flared and Adora instinctively braced for it.

Finding herself on an ornate marble balcony high in the citadel, that overlooked the sprawling enclosures below. The sky was warm and clear, unblemished by any clouds. Tall stain glass windows stretched out of view on the inside of the balcony and she could make out the endless shelves of books deep inside.

Light Spinner was pacing a few feet away, wringing her hands and glowering down at a young man with dark hair. Who was pacing in her wake. Wearing lavender leather shoulder guards with gold

trim and matching gauntlets. A teardrop ornament hung from his neck, illustrating that he was from the upper class of Bright Moon. A gold belt with a crescent shaped buckle adorned his waist, with dark blue pants and simple white long sleeve shirt.

Adora instantly recognized the more youthful features of King Micah. His soulful brown eyes, always so wise and kind. Were wet with rising fear, as he attempted to calm down his teacher. Already well aware of how dangerous Light Spinner could be in this irate state. As she was ranting and raving, her temper like a powder keg was close to exploding. As her apprentice, he would become a target if he wasn't careful. When she was this volatile it was like trying to navigate a hidden minefield.

Adora's heart was beating fast, with anxiety and dread. She had learned young not to be too close to that woman when she was ready to explode. Anyone nearby would become a target of her rage. It was instinct to cower and seek shelter. But Adora refused to give into her fears, borne from the trauma of being raised by that vile, abusive woman. Grinding her teeth, she pushed down her emotions. Erecting that wall of dissociation that allowed her to act without being hindered by her emotions. The need to protect Micah, since he was only a child was an imperative she couldn't refute. Even if this was a memory and honestly she could do nothing but watch. She still moved in close, hovering in front of the scared apprentice to keep Light Spinner back. Just like she had done again and again for Catra while they grew up.

"Cowards, the lot of them!" The Gar snarled, "They are going to doom us all, by not heeding my research…I am not reckless…I have been nothing but meticulous and thorough…I have spent my whole life…preparing for this…why can't they see…after all this time, have I not proven myself! Why can't they trust me!" She growled, slamming her fists onto the balcony railing. Her voice sounded, pained, wounded. As she stared out towards the horizon.

"Light Spinner it's going to be ok? We just need to find a Sorcerer on the High Council to agree to your plan and then the rest will

come around. I am sure of it." Micah closed in, reaching a hand out to comfort his teacher. Which was a mistake. Light Spinner spun upon him in an instant, her eyes burning with humiliation and rage at being caught in a vulnerable state. Feeling a need to put the young man in his place for believing she was weak.

"You are a naive fool! If you think any of them would ever agree to anything proposed by a Gar! I am done pandering to those ungrateful hypocrites, let them burn when the Horde comes for Mystacor!" She snarled.

"Light Spinner, You don't mean that." Micah sought to calm her down, his eyes stricken by the brutal things she had just said.

Light Spinner took a deep breath, brushing her hands down her hair in an attempt to maintain order within herself.

"Dear boy…I need you to trust in me." She finally calmed down and turned to him, reaching out to cup his cheek tenderly. Adora could see in the gleam in her eyes that she was planning her next moves. Micah valiantly tried not to cringe upon his teacher's touch. Squinting his eyes just a little as she patted his cheek tenderly.

"What are you going to do?" Micah inquired in a soft, almost timid voice. As she withdrew her hand.

"I will find Serenia myself and retrieve the artifact I need to complete the Spell of Obtainment." She nodded, her eyes firm, resolute that she needed no one to achieve her ends.

"Go, now. Return to your studies." She commanded, returning to stare out over Mystacor. Micah merely nodded, returning inside the library at a brisk pace.

"Adora…you stay." Light Spinner commanded sternly, never turning from the view. Expecting Adora to listen and obey as she always did. Adora was shocked once more how Beatrix knew she was there, even as an invisible spirit to her memories. It was humiliating and frustrating, how her feet just planted refusing to

move. After all the strides she had made over the years to free herself from this dreadful woman's influence, she was a dutiful soldier yet again. Standing and awaiting her orders. As she shimmered into view once more, this time against her will.

"You must let go." Light Spinner sighed, bowing her head.

"Let go of what!" Adora shouted in exasperation back at her.

Light Spinner began to turn to face her, as she did she transformed in the dark, malevolent visage of Shadow Weaver. Her soulless white eyes glowing down upon her in that same cold, detached way she remembered from her youth. The faint, musty smell of death and decay that clung to the sorceress like a putrid perfume. Assaulted her nose.

As the Fright Zone's pale, green metal halls materialized around them.

Adora's heart leaped into her throat as she was once more confronted with the worst parts of her life. Except this time it was far worse, with the pulsing red veins of corruption now covering every surface.

Chapter Two

Chapter Notes

> Thank your for your comments Pink Storm and Bitzy Bee and all the Kudo's. Eva Wolf...I have no idea what your wrote...lol. But I still appreciate whatever you said.

"You are a Princess, so you have a Runestone. Yours dwells there, within your sword. With it, you channel the elemental magic of Etheria. Let it flow through the sword and into you. You must learn to concentrate. Focus your power…Calm down. Your frustration will cause the energy you produce to become destructive if you're not careful. There must be peace in your mind if you are to heal. Come closer and allow me to help you…You are afraid, but refuse to admit it. Afraid of your power. Of it spiraling out of control. Let yourself feel it, then move past it. You are greater than your fear." - Shadow Weaver, Prisoner of Bright Moon.

-Spirit-

The pearl white stallion grunted and snorted, brown eyes rolling in fear. As he stood only inches away from the table that Adora was laying upon. Dancing anxiously on his hooves. His strikes upon the smooth floor echoing off the walls like gunshots.

He needed to do something! Anything!

Her hand was still outstretched, towards him. Having fallen from his muzzle moments after, her consciousness was pulled away into the First Ones memory device. Her finger's laying limp over the edge of the crystalline table, as her body was slowly being

covered in pulsing red veins. Her once peaceful expression now twisted into a painful grimace, as the vein's began to crawl over her face. Like some ominous parasite, driven to devour her alive.

The runestone horn Liam had created for him was glowing a pure white with magic. But Spirit was scared to use it, if he touched her…he could become infected too.

He had no idea what was going on, but it was terrifying him. The crystals that had once glowed a warm amber were now dark as pitch. A malicious whisper, hummed from the depths of those crystal formations. Make his ear's twitch, as his stomach twisted into sickening knots. Haunted by how similar the pull of hopelessness was, that was embedded into the Beast Island's signal. Everything about that table had turned ominous and predatory, in a matter of minutes.

Desperate and terrified. Spirit shook his head violently, tossing his orange mane in some futile attempt to shake off his fear. He had no idea how to wake her up!

(ADORA….WAKEUP!) He screamed desperately through their link, again and again. But it was pointless as he had been at it for a while. He was failing to keep his promise to keep her safe!

Stamping his hooves in frustration, he reared and whinnied plaintively. His mind spinning with dread as he finally abandoned her. Racing away down a corridor, he needed to get out! He needed to find help…he couldn't do this alone!

-Entrapta-

The narrow hallway, Entrapta now found herself in. Lay far beneath the beacon itself, a separate and mysterious avenue she had found days earlier, jutting off from the central labs. It stretches onward out of view. As if it traversed the length of the island itself. It was dark, the first ones glyphs that usually glowed along the walls were strangely absent. Creating an ominous foreboding atmosphere that had Entrapta on edge. She kept her emotions under control, focusing on the facts and her many hypotheses for it's use. It might have been a hidden evacuation tunnel or perhaps a secret route that would lead to yet one more heinous undiscovered mystery upon this wretched island. Entrapta had long since lost her wonder of discovery here on Galius. This place was nothing more than a biological hall of horrors, everything developed here had been created to be a weapon, or a virus, or a plague. The scientific discoveries twisted to some vile purpose, programmed to control or wipe out life. So she had no delusions about what she was going to find at the end of this corridor.

The only source of light was from the twin beams of Entrapta's two large visored eyes inside her mask. Illuminating the way ahead in an eerie blue glow. She held her tracker pad in front of her, a schematic glowing upon the screen with a blinking energy source at the very end of this tunnel. She had been exploring Galius relentlessly, seeking to uncover all of its secrets. The trove of data it contained was vast and the deeper she got, the darker it went.

Entrapta no longer marveled, with the same innocence at their techno-organic machinery as she once did. The First Ones were hell bent on understanding, controlling and forcing the universe to bow to their will. A crash course to destruction, she had already experienced first hand by messing with the Black Garnet. Planets stripped of all resources and littered by the corpses of thousands of beings was their ultimate legacy.

They were no better than Prime…

“I am currently four miles beyond the beacon and heading north, the signal is getting stronger.” Entrapta announced over the com’s. The clanking of metal legs echoed behind her. As two horde bots followed in her wake, their energy cores hummed as they both scanned the walls.

“I wish you would have waited for a contingent of clones to go with you.” Wrong Hordak commented anxiously, threw the com piece in her ear.

“No time! I found the origin of the corrupted files, by tracing the data transfers backwards. From the memory core of the Crystal Castle, back to Darla’s databanks then back to Galius primary server’s.” She explained, in rapid fire, as her anxiety and fear of losing both Hordak and Adora was now roaring through her mind. “I am following the data signature…to the Beacon’s main server room….I think…I have bots.” She defended, finding Wrong Hordak was taking his role as protector a little too seriously. She was not one of his clones and his constant clucking at her over the last few weeks. That she was taking too many risks was getting annoying. She was perfectly capable of taking care of herself; she didn’t want anyone getting in her way or challenging her judgment. Every move she made was based on fact and solid reasoning, she was going to save them!

NO MATTER THE ODDS.

-Adora-

As quickly as the corrupted halls of the Fright Zone appeared, they merely faded away. A brief warning of danger, quickly forgotten. Disappearing like a distant echo, as her consciousness

was suddenly pulled away into the surreal, shifting landscape of a very familiar dream.

There was only darkness, an endless void of nothingness that stretched beyond her comprehension. Adora stood within that eternal night, her heart pounding with fear, eyes darting in a rising panic as she found nothing to get her bearings. She was lost...alone and had no way to control what was to come next. Galaxies blanketed the heavens above, millions upon millions of stars began to shine above her. Twinkling and glowing in different intensities, like tiny lanterns against the black backdrop of space. They seemed so close, hovering just out of reach. She might be able to reach out and touch them if she had the courage to move. The brightest stars began to tremble, as if shivering in fear. Then they began to fall, one by one. Streaking across the void until they faded out of existence upon some distant, unclear horizon.

(You must let go) Light Hope's voice called out, quickly drowned out by Adora's own earnest demands to action.

(Catch them! Before they disappear.") An urgent voice echoed to her, vaguely sounding like her own. But vibrating with deep primordial undertones, that made it sound ancient, timeless. As a radiant flash of light illuminated the void just in front of her.

(Hurry...you must protect them.) Her own voice demanded. As the radiant glow of She-Ra stood before her. Her wild flowing hair snapping in the ethereal wind now howling around them. The electric thrill of her presence echoed against Adora's skin as she stared in awe and wonder at her immensely powerful magical alter-ego.

Her urgent call to action, spurned Adora forward. Ignoring her fear, resolute in her purpose to always protect others. Even at the cost of everything else, even her own well being..even her life. Driven by her duty as Etheria's champion. She ran forward, raising her hands up to catch them. The stars out of control fall, began to slow, as if she was beaconing them to her. They started to float

towards her. Like snowflakes in the wind, the starlight began to flutter obediently into her open hands.

(You must let go) Mara’s voice beseeched her. The command had less power, once again overshadowed by Adora's ardent need for praise from who she deemed a superior being to herself. Because she was nothing, unless they told her she was worthy, useful…powerful…

“I've got them! I've got them!” Adora spun in delight, to confront She-Ra with a beaming smile of confident self-assurance. She stared down at her hands now translucent, like they were made of the purest ice. She could see the shimmering lights of the stars filling her palms. Slowly closing her finger's to keep them safe. Exhilaration replaced the fear, before the indescribable burning seared her palms. She screamed in agony but refused to let them go. The smell of burnt flesh, stung her nose yet she still would not uncurl her fingers. Knowing that if she lost control over them they would float away and their light would die. So she held onto them more tightly, as suddenly all the tiny lights went out, the cracks between her fingers went dark.

(You must let go) Catra demanded, softly entreating her to finally listen. Yet Adora’s stubborn refusal to release her control over them was stronger. They were weaker than her, they needed her guidance, her protection…

“No...no,no...Please...I've tried so hard...” Adora sputtered out, tears falling down her cheeks. Slowly opening her hands, confronting the scorched holes in her palms, the smell of burnt flesh assaulted her nose. Pungent and thick in the air, hovering around her like death.

The powerful essence of She-Ra began to fade. As the goddess merely walked away. Head bowed with disappointment back into the timeless void. Leaving Adora sobbing brokenly on her knees in the darkness.

The void lightened just enough around her to become a colorless, gray. Devoid of life and substance. A hollow, barren existence surrounded her. It wasn't eerie or ominous as the void. Yet the sense of apathy and hopelessness that now surrounded her was even more painful to endure.

"You didn't save us?" A chorus of voices rang out, from the squadmates she had lost. Their young voices echoing with disdain towards her. Full of pain and despair at how unjustly their lives had been cut short.

Adora snapped her eyes open, finding herself kneeling on the thin mattress of her bunk in the barracks.The room was covered in pulsing shadows, creeping over the walls, hovering just out of view. An overwhelming sense of impending doom hung heavy in the air. As she found Tama and the rest standing around her bunk, staring down at her with scorn and betrayal. Red veins of corruption covered their faces, wrapped around every inch of their bodies. Binding their arms to their sides and rooting their legs to the floor. Spreading out from their feet like ghastly, organic tendrils from some dark demonic tree.

"I…I'm…" Adora stuttered, unable to speak. Burdened by the weight of her grief and shame that was slowly crushing her. She had failed them. By not living up to Shadow Weaver expectations. Failing her responsibility as their squad leader. To watch out for them, take care of them, keep them out of trouble.

She let them die…it was her fault.

(**You must let go)** Tama pleaded weakly, her tender voice gasping like a final breath. Struggling to be heard over the pounding agony of Adora's guilt.

“You didn’t protect me!” Another chorus of voices rang out from the darkness. Ringing in her ears, in the dulcet tones of the person she held most dear. Full of heartache, bitterness and resentments. At the one person she had trusted most, who had abandoned her again and again when she needed her most.

Choosing duty, choosing responsibility, choosing everyone else and never her.

“I…I…can’t..” Adora whimpered, crouching before the various feline specters that haunted her. This time Adora screamed, unable to open her eyes and face the many incarnations of Catra. That she knew was now surrounding her. All the versions of her true love, she had known, all the versions she had failed… all bound so unmercifully by the corruption tormenting her mind. Her poor, selfish choices had caused Catra to suffer again and again. She had failed her so many times! She had been so oblivious to her pain growing up. Had abandoned her, rejected her, denied her…in all the same ways as Shadow Weaver. Which was her greatest failure, her worst sin. All for the sake of her duty…her responsibility towards some…Destiny….to be a Force Captain, to be She-Ra…to be a hero…

(You must let go) Catra whispers. Pleading for her to finally hear her. Yet Adora was frozen, huddled in the corner of her mind. Wallowing in her failures, her cowardice.

“You left us, betrayed us…” Levi and the rest of her living Squadmates stood before her, their faces twisted in a fierce scowl full of loathing and revulsion. Half of their faces were webbed by those amber veins of corruption. The malicious darkness that once hovered all around her. Was now slowly washing over them, devouring them. As they stood in judgment, unphased by the shadow’s slowly consuming them. As Adora curled up tight in a

ball between them, covering the back of her head as if to protect herself. Whimpering and muttering her apologies, over and over. Her voice became breathless and hoarse. As she desperately sought their forgiveness.

(You must let go) Levi pleaded, her voice barely heard above the howling of Adora's pain and heartbreak.

"Your best will never be good enough." Glimmer's voice accused her, in a dull, disappointed tone.

Adora reluctantly squinted her eyes open just a crack, as she cowered. Finding the Queen of Bright Moon standing before her, arms crossed over her chest. Looking down upon her in utter disdain. At how pathetic and useless she was. The veins crawled like a sickness over Glimmer's face, obscuring her body in a pulsing mass of corruption.

(You must let go) Glimmer's plea's faded into the void, unheard by the one who needed to hear them most.

"It should have been you…who died." A discordant chorus of both Shadow Weaver and Angella's voice called out to her next. Adora snapped her gaze away from Glimmer as she faded away into the darkness. To confront both maternal figures she had once known. Standing back to back, one bathed in light, one cast in shadow. Both quickly become completely overwhelmed by the fleshy veins of corruption. Devoured in seconds and fading away into nothingness.

“I know….I’m sorry…” Adora muttered, clasping her hand over her mouth and falling forward onto her knees in defeat. Pressing her face into the ground, as she wailed in grief and misery.

(You must let go) Queen Angella and Shadow Weaver called out one last time, weak and trembling.

“We chose you, believed in you. After all this time and effort, we put in to train you…empower you…you still can not live up to your potential? You are a disappointment. Unfocused and distracted… you are scared and compromised by your emotions…unbalanced… incapable of wielding She-Ra’s magic. How can you be so weak, so useless!” Sheana and Despara’s ethereal voices echoed from the darkness, like a reaper’s scythe. Slicing through the tattered remains that was left of Adora’s self worth, destroying the fragile sense of identity she had once laid claim too. Shattering her completely…

Adora was nothing…she didn’t matter…she was a failure…

Never allowed to choose, because she was shackled to some greater Destiny.

To be Etheria’s champion, to be Bright Moon’s savior, to be the First One’s greatest weapon…to be sacrificed for the greater good.

That was all she was ever good for.

Adora crumpled into the void, her persona completely overwhelmed by the corruption. Sealed within a pulsing, cocoon of glowing red veins. The once brilliant blue glow in her eyes

began to dim. As the corruption was devouring her magic, slowly weakening her. So that it could tear into the very depths of her, blacken her heart and twist her soul to do its bidding…just like it had done to Catra…just like it had done to Light Spinner…Just like it had done to Light Hope…and so many other's over the last millennia…

A deep, malicious laugh of triumph thundered from the void.

-Spirit-

The frantic stallion, charged into the vast cavern of control crystals. His hooves clattered across the smooth crystalline floor with such intensity it was like the shattering of glass. The vast room was dark, the crystal formations that once encircled the primary communication dais were as black as pitch. The outer pillar's that once housed both power and data crystals looked like dead stone. The two clones snapped their focus away from the now dark, corrupted control pillar rising up in front of them. At the sudden burst of sound, their soft green eyes stricken and afraid. As they briefly took in Spirit's sudden entrance, before turning with bleak frowns back to the pillar. Spirit, huffed as he noticed several more clones were hovering behind them, crudely dressed in mismatched armor, with strange cudgel-like weapon's trained upon them.

Before the contingent of clones from the Sky Tree had shown up to take them into custody. The two clones had been valiantly attempting to recall their host program and seal the corrupted files back behind that firewall. That they had unwittingly released upon the command network from the Crystal Castle's memory core. Now they knelt in shame before their brethren, data pad's discarded before them. Their control program still running across the screens.

“We have apprehended the rouge clones.” A clone taped his left ear, sending a confirmation over the com’s.

Another clone crouched down surveying the program running on the screen of the nearest pad.

“It looks like they were attempting to shunt the file back behind the firewall.” He commented in a bland, unemotional tone.

Spirit nickered in alarm, as they approached the ominous glowing pillar of darkness. That dominated the back of the room. Glaring and pointing his horn threateningly down at the two clones as well. Who were now cowering before all of them. Prostrating themselves and begging for mercy.

“Halt, Steed of She–Ra?” An armored clone turned to confront Spirit. Concerned that he was about to gore his prisoner with his horn.

“We are sorry…” The first clone whimpered, nearly laying flat on the ground before Spirit.

“We meant no harm….” The second whined, bowing low to the ground upon his knees.

“When Adora did not return…we got worried…Kronis explained that this place was holding her prisoner…we were just trying to save her…” The first clone pleaded.

Spirit tossed his head in distress, not liking how Kronis had manipulated these hapless and naïve clones. No doubt Liam had been duped into this reckless plan to 'Save Adora'.

“Please, allow us to help…” The first clone crawled back towards his pad, casting Spirit and the other clones worried glances over his shoulder. Nervous that any movement towards his equipment would be met with swift punishment.

“Please, allow us to fix our mistakes…” The second followed this brother’s pathetic submissive crawl. Seeking to return to his own

pad to resume their desperate attempts to contain the corruption.

"Hordak is currently offline…we need direction?" Another armored clone inquired, nodding at the response he was receiving from the Sky Tree.

The First clone turned to Spirit, his expression mournful.

"Liam and Kronis left to find Adora. We need Liam to put the power and data crystals back…So that the Beacon can come back online and protect itself." He beseeched, clasping his hands before Spirit as if praying for his help.

Spirit nodded and then reared, kicking his front hooves in renewed determination. Dashing away into the depths of the beacon to retrieve Liam. He would deal with Kronis after this crisis was over.

-Catra-

"Ok, let's try this again." Cyrus offered, tapping on the central screen along the far wall. As they both stood in the moldy, tomb-like remains of a large office deep within Arxia. Catra was pacing behind a grand, smooth black desk. Tapping her chin thoughtfully, as two orbs of fire floated behind her. Illuminating the open journal in her hand and the ancient office in flickering orange light. The glass window behind the desk was shattered, the damp earth having invaded the open space that remained. Stone and soil had cascaded into a small landslide into the room behind the desk. The walls were empty, smooth bulkheads except for the large screen that dominated the far wall.

Melog sat near the open doorway, yawning. Their coat is a rusty red, with a mighty flame crackling around their head. Round ear's

flicking and swiveling at every small sound. Piercing blue eyes alert and scanning the darkness behind them, as their tail thumped aimlessly against the metal floor.

They had found this office during their last exploration yesterday. Since it was the first, they hoped it was also Senator Keldor's. But there was nothing left behind to illustrate it was his.

Whoever had owned this space, they had cleared it of anything that would give away its owner. When the Eternian's were evacuating the planet.

The sudden chime and explosion of sparkles announced Glimmer's teleport. Catra snapped her gaze up from the journal in surprise. Her heart sinking and stomach lurching at finally getting caught. To find not only the Queen of Bright Moon, staring at her in confusion. But also Scorpia and Perfuma as well.

"Hi…" Catra waved at them weakly. Knowing damn well she was not supposed to be going down here. She knew Glimmer was furious, she had every right to be. But her expression was flat and unreadable. Which was making Catra immensely nervous.

Glimmer was refusing to show Catra how hurt and angry she was. Catra was once again doing as she pleased, uncaring about the consequences to herself. Lying and keeping secrets about her whereabouts. Only to get caught and having the gall to look contrite about it. When clearly she wasn't.

Glimmer merely rolled her eyes, so sick and tired of dealing with Catra's self sacrificial bullshit. Then lunged for Cyrus and grabbed him by his collar and shimmered away. Leaving Scorpia blinking in confusion for a moment, while Perfuma fretted beside her. Tapping her fingertips togethers as she surveyed the room. "This is awkward…" She muttered, knowing Catra was in trouble for disobeying Casta's strict order to stay out of Arxia for the time being.

In an instant Glimmer was back, popping into existence just beside Catra. Who yelped and jolted back, her hackles up and tail fluffed in alarm.

"Sparkles…I can explain." Catra began, clutching the journal against her chest as if it was a shield.

Glimmer huffed, "I will deal with you later, We need to get Adora!"

"What's going on?" Catra was suddenly awash with dread.

"Max is badly hurt." Scorpia closed in with Perfuma and Melog.

Catra had no time to react as Glimmer blinked them all away to Adora's side.

-Adora-

"Get up!" Shadow Weaver's stern, authoritative voice boomed out of the darkness. Jolting Adora out of her hopeless despair, as if she had just been electrified. Suddenly the empty halls of the Fright Zone took shape once again, with the pulsing veins of corruption. Webbing over the pale green, metal surface like an organic parasite slowly consuming its prey.

Seeking Balance

Chapter Notes

> Thank you, Eva Wolf, your English is excellent! Also thank you, Bitzy Bee and Pink Storm for your comments and also all those who left Kudo's! Working on the last chapter of this Arc, so hang on tight. Hope that those that have read this far are still invested in this story and the character's journey. Leave a comment, I would love to hear from you all and what you think.

"She-Ra is a being of pure magic. To unleash her full strength you must be focused, clear headed. You are allowing your emotions to pull you in too many directions. " Shadow Weaver- Etherian Rebel, Traitor to the Horde, Dishonored Sorcerer of Mystacor, Master Stone Mason, Thief, Orphan, Gar:Descendant of the Betrayer.

-Entrapta-

"Well, this is not unexpected…" Entrapta commented in mild discomfort at what she found at the end of this secret tunnel.

A massive set of three crystal pillars, set upon a dais. Rising up in the center of a massive, cavernous room. A black diamond hovered just above the pillars, as it did at Arxia. This crystal configuration resembled the Crystal of Arxia in every way, but was as black as pitch. The room was barely lit, most of the crystal lanterns were shattered. The lanterns that had survived, hanging along the walls. where glowing an eerie twilight blue. Casting long shadows from their rusty scones that made the ancient room even more creepy and ominous.

It didn’t deter Entrapta at all, as she surveyed the massive chamber. Slowly walking towards the crystal’s, observing the pulsing red veins webbing along their surface. It explained so much as to why all the tech on beast island was corrupted. These pillars were the source.

“Interesting, these veins are very similar to the ones that corrupted She-Ra’s sword?” She observed, as she cautiously ascended the steps. “I wonder if it would be wise to take a sample?” She tapped her chin and quickly shook her head. “Perhaps not, past experiments have proven quite deadly when tech is infected by this…muder virus.” She stopped at the top of dais, casting the light from her visor into the middle of the crystal pillars. Finding an empty triangle shaped housing sitting in the center of the crystal pillars upon a smaller, cube shaped control dais. That was shiny and smooth, etched in First Ones glyphs. The corruption was still pulsing and creeping from the empty socket like a fungus. Thin tendrils reach and clasping to the surface, seeking to devour the pillar’s whole.

“Interesting…” Entrapta muttered, taking readings of the panel. “The empty slot resembles the disc I found at Dryl…that infected the sword…This may have been where it was created?” She pondered, glancing upward to find another data crystal housing, that was empty just above the triangle shaped slot. This housing was very rudimentary, like a plug? To insert a simple crystal shard.

“Fascinating..” Entrapta hummed, shifting her gaze back towards her two bots briefly. She really needed to collect data…but how safe would it be to plug in one of her bots into the dias? She quickly descended the stairs. Busy calculating the odds of success versus death, when her earpiece activated with a transmission.

“We have apprehended the rogue clones…they want to help contain the virus?” A clone inquired.

“Wrong Hordak, what's the status of the Guardian Protocols currently downloading into the Etherian Network?” She called out,

already multi-tasking. As she ripped off a panel at the back of one of her bots, plugging in her data pad into a port beneath the core processing unit.

"With the extra power routed from the Clone pod's, to processing speed. The installation of the new program is seventy-five percent through all systems planet wide. The Crystal Castle has been taken off the grid and contained behind another firewall…the virus is now localized to the Beacon. " Wrong Hordak advised.

"Great! Ok, if those two want to help, let them. I will download my purge program directly into the virtual memory core when they get the Beacon back online. " Entrapta commanded, double tapping her ear piece to cut the communication.

She finished weighing her options and then took the risk. Tapping in commands onto her pad. The bot she had been reprograming clanked up to the dais obediently, a panel sliding open, revealing a longer, wider connection cord. Entrapta quickly unfurled the heavy cord, pulling it towards the connection port set in the dais. As the second bot took position a few feet away, two laser guns springing out of the underside of it's hull and targeting it's companion. The horde bots used to just fire from a tiny port housed just below their central core in the middle of their hull. But Entrapta had found its targeting clumsy and it took too long to recharge. She had since upgraded the bots on Beast Island with thulite energy pistols she adapted from Brojee's tech. That had been given in trade for the scrap they took from Beast Island. She now had those weapon's integrated into the bot's lower hulls. The firing rate was faster since the battery pack was designed for rapid charging and was way more precise. Since the guns were now mounted on a rolling ball that could aim the barrel in a 360 degrees orbit.

The bot stomped into position to defend Entrapta if or when the other bot's system's became corrupted by the infected data inside the Crystal of Galius.

-Adora-

Adora slowly picked herself up off the floor, eyes scanning the ghoulish halls that were now stretching out before her once again. Her heart was pounding but she felt the comforting grip of the Sword of Protection once more in her hands. Glancing down she found the First Ones relic, once again whole and humming softly with magic power. The sense of safety and confidence she had once known, by feeling its weight in her hands. Washed over her, with a sense of grim nostalgia. She-Ra could be summoned so much easier this way…but it was at a price. She was a weapon of the First Ones. She knew that if she called out the activation phrase, she would be endowed with Sheana's magic. She would be more powerful and able to defend herself. As she could sense the shadows lurking just out of view, the sour smell of decay was heavy in the air.

But it wasn't right…she couldn't use the relic…it was a prison… enslaving Sheana's Magic, her very essence to the Runestone… Adora growled and spun the sword and slammed it into the floor, shattering the Blade.

She as soon as she felt the resistance of the tip striking the ground and heard the familiar crack and explosion of shards. Her heart sank and fear and uncertainty returned As she stared forlorn down at the shards upon the floor, the hilt of the broken sword still clutched in her hand. The emptiness inside her was heavy, no longer able to feel the magic she had once relied on. She had never felt so worthless, so alone and scared, as she did now. Yet she couldn't deny how relieved she felt at finally being free of a forced destiny.

Her life was her own! She would live it on her own terms!

“I will never be a Weapon.” Adora breathed, her voice wavering slightly with trepidation, even though her eyes were fierce with determination. As quickly as she felt that resolve it faded into worry. She no longer had any way to reliably become She-Ra. Unsure of herself and her power, her confidence was shaken and she was struggling to find her footing…

As she wandered, cautiously threw the halls of the Fright Zone. The shadows lurked all around her. Like a predator staying out of sight, stalking her and waiting for the best time to strike.

Unconsciously Adora made her way back to the barracks. She didn’t know what she would find, only that place. Had held the foundation’s of what had molded her. The bunkroom was her first home, where she had been a part of a family. Lazlo had given her a sense of duty to her Squad, loyalty to her strike team and respect for her superiors. Shadow Weaver had instilled in her a selfless drive towards service, to always put the needs of others ahead of her own. She had found honor, integrity and courage within those halls. She had become a soldier…she had value then.

Slowly pacing through the doorway, she found Catra hunched over a black and white checkered game board on her bunk. The feline glanced up, from contemplating the many different game pieces scattered over the light and dark squares. She was younger, with her long wild mane and gray tufts. Dressed in her red tunic and torn dark maroon leggings.With her horde Force Captain badge pinned to her breast and mask firmly in place upon her brow.

“Who controls you?” She stated, matter of factly, staring avidly down at her hands. Holding a carving of Shadow Weaver in her right palm and Adora’s current transformation of She-Ra in her left hand.

“I…I…don’t know?” Adora stuttered, suddenly uncertain how to respond.

“Disappointing, at this rate you are going to lead the universe into total annihilation.” Horde Prime commented snidely, as he breezed past her to sit in front of the game board. Dressed in his flowing white robes, leather pauldrons and silver metal gauntlets and gloves. He tapped his chin thoughtfully, before moving a finely carved game piece forward. That resembled a dark faceless figure, the rest of his game pieces already on the board were clones.

Adora’s scanned over to Catra’s side of the board. Noting that all of Catra’s pieces were small figures of the Princesses and their squad mates.

The shadows, once hugging the walls, began to grow. Lengthening and twisting around her, until she was trapped within a wall of darkness.

Adora moved into a defensive stance, holding her fists up. Then thrust an arm over her head, shouting desperately her power phrase as she once did years ago. Needing to use those words as a means to focus upon that magic, to call it from the ether. “For the Honor of Grayskull!” Her voice reverbated against the curving iron roof of the cadet barracks. But the magic did not ignite as it once did into the palm of her hand. She stared up at her empty hand in horror, as failure bloomed inside her heart, making her chest ache.

“Who are you?” Shadow Weaver’s voice demanded, flowing out of the shadow’s to tower over her.

“I…don’t know.” Adora muttered, staring dumbstruck as she slowly lowered her empty hand to rub her chest. Disheartened that the magic would not heed her call, the sick feeling of betrayal, of worthlessness burned deep in her gut.

“Enough of this!” Shadow Weaver shouted, her tone furious and exasperated. “I raised you to be strong, to be a ruthless, cutthroat warrior. Who would prevail, no matter the odds. You have become weak and confused about your true purpose. It seems I must instruct you one last time.” Her sharp cackle pierced through, Adora’s faltering confidence in herself. Instincts born from years of survival, kicked in. That cruel, malicious laugh was an alarm. Sending a sudden burst of adrenaline to every muscle in her body. Adora quickly crossed her arms over her face to shield herself. Knowing that violence was soon to follow. That the cutting burn of shadows or the crackling heat of lightning would strike her down if she didn’t defend herself.

Shadow Weaver growled and flung her hands to the side, calling down the darkness. Before sending a massive wave of shadow’s directly at her. The shadow’s parted along the sides of her arms as if they were her shield. Evaporating into the air around her, purified by Sheana’s magic…yet she had not conjured her shield?

“Do you wield the power to save the Universe?” Mara pushed through the wall of shadow’s. Her demanding question, forcing Adora to slowly lower her arms and regard her mentor with a confused frown. Then Mara raised her arm, flicking her wrist and causing Adora to stare down at her own hands in amazement. Finding her sword, the one she manifested from Despara’s silver bracer. With the more slender blade and sharp, refined pommel. The cross guard was silver and the runestone was no longer blue, but now red…Despara…

“Or, are you the power to save the Universe?” Mara raised a dark questioning eyebrow. Silently, confronting Adora to take a moment and think it through.

A flash of divine light exploded from the amber runestone embedded into the center of her sword. Blasting away the shadow’s and everything else beyond them.

Leaving Adora once more in a gray, featureless world that lacked any substance.

A blank slate, for her to define. In the distance two light's shimmered, one a radiant blue the other a pulsing amber. The thundering sound, of a rapid heart beat, vibrated within the very essence of this world between…life and death…light and dark…the duality of magic…the essence of the universe.

Adora squared her shoulders, raising her head high. Pushing down her turbulent, unresolved emotions and locking them away to deal with later or never. Her expression became hard, her eyes fierce and determined. As she forced herself to move past her fear, past her insecurities and worthlessness. Moving forward, with her armor of detachment once more in place. She was a soldier, always brave in the face of death. Capable of being ruthless to her enemies and in control…always in control.

The twin lights began to fade…into the gray world that surrounded her and soon her own consciousness did as well.

Becoming numb and disconnected, becoming nothing at all…

-Beatrix-

She knew she was dead, yet a fragment of her remained. A dull echo of who she had been in life, trapped within the facets of this ancient ruin. No longer shackled by the burdens she had carried in life. The guilt, the resentments and regrets that had accumulated from a life, that had not turned out how she had planned. Freed from the bitterness, the rage and the misery that had once consumed her. Left to pace the empty halls, like some restless ghost. She had been lost for a long time, the memory of herself drifting and unfocused. Unable to reform into any cohesive shape. Until, Adora's scream's of pain and torment echoed through that lifeless world between.The familiar darkness that had slowly consumed her living self was once more devouring another victim.

It was enough to spur her motherly instincts to protect her child once more.

The fragment of her soul, trapped within the Crystal Castle roared to life. As she charged down the endless corridors, passing effortlessly through the walls as she made her way towards those desperate screams.

Passing into the memory chamber, she was confronted by a small group of princesses. All in varying states of panic…Glimmer was hovering over the head of the crystal table where Adora was laying, her brow furrowed in deep worry. While Melog whimpered from his position sitting at the end of the table. Ears flattened and head bowed in misery. His coat had turned as dark as coal, his fiery mane crackling low along his thick neck, glowing a somber blue. As Adora was completely cocooned in pulsing veins of corruption. Catra had crawled onto the table and knelt beside her. Having pulled Adora’s limp body onto her knees, now cradling Adora's head in her lap. Holding her close and pleading for her to fight! Rocking back forth, ears pinned to her head, as tears streamed down her face, her mismatched eyes so full of distress and fear. That Beatrix was overwhelmed once more with the need to soothe her other child from the overwhelming despair ripping her heart apart. A burning purpose to regain control of this spiraling crisis, flared like a star inside of what remained of her consciousness.

Scorpia prowled the room, looking desperately for a way to help with Perfuma trailing behind her. Offering her support and positive words of encouragement that they would find a way to save Adora. Keeping a watchful eye on Scorpia’s stinger, which was trembling. The scorpioni was agitated and worried, hating feeling completely useless.

When a flash of light ignited at the head of the table. Glimmer yelped and leaped backward. As all eyes snapped at the sudden appearance of the spectral visage of Light Spinner. Standing before the table, dressed in simple, flowing robes etched in First Ones glyphs. Her long hair flutters in the ethereal breeze, the

sharp elven features of her face were flawless, her now pale green eyes glowing with fierce determination.

“Shadow Weaver….Light Spinner?” Catra gasped, ears pinning to her head in fright. Unsure what to call her.

“Please…I have forsaken those petty titles…they are meaningless to me now. You may address me by my true name…Beatrix.” Her smile was small yet tender as she gazed down at Catra.

“O…kay…” Glimmer acknowledged, blinking in complete disbelief at what she was seeing.

“We have no time for pleasantries I am afraid. If you want Adora to survive this, then you need to listen to me and do exactly as I say.” Beatrix paid each Princess a piercing stare, expecting them to obey without debate.

-Entrapta-

The download was taking too long…Entrapta crouched at the base of the dias several meters away from the slowly infected bot. She had another connection cord plugged in the central core of the bot and into her data pad. Her finger’s tapping against the sides of the pad nervously. While the bot’s main connection was plugged into the dais. She was filtering out the virus as the data entered the bot, containing it inside the bot’s memory core and extracting only the data into her pad. But the pulsing veins of corruption webbing out from the bot's central core was starting to overtake the robot's outer hull. The power cell flickering as the bot struggled to stay online.

Entrapta scanned the data on her pad, flickering her eyes up to ascertain how much time she had left until the bot was completely corrupted.

“The First Ones created another portable Rune Stone…the Disc of Destruction? So what I thought was a simple data crystal…that contained a murder virus…was a Runestone and it came from here? The…crystal pillar’s are not the same as Arxia’s…I only have a rudimentary knowledge of Stone masonry…going to have to fix that I guess. But they contain dark magic…unlike Arxia which contains light magic. But that doesn’t explain how the Rune Stone was corrupted?” Entrapta muttered, scrolling through the data feed, reading the information at an intense pace.

The bot twittered, as if in pain. Its round hull trembling as the tendrils began to overtake its body.

“I am sorry…but you need to hold on just a little longer. I’ll purge your system…if you survive.” Entrapta promised, passing the other bot a tentative glance over her shoulder, whose energy guns were pointing directly at its companion. Prepared to obliterate its power core if it went nuts.

“Oh….oh….that’s not good…that’s bad…that’s really bad!” Entrapta exclaimed as she finally got her answer’s from the screen about how the Portable Runestone had been corrupted and then screamed as the infected bot lurched. Its inner gear’s squealing in agony as it fought against the virus but was unable to stop its new commands. Completely overwhelmed by the corruption. Enntrapta scuttled away, the cord snapping away from the bot’s CPU. As its own laser guns erupted from its body and laid down a wide swath of energy beams directly at Entrapta.

The other bot retaliated, firing energy bolts at its companion. The shot’s struck the floor, scaring the metal in black scorch marks. As the infected bot leaped backward, firing back at its companion. Entrapta was forced to duck behind the dais to avoid getting shot and then made a hasty retreat down the corridor. Leaving the two bots to fight and hoping that the uninfected one won. It took less then a second for Entrapta to see the pro’s and con’s of them just fighting it out. The data was not in her favor, the infected bot would be just like the ones back at Dryl so long ago. So full of homicidal rage that it would overpower the other bot in no time

and then it would be after her. She cringed and quickly sent new order's to the uninfected bot to retreat to the tunnel and lure the corrupted bot out of the room. Then it was ordered to detonate itself. Entrapta knew the tunnel would cave in and seal off the entrance but she could excavate later to regain entry.

The two bots however would be irreparable, she had just ordered one to commit suicide just to take out it's friend. She tried to remain impartial to the callous disregard of their lives, but the silent, guilty tears fell anyway.

-Spirit-

The rapid pounding of his hooves, charging down the corridor echoed from just beyond the cavernous room. The two clones never looked up from their task, yet the clones guarding them turned, weapon's drawn. As Spirit exploded back into the room with a pouch dangling from his teeth.

Liam raced in after him, out of breath and heaving for air. "What is going on?" He panted, casting the armored clones a look of alarm. As Spirit spun around and dropped the bag in front of the communication dais.

"Put the power and data crystal's back." The first clone commanded.

"Why? I haven't found Adora yet." Liam picked up the bag, confused. "If we power up the beacon then the Security system will attack us!"

"Our reasoning was faulty." The second sighed, in dismay.

"We must repair the damage we have done to the Crystal Castle." The first clone instructed.

“This wasn’t the plan?” Liam snatched up the pouch, shaking it aggressively at the clones. He stood his ground, refusing to budge.

“Kronis was incorrect in his assessment of the Beacon…Adora was never in any danger…until we interfered. Now we may have endangered all of Etheria. ” The second clone advised sadly.

While Spirit lost his cool, the anxious feeling of time slipping away and Adora getting ever closer to death. Snapping his patience to the breaking point, he lunged for Liam. Hooking his glowing horn into the front of his tunic and lifting the hefty young man off his feet. The sharp cry of alarm and fear that tore from Liam’s throat was music to Spirit’s ears. He would not stand by while Adora succumbed to the corruption. Trotting over the nearest triangle shaped base and dangling him beside it like a rag doll.

“I suggest you do as you're told, or suffer the consequences. Human.” An armored clone broke off from the group and fired a bolt of energy from his cudgel directly at Liam’s flailing feet. The energy bolt scorched the floor just below his dangling boots.

Liam yelped and nodded. Spirit lowered his horn, allowing him to slide back to the ground. Liam quickly got back to work, setting the proper crystals into their original housing in every control base along the edge of the room.

-Scorpia-

“How in the Seven Kingdom’s are you still alive!” Scorpia exclaimed, raising her pincher’s above her head in utter disbelief at what she was seeing.

“I am not.” Beatrix huffed, turning to Glimmer. “What season is this?” She inquired, her mind already envisioning the complex

spell craft she needed the Queen of Bright Moon to cast.

“We are near the end of the cool season.” Glimmer answered.

“I-Lo will begin to wax this time of year. That will help, Adora’s ability to fight against the corrupted magic. ” Beatrix nodded, turning to Catra.
“I-Lo…the twin moons…” Perfuma muttered in confusion. The smallest of Etheria’s satellites and also the strangest. As they orbited each other as they also spun around the planet.

“I do not have time to go into a lecture as to how Mystcor Sorceress accesses Etheria’s magic through the moons. I just need you all to do as I say, trust that I know what I am doing and that if we work together we can save Adora. ” Beatrix growled, rolling her eyes in frustration.

“Ha!” Scorpia blurted out, her voice full of hate and disdain. “Why would I blindly trust the woman who murdered my entire family! You are cruel and manipulative and power hungry. ” She snarled, eyes narrowing in suspicion as she crossed her arms over her chest stubbornly. Glaring fiercely down at the spectral form of Beatrix.

Beatrix’s faded, green eyes widened in sudden clarity as the cruel memories of what she had done in life flooded through her consciousness. She was frozen for only a moment, as several emotion’s passed over her in quick succession. Her pained expressions eventually hardened once more into acceptance and resolve.

“What need would a dead woman have for power?” Beatrix commented dryly.

Scorpia’s mouth hung open in shock at Beatrix’s blunt rebuttal. Then sighed and nodded, acquiescing with a thin, chastised grimace.

“Very, well then. Glimmer, you are the most experienced in spellcraft. So you will conjure the seals in light magic. It is going

to be a three tier spiral…for power, containment and purification. Do you remember how to do that? "

Beatrix, raised an inquiring eyebrow.

Glimmer huffed and nodded. "That's rather complex….but I think I can do it."

Beatrix then turned to Catra next. "You are threaded the most tightly to Adora, so your magic will become our tether."

Catra opened her mouth, about to ask a question. But Beatrix was quick to silence her by speaking again.

"I will instruct you, when we are ready for you to use your magic." Beatrix had little patience, as they were running out of time. Already she could sense Adora's magic was little more than a whisper thin barrier. The corruption had already fed off most of it and soon it would be devouring her life force as it had done to her. After casting the Spell of Obtainment.

"Perfuma…I will need you to reinforce Glimmer's circle with your magic. The Greater Element of Earth is very adept at strengthening other types of magic. " Beatrix curled her finger towards Perfuma, calling her over to stand next to Glimmer.

"Scorpia, I will need you to create a bridge so Catra's consciousness can cross over into the realm of memory," Beatrix beckoned Scorpioni over to the table next to Catra.

"I just learned how to control my lightning…I have no idea how to do that?" Scorpia whimpered, suddenly overwhelmed by her insecurities.

"You're not simply the Princess of Lightning ! " Beatrix sighed in exasperation, then continued. "That is merely a physical manifestation of your intent…you understand that, correct." Beatrix pinched her nose in frustration.

“Yes…hypothetically…Njourn has been teaching me…but that is all I am capable of doing right now.” Scorpia pushed, glancing sideways briefly. As Catra had gasped in shock, quickly ducking her head to conceal her frown. As both pride and jealousy went to war inside of her. She was desperate to reconnect with Ouroboros as she knew already Cyrus's teachings would only take her so far.

“Scorpia…you are capable of anything you set your mind to. Believe in yourself!” Perfuma offered her a bright, confident smile.

Scorpia was instantly warmed by her affirmation, but was still very nervous. She was not naturally talented at anything. Whenever she was put on the spot to do something she had not practiced, it never turned out very well. But Adora needed her! She had to be brave! She had to try!

“Ok…I will give it my best effort!” Scorpia finally declared, placing a pincer on Catra’s shoulder and offering the shorter feline a confident smile of her own.

“I know you can do it.” Catra quickly placed a hand over her pincher, offering her support with a genuine smile of encouragement.

“Shall we begin then?” Beatrix was quick to set to work, instructing Glimmer in the many layers of the conjuring circle as Perfuma strengthened the glyphs by calling upon the roots of the Whispering Woods.

They broke through the floor, cracking and shattering the base of the room. Curling and twisting over the light glyphs of the phases of the moon, the rune symbols and the central symbol of I-Lo, making the various seals a solid construct that glowed with light magic.

Then the late sorceress moved to Scorpia and Catra’s side instructing them as to their part to play in the spell. Scorpia raised her tail high into the air, where her stinger trembled and swayed,

beginning to dance within the air. Gathering the threads of dream magic from the ether, infusing Scorpia with power. Her pincher’s holding onto Catra’s shoulders in a firm grip, not wanting to lose her hold when she crossed the bridge. As the brilliant amber threads wove like a flowing current down her tail and across her torso, weaving down her arms and over her pincher’s. Crossing over Catra’s shoulder’s and down her tawny arms. As Catra set Adora’s head tenderly back down upon her lap and closed her eyes, bending down over her head. Her hands pressed flat on either side of Adora’s temples. Shuttering in revulsion as the fleshy tendrils were writhing under her palms. As she drew her consciousness inward, focusing on sensing Scorpia's magic, on finding that bridge that was going to carry her across into the realm between. That Adora was currently trapped in and fighting for her life. The thread’s of dream bound Scorpia to Catra and Catra to Adora. As Catra’s mind was suddenly catapulted across that bridge between reality and into the realm of dream. In a flash of pure intention. Catra maintained her focus on reaching Adora who was trapped in flow of memories, as the real world faded away. All of her senses replaced by the suffocating darkness currently devouring her true love.

Chapter Two

Chapter Notes

> Thank you Eva Wolf, Pink Storm and Bitzy Bee for your comments. This last chapter was running long...so I had to break it up. Thank you all who left kudo's as well.

“ You inspired us. You inspired me. Not because it was your destiny, but because you never let fear stop you. And now, I choose to be brave.”- Queen Angella of Bright Moon

-Adora-

The most piercing, awful screaming echoed and rebounded all around her. The raw brutality of those cries pulsed in her ear drums. It was the desperate howls of a trapped animal, willing to gnaw off its own leg just to be free. So full of agony and despair. Adora’s heart leaped uncontrollably with terror, beating frantically in her throat like the wings of a frightened bird. The misery exploding from the dark was difficult to endure. The wretched sounds of torment. Gave Adora terrible visions of a horde of demon’s from some forgotten hell, ravaging some helpless victim. Tearing and shredding into their fragile, tender flesh and ripping them apart.

It was jarring and gut wrenching to hear. Made even worse with the realization that it was her own voice, wailing in misery into that void. Creating a suffocating wave of anxiety and fear that was twisting her stomach into sickening knots.

An indigo glow flickered in the distance, compelling Adora forward as if being pulled by a string. A cavernous room slowly came into

view, a low somber light glowed from teardrop shaped crystals held against the walls by iron scones. Faintly illuminating the smooth metal walls. Three dark crystal pillar’s upon a dais, ascended upward out of view. With a floating diamond in the center, pulsing red glyphs circled the object. Casting a malicious ambience over the walls of this monstrous chamber. The sight of the dark pillars filled Adora with a primordial fear that left her shaking and frozen in place before the stairs of the dais. Whatever magic lay inside those crystals, it was vile and malicious, created to inflict incredible amounts of suffering.

Unable to summon the courage to move any closer. As her terrible screams continued from the middle of those dark pillar’s, as if she was being torn apart from the inside out. She remained rooted before the stairs, eyes wide in terror and trembling. Humiliated by her cowardice, she ground her teeth and grimaced. Clenching her hands into fists, mentally chastising herself for being weak.

Then Adora felt a small touch, finger’s slipping into the palm of her hand. She snapped her gaze away from the ominous black pillar’s. To find a small child, wrapped in an old, threadbare gray cloak standing beside her. Her face is hidden in shadow by the hood's low cowl. Only her bright emerald eyes could be seen. The girl's tiny hand clutching Adora’s so tightly, as if anchoring her to this place so she couldn’t flee.

“It will be alright…you need to push through this…be brave Adora. ” Her voice was soft, yet laced with iron. As she turned slowly, raising her face up to reveal herself.

Adora gasped, to find Trixie standing beside her. Her face, smeared with grime and dirt. The young Gar walked forward, lightly pulling upon her arm. Urging her to move forward with her up the steps.

Adora swallowed hard and nodded, obediently following the child. That would one day become the bitter, cruel and manipulative shadow that would darken her own childhood.

Trixie slowly guided her up the stairs and into the shadows of the pillars. The horror that awaited within was beyond anything Adora had witnessed before. A cold shiver of dread, trembled over her. As her heart clenched in her chest and her breath refused to draw inward as she began to panic.

She saw the Disc of Destruction…Despara's portable Runestone locked into a pyramid control panel, with a dreadfully glowing dark blue shard plugged in above. Black tendrils were crawling out of the plug, as angry red veins webbed outward from the center of the triangle shaped RuneStone. The darkness and the corruption was mixing and twisting with each other as it crawled, like a viral fungus. Over the pyramid and across the bottom of the dias to the base of the crystal pillars.

Adora's mind, seeking to give a visual representation as to the gravity of what was happening. Gave the magic of the Goddess, Despara a form she would recognize. Which was a version of Adora herself, with short light blonde hair. Who was naked and kneeling, with her arms over her head. Her wrists cuffed and locked in place by thick metal chains, like a victim about to be sacrificed. The once strong, fearsome vision of herself. Was now bowed and writhing in agony, as dark tendrils of corruption snaked out from the top of the pyramid and crawled over her hands and down her arms, quickly engulfing her. Her eyes were glowing a brilliant ruby red, with her power. As radiant veins of blood red, oozed from the corner of her eyes and ran down her face like tears. As if the power inside her eyes was bleeding out. Mixing with the dark tendrils creeping over her body, twisting and convulsing into a horrific, writhing mass of viral corruption. That was far more potent and deadly than Despara's wrathful vengeance from before. That had destroyed the first test subject and the lab.

Despara screamed defiantly and fought viciously against her restraints. The black stain that stretched across her eyes, which resembled Shadow Weaver's mask. Was smeared and trailing down her cheeks with her bloody tears. The scars she wore across the bridge of her nose and her jaw were inflamed and pink from

her intense exertions to free herself. Sweat beaded and rolled down her face from her hairline.

Blood oozed from beneath the cuffs, as her powerful arms were straining to pull the chains free from the bolt above her head. Her abdominal core of well packed muscle was flexing and twisting as she bucked against the heavy chains. Her toes curled into the dias, seeking to find purchase. While her thick, well muscled legs pushed forward attempting to add more pressure against the chains.

"This all could have been avoided, if you would have just submitted and allowed your magic to bond with our Champion… now you will have no choice and you will be forced to bond with me. " A smooth, condescending voice advised beyond the pillar's. The first attempt to bond her magic to a First One had been disastrous. Costing them a, would be Champion, several scientists and also a laboratory. Sealing Despara inside the Portable RuneStone was one thing, but the First Ones also needed the goddess to submit. So her magic could be controlled, weaponized. The parasitic magic from the Crystal of Kaydak was seeking to drain her magic enough to weaken her. So that they could bond her against her will to another Champion. So Despara was giving it her all, fighting for her freedom.

Adora clenched her fists, grinding her teeth as she fought the urge to intervene. She had no idea how to help Despara and tragically she knew this had already happened. This was a memory and there was not a damn thing she could do to stop it.

"Now, there is no sense in resisting. It will only prolong your suffering." A very well dressed Gar mounted the steps. He wore a purple suit and long black leather cape with silver goat skull pendants. Sighing heavily, as if it pained him to do this. As he stood just outside the crystal pillar's. Leaning upon a walking staff with a silver goat's skull as a ball grip on top. Staring down at Despara with a fake sympathetic smile, that looked more like a sneer. His skin had a grayish blue hue. He is rather tall with broad shoulders yet lacking in any real muscle mass. His dark hair hung

low over his pointed ears, wild and graying significantly. His dark blue eyes were shaded by heavy brows that made him look like some predatory bird. His sharp jaw line and square face was accented by a small dark mustache and goatee. He looked ever the pompous aristocrat.

Despara paid Senator Keldor, no heed. Continuing her futile struggle against her bonds. When a black, void deep shadow shimmered into existence beside her. Followed by the stagnate stench of rot and decay. A single red eye opened in the center of its featureless shaped head, fractured in the center as if the pupil was shattered. It loomed over her, staring down at her plight, in silent scrutiny.

"My lord… " The Gar was quick to fall to one knee, lowering his head respectfully.

Adora clasped her hands over her mouth and nose in an attempt to stifle the foul order that followed the appearance of the Shadow. As her stomach heaved and she suddenly felt light headed and woozy. The sight of the void like shadow was so much more disturbing then the shades Shadow Weaver had conjured to spy on her. Made even more terrifying by the cold, sinister feelings that accompanied its presence.

Trixie was not affected by the shadow's appearance, her eyes narrowed in contempt as she slipped in front of Adora like a tiny sentinel. Prepared to shield and protect her, confident that her small frame was capable of summoning enough magic power to fend the darkness off. Or perhaps it was simply maternal instinct no matter the odds, to fling oneself in front of danger to protect one's children. She had done it before, sacrificed her life so that her daughters could live, without a second thought.

"I will never submit to the Nameless One!" Despara raged.

"It is only a matter of time…and my patience is infinite. Those who thirst for power, the ones who crave to dominate and control. Will come to me for aid and I shall offer them what they seek. As

it was in the beginning, as it will be again. I shall infect the willing souls. In so doing, I shall subjugate the living to my will. Until I am once again whole. Then I shall devour this universe, bringing an everlasting peace with my ultimate silence. You can not stop what is eternal. ” The shadow’s words were cryptic, but sounded eerily like some all-powerful monologue Horde Prime would spout.

Adora shivered with dread. As Despara began to laugh. Her voice was manic and full of wrath. As the Nameless Ones dark tendrils were now fused with the Disc of Destruction’s corruption.

“My rage is infinite also….so is my thirst for justice! I will be free again and so will Sheana…then we shall see who truly is eternal!” She bellowed, her declaration exploding like a thunder clap.

A flood of anguish tore through both Adora and Despara. As the brutal memories of the goddesses' chosen vessel’s, murder. At the hands of these Eternian’s. Flashed in vivid and bloodstained clarity through her mind. As a yearning for vengeance boiled in the very pit of her essence. The pain and terror of being ripped away from Sheana, from the very ether of Etheria itself. Enslaved and sealed inside this wretched Runestone. The twisting torment of the Nameless One tainting their magic, making them hungry, making them mad with dark desires to devour…to consume…it came screaming into the living world. Heedless of intent or purpose, writhing like a mad thing, in the heat of rage, of wrath it surged forth in crushing waves. Overwhelming the dais, covering the crystal pillar’s. Increasing in speed and power as the dark viral corruption was now out of control and seeking to consume everyone and everything on Galius.

Senator Keldor turned on his heel as he lost control of Despara’s magic once again. This time the viral corruption that was created was far more heinous in its intent, fueled by a thirst for ultimate destruction and far more murderous.

It devoured everything in its path as it spread, computer and biological alike. Those who would survive the corruption of Galius

would evacuate to Arxia. Telling horrific tales of their escape, as the island was consumed by corrupted magic. Senator Keldor would forever be scared by that endeavor to control Despara. As the corruption fueled by a dark malicious wrath had nearly consumed him as he tried to escape back up the tunnel. Leaving his body in a slowly rotting state of decay.

Adora was thrust back into the gray limbo, with only the steady sound of a distant heartbeat to focus on. As she struggled to cope with the last and most horrific revelation from the past.

Despara walked out of the gray mist, head bowed humbly before Adora. Wearing the sharper, darker armor of She-Ra. Her long shimmering cape, like starlight, snapped in the wind of her power. The hilts of her silver swords hung from her hips as her boots made no sound as she walked.

"In the day's following the Island's corruption. A strike team from Rebel Squadron Grayskull would mount a suicide mission to Galius. Seeking to stop the spread of the corruption before it devoured the whole planet. By separating the Disc of Destruction from the Shard of Kaydak. One would take the Shard of Kaydak, while another member hid my Runestone in the Starseed mines of Dryl." Despara confessed, still unable to meet Adora's concerned stare.

"That was how the sword of protection got infected…with that rage virus. I was out of control…out of my mind…just like you were at the end." Adora breathed, finally having her answers. "I am so, so, sorry…that he did that to you…" Adora sniffled, spreading her arms wide and inviting Despara into her embrace.

Despara swallowed, nervous and uncertain about allowing her Vessel to comfort her. She was loath to show weakness, to be vulnerable with anyone other than Sheana. It was her purpose to make this human woman stronger, capable of defending the Universe. Receiving comfort from her seemed wrong?

But in the end Despara gave Adora a grateful, watery smile and allowed the shorter blonde to hold her. Despara had to bend slightly to hug Adora, since she was over seven feet tall. Her larger, more muscular frame almost enveloped the smaller human proportioned Adora. Who barely came up to Despara's chest, yet she was not deterred in any way by the height difference. Adora still clutched onto the goddess, tightly. Offering as much comfort as she could muster. Holding the essence of death itself in a loving embrace. As the goddess cried silently, as she tucked her head against Adora's neck. Finally able to purge the grief, loneliness and pain she had kept bottled up inside for nearly a thousand years. Her suffering was over and she was so very grateful to finally have a vessel whose will was so strong and had an endless amount of love and compassion for others.

"Thank you….Adora…" Despara faded away in her arms, dissipating into the gray world like smoke. Then the world faded into nothingness along with Adora.

Adora's return to awareness again was excruciatingly slow. She was groggy and disoriented. The first sense to come alive was the soft sound of footfalls, then she felt her legs moving, the muscles once nonexistent flexed and stretched as she walked. Then finally the twilight world began to form around her. As she found herself moving through the warm shade of tall trees, both ancient and grand. Her thoughts felt sluggish, as if she was slowly waking up from a very long, very deep slumber. She was in the heart of the Whispering Woods and moving south. The sun was setting, the last ember's of light glowing low on the horizon amid the trees. She was close to Bright Moon. As the ancient oaks and the more lush fertile growth of the lowland valleys stretched out before her. Filled with lush orchards and gardens hidden in the wide open glades and meadow's scattered throughout the woods,

She felt the gentle presence of grazing animals nearby, hidden within the undergrowth that surrounded the ancient trees. Moving quietly through the naturally trimmed glade, full of berry bushes of plump ripe fruit. This area looked both familiar and alien at the same time. A strange sense of deja vu tickled at the back of her mind. She remembered this…but it was like a lost and forgotten dream.

The old growth of the woods that surrounded her. Was much more pristine, the colors more vivid than in real life. The sky overhead, at least what she could make out of it. From within the webbing cracks between the dark green leaves of the branches high in the canopy. It was full of starlight. The millions of tiny sparks glittering within the backdrop of a glowing twilight sky, that held a layer of magic hidden just underneath.

Adora moved like a specter, unseen but not undetected by the wild life. Who would acknowledge her with wary looks and flickering ears. As she silently passed deer and boar, grazing peacefully along the mossy banks of a slow moving stream. She had hiked through most of the valleys and orchards that surrounded Bright Moon castle over the last few years. She felt she knew her way around the Whispering Woods, at least a good chunk of it. The stream she was following was a part of the runoff from Half Moon lake, judging by the location and direction the water was flowing in. It was part of a branch of the Singing River, the rugged peak of Sky Dancer mountain. Was looming close by in the distance beyond the tree line. If she continued on her course she would eventually reach the lake that surrounded the Castle of Bright Moon.

Adora kept to the stream, intending to follow it to the castle. In time the woods shifted, as a mighty weeping willow rose up before her from the center of the stream. Who's curtain of dark lavender leaves obscured the banks on both sides of the river. Its tender roots twisting and knotting through the clear water, creating a natural dam of sorts. That only allowed a fraction of the river to trickle around and filter through its slender roots. Lowering the water level on the other side of the dam by a few

inches or so. Adora couldn't say if she was still near Bright Moon as she couldn't place where she was at all anymore. She had two choices, remain on this side of the bank or cross over to the other side, by climbing over the less than sturdy looking roots. Glancing into the water, watching the silvery scales of fish glinting beneath the surface. Hiding within the submerged roots, darting and dancing out of cover beneath the surface. The branches overhead tossed in the sudden gust of wind. The fragile leaves released from the slender branches to fall like rain onto the water. Where they floated downstream, spinning with each other as elegantly as dancer's within a ballroom.

Adora froze, as she heard a small voice calling to her from the tree line of fat oaks on the other side of the stream. Turning towards the other side of the bank, she searched the line of tall, ancient trees and thick river weed. That grew on the other side, for the voice. Her gaze fell on a familiar child leaning casually against the rough bark of a massive oak tree. Trixie was older yet again. Her once tiny, fine boned body had turned lanky and lean as she was now on the cusp of adolescence. She paid Adora a cocky smirk, spinning a dagger in one hand deftly, then sheathing it at her hip. Her dark hair was crudely plaited into a braid, wisps of stray hair fluttered in disarray around her pointed ears. She wore simple brown leather breeches that only reached her knees and a flowing long sleeve shirt of dark burgundy. That she had tucked into a wide hide belt that had several large pouches sewn along its length. A same dull gray cloak, now even more tattered and worn. Hung from her shoulders, the hood now lined with wool. Then, she swiftly pulled the hood up over her head, lifting a black veil that had been tucked around her neck. Covering her mouth so that only her wary emerald eyes could be seen. Always shifting, always alert to threats that may lurk just out of sight.

"Trixie?" Adora breathed.

"I need you to hold on…" Catra's voice echoed through the forest. "I can't imagine my life with you gone."

Adora spun around, wanting to call out to her. The pull to reach Catra was incredibly strong, but the rustle of Trixie moving off the tree and scampering down the bank on her bare feet instantly drew Adora's attention back to the forest around her.

"Years wasted by fighting, yearning but denying. " The pain and sorrow, in Catra's song, cut into Adora like a knife. Adora's attention was once again pulled to the forest, needing to get to her…soothe her, show her how much she missed her, loved her…

"She is calling you…we don't have much time." Trixie sprinted for the edge of the mossy bank on the other side and then jumped. She soared over the stream, as if she was as light as a feather. Floating down onto the other side, as gracefully as a willow leaf.

"I am not willing to give up on the joy that I've found." The forest trembled in determined vibrations of Catra's next lyric. "I would be so lost if you left me, now." The magicats voice ascended into the darkening blue twilight sky above.

Trixie quickly grasped Adora's hand. Pulling her deeper into the forest. Adora's eyes flew wide in surprise to find a glowing orange thread now wrapped around her wrist. She could feel Catra's magic within that thread, pulsing and flickering like firelight. Her wild, passionate essence was infused within that tie that was now bound to her.

The forest sped past her in a blur of motion as Trixie led her at a breakneck pace towards the shimmering banks of Half Moon lake. The darker hues of the coming night had fallen over the sky, during their rapid trek through the forest. The Greater Moons were heavy in the velvet black sky, all in different states of waning. Yet Elidor was full, it sat proudly just above the peak of Sky Dancer Mountain. Regal and imposing, casting its gentle silver light upon the dark water like a heavenly lantern. Turning the waves, rushing to shore a lustrous, sparkling silver. Adora stood solemnly upon the rocky shore of the lake. Taking in the ethereal glory of the night sky, slowly coming into view high above

the fading light on the horizon. The shimmering backdrop of millions of stars. Made her feel so small, so insignificant…

“I wonder if she would be proud of me?” Glimmer sighed, gazing out over the water of the lake. Her lavender eyes were distant and full of longing, she missed her mother. There wasn't a day that had gone by since her sacrifice that Glimmer didn’t regret their last, antagonistic confrontation. She would do anything to go back and apologize for that fight. To hug her mother one last time and tell her how much she loved her.

Adora snapped her gaze back down. Finding the Queen of Bright Moon standing beside her, once again dressed in her royal robe from her coronation. The pearl white sheen of the garment seemed to reflect the moonlight. Glimmer looked as she once was two years ago. Her stare was colder now, hiding so much grief and rage. As she stood before Adora, with her father’s staff in her hands. Her eyes shimmered with unresolved pain as she avoided Adora’s eyes. Unwilling to confront her best friend and the shared grief and regret she would see reflected back at her through those kind blue eyes.

“I’m sure of it.” Adora affirmed, offering her best friend a warm, tender smile.

“I miss her.” Glimmer whispered, sniffling softly. As Adora reached out and clasped her hand in hers. Offering her comfort and support, always.

“I miss her too…I promised that I would take care of you…take care of everyone, and I will!” Adora declared. Glimmer turned to her for the first time and smiled, triumphantly.

“There’s my best friend…I knew you were still in there.” Glimmer giggled softly and glanced down to Adora’s feet.

Adora followed her gaze to find that she was wearing She-Ra’s boots. Somehow she had summoned that piece of armor.

(Everyone you hold dear is weaved into your magic, my dear.” Razz’s voice whispered from the woods behind them. “Glimmer...is your determination, she gives you wings, so that you remain steadfast upon your goals.)

Adora gasped in shock, as Trixie clasped her hand and pulled her away from Glimmer. Trixie was older, her face was clean and she now looked more nourished. With healthy looking skin and shiny black hair. Looking like she did when she had been taken in by Mystacor. With her long sleeve white shirt, bunched up around her elbows and dark pants. With sturdy leather boots upon her feet. Wearing the twin braids and leather veil. With a heavy leather apron of a Stone Mason apprentice.

Her eyes shone with a stern resolve to prove herself. Adora had witnessed that fierce stare many times from Catra growing up. Usually during their combat simulations, when their cadet rankings were on the line. Then her wrist caught her eyes and Adora smiled fondly. Finding a silvery-pink thread had now been knotted and weaved with Catra’s. She could feel the Queen of Bright Moon’s steady conviction to always prevail, so be the rock everyone could draw strength from.

“Hold on, I want you. Hold on, I need you. Take my hand, I’ll lead you home. “ Catra's beautiful voice serenaded her as they disappeared into the heart of the woods once more.

When the blur of light and color slows and her surroundings come back into focus. Adora finds herself on a lush outlook deep in the Whispering Woods. With the breathtaking view of a valley and the Singing River. Just is just a ribbon of crystal blue under the starlit sky. The many moon’s of Etheria hung in the dark backdrop of space. All in various states of Waxing or Waning. This view was always awe inspiring, leaving Adora staring breathless, with wonder at the natural beauty Etheria possessed.

“Did you find your answers?” Mara’s gentle voice drew her gaze away from the valley below.

Finding her mentor, her hero, standing beside her. Dressed once more in the majestic armor of She-Ra. Her platinum blonde hair fluttered in the warm breeze behind her. Glowing blue eyes staring at her expectant and hopeful.

"Yes…and so much more." Adora nodded. "Thank you for inspiring me…to be the best She-Ra I could be. You may not have been a hero to your people or to Etheria…but you're a hero to me." She clasped Mara's hands in hers, professing her gratitude with an earnest smile.

"Adora…" Mara breathed, overwhelmed by her praise. Then she began to study Adora intently, her gaze ardent and full of pride. "I believe in you. You have already saved the world we love. I know you can save the universe as well."

Adora sniffled, valiantly trying to hold back her tears. With Mara's encouragement once more, Adora felt her confedence in herself returning. As Mara's bracer's formed in a flash of divine light upon her wrists.

(Mara...is your courage. She guides your hands, so that they will be both strong and compassionate, when confronted by adversity.) Razz's voice echoed joyfully from the valley below.

Adora's smile broadened as a thread that shimmered both gold and silver was added to the weaving threads that were already knotted around her wrist. She could feel the bold, yet serene power humming from that thread.

"Hurry…we must go!" Trixie grasped her hand and pulled her onward. The Gar was once again older. Her body had blossomed into womanhood as she was nearing the end of her adolescence. Her long dark hair was free and fluttering in the warm breeze. Wearing simple tan pants and a soft, lilac tunic, with billowing white sleeves with deep maroon leather pauldrons with gold trim. That illustrated she was now an Apprentice of the Sorcerer guild. A faded wine red face mask, held in place with gold hooks hung from her pointed ears.

“I see you lying so lifeless, I’m scared I am losing you to this crisis.” Catra’s voice broke, as she gasped for breath. “Locked inside your mind, struggling but fighting. “ Her tone was heavy, overwhelmed by fear. “I take your hand in mine, I need to feel your warmth. I pull you in, desperate to hear your heartbeat. “ She sang mournfully through the trees, as Adora raced away with Trixie.

“Hold on, I want you. Hold on, I need you. Take my hand, I’ll lead you home. “ Catra’s song followed them as they disappeared back into the forest.

When the world came back into focus once more. Adora found herself in a wide open clearing near Bright Moon. The tall grass and wildflowers scattered throughout, made the air heady with soft scents. The sky was warming slowly as dawn approached, with not a cloud to be seen. Several archery butts of woven straw were set up on the far side. With ripe apple trees guarding the edge of the clearing on either side and the peak of Sky Dancer Mountain could be seen in the distance.

Bow was sitting on the ground, content in his endeavors to repair the reinforced fletching on one of his trick arrows. It had a cartridge attached to the shaft and a four pronged arrow tip. His retractable bow and quiver was laying beside him.

Adora recognized this place instantly, this was Bow’s special training ground. He built it himself away from the Castle so he could experiment and develop his more dangerous trick arrows without accidentally damaging the Castle. She had spent many days training with the Sword of Protection nearby. While Bow tested his arrows. This place held fond memories for her. As well as Bow, as they had spent countless hours together here over the years. Bonding and getting to know each other first, then having many heart to heart conversations about Glimmer, about Catra… about the war. Bow had always been her emotional compass. Able to direct her in how other people feel, even how she felt. When

she was confused, or adrift and lost to how to navigate her relationships. During the high pressure times of the war. He had a level head and the biggest, kindest heart she had ever known. She had always felt safe to speak her mind and not have to worry about him judging her or ruining their friendship. Bow always tried to understand all sides and worked tirelessly to make sure all of his friends felt they were being heard and cared for. He was always positive and encouraging, his ready smile and goofy jokes always brightened her day no matter how stressed out she was. Bow was the one who taught her how to have healthy boundaries, to value herself and speak up when she didn't agree with her friends.

She looked to him for guidance when it came to her relationships with the princesses, with Glimmer….with Catra. She was kinda dumb when it came to feelings and why people acted the way they did. She had come to depend on his empathic nature to help guide her through the most difficult times in her life.

"Ok…it's going to work this time. I know it!" He encouraged himself.

"I know it will." Adora offered him a strong confident smile as she approached.

He paid her a beaming smile before rising to his feet, grabbing his bow as he stood up.

Bow gave her one last warm, knowing look.

"You have so much confidence in me." He chuckled with amusement.

"Why wouldn't I? You're an amazing inventor. " Adora placed both hands on her hips, her expression confused.

"Because I've already failed countless times getting this stupid, flash bomb arrow to work…why would this time be any different." He pushed, shaking the arrow at her.

“Well…because you are still trying to fix it…you are not giving up? So why would I give up on you? So maybe this is the time it works…” Her explanation was awkward and rambling, but full of honest encouragement.

“Exactly….think positively and persevere, that is the key, right.” His smile was genuine, a hidden meaning lying just beneath the surface.

Adora raised an eyebrow, catching the subtle context towards her own personal struggles. Not to give into the insurmountable odds currently stacked against her. In repairing her relationship with her old bunkmates, or the current threats to Etheria, or even her magic…

“Bow…what are you trying to say?” She was intrigued and wanted clarification, as to what he was getting at. It wasn’t like she couldn’t relate to what he was saying, she just wanted him to be upfront about it.

Bow merely sighed, turning towards the target and knocking his arrow. Getting through Adora’s Horde conditioning to plan obsessively for every contingency, to be in control of every situation. To always be that strong, unbreakable vanguard that protected them from every threat. Taking the brunt of the attack upon herself, heedless of her own well being. Causing her to overthink, then catastrophize, then over work herself to the point of complete exhaustion both physically and mentally. Until she was just a shell, going through the motions of living. Always so willing to sacrifice everything, for the greater good. It has always been an uphill battle for him. That he still felt he was nowhere near, getting her to realize.

“I’ve been working on this new trick arrow for weeks Adora…I don’t put unrealistic expectations upon myself I can’t achieve. I take each failure and learn from it, so that I can improve and one day…one day I’ll get it right. If it takes, weeks or months or even years…that's ok…my progress towards my goals is steady. I don't have to succeed in a day.” He quickly sheathed his arrow in his

quiver and walked up to her. Clasping her shoulders in his hands, if offered her a kind, understanding smile. His warm brown eyes were concerned, yearning for her to finally give herself a break.

"Stop trying to be perfect…just be you…take each day as it comes. Knowing that you are loved…failures, faults and all. You don't have to earn it, Adora. Your life is important too. I wish you would see that already." He heaved a deep breath, as Adora pulled him in and held him tight. Silent tears falling down her face as she once again absorbed all his love and encouragement. She really needed to hear that. To know that she had people who genuinely loved her for who she was. That she was worthy…not because of what she could do, but for who she was. His words settled like a balm over her turbulent mind soothing her heartache and calming her doubts and insecurities about herself.

She was valued and she was loved…

Her chest glowed in a flash of divine light, as She-ra's armor enrobed her body. Adora gasped and pulled back. Finding Bow grinning proudly up at her.

"I knew you could do it!" He exclaimed, taking in his best friend now standing tall and powerful before him. Her half skirt snapping in the wind as it rushed over the clearing, flower petals and leaves swirling away into the thick underbrush of the trees beyond the glade.

Adora slowly took in her white tunic, emblazoned in the golden star of She-Ra with the blue runestone in the center. Her smooth golden pauldrons with the heart cut out in the neck guard. The long pants with golden stripes along her thighs and the half skirt that hung low down her hips.

(Bow...is your heart. He gives you the strength to persevere no matter the odds.) Razz's weathered voice whispered from the trees.

“I know you can hear me calling,” Catra’s pleading voice, echoed from beyond the horizon.

Adora spun back towards the Whispering Woods, her wrist flying into view as she turned so abruptly. Smiling fondly as she noticed yet another thread coiled and knotted with the other’s. It didn’t glow with magic, but was a lustrous deep blue. As gentle and kind as the soul it was connected to.

“I know you can hear me crying, “ Catra’s serenade called out to her, the pain and worry tugging at Adora to move.

“I know you can hear me screaming, Please don’t leave me!” Catra’s voice ascended into the warming sky, a sincere plea for her to come to her.

“We must go.” An elegant, deep voice, full of stoic authority drew Adora’s gaze away from the sky. Her eyes fell downward to find Light Spinner standing before her, reaching for her hand. Dressed in the long pink and dark purple robes of a Master Sorceress. With the dark maroon leather pauldrons and gold trim. Her guild badge sitting proudly upon her chest and deep red veil concealing her mouth. So the only way to gauge her emotions was through those piercing emerald green eyes. That held a calculating gleam that made Adora wary.

Adora blinked, suddenly nervous about taking this woman’s hand. She pulled her hand away, holding it close to her chest when Light Spinner reached for it. All the times before she had taken Beatrix’s hand and followed without debate. Those incarnations were not yet tarnished by the sins, her adult self would commit. This version of her was already choosing to head down that dark path. Her hunger for power and validation, already tainting her choices, towards the cruel, bitter, manipulative monster she would one day become.

“Adora…please…come with me..I need you to trust me.” Light Spinner pleaded desperately, reaching for her again. Her green eyes were glossy, searching Adora’s uncertain expression. For any

trace of loyalty, or compassion that she might still harbor for her.

Adora was taken aback, still holding her hand out of Light Spinner's reach. Glaring cautiously at the sorceress, unwilling to take her hand. This version of Beatrix was proud…she would not beg…or plead? She would not look so vulnerable…so scared? Adora quickly took the woman's measure, narrowing her eyes as she debated her choices. This Beatrix had been the one to lead her to Glimmer, to Mara and to Bow…this time…

Adora took a deep breath and reached out and took Light Spinner's hand, willing to trust that she would be taken to Catra. Light Spinner breathed in relief and gave Adora a warm, confident smile. As the woods sped past them in a blur of light and color once more. Catra's song grew stronger, trembling through the fabric of this reality.

"I know your world has become dark, I need you to search for that spark.

Please keep on trying, wanting and striving.

I will be here forever waiting for you.

I swear I will love you for the rest of my life.

Come back, I don't want to let you go.

I just wanna take you home."

Chapter Three

Chapter Notes

> Ok...so one more chapter...cause I need to put a proper bow on this arc before we move on. Thank you Bitzy Bee, Pink Storm and Oddbodkin for your comments.
> I need to seriously catch up on my RWBY. Thank you to all who left Kudo's as well.

"Adora, I've had the ability to form complex thoughts for like...a week and even I know you can't help anyone by hiding. Where would all the horses I freed from their barns be if I just sat in a pasture and moped?" Swift Wind- Trusty Steed of She-Ra

-Catra-

The final words of her song were still floating away in the breeze. A beautiful entreaty filled with hope slowly fading upon the horizon. The power of her song, capable of transcending the realm's between, reaching out to her lost love and calling her home.

Catra pressed herself up tight against the gnarled trunk of an old oak tree. Her hands unconsciously tracing the uneven bark behind her back. The huge tree bares the scars of previous wounds inflicted during past battles within the Whisper Woods. Freshly healed over with new growth, a testament to the strength and resilience of the trees. That has survived so much over the last few years. Once again the vast forest was under attack, by a sinister force.

The base of the oak and elm trees just beyond her hiding spot, were being slowly strangled by corruption. The pulsing vines

crawled up from the earth and spiraled around the base, choking the trees. Not all of the forest was diseased, but many glades and orchards were already blighted. Succumbing to the viral corruption or already dead.

Catra had been avoiding the corruption, seeking to stay ahead of the creeping darkness consuming the forest. She glanced around the trunk briefly, scanning the looming forest for the shadows hunting them. A cold dread always preceded their appearance. Like a harbinger of impending doom, alerting Catra to run!

Catra's tail was tucked low around her waist, so it would not give them away. Her ear's twitching anxiously as she listened for any kind of disturbance to the dry litter of leaves and twigs upon the forest floor. But thankfully there was no sound of their pursuers.

"Cat…are they gone?" A soft, fearful whisper issued up from near her chest.

Catra sighed and glanced down briefly, not wanting to take her eyes off the forest for very long. They had been running from monsters made of shadows all night. They resembled Shadow Weaver's old shadow spies, but their single, sinister red eye had a shattered pupil. Hopelessness always accompanied them when they drew close. Creating a paralyzing terror that hung heavy in the air around them. Catra had figured it was better to just keep her distance, then engage lest she get caught up in their dark spell and unable to defend her two wards.

The sky was starting to warm with the coming dawn, the gray mist once enshrouding the forest fading slowly As the pre-dawn fog started rising up from the ground as the world began to heat up. Now hovering overhead in the canopy of branches like a low flying cloud. Catra was thankful, as it was one less thing obscuring her sight.

Catra offered the young version of Adora she cradled against her chest with her right arm a small, reassuring smile. She had a soft, tender round face. Her light blonde falling free down her back.

Wearing a light, white sundress with thin golden straps and a matching silk sash that she had tied up at the back in a bow. Her bare legs were marred by angry pink scratches, bruised knees and bare feet caked in mud.
"Shush…Sheana…we gotta be quiet!" A harsher, more rough voice chastised from her other arm.

"It's ok….Despara." Catra glanced down offering the other version of Adora a warm, tender smile of understanding. Holding the girl tight for a moment, so she could draw strength from her steady presence. She looked identical to Adora as a first year cadet. But with short hair, cropped along her sides. Wearing dark gray pants that only reached her knees and a sleeveless indigo colored tunic with silver accents. Her legs were also dirty and scratched from their frantic, rather deadly game of hide and seek. With the horde of shadows currently hunting for them.

Sheana huffed and stuck her tongue out at the other girl, raising her chin with a petulant air. Despara grunted, folding her arms over her chest in indignation.

Catra had come to realize over the course of the night that the girls really cared for each other. But they tended to butt heads at times, their personalities mirroring both her and Adora's as small children. Sheana was brave and kind, always taking the lead and trying to protect Despara. While Despara tended to be more rash and confrontational, not always agreeing with Catra's plans. She had her own ideas about how they should deal with the shadows hunting them and it wasn't run and hide. She was a fighter through and through. But Sheana kept her under control though, knowing exactly what to say or what to do to make Despara stop and listen to reason.

As Catra had been keeping the last remnants of Adora's magic safe all night and she would protect them until Adora showed up to claim them.

"Adora is going to find us….soon…" Catra promised, having complete faith, that Adora would follow her song. As she did

before when she traveled between realities and they shared one dream atop the Sunna Stone. It was the sudden rustle of rushing feet that had Catra's hackles rising in alarm. She pushed both little girls behind her, widening her stance and raising her claws to defend them.

As the underbrush of ferns and bushes in the front of them began to quiver and be pushed aside roughly. As whoever or whatever was coming upon them, was intent on barreling right through them.

-Glimmer-

The magic seal was holding, but barely. The writhing mass of corruption within the containment sphere was a constant, ever present pressure. Slowly wearing her down. At this point it was only her grit and stubbornness holding the corruption at bay. Glimmer groaned, bearing down and grounding her stance to maintain her focus. Her eyes glowed with power, as she tucked her chin refusing to give up. Unwavering in her resolve to maintain the seals, she summoned every ounce of her magic and channeled it through her hands.

Glimmer's glyph work, now circled the memory table, creating an outer containment sphere. While a smaller ring of glyphs inside the sphere, created a glowing layer of protection. Encasing both Catra and Scorpia. As they sought to pull Adora out of the fugue-like state she was trapped in. The corruption crawled, desperately over their glowing skin, unable to penetrate the magic barrier keeping them safe. The central glyph representing the moons, I-Lo glowed just beneath the table offering Adora strength by fortifying her magic by tapping into her source.

Perfuma was standing beside the containment sphere, casting her arms before her. Grunting with the exertion of maintaining a steady flow of earth magic around the memory table. Glimmer's containment was reinforced by a runic cage of roots, holding back the demonic veins of corruption that were now writhing against the glowing sides of the cage. The mass of corruption that had cocooned Adora had quickly overwhelmed the memory table. Covering the floor inside the barrier. Now unable to grow in size or escape the barrier. It was left to roil and twist against the sides, like a writhing mass of dark, clotted blood. It was disturbing to witness and both Glimmer and Perfurma had opted to close their eyes to maintain their focus.

Beatrix stood nearby, eyes closed and head bowed as well. Not because she found the corruption disturbing. But because she had come to realize the truth as to her sudden existence…here in this First Ones Temple. That was designed solely to archive the memories of She-Ra. So that it's A.I could create holograms to train and guide the Champion towards their purpose. This woman whom she resembled, had given her life here in the depths of this Castle. She was just an echo of that woman's final thoughts, captured by memory crystal's embedded throughout the temple. Stored in its data banks and now given temporary life. So now her focus falls inward, coming to terms with her very fragile existence. She was not real…but she was conscious…the Crystal Castle had created her…in a desperate act to save itself. Knowing she had the knowledge to guide these princesses in their magic, hoping they would have the power to free Adora from the corruption. Beatrix's form flickered as if glitching, then faded away.

-Entrapta-

The room was dark, except for the sharp glow of a massive terminal of several screens that shone from the far side of the lab. A set of sliding door's hissed open, the hum of the corridor lights buzzed for a moment, along with an invading beam of light. Illuminating a portion of the dark room. As Wrong Hordak entered, his gate steady, as he nervously pulled down his black sleeveless tunic over his hips. The last twenty-four hours have been stressful for everyone, with Hordak's operating system becoming corrupted. The remaining clones up in the sky tree were giving it their all to keep Etheria's system's online, while a greater portion of them were pulled away to increase processing speed.

Wrong Hordak was not designed as a command clone like Hordak. He was a caretaker, created to be a simple worker to clean and maintain the Velvet Glove. Being thrust into the role of leadership in Hordak's absence was overwhelming and totally alien for him to comprehend at times. He was soft spoken and naturally kind. He did not possess the programming to make the hard choices, to command his brethren with a firm hand. So far they were following his orders without debate, their loyalty to Hordak overlapping to his second in command. To Him. He had taken on the responsibility, solely because in the last few weeks. Hordak had come to trust him, believing him capable of caring for their brethren and Entrapta. In all the ways, his own programming made him incapable of.

He took his role seriously, seeing Entrapta so driven to the exclusion of all else and always two steps away from a complete breakdown. Was torture for Wrong Hordak, as he wanted to ease her burden's and comfort her. As clumsy and confusing as his attempts may have been so far. Since feeling emotion and showing compassion are still such foreign concepts to him. But he is much further along in his individuality than his brethren, hence Hordak nominating him to lead. He had become their mentor, their teacher and ultimately their compass to guide them in adapting to Etherian society. To become independent, self-sufficient individuals just like Wrong Hordak. Who could possess their own wants and desires and drive to achieve their own goals in life.

The light disappeared as the door closed, sealing him in the somber half light. As he made his way across the laboratory, past long metal tables covered in all manner of tech and data crystals. Moving past the wreckage of disassembled bots and stacked crates full of parts.

Finding Entrapta sitting upon a pillar of her hair, while her finger's tapped frantically on a keypanel before the screens. Her left pigtail, acting like another appendage typing quickly on her data pad, in her lap. She had it plugged into the terminal's access port under the main screen's display.

Wrong Hordak took a moment to take in Entrapta's twisting expressions, as she surveyed the pad and then the main screen. As her face moved through various emotions, from confusion, curiosity to outright fear.

"You called for me, Entrapta." Wrong Hordak offered, standing beside her solemnly.

"I found another data bank…I thought perhaps this place would have a server room…it still might…but I haven't found it yet." Her words were slow, distracted. As she mulled over all the information she had accumulated in the last few hours.

"This place was a First Ones laboratory was it not?" Wrong Hordak asked.

"Yes…mostly…Etheria is infused with First Ones tech. They wired the planet so that when they siphoned away all the magic. The tech would compensate for the loss, it was to be used as a life support system to keep Etheria alive. Giving the planet time to reabsorb the magic from Etheria's moon's. It was not a good plan…" Entrapta, sighed. "It has complicated my attempt to save Hordak and Adora." She groaned, pointing to the screen. Which was displaying a diagram of the planet. With all the RuneStones, Beacon's, Communication hubs, Watch towers and various other monoliths that were all deeply interconnected…like the circulatory

system of a living body. All webbed across the planet and glowing green so far, except for Crystal Castle which was a bright red.

"I thought that after we cut the Beacon off the Etherian grid, it would be like severing a rotten limb. I could just download my Purge Program into the Central Processing Unit and delete the virus out of the virtual memory core…but it's turned out to be way more complicated than that. My program, once activated, will override the system. Forcing the Beacon to reset itself, all the data it has collected in the last thousand years will be wiped…with Hordak's program currently running inside the Beacon…it would delete him as well. Perhaps Adora's consciousness too, since she also plugged into the system. So I can't use it! But it's too dangerous to allow the virus to remain contained in the Beacon, there is alway a chance it could get out and corrupt all the computer systems on Etheria." Entrapta groaned, pulling at the hair at her temples. "The virus is also locked in the Crystal of Galius…" She thumped her forehead against her desk. "So basically…this whole place is corrupted…I had my suspicions…but it's frustrating and disheartening that I may have to purge this place too…all that data…lost…" Quiet tears of grief and frustration crept out of the corner of her eyes. "I don't want to do it…but I also don't see any other way?" She whimpered.

Wrong Hordak placed a comforting hand on her shoulder, gently turning her from the panel. Entrapta sobbed brokenly into his chest, clutching his shoudler's tight.

As Wrong Hordak stared mournfully up at the screens.

'Big brother…" He moaned, sniffling as he struggled with his own despair.

-Adora-

[Unauthorized virus detected, security protocol activated] The digital voice of the Crystal Castle echoed from within the flashing red world. As Adora came aware as she faded into another memory. She spun on her heel, finding herself once more on the communication dias. This time surrounded by black crystal pillars, within the cavernous room. The crystal formations were now twisted and melted, covered in writing corruption. Just like the Fright Zone…just like the crystal pillars back on Galius. After Despara's rage virus had gone out of control.

"Adora…what is going on!" Catra's terrified voice shouted out, barely containing her panic.

Adora cut her gaze behind her, finding a much younger version of Catra. Dressed in the maroon tunic and partly shredded burgundy pants. With her loose belt with her horde insignia around her waist and Force Captain badge upon her chest.

Her hair was fluffed up in fear and wild around her shoulders. Her battle mask firmly in place upon her brow. Her gray tufts hanging around her dark ears, that were standing up, alert and quivering at the strange sounds emanating from the darkness within the corridor ahead. She was half crouched, tail lashing and claws fully extended. Preparing to fight, if she had too.

The sound of the doors slamming shut, vibrated around the room.

"That is not good…" Adora moaned, dashing down the ramp and lunging for Catra's wrist. Sprinting for the far side of the chamber, with Catra in tow. A massive tide of shadows spilled out of the corridor ahead, spiraling and howling towards them. Glowing red eyes, fractured like broken glass glowered with predatory intent. A foreboding sense of impending doom fell upon them. Sending them into a state of panic, hyper aware that these shadows would devour them if they got to close. Adora spun around, racing back across the room. Desperate to reach the quickly closing door on the other side, before it slammed into place.

“What are you waiting for, turn into She-Ra already!” Catra complained as they ran.

Adora glanced down at herself, finding that she still had the pieces of armor she had manifested earlier…but she was still just Adora.

“This is as She-Ra as I can be right now.” She growled, “We need to run!” She let go of Catra’s hand as she slid under the closing door. Catra’s tail snapped around her waist as she leaped through the crack at the bottom before it slammed shut. Leaving them both heaving for breath in the darkness. The echoing drum of their heart beats, thundering in their ears.

“What is going on…” Catra snarled, her eyes glowing in the half light of the corridor. As they now ran side by side down a narrow, flickering corridor with absolutely no destination in mind. Other than getting as far from those shadow’s hunting them as possible.

“This place…it’s corrupted, confused…it's trying to protect itself… and it sees us as a threat.” Adora advised in exasperation.

“Well, can you ask it to stop?” Catra complained.

“I doubt this place will listen to me right now.” Adora growled back, she was only like half a She-Ra and she knew the Crystal Castle only responded to her when she was in full She-Ra form.

The eerie howling of the shadow’s announced their approach, seconds before they rounded the corner behind and barreled towards them. A mass of darkness swirling at top speed, intent on devouring them.

“Adora!” Catra shouted in alarm.

Adora turned mid stride, only to find another horde of darkness racing towards them from up ahead. They were trapped...in a intersection of four corridor's. Adora's eyes darted ahead..than behind...making a snap decision.

She lunged for Catra's hand, yanking her sideways with a cry of alarm and into an adjacent hallway as the two hordes of shadow's collided in the juncture behind them. Adora pulled her behind at breakneck speed, rounding another corner and dashing threw another juncture of corridor's, picking a archway at random. Then charging towards a doorway at the far end of the hall, filled with brilliant white light.

The door sealed behind them, leaving them bent over and gasping for air. When Adora had taken in enough oxygen to clear her head. She laughed brightly, in both relief and joy. Pulling Catra in and holding her tight.

"I'm so glad you're alright….I've missed you so much." She declared, tucking her face into Catra's neck, releasing a shaky breath.

Catra was startled by Adora's sudden affection, arms hanging loose at her sides as Adora embraced her. Frozen and uncertain for only a moment before the familiar grudge of betrayal and distrust ignited inside her chest.

"Get off me!" Catra snarled, as she wiggled out her embrace and pushed Adora off harshly.

Adora's mouth hung open in stunned disbelief, slowly coming to realize that this wasn't her Catra. Light Spinner had not taken her to the Magicat who was singing but to a memory of her. Just like with Glimmer, Mara and Bow. This was the memory of when Catra had finally severed their friendship.

This Catra didn't trust her, this Catra was angry and hurt because of her choices, her failures as a friend. Months ago Adora broke her heart at Thaymor, by abandoning her for the rebellion, betraying their promise. This night had been pivotal for both of them. Adora had still harbored hope that she could convince Catra to come with her. She had botched her chance, by not listening to her, or acknowledging her pain. She was still so oblivious and confrontational with Catra. She had been incapable of truly

understanding why Catra couldn't just follow her. But this time… this time would be different.

Adora swallowed her hurt at being rejected, boxing up the pain and pushing it aside as she had learned as a Cadet and focused on her duty.

"Those things are not going to stop hunting us. We need to keep moving. " Adora began to survey the empty room for a way out. The memory had changed, last time it was spider's attacking them…now it was shadows…that resembled the manifestation of the Nameless One. Identical to the shadow that had confronted Despara back at Galius.

The pieces were slowly moving into place in her mind…When Mara and her crew had gone to Galius to deal with the Beast of Beast Island. Light Hope must have been corrupted by the rage virus, when she accessed the Lab's control systems. It had compromised her thinking and her reasoning had become faulty. Until she became obsessed with her prime directive…pushing her to set off the Heart of Etheria. Through that virus, the Nameless One had tainted Light Hope…used her to try and destroy all life on Etheria. The Nameless one was an insidious dark force that had been slowly poisoning the universe, by tainting soul's. It had been gathering puppets to do its bidding for a thousand of years if not longer.

How was she going to defeat such an overwhelming influence upon the universe? It seemed impossible.

"Where, genius?" Catra growled, crossing her arms over her chest petulantly. As she bitterly surveyed the empty white room.

It took Adora a moment to draw herself back from the grim realizations she had just found, shaking her head to clear away the dreadful thoughts.

“I don’t know, but we need to protect each other…at least until we can find a way out.” Adora huffed, not even seeing a crack in the smooth walls that might hide a door.

“I don’t need you protecting me.” Catra vowed with a scathing snarl. Placing her hands on her hips.

“Well, I for one need you to protect me…” Adora responded honestly.

The lack of the blonde's normal arrogant bravado. Instantly cooling Catra’s ire, making her confused. Casting doubt upon the spite and fury she harbored towards Adora since Thaymor. Unable to direct the heat of her glare at Adora. She glowered down at the ground instead.

“I got no weapons on me and no She-Ra. You're faster and more agile which makes you the better fighter, in tight spaces at least.” Adora shrugged and passed Catra a confident smirk.

Catra’s eyebrows raised in surprise. As she strode over to the blonde and grabbed the sides of her head. “Are you alright there, Adora. I am starting to believe you might actually have brain damage from that fall in the Whispering Woods. You never had any faith in me before?” Astounded by what she was hearing and finally warming up enough to Adora again to banter.

Adora chuckled and placed her hands tenderly over Catra’s, holding them against her cheeks.

“I’m not as arrogant or oblivious as I used to be.” Adora smiled fondly at her, slowly closing the distance to rest her forehead against Catra’s. “You might not think you need me…but I know I need you.”

Catra’s cheeks instantly heated up, as she sputtered and pulled away. Casting her gaze aside, unable to even speak. Once again, Adora’s honest declarations leave her breathless and totally overwhelmed.

“I knew you would be weird about me letting you escape…I told you…this is not because I like you.” Catra finally found her voice, slapping a hand over her eyes in exhasperation as she pulled away. She had no idea how to deal with an appreciative and overly affectionate Adora. It was exhilarating to finally receive genuine compliments from her, but it was also frightening. It had her cheeks blazing and her heart slamming in her chest like a drum beat.

She had no right to hope Adora still wanted her. Not after kidnapping Glimmer and Bow and letting Shadow Weaver torture the princess of Bright Moon and nearly getting Adora’s mind wiped. Adora must be trying to manipulate her? What was her angle with acting so sweet and caring? They were enemies? What did she want from her? She would just have to play along for now, let Adora do her magic quest thing and the first chance she got she would escape. Catra lightly brushed her hand over the pocket of her pants, where she stashed the data crystal from that freaky room. Where Adora was talking to the hologram before they got attacked. Needing to confirm that she had the prize she had come for. It would make enduring all this confusing, emotional bullshit more palpable.

A low hissing sound announced another door had opened. Tentatively, Adora reached for Catra’s hand. Worried that she might be rejected again.

“Let’s go.” Adora commanded, releasing a breath of relief when Catra did not pull her hand away. Adora led her down a narrow corridor, glowing with First Ones glyphs. Walking in silence for a time, as they cross beneath a waterfall. Delving ever deeper into the depths of this First One’s temple. Eventually coming to another closed door at the end of a long tunnel.

“Ugh…another dead end.” Catra groaned, finally shaking her hand free of Adora's in frustration.

“No, it’s not.” Adora mused, as she read the glyph upon the door. Moving forward and pressing her palm against the door. “Eternia.”

She announced and the door promptly pulled apart. Catra gave her an incredulous look.

"Eh…long story." Adora muttered, as they entered the room. That went completely black as soon as they had made it halfway across.

"Cool, you found the infinite darkness room." Catra mocked, placing her hands on her hips, unimpressed.

Adora sighed…nervous about the impending outcome. Would the Crystal Castle reenact the same bad memories as before to break them apart? Or would this time be different, since Adora already was taking a new, more open hearted approach to reach Catra.

"Have fun, I am going to try and find another way around." Catra tossed her a curt wave, heading for the light at the other end of the room. Only to yelp in surprise when she realized that the door was gone.

They were left in total darkness, Adora waited to see if the tiny light would appear that had scanned their minds last time. But nothing happened.

Back then they didn't trust each other and when the Fright Zone appeared. Adora had instantly attacked, verbally accusing Catra for playing some kind of mind trick on her.

This time as the green halls of the Fright Zone phased into existence around them. Adora took it in stride, whatever the Crystal Castle had in store for them this time. She would make sure they stayed together.

-Beatrix-

It was difficult to see at first, the air was humid and filled with what felt like steam. Wherever she was it was overheating, the sharp smell of electric fires was thick in the air. Her eyes were blurry, stinging from the smoke and her skin felt oddly damp as if she had a fever? Beatrix glanced down expecting to see her corporeal body as it once was. Surprised to find nothing at all, she was once again drifting like some lost spirit. Her consciousness once again left to haunt the Computer system's of this ancient ruin. Her soul was so interconnected with this ruin. That the unpleasant sensations of crippling sickness she was feeling, was the Crystal Castle's slow agonizing death....as it's system's were being strangled and consumed by the corruption.

"Help…..me…." A weak, trembling voice floated out of the nothingness.

Beatrix was stalled for only a moment before her resolve pulled her onward, towards the unknown bearer pleading from the darkness. Crossing a long, narrow bridge of angled panels that were slotted together randomly. She made her way deeper into this odd chamber. Strange configurations of dark crystal, diamond shaped control sphere's hovered over her head, and branched along the walls. All connected like symmetrical grapes upon a vine. Hanging from metal conduits plugged into access ports along the sides and arching roof. All of the components were covered in corruption. Their outer metal casings compromised, melted and caved in on themselves. Beatrix was quick to ascertain that this must be some sort of server room…or central computer core of the Castle.

When she reached the end of the bridge. She found Hordak, hanging naked from a large diamond control sphere. That was hovering out over the abyss, that was stretching out into complete darkness far below. His hands were bound above his head by a pulsing mass of corruption that was leaking out two access ports in the center of the large sphere. The clotted veins twisted and crawled down his rotting arms from his wrists and covered nearly all of his thin, decaying body.

“Where am I?” Beatrix gasped in revulsion, taking in the vast room with rising terror. As her form materialized once more, if a bit more fragile in appearance since she was transluscent.

“This is the Crystal Castles, Central Processing Unit…” Hordak whispered faintly, squinting his eyes open for only a moment. He was barely lucid and Beatrix doubts he recognized who was now standing before him.

Beatrix took in the intense pain etched upon his narrow face, how he fought to take a breath. How his chest rattled upon every weak exhale. Debating if or what she might do to free him. She no longer had a grudge against this alien tyrant, yet she struggled to feel anything at all. Where she had felt such a adamant need to protect her daughter’s, this time…she felt only cold apathy. Perhaps this was also the last emotional attachment Shadow Weaver had held for Hordak before she died.

It was curious…

“Help…me…” Hordak whimpered, he could barely open his eyes. But what Beatrix could see of them, as his head hung limply, lolling to the side like a dead weight upon his neck. They were glowing a blood red just like they were in life.

She had sensed that dark magic on him, the very same taint that rotted her own soul after casting the Spell of Obtainment. The faint smell of rot and decay, as he had been slowly dying since his battalion had crash landed on Etheria so long ago. He was a clone of Horde Prime…. a perfect genetic copy of that all powerful conquer of the known galaxy?

Curious…

“Your, dying Hordak?” She stated, her tone dry and matter of fact.

The laugh that burbled out of the clone was brittle, full of sardonic amusement. Over what he deemed a well deserved fate. After all

the pain and suffering he had put Etheria through and countless other worlds while under Primes control.

"Come to gloat, witch?" He snarled, finally comprehending who was standing over him.

"Hardly, I admit. I wanted revenge, I wanted to see you suffer and bow down before me. A broken shell, devoid of hope. I fantasized about that many times at the beginning, when I was at Bright Moon. Aiding and conspiring with the enemy to take you down! But as the years past and Horde Prime arrived to conquer the planet. My priorities shifted…now. I honestly do not care." Beatrix shrugged.

"You should care…I gave up my physical body to become Etheria's Facilitator…I alone control the computer systems of this planet." Hordak growled, "If I succumb to this virus, so does Etheria."

Beatrix's eyes widened in alarm and then narrowed in contemplation. She did not believe in the no win scenario. She was highly intelligent and resourceful. She would figure out how to save Etheria, that was her priority. Saving Hordak, was not.

-Kronis-

He found himself before a blank wall, again. There were no glyphs for deciphering or panel's full of buttons to navigate. He was simply lost in some faceless labyrinth in the very depths of the beacon.

[Power restored…reactivating primary control systems…Mainframe check…backups loading…server connection reestablished… Connection to interplanetary system's failed…virtual Memory core compromised…rerouting…rerouting…rerouting…]

“That is not good…” Kronis muttered, spinning around and jogging back the way he had come.

[Unauthorized presence detected…security protocol activated]

“No…no,no,no,no.” Kronis began to panic, glancing left and right as he ran through a junction of corridors. Desperate to find a way out, as sharp clicking began to echo all around him.

-Adora-

“That is not good?” Adora moaned, as she moved closer to the metal wall of the corridor. Ugly, fleshy tendril’s had crawled along the surface and the green metal now looked corroded? It oddly reminded her of the corrupted tech that was on Beat Island…this was a memory simulation…and she had seen an infected Fright Zone before…Solidifying all her worst theories as to why the simulation had turned into a nightmare.

The Crystal Castle was corrupted!

“Whatever it is, it’s gross and I do not want to stick around and find out.” Catra crossed her arms over her chest, glowering at the infection currently eating the wall. Storming off down the corridor, intending on leave Adora behind.

“Catra, wait!” Adora called out in a panic, jogging after her.

They both quickly got their bearings, realizing that they were close to the Black Garnet chamber.

“Glimmer…Glimmer…it’s going to be ok. I’ll save you!” Adora's frantic voice echoed from inside the gloom of the open doorway.

Adora stopped, her blood running cold. While Catra narrowed her eyes in disgust. The open doorway lurked several feet away, but

neither of them moved to voyeur on the terrible memory currently unfolding inside.

“What have you done to her!” Adora cried in horror.

“Leave us…” Shadow Weaver’s low, sinister command whispered from the chamber. Several guard’s quickly exited the Chamber and moved briskly down the hallway. Wanting to get as far away from Shadow Weaver as they could.

A moment later, Shadow Weave spoke again.

“Return to the Force Captain quarter's and pack your things, now that Adora is back. There is no need for you there.” Her snide, condescending tone towards Catra infuriating as always.

“Seriously! After everything I’ve done for you. It’s still her you want!” Catra retorted. Her voice layered with seething fury, confusion but mostly hurt.

“I said go!” Shadow Weaver bellowed.

Then Catra was flung out of the room. She landed hard on her knees in the doorway. Scrambling back up to her feet, prepared to defend herself or run.

When Shadow Weaver made no other moves to attack, she stood for a moment glaring bitterly back at Adora inside. Then the door promptly slid shut in her face.

Catra’s right ear perked up as she then pressed that ear against the door. Eavesdropping on what Shadow Weaver was saying inside. Her eyes flew wide in fright and then she was sprinting down the corridor.

“Shadow Weaver was so cruel to you. You never deserved being treated like that.” Adora turned to Catra, reaching for her hand. The sympathy shining in her blue eyes was infuriating.

Catra growled and stalked after her memory self, hands balled into tight fists at her sides. Refusing to take Adora's comforting hand. Adora was quick to follow, her shoulders slumped in sorrow.

Memory Catra had stopped at an access panel to a power junction box at the end of the hall. Using her claws she picked the lock and pried open the panel. It only took a couple precise cuts with her index claw to sever the wiring for the machine inside the Black Garnet Chamber. Prevent Glimmer from teleporting.

Glimmer's agonizing screams as she fought to teleport, suddenly went quiet. Followed by the sharp sound of a fist connecting with a metal mask. Then a grunt and the sound of a body hitting the ground.

A smug, satisfied smile graced memory Catra's lips. But her mismatched eyes were glistening with unshed tears, stubbornly refusing to let them fall.

Adora chuckled and bumped her shoulder against Catra's.

"You cut the power to the machine preventing Glimmer from teleporting…that is how she was finally able to escape and punch Shadow Weaver." Adora nodded.

"Well…obviously. I would never let Shadow Weaver erase your memories and she needed a beating. I was more than happy to help Karma on its way." Catra smirked.

"Your good deeds then were few and far between but not non-existent. Thank you." Adora slipped her hand into Catra's and this time the cat did allow it. The Fright Zone faded, leaving them in a glowing corridor.

"What was that anyway?' Catra asked, as they walked hand in hand threw the beacon once more. Eventually crossing over a stone pillar that had fallen over a huge hole in the cavernous room. That had several open doorways lining the outer walls on either side of the hole.

“This is a simulation of our memories…the Crystal Castle is trying to help me tap into She-Ra’s magic.” Adora released Catra’s hand and pointed to her chest armor. My magic is tied to all the people who mean the most to me and you're the last piece.” She admitted with a small, hopeful look. Hopping down off the fallen pillar after Catra. Following her across the other side of the room.

Catra turned and walked backwards. “Seriously!” she scoffed and rolled her eyes.

“Seriously….Catra…” Adora began as another simulation began to take shape around them.

The bunk room appeared, it was close to supper time. As the shadows were heavy near the curving walls. The overhead lights were buzzing, illuminating the two rows of bunks. They looked on at their squad mates, milling about. They were all in awkward adolescence. Kyle with pimples, Rogelio towering over his best friend. Atila and Sara were talking quietly near the back door, with Otis. While Lonnie and Louis were bickering over something, as they knelt along the side of his bottom bunk. Pointing and gesturing to a pile of random junk they had scavenged during their free time today. Max and Levi were sitting on the top bunk at the back, looking at a book on the thin mattress between them.

Adora sat on her bottom bunk, kicking her feet. Head bowed and looking sullen, Shadow Weaver had appeared after combat drills and took Catra away. She had been fretting ever since. Whenever Shadow Weaver took Catra in the past, it was usually for what their Guardian called, ‘private instruction.’ Which usually ended up with Catra returning with odd bruises and being extremely tired.

Whatever Shadow Weaver was doing, it was far more intense than her own private training.

“Hey, Adora!” Catra’s excited voice called from down the hall to their bunk room.

Adora jumped to her feet and dashed out of the room.

Finding Catra striding with pride towards her, holding a metal mask in her hands.

"Look what Shadow Weaver gave me. Isn't it awesome, it's to keep my hair out of my eyes. She says it's a battle mask, for a magicat warrior. Now I have the tools to become fierce and powerful and she expects great things from me. " The magicat was beaming, she was so happy to receive this gift from their guardian.

"Where did she get it?" Adora asked, happy for her best friend to finally receive some well deserved attention from their Guardian. She had yet to earn any gifts from her, but she would one day she was sure of it.

Catra shrugged, placing the mask upon her brow.

"Don't know, don't care…I am going to wipe the floor with you tomorrow during hand to hand combat." She promised, jogging way into the bunkroom to show off her new accessory to their squad.

"I never did achieve greatness…no matter how hard I tried. I could never earn Shadow Weaver's praise. " Catra commented, sourly. Casting her eyes down in disappointment, chewing on her lower lip to stop it from trembling.

"Catra…you shouldn't care about earning that terrible woman's praise." Adora advised, reaching out to pull her in for a hug.

Catra rolled her arms off and stomped out of reach.

"I learned a long time ago that competing against you is pointless! It doesn't matter how hard I try! I never get to win! " She snarled, disappearing around the corner.

"Catra!" Adora called, frantically chasing after her.

When she finally found Catra, she was huddled inside a storage closet near the Forge. Rocking back and forth and muttering to

herself, combing her claws through her tufts then ripping at them. Pulling the long fur out in ragged clumps.
"I don't get to win…I don't get to win…Shadow Weaver's gone….Hordak is going to kill me…Adora….Adora…Stupid, Stupid, stupid…" She whimpered and moaned. Chanting in a trembling, broken and desperate voice. Pleading for Adora to save her, as tears streamed down her cheeks. Hiding away as she allowed herself to be weak, to attempt to purge the shame, self loathing and heartache that always wore her down and tore her to shreds.

"Catra…" Adora rushed to her side, her heart aching at the tragic, overwhelmed sight of her true love breaking down. This must have happened after Shadow Weaver escaped? Catra was barely lucid, glancing up in disbelief as Adora kneeled before her. She couldn't believe that she was really there?

The shadow's were thick in the utility closet, converging behind Catra like a dark shroud. Just as Adora closed in, the darkness rose off the wall like a living thing and enveloped Catra. The magicat screamed in terror as the shadow's pulled her inside their darkness.

"Adora!" Catra screamed in fright, arm still outstretched as the void began to devour her whole.

"Catra!" Adora lunged, grabbing her by the wrist and pulled. But her grip slipped and Catra fell into the abyss screaming for her.

"NO…no, no,no,!" Adora pounded fruitlessly against the back wall of the closet.

As the Fright Zone faded away, replaced by the lifeless void.

Adora stood upon the dead earth of some corpse planet. The blank sky stretching over her is devoid of light. As if the darkness here was so thick, so all consuming, light could not survive here. The echoing sound of a distant heartbeat thrummed through the void. With the smell of decay heavy in the air, making her queasy. The ominous glare of some unseen sinister force surrounded her.

Making her shiver, making her cower. As the void howled in pain, the limitless hunger to devour all life in the universe forever unquenched. It was a painful ache, always gnawing, always clawing, so all consuming it could not concentrate on anything else. It reminded Adora sorrowfully of Omega Prime. The tortured creature was always in pain, because it was always hungry.

(Welcome Adora) A voice, deep and eerily mournful, vibrated throughout this place of nothingness. A voice she recognized from Despara's memory.

(I find it rather exciting that the current vessel of She-Ra, is capable of slipping in and out of my dimension so easily. You have invaded several times so far. By accident or by choice, it matters not.)

The disembodied voice was amused.

Adora sucked in a breath, needing to settle her heart. It was pounding so hard, she could feel her pulse in her throat and hear it roaring in her ears. She was scared…the most scared she had been in years. But she never let fear stop her.

She was here for Catra and she was not leaving without her!

"Where is Catra?" Adora raised her chin defiantly, shouting her demand out into the depths of the void.

(Oh, she is here…somewhere…) The voice responded, their tone bored and slightly distracted. As if it had misplaced Catra like she was nothing but a simple useless bauble, one would cast aside in a junk drawer.

(Her soul is so easily tainted by my darkness. Honestly, her suffering was delicious. Perhaps the most satisfying that I have tasted in a very long time. I offered her the power to make everyone who ever hurt her pay! She took it without any doubts. So full of rage and sorrow, she

willingly let me devour her and then recreate her in my image.) The voice sounded smug and amused. **(Your suffering is much the same. A many layered torment full of guilt and self loathing. I will relish the sweet taste to come. When you finally submit to me…)** The voice whispered to her, soft and silky like a lover's touch.

Adora cringed and physically recoiled. Quickly, gathering her courage she jutted out her chin defiantly.

"Who are you!" She demanded, already knowing but needing to hear it to make it real.

(I believe you already know who I am, Child of Destiny) The voice responded, once more in that dull, bored tone.

Adora narrowed her eyes….she knew, she was unwilling to voice it lest it give the Nameless One more power.

" *Heeeey, Adora* ." Catra called out, her voice strangely modulated and eerie.

Adora spun, as the disembodied voice began to laugh with mirth. Highly amused by the sudden terror upon her face.

Void Catra emerged from the blackness, as if she had been birthed from it. Her face and body fractured by darkness and the glow of discordant portal energies.

"Catra…" Adora whimpered, raising her fists in defense knowing that this monster born of the portal's dark reality would attack. She was corrupted…and driven by wrath to seek vengeance upon the person who hurt her most. Adora was surprised when Void Catra never attacked, but fell to her knees, prostrating humbly before her Lord. Casting her gaze upward in reverence.

"I await your command, my lord." She offered in humble servitude to the darkness.

The unholy voice laughed, the coarse, abrasive sound slicing at Adora's wavering bravery and self assurance that she would prevail. That she could reach Catra, bring her back from the abyss she was trapped in. This confrontation was a disturbing mirror of her traumatic memories of facing Prime, of facing a chipped Catra. That it left her shaken and unable to move, or speak at first. But she quickly gathered her resolve.

"Catra, you need to fight him!" Adora pleaded, moving tentatively towards her. As Void Catra released a deep, long suffering sounding sigh. Slowly rising back onto her feet and turning with a malicious smile towards Adora. As if dealing with her was a nuisance she rather not engage in.

(You seriously have to stop telling me what to do." Catra sneered. "I have power now, real power…and I will make everyone pay!" She declared, screaming in wrath as she lunged for Adora. Black claws shining with a dark blue glow, as if they were made from the Crystal of Kaydak.

Adora reeled and took a defensive step back raising her arms to take Catra's wild slashes across her bracer's.

"Let her go!" Adora shouted into the void, her eyes burning to exact retribution upon the Nameless One on Catra's behalf.

(First Ones….Always so demanding!) The voice echoed with a humorless chuckle. **(Who are you to demand anything of me!….I have seen your heart, tasted your soul and devoured your flesh…You have already proven yourself unworthy as an adversary. You are weak…and I am bored…finish her.)** The Nameless One commanded, their voice booming and then ebbing away.

Catra came in hard and fast, slashing upward across Adora's chest plate and then swinging her leg in a roundhouse kick. Only to leap away out of Adora's reach, the cackling laughter erupting from her throat was cruel and manic.

Adora took the hit yet again, glancing down to find her chest piece had absorbed the cuts from her toe claws. A golden glow humming from the blue Rune Stone embedded in the eight point star as the chest plate repaired itself.

When Catra charged in again, Adora feinted to the left and then weaved right. Slipping in behind her and wrapping Catra in a head lock with one arm, while binding the other arm behind her back.

"Catra…I am not leaving here without you…do you understand. I am going to save you. " Adora promised, tears finally breaking free of her eyes and trailing down her cheeks. Just like before when she fought Catra on Prime's dais, her heart was breaking as she fought desperately to get through to Catra.

Catra snarled, grabbing Adora's arm and bending over rapidly, flipping her over her head and onto her back.

Adora cried out in alarm, as Catra swiftly swung herself over Adora's head and bracketed the blonde's hips with her thighs. Hovering over Adora's now prone and trapped body, smirking down at her with smug satisfaction.

"I don't want to be saved…Adora." Catra crooned, pressing a finger against her forehead just between her wide, tearful blue eyes. Then brushing her fingertip seductively down Adora's cheek. Finally gripping her chin in her finger tips aggressively and giving her head a rueful shake.

Adora twisted and then buck upward hard, turning just enough to land an elbow jab to Catra's sternum. The magicat gasped and gagged as the air was suddenly expelled from her lungs. Forced to retreat off Adora's chest and crawl away, gasping desperately for air.

"I will never give up on you Catra." Adora professed, tears now streaming down her face as she stood up.

Catra started to laugh, it was a choked, weary sound as she slowly rose back up to her feet. "I gave up on me!...I was never

good enough, I was never going to win…so why keep striving for something that was never going to happen…I had a cursed life and I was over it. I wanted to die…Adora…instead I am this… thing." She snarled in revulsion, inclining her tainted body with her hands.

Adora was stunned, a lump of grief forming in her throat. She had never thought that at the time of the portal…that Catra had sought oblivion instead of going with her.

It hurt…it hurt really bad and her heart shattered. For the girl who struggled in her shadow her whole life, who never felt she was worth anything, least of all being worthy of love.

"I'm sorry….I was so blind to what you were going through growing up. I treated you poorly…you deserved better. But I will never leave you behind Catra…I want you…I need you…Please… come back to me." Adora wailed, pleading for her not to give up this time.

Catra cocked her head to the side, her words resonating with her.

"You are the strongest, most resilient person I know. Stubborn and obstinate…you are no one's puppet…not Shadow Weaver's, not Hordak's…not Primes and definitely not the Nameless One's. No one controls you!" Adora proclaimed, her voice strong and assured.

Catra again staggered for a moment as Adora reached her again. Her words of encouragement and affirmation chipped away at the bonds the Nameless One had over her soul.

Then Catra threw her head back and laughed again, her voice loud and abrasive with dark humor.

"The Nameless One…is eternal, Adora. He will return…it is inevitable. To devour us all…end our suffering and then we will know true peace forever." Catra heaved a cleansing breath. Then rose up and leaped into the air, spinning in the air and swinging

her leg down. Chopping Adora's arm, there was a muffled crack as her arm broke just below her elbow upon impact.

Adora cried out in agony, clutching her arm to her chest.

"Catra…please stop…I don't want to fight you.." Adora begged, slowly backing away from her.

"Then submit…kneel before me…so your death can be swift." Catra sneered, her grin smug and malicious. As she stalked towards her, razor sharp claws glinted in the half light.

Adora was desperate and had run out of ideas to reach her. She bowed her head and slowly fell to her knees admitting defeat.

Catra cocked her head again, the act of Adora surrendering to her. Cracking through the fury and pain shackling her soul to the darkness.

When Catra closed in, hovering just in front of the blonde. Adora slowly raised her face upward. Taking in the nightmare monster her beloved had become. Adora's eyes were tender, full of understanding and love.

It forced Catra to pause again, as Adora reached up with her good arm and clasped her hand softly. Threading their finger's together...

"I love you…Catra. It took me a while to figure it out….cause I'm a dumbass. But I have always loved you." Adora pulled her down, as Void Catra's knees buckled in shock. Her eyes wide in surprise, mouth open in complete disbelief at what she just heard.

Then Adora leaned forward, cupping her cheek tenderly as she closed her eyes pressing her lips to Catra's. The kiss was soft and honest and full of promise.

Catra's mask appeared upon Adora's brow, in a flash of gold. Then the wings of She-Ra flared along the sides of her head as her crown took form.

The miserable, wailing howl of rage echoed from the void as She-Ra's divine light overwhelmed the darkness. The warmth of hope pushed back the despair, once enshrouding Catra. Freeing her from the Nameless Ones chain's once again. Adora felt the incredible heat of flames enshrouding her, instantly she felt at peace as the cleansing fire of her true love carried her away.

"Catra…..She is your hope. She reminds you to never give up on someone...perhaps you need to heed her advice." Razz's ancient voice floated through the firelight.

When Adora opened her eyes, Catra was whole.

Kneeling before her just as she was before she left for her journey to the Crystal Castle. Wearing her white training shirt and leather jacket, with her ripped black leggings. Her mane hung thick and rather wild over her ears and down the back of her neck near her shoulders. Adora had never been more thankful in her life to see her again, just as she remembered her last.

Slowly pulling away, Catra giggled with delight. Cupping Adora's cheeks and breathing a sigh of relief.

"Thank the stars you heard me." Catra's arms flew around Adora and she pulled her tight into a desperate embrace. Needing to feel her, smell her and hear her heartbeat to confirm she was real and alive and in her arms again.

"As wonderful as this reunion is, we have to go!" Shadow Weaver's impatient voice broke the beautiful ambiance of their hug.

Catra growled and pulled away, rising to her feet and offering Adora a hand up.

Adora stood, flexing her fully healed arm and finding that she was now towering over the magicat in She-Ra form.

Glancing around briefly, getting her bearings. She found that they were huddled beneath a naturally formed, sandstone arch at the top of a hill. The Whispering Woods sprawled out beneath them. As the brilliant flame of the sun began to bathe the far off horizon beyond the forest. Casting the open sky in a wondrous glow of pinks and oranges.

Shadow Weaver stood to one side of the arch, dressed in her deep red robes that were snapping in the wind howling up from the forest below. Her long black hair was fluttering like living shadows as she drew magic from the world around her. No longer wearing her mask, her terribly scarred face was on display.

The forest on the side of the Arch that Shadow Weaver was guarding, quickly being overwhelmed by dark phantoms. As a horde of thousands of shadows converged upon the tree line. Howling in tormented hunger, eager to consume their prey.

Adora suddenly felt her hand being taken again, at first she was confused and alarmed. Thinking it was Trixie ready to pull her away again. She snapped her gaze down, to find a child version of herself with short hair holding her hand and looking up at her with a sad pout.

“I’m sorry….I didn’t know my virus contaminated the Crystal Castle .” Despara moaned.

“Despara…” Adora was quick to soothe the goddess who looked so small and worried. Another child that resembled her with long blonde hair stood beside Despara.

“Sheana…” Adora gasped, baffled by what she was seeing.

“Take Adora and run. I will hold the darkness at bay as long as I can.” Shadow Weaver commanded, thrusting an arm sharply towards the lighter side of the arch.

“I am not weak any longer. I am not going to let you fight alone again.” Adora promised, pushing the two little girls behind her as

she strode purposefully towards Shadow Weaver. Her expression was fierce, her glowing blue eyes as hard as steel.

"You are still not balanced!" Shadow Weaver confronted her briefly, before concentrating on her casting. As a glowing indigo seal spreads from the center of her casting hands, the glyphs rotate at a rapid speed. As the shield grew in size and strength, blocking the whole side of the arch.

Just as the shadows closed in at tremendous speed. Surging upon the barrier, pounding against it like swarms of predatory snakes. Resembling Shadow Weaver's old Shadow Spies, except the red eye in the middle had a shattered pupil…just like Shadow Weaver.

"I can still fight!" Adora raised her arm, calling down her sword. A flash of light appeared in her palm and then promptly snuffed out.

"What the hell?" Adora hissed, livid at still being unable to fight. She did not understand was she not fully transformed? She was eight feet tall and in full armor. So why wasn't her weapon's manifesting?
"Go! We have no time! Go!" Shadow Weaver shouted, groaning under the strain of the darkness now bombarding against her shield.

"Adora…come…on." Catra pulled desperately on her arm.

"You are going to die!" Adora screamed in panic at Shadow Weaver. Her heart clenched tight in her chest, as the fear and grief she had experienced before at being unable to save her. Washed over her with renewed strength, as she now felt helpless again.

"Child…You could never save me. I was dead long before you arrived upon Etheria. But I need you to live…honor my sacrifice by avenging me. Become the hero, I know you can be. Destroy the Shards of Kaydak, so that the Nameless One can no longer seduce anyone else." Shadow Weaver pleaded.

Adora’s lips thinned for a moment, this woman was as much a victim as she was a villain. She would have to come to terms with the complicated feelings she harbored for her, but today was not that day.

“Fine.” Adora growled, spinning on her heel and reaching for Sheana. Swinging the little girl up and onto her hip as she jogged away down the hill.

Catra swung Despara onto her back and sprinted after her. They disappeared into the woods on the other side, listening to Shadow Weaver’s war cries. As she held the unholy masses of deathly shadows off.

Chapter Four

Chapter Notes

> Thank you Pink Storm and Bitzy Bee for your comments. This is the longest chapter to date, but I just could not chop it up again. I know both of you will enjoy this conclusion!
> Thank you to all who left Kudo's as well.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"I won't give up! Not on my friends, not on Etheria, not on myself!" Adora- She-Ra of Etheria

-Beatrix-

A pale amber light had replaced the eerie darkness of the abyss beneath them. The depths glowing menacingly. The walls and far off roof of the massive chamber still pulsed with corruption, now illuminated by that same warning glow. As Beatrix contemplated the predicament Hordak was in. The ominous red sheen that hovered on every side of her was disconcerting. It reminded her of blood, it was as if the walls were covered in it. The parasitic mass of corruption that covered every surface. Pulsing and writhing as it continued to grow and multiply around her. Melting and corroding the control spheres and conduits as it feasted upon the Crystal Castle, was terrifying as much as it was revolting. As such Beatrix was struggling to keep her focus upon the bound clone before her. Anxious and wary of her surroundings, that were as deadly as any predator inches away from attacking.

"I can't…die…here.." Hordak struggled to speak. His hologram was flickering, beneath the writhing mass of veins devouring him.

"Saving you, means saving the planet…yes? " Beatrix arched an eyebrow, bidding the clone to explain in better detail.

“Yes…but Entrapta has cut my program off from the Etherian grid. I can’t leave this place…” Hordak groaned, growing silent and contemplative for a moment. As he once again searched through the network connections. Morbidly wanting to confirm one last time that he was indeed trapped. Startled to find a backdoor out of the Castle...leading to a nearby Spire? He could have sworn all access had been cut off? But perhaps in his compromised state he had merely overlooked it the last time he had scanned.

“I thought you two were close?” Beatrix chuckled, “Interesting that it is the princess of Dryl, who finally takes you out.” One half of her thin lips, arched upward in a mocking smile.

“She is not swayed by pointless emotions, she is ruled by logic and reason alone. When she makes decisions.” Hordak growled in her defense. “Trapping me here to die is nothing personal…she has no vendetta against me.”

“Then this virus was not on purpose to trap and destroy you?” Beatrix mused. “You are known to twist the truth and fabricate your own version of history, Hordak. So that you may sway the loyalty of the masses. How can I trust that it wasn’t you who infected the Castle, in some failed attempt to gain control of this place. That Entrapta trapped you here to die by your own misbegotten plan.” Beatrix accused him. Her tone is acidic and without remorse.

“No…the Beacon had been corrupted by a rage virus, tainted by the dark power of the Nameless One. It had been stored and locked behind a firewall, that unfortunately got released by a couple of my wayward brothers. ” Hordak snarled, bitterly.

Beatrix’s eyes widened in horror, then quickly narrowed in scrutiny.

“I had wondered why I smelled that foul rot upon you…even before this unfortunate event. “ She spat, folding her arms in disgust.

Hordak started to laugh, it was a wheezing, brittle sound. "Horde Prime owed his power and his immortality to the Nameless One. He sold our entire race to that devil eons ago, that darkness is part of our very D.N.A. I no longer had a means to create the amniotic fluid that kept my body alive…so I and my brethren who were stranded here in Despondos. Began to rot and die…until I was the last. "

"Explains why your body was decaying when I knew you." Beatrix nodded, "Well, then it can't be helped. I will do as you ask, Lord of the Horde."

A frail, yet grateful smile appeared for a brief moment upon Hordak's face. It was enough to make Beatrix gag in revulsion. She coughed to conceal her discomfort at seeing such weakness in the other worldly tyrant that once ruled over her.

"Plug your hands into the slot's, then I will transfer my command protocols to you. You will become my decoy, the virus will be confused for all of a second. Then it will infect you, believing it still hasn't fully corrupted the Planetary Facilitator. As I escape through the backdoor, Entrapta seems to have conveniently left open. I will transmit myself as a compressed file packet to a nearby communication spire. It is odd, but fortunate. That Entrapta seems to have still left that access point open." Hordak muttered, a rueful smile pulling on his thin lips. In the end he realized she couldn't do it, she couldn't kill him and he was both thankful for her compassion and angry at her weakness. That she could hope for some miracle….to appear that could cure him. Or that she could trust that he wouldn't just give into the corruption and use her escape route and take the virus with him to infect the rest of Etheria. Or that he would somehow figure out a way to save himself She had given into faulty reasoning…allowing a grand delusion to sway her judgement, because she could not let go of her attachment to him. This weakness could get them all killed in the future. He would have to speak with her about it.

"If you manage to survive the corruption long enough. You will unfortunately not survive the purge program when Entrapta

activates it.” Hordak advised. “This installation is destined to be wiped clean of all data along with the virus.”

“Fine.” Beatrix grumbled in resignation, moving forward and shoving both her hands into the access ports on the CPU sphere. Giving Hordak access to her code and allowing him to download his protocols, that would draw the virus into her like moths to a flame.

-Catra and Adora-

The deeper they traveled into the woods, the more overgrown the forest became. The trees seemed to crowd around them, forcing them to cautiously shuffle through the maze of roots or climb over or under twisted tree trunks. Adora was in the lead, pushing limbs aside to open the narrow trail that they had to follow.

An iridescent twilight glow hovered around them, along with floating motes of magic. That would dance among the branches above, only to fall, in a graceful twirl down within the wide leaves of the ferns, ducking in and out of the bushes like children playing. This hidden world seemed frozen in a state of warm tranquility, that only happened just before dawn. In that quiet, lazy atmosphere of not being quite awake yet but not quite asleep either.

The forest pressed against them as they walked ever deeper into its natural embrace. Soon they were groping their way ahead, through the heavy brambles and overgrown shrubs barring their way.

“This place is getting weird…Adora.” Catra moaned from directly behind her. Her ear’s twitching, as her eyes tracked a couple motes of light in the branches above that looked like they were about to dive bomb for her head.

“Don’t fight the Woods, let it lead us where we need to go. I trust that it will keep us safe.” Adora advised, her voice soft but certain.

Reaching out her hands to allow the motes to circle her golden gauntlet, before ascending away into the branches above. They had left the shadow's far behind now, as the woods pulled them away.

"We are being drawn to the Heart. " Sheana advised in a soft, reverent voice. Her blue eyes shimmering with magic, as she watched the motes of light playing above them. Despara shuffled behind her, reaching for her hand. Sheana glanced over her shoulder and gave her eternal partner a soft, tender smile. Clasping their hands tightly, signifying their unity to always be together now, throughout the eon's ahead.

At the mention of the Heart, Catra instantly assumed they were talking about the real Heart of Etheria….she was suddenly very excited. Hoping that perhaps Ouroboros would be there to guide her again. She had been feeling rather adrift for the last few weeks, trying to figure out her magic all on her own. Old wounds of being abandoned starting to open and fester again. As intrusive thoughts stabbed at her. That perhaps again, she was not good enough for her guardian to train. That he had met her once and that was enough for him to want nothing more to do with her.

What she wasn't expecting was to stumble into a hidden glade surrounded by guarding forest. The heavy boughs of oak and spruce, hung low, their leaves vibrant and so much more alive then in the woods in the real world. A quiet, slow moving creek cut through the glade, sparkling in the pre-dawn light. Gently sloping hills butted against the meadow on the far north side, long grass dropping down the earthen hillside. A young willow tree grew atop the summit of the tallest hill, its roots and weeping branches cascading down over the shallow incline.

A tiny cabin was tucked into the slope of the hills, hidden by the willow tree's roots and branches. Protected from the outside world by a natural curtain that made the tiny hut nearly invisible.

"This is the Heart of the Whispering Woods." Adora announced in wonder, as she gazed around the glade. When suddenly her eyes

flared wide in recognition of where she truly was, when she saw the hut.

"Razz…" Adora recognized this glade and the quaint hovel that seemed as if it had grown out of the Whispering Woods itself. She grabbed Catra's hand and dashed across the meadow of wild flowers. Her greater strength and height by being in nearly full She-Ra form. Nearly hauling the smaller magicat off her feet, making her skip on her toes a bit, as she gains her momentum. Then having to run full speed just to keep up.

Adora was so excited to finally introduce Catra to the eccentric old recluse of the forest. Who had guided her so much over the years. She was someone Adora had come to depend on and trust. Her words of wisdom were not always easy to understand, but they had been invaluable to her. Razz had become like a grandmother to her, now that she knew what one was.

Sheana and Despara followed at a slower pace, taking in the glade with nostalgic wonder. Sensing that they had moved from dream and into the realm of memory once more. Sheana had not seen this place in a thousand years, Despara for even longer. They stopped at the creek, to dip their bare feet into the cool, crisp water. Humming with satisfaction as the gentle current washed away the dirt and soothed their feet. Soon they were wading into the water, splashing and giggling as they played with one another. Enjoying their freedom…their time with each other and these sweet moments of happiness that were long overdue.

"Razz!" Adora pushed the stiff, hemp woven curtain aside. Her cheerful introduction fell silent upon the somber sight inside. Catra gasped in shock beside Adora. Her finger's curling tightly around Adora's hand. Instinctively holding onto the person she would always draw strength from.

Aoi was comforting a small pixie, Catra knew was named Loo-Kee. At the back of the hut. He was wearing a white helmet with a grayskull on it. Wild blue hair flared out beneath the edges of the bulky helmet. His long pointed ears were pinned down by the

helmet, hanging limply down either side of his neck. Red overall's that once covered a pudgy belly, now hung off a slender frame that were dirty and torn. His warm brown eyes that once shone with mirth and hidden amusement at the world. Where now dull and drawn, from enduring far too much hardship.

Aoi's long auburn hair was braided down her back, with sunstone beads woven within the weave. Her golden tufts were threaded into thin braids as well, tucked into her thicker mane behind her dark ears. A knotted leather headband, with sunstone shards was tied around her forehead. Her tan fur was dull, the freckles on her cheeks barely visible beneath the shadow of exhaustion under her eyes. Wearing her leather skirt with slits on the sides and her leather halter top. The bright orange and red kanga cloth was strapped over her chest. The slight bulge of the pouch against her back, had two small, furred hands waving frantically. As the toddler inside purred and chatted aimlessly.

The pixie was staring mournfully down at the rotted hand he bore, sniffling and moaning in despair. Aoi's, sky blue eyes shimmered with sympathy for her friend's misery. Rubbing his back in small circles and speaking soft words of comfort. That he would be alright, they had come to get help.

Catra swallowed the painful lump, forming in her throat at seeing how worn down her mother looked. The toll the war had taken upon her and also the stolen innocence of the little Pixie who had been unfortunately caught up in it. None of this was fair! None of them deserve to suffer like this…no one did.

Adora gave her hand a quick squeeze of comfort. Catra turned briefly and offered her a small, grateful smile. Adora would always be there for her, her rock, her confidant…her ally through every struggle. With a soft sigh, Catra returned her gaze towards the unfolding memory. As they both watched, with heavy hearts.

Saladin argued with another Magicat near the stone hearth, the male magicat was in his hunter's armor. A boiled leather jerkin, studded with sunstone shards and matching leggings that

wrapped around the top of his bare feet. With thicker padding to protect the softer parts of his feet underneath. He had his bow slung over his shoulder and a hide quiver full of arrows upon his back. A dagger belt hung over his waist, the many bone hilts within easy reach at his hips. His hackles were up, the dark chestnut fur at the back of his neck fluffed in agitation as his dark tail lashed aggressively behind him. His black mane tied up in a top knot, the gray tufts flying free down the sides of his square face. Golden eyes glaring heatedly up at the much taller magicat standing next to him. The female magicat loomed over Saladin, with her hands on her hips, as if trying to invade his personal space and intimidate him. She had a pale, silver coat and a long raven mane and tail. She was strikingly beautiful, with sharply angled, high cheekbones and a delicately pointed chin. Wearing elegant plate armor that bore the runic symbol of the Moon upon the shining chest piece. Catra's eye's flared in surprise as she found this magicat, bore the same battle mask upon her brow. That Shadow Weaver had given her as a child, but it was a shimmering silver. The sheen of the metal was radiant and pure like starlight.

It truly did belong to a magicat warrior…

"Tut, tut…there is nothing for it. No cure, No Magic…nothing, can heal something that is dead. But that does not mean I can not help." A familiar croaking voice issued from the depths of the hut. Then Razz appeared, looking just as she was in the present day. In her tattered and worn pink dress and shawl, her wild white hair and thick glasses. Shuffling about with her broom and nattering to herself as much as to her guests. As her clarity for the present time came and went.

"Loo-kee can stay here for as long as he wants. But you must go! Your journey still lies ahead of you and I am afraid your time may be short." Razz rushed the two magicats by the hearth out of her hut. They left reluctantly, as she brushed her broom behind them as if sweeping them out of the door. Aoi gave Loo-Kee one last hug and the Pixie offered her a small, understanding smile. Then

as she turned to leave the hut, Loo-Kee waved at the kitten hanging from her back.

"Bye, bye…" A tiny tan hand waved back, followed by a small, tender voice.

"We'll see each other again, Loo-Kee…I promise!" Aoi shouted, as she was forced through the curtain by Razz's impatient threat of her broom handle. Passing through the specters of both Adora and Catra. Who had stood frozen there in the doorway. They turned around to follow the Magicat's outside, as if gravity was pulling at them.

A moth hybrid stood just outside the hut now, wearing a dark gray cloak. He held Razz's gaze firmly for a moment as the Magicats continued through the glade.

"Will you deliver the message from my vision to your little sister?" He inquired.

"Yes, yes…I will speak with her swiftly…before my mind is muddled. I shall not forget, it is too important, the magic must be protected." Razz nodded, pulling absently on the opal teardrop earring in her left ear. That represented the sister she needed to speak with. A subtle reminder for herself not to forget. Then turned on her heel and disappeared into the hut once more.

Adora and Catra were pulled after Razz, reentering the hut after the old woman.

Finding her rummaging at the back for something, while Loo-kee sat at a small round wooden table near the hearth, crying softly. He had his rotted hand resting upon the table top. The skin leathery black like coal. The bits of flesh had peeled away. Revealing the pale white bones of his hand underneath. The revolting stench of decay was thick around him. He had been in excruciating pain only a few days ago. Unable to sleep, or eat or even speak. Only scream and writhe, in unspeakable agony. Now

he felt nothing, his hand didn't move any more as it was long dead. His good hand was absently spinning a clay bowl full of strange shimmering ointment. Lost to his thoughts, he was barely paying attention to the old woman, now puttering about.

"I can not save your hand, little one. But I can save you." Razz sighed, her voice heavy. Bustling over to the table with clean cloths and setting them by the bowl. Then scampered back into the recesses of the hut, muttering and rummaging again. When she shuffled back into the light of the fire, she had something behind her back. Loo-kee gave her a strange searching look, wondering what she had hidden. Then in a flash of steel, Razz swung a hand ax out from behind her back and chopped Loo-Kee's hand clean off. Just below the elbow. Severing all the tainted flesh from his body.

Loo-Kee screamed in shock and terror at having his limb so abruptly severed. His brown eyes wide in horror, as fresh tears of loss cascaded down his round cheeks. The healthy stump started to throb, as blood spurted and oozed from the open wound.

Razz was quick to apply the ointment. Which stung like hot steel. The wound instantly sealed as if cauterized. Wrapping, the now seeping flesh of the remaining limb tight in the sterile cloth. Cradling the limb carefully in another heavier cloth, slinging it around Loo-Kee's neck. Razz's hands were quick and gentle as she worked, whispering soothing words of comfort and reassurances.
"It will be alright, you can stay here with me for as long as you like. Your suffering is over, little one. You can find happiness again. Here in the Whispering Woods." Razz promised, bending down and embracing the pixie tenderly. Loo-Kee cried and huddled in Razz's arms. Then disappeared in a cloud of sparkles, the sound of his scampering bare feet dashing out of the hut, his farewell to Razz.

Adora and Catra stood in stunned silence, slowly absorbing what had happened.

“She’s kinda scary...” Catra muttered, as they took their leave. Heading back to the stream to find Sheana and Despara.

Adora’s brow was furrowed in dismay, that was not the first impression she wanted to give Catra. She had known Razz for years. As a crazy, slightly confused old lady who lived alone in the woods. But in the last few months she had come to know Razz a little bit more. She was not only wise and kind, but she had a steel to her as well. Capable of making the hard choices, as she did with Loo-Kee. Razz was a warrior, fierce and commanding as any soldier she had ever known. As shocking as it was to witness, Adora understood why Razz did it. Her cure was brutal, but necessary to save the pixie.

“Whose memory was this?’ Catra inquired, as they walked across the meadow.

“I assumed it was one of yours, but I honestly don’t know?” Adora answered, perplexed.

“I do kinda remember that Magicat with the battle mask…I don’t remember her name though.” Catra mumbled, her focus drawing inward searching for the barely remembered moments of her past. Which were more memories of emotions than anything else. But that Magicat made her feel safe….protected and calm.

“C’yra…she was the Rune Bearer of Light from the Lunari pride.” Adora answered.

“She must have traveled with my family…I never questioned where Shadow Weaver got my battle mask…but now I wonder if she was there when my parents died? Did she defend my stasis pod too? “ Catra was suddenly overwhelmed by sorrow.

“That makes sense, she left her daughter…Angella to protect the future…” Adora responded, squeezing her hand firmly to offer support. As Catra turned in surprise at Adora’s words.

“Angella…as in Queen Angella…as in Glimmer’s mom!” Catra was completely unprepared to hear that. But it made sense now, why

Angella had a statue in the Basilica. She would have taken over as the Rune Bearer of Light after C'yra died.

Their conversation was stalled instantly when they reached the stream and they still hadn't seen either of the girls.

"Where are Sheana and Despara?" Adora exclaimed, as a cold dread settled in her stomach. Terrible vision's of the shadow's devouring them in their absence taunting her cruelly.

Catra instinctively raised her nose to the sky and sniffed. "I don't smell them…" She muttered, releasing Adora's hand. As they both looked for tracks along the muddy bank of the river. Finding no trace of either of them.

"We have to find them!" Adora shouted, her heart leaping in fear into her throat. She couldn't lose them! The overwhelming need to protect them, care for them and ensure they found happiness once again was a driving force inside of her.

She needed them…

-Beatrix-

Beatrix watched as Hordak's form dissolved and flickered away. Taking a deep breath she waited, her resolve and commitment to see this through to the end. Was like a steel rod. Keeping her standing proud, emerald green eyes staring unwaveringly at the corrupted CPU before her. As the fleshy tendrils began to writhe and crawl from the depths of the sphere. The bloody veins seared her hands, as they crawled over her digital flesh. The taint of the darkness burned like acid, bubbling and oozing from its veins. As the corruption began to taste the essence of what it was about to ingest. Unable to resist, the viral parasite was quickly absorbed into her code.

(You are not as you once were…artificial? Your soul tastes like a reflection…it lacks substance?) The Nameless One

whispered in her mind, in curious confusion.

Beatrix cringed, hearing his lowly, hissing voice whispering to her again. Just like it did after the Spell of Obtainment, it was revolting. It made her feel weak, vulnerable and disgusting. She pulled her hands free of the CPU. Instinctively wrapped her arms around herself seeking, to both conceal and comfort herself. As the vile corruption began to bloom from the center of her forehead. Slowly creeping over her face, tracing over the same pattern as her scars.

As the Nameless One began to reclaim her, binding her to him just as he did when she was alive.

"I will fight you…just as I did in life…you seduced me with power, when I was desperate and afraid. Tainted my soul and twisted my intent…creating a monster of me. Driven by all my darkest desires…you used me to try and destroy the Children of Fate…but I never stopped fighting you…even as your darkness slowly consumed my flesh…and rotted my mind. " She ground out, as the corruption snaked down her neck. Pulsing and twitching as it rooted itself inside her digital essence, feeding and multiplying upon the magic energy that had given her life.

"I fought you…I found a way to use your 'parasitic magic" to my own benefit. To sustain myself … I forced the Black Garnet to accept me and I fed off the magic of dream…just as you fed upon me. It allowed me to clear my head of your vile whisper's… at least for a time." She panted, struggling to think clearly. As the writhing mass of corruption wrapped around her chest. Binding her arms tight to her body, consuming her as it crawled its way downward.

"So I could train them to destroy you…and they will destroy you." Beatrix grunted through clenched teeth, her knees shaking as the last of her strength was absorbed. The veins webbed across her hips and spiraled down her legs. Rooting her to the floor of the bridge.

(You arrogantly proclaim victory…but I have already tasted both of your weapon's and I have found them disappointing. They are weak…and easily corrupted. They have proven worthless like all living things. You are nothing…you are merely food that I enjoy playing with.) The Nameless One's callous laughter echoed in her mind.

Beatrix crumpled to the floor, as the corruption began to entomb her. Yet, she refused to give in, refused to give up on her daughters. They had already proven to her how strong and resilient they could be. Capable of achieving the impossible. She would not listen to the tainted words, that whispered only of despair and torment. She would find refuge in her faith in them and fortify her will to defy him with words of hope.

"The two shall come, One sleeping, lost to time. One stolen, lost to space.

Child of Time, Child of Space…" She began to recite the Prophecy of Fate, breathless and hissing in agony as the Nameless One feasted upon her once again.

"Each born of magic, given form through blood and bone. One shall walk Etheria, upon the dawn. The other shall greet the twilight. Both reaching for and sheltered by each other." She rocked back and forth, focusing on the words. Refusing to dwell upon the darkness, seeding into the very depths of her being. Twisting and tainting her to the very core.

"They shall ascend upon the final day, becoming part of the stars. To usher in a new beginning. Each gives sustenance to the other. Space offers dreams of life-Eternity in Death. Time offers the soul salvation-Strength in the weft, elegance in the weave. A tapestry made whole, so shall be one to the other." Beatrix grit her teeth, refusing to scream as the overwhelming pain of being eaten alive began to overwhelm her.

-**Kronis-**

He couldn’t see, couldn’t move…completely bound tight in sticky, green spider webs. As the eight legged monster dragged him, thrashing and screaming uselessly down one corridor then another. Intent on taking him somewhere, to kill him at its leisure he assumed. He had believed it was his end, bitterly accepting that it would be the curse of the First Ones that finally killed him. He had never believed that the beast would deposit him in the damp earthen bowels below the beacon. He thanked his good fortune for all of a minute, breathing a sigh or relief as the clicking of the spider faded away, retreating back into the confines of the beacon.

He was just starting to regain his bearings and devise a plan to cut the webbing with one of his tools in his utility belt . When he felt the sharp, cold metal of a blade slicing the bindings away. He was quick to roll away as soon as he felt able to move. Squinting and disorientated for a second, staring blindly into the gloom of the tunnel. As his current blurry capture came into a murky focus, within the faint half light cast from some still unseen source. Sitting on the damp ground, Kronis was completely stunned. As he was face to face with a rather strange savior. A one armed Pixie stood before him, bearing a teardrop crystal lamp tethered to the stump of an arm and a very large short sword gripped tight in the good hand. An ancient space fighter helmet was atop its head with the mirrored visor down. With a gray skull emblazoned on the side. An odd assortment of armor adorned it’s small body. A collection of pieces that neither matched or provided the proper protection for a body so small. An overly large ancient looking chain link shirt was draped over a boiled leather jerkin, studded with orange crystal shards. Lashed onto its narrow hips by a bulky Horde utility belt. With short black leather pants that barely made it to its furry tan knees, what looked to be silver plate gauntlets, with a moon etched onto them were being used as greaves upon its lower legs. Large bare feet sprouted from the bottom of the leg armor, which made little sense. Why would the creature make so

much effort to protect its body and not its feet? The creature looked absolutely absurd and Kronis was struggling to take it seriously.

“They want to speak to you.” The pixie demanded, in a high pitched squeak. Thrusting the tip of the sword under Kronis’s chin, a silent threat of harm if he didn’t comply. Flicking their large, round head to the side sharply, to indicate what direction they wanted the Gar to walk. Kronis grunted and lifted his gloved hands up in surrender.

“Who is…they?” Kronis inquired dryly.

“Aion.” Was all the pixie offered for an explanation.

Curious as to who this Aion was, who wanted to talk to him, he allowed the pixie to guide him deeper down this mysterious tunnel beneath the beacon.

-Adora and Catra-

Adora was once more pulled into the darkness, yet her grip on Catra’s hand remained solid. They moved within the barren realm between dream and memory. The endless landscape was flat and gray, the mists of creation enshrouding what was yet to be.

“You have weaved everyone you love into your magic...but where is Adora?” Razz called out, her short silhouette standing upon that unclear horizon. Then flashed away in a swirling storm of starlight. That ascended into the heaven’s to blanket the sky in sparkling stardust.

A dark room appeared slowly, at first the ornate golden casing of a large round window formed. Then a familiar window bench, with pink and lavender throw pillows scattered along its length. The purple walls, filled with target’s and wanted poster’s of brigands, thieves and horde soldier’s. Bookshelves embedded into the walls, full of journals and history texts. A messy vanity on one side, the

drawer’s slightly ajar with clothing spilling out. A large hanging bed dominates the roof with floating stairs leading up to it.

Adora instantly recognized this room as Glimmer’s. Even before she saw the Queen of Bright Moon standing before her window. Magic staff in hand, as she glared out at the rain storm raging outside. A flash of lightning illuminating her tired, yet fiercely determined expression. A dangerous look Adora recognized, when Glimmer was about to do something reckless.

Adora glanced sideways briefly, needing to confirm Catra was still with her. The hybrid’s stare was transfixed upon the Queen. Her emotional state right now was hard to read. As she had hardened her expression, into her well practiced scowl. Her eyes slowly took in the room, the Queen with a tactician’s scrutiny. Catra had never seen the inside of Glimmer’s room. The mess and disarray of her belongings, a clear sign of the stress and worry the Queen of Bright Moon had been going through at the time.

Then Adora’s memory self appeared, striding across the room to Glimmer’s side.

“Glimmer where are you going?” Memory Adora confronted her, worry etched deeply upon her brow. As she strode across the room, blue eyes full of concern for her best friend who had been pulling away for months.

“This isn’t working, nothing we do is working. The Horde is always ahead and I can’t just sit here and wait for the next bad thing to happen!” Glimmer ranted, her tone immensely frustrated. As she turned and glared up at Adora, confronting her point blank with her fury. Daring the blonde to say something, anything to set her off. She was on the verge of violence and she only needed a little push to explode.

“So what, you're going to teleport into the Fright Zone and try and solve this all by yourself!” Memory Adora accused, moving in swiftly in only a few more strides. She was not scared of a furious

Glimmer, she had never lashed out violently as Catra did. So she always found the young Queen less threatening.

Catra's ears pinned back, as guilt washed over her. Finally figuring out when this memory had occurred. This was just before the sacking of Salenias…her spy, Double Trouble, had been feeding her information about the rebellion for months. That she used to her advantage. Slowly, destroying their morale and confidence, one loss after another. As her forces take over more and more territory, creeping ever closer to Bright Moon. Until all that was left was fear and desperation as they were on the brink of losing the war.

"Some ones gotta do something!" Glimmer snarled, turning away from Adora. Unable to even look at her, resentful over how strained their friendship had become. How she just couldn't seem to get over her mother's death or the blame she cradled close to her heart. Adora had failed her, failed her mother, failed her kingdom. She was also hurting and frustrated at both Adora and Bow. They had been leaving her behind, not including her in their plans or even consulting her. She was feeling so alone, feeling like neither of them trusted her, or believed in her anymore.

"Glimmer please, you can't leave in the middle of the night without backup." Memory Adora pleaded, moving around her. Forcing Glimmer to look at her.

Glimmer bowed her head with a sigh, unable to confront the fear hidden within Adora's concerned expression. "The less people involved the better. We don't know who to trust." She was still too upset to look at Adora and shifted away, staring at the floor.

"And what about me! Were you going to tell me or Bow?" Memory Adora accused, her voice rising in dismay and starting to tremble as she now looked on the verge of tears.

"Adora…I…" Glimmer finally found the nerve to look at her. Her anger cooled at how upset and scared Adora sounded. Thinking that she would just run off on some suicide mission all by herself.

“Stay!” Memory Adora cut her off, tears pooling in the corners of her worried blue eyes. “Please, I know we can figure this out if we just work together.” She coaxed, moving in and placing her hands on Glimmer’s shoulder’s. Desperate for the Queen to listen to reason, to hold her here and not let go. “No more secrets and no more doing things without us. We need you here…” She took a breath, staring at Glimmer as she summoned the courage to be honest, to allow herself to be open and vulnerable with her best friend for the very first time and express what she truly wanted. “I need you…” she whispered softly, barely holding back her tears now.

As Glimmer came to terms over how reckless she had almost been, how devastated both Adora and Bow would be if she had gone alone and got herself killed in the process. She gazed up at Adora’s watery eyes, who looked so scared and on the verge of crying and she sighed in remorse. She recalled her staff and it disappeared in a flash of moonlight. Adora meant more to her than her vendetta.

“Ok…I’m here.” Glimmer nodded and offered Adora a warm, loving smile. Adora released the breath she had been holding and smiled back, with just as much fondness towards her. So very thankful that her confession was accepted.

Catra grit her teeth and ducked her head in shame. Adora had confessed to her in a very similar way, but she had rejected her. She had been weak, and like a coward. Had allowed Shadow Weaver to get into her head. All her self conscious doubts about what she really meant to Adora. The feelings of being worthless, that she didn't matter had come back and cut deep. Just like this moment did, it hit hard, as it was a mirror of Adora’s confession to her in the woods. The night before the mission to the Heart. It wasn’t the words she had wanted to hear at the time, but those words had still meant the same. She had just been too angry and upset to notice. Glimmer on the other hand, she understood and she accepted Adora’s love.

“Catra…” Adora turned, feeling how Catra had gone stiff beside her. Heard the low, angry growl rumbling almost imperceptibly in the cat girl's throat. As she refused to look at Adora, glowering down at the floor. As a new wave of self loathing began to simmer deep inside of her.

All she did was hurt people…

“Nothing…it’s nothing…Adora.” Catra finally ground out, blinking away frustrated tears. Pretending to be more interested in the decorations of the room then the two occupants now dissolving along with the memory.

The glory of the Whispering Woods spread out before them. As Adora in her current She-Ra form stood at the edge of a rocky outlook. The sky was luminous, as if dawn was just breaking over the woods. The barest wisps of clouds streaked over the celestial court of moons that hung in the sky, all round and full. A warm breeze rustled the forest below, rushing up and over the outlook bringing the soft, clean scents of flowers and running water. From the flora that grew along the grassy banks of the lazy river sprawling below in the valley.

Memory Adora was struggling to remain in She-Ra form, her transformation flickering briefly then turning solid once more. As the turmoil inside her settled for a moment. As she starred in awe and wonder at the inspiring sight, a wistful smile gracing her beautiful face. When Mara appeared, also transformed into her version of She-Ra and strode up to her. Admiring the view with the same wonder as Adora.

Memory Adora noticed and glanced over, gasping in surprise. Then returned her gaze back to the glorious horizon that stretched out beyond the forest.

“I am going to save Etheria. No matter what it takes.” Memory Adora vowed, her glowing blue eyes firm with resolve. “Your sacrifice won’t be in vain. I promise. ” her voice wavered with grief, as she closed her eyes and bowed her head.

“But at what cost?’ Mara replied, solemnly. “ I never wanted to die. I sacrificed myself to you would never have too.” Mara turned to confront Adora. “Why are you doing this, Adora?”

“It’s better this way. My friends will be safe, they will be happy. “ Memory Adora admitted, unable to look her mentor in the eye.

“And you?” Mara reached out and clasped Adora’s cheek, gently coaxing her to look up. “What do you want when this is all over?”

Catra was struggling to witness this heartfelt moment between them. Memory Adora looked so incredibly sad, as if she had just lost everything that mattered most to her…the bitter clarity struck her like a slap across the face. She had taken off, rejected her confession and left Adora when she needed her the most. Adora had been scared about going to the heart, she didn’t want to die either. She had needed Catra to be with her, wanted her to be beside her if it was to be her last journey. But Catra had abandoned her, she had run because it was too painful for her to stay. Catra was angry at herself for putting Adora through all that heart break, yet thankful she had gone back and made it right.

Adora turned to her, sensing the shame and heartache that were now tearing Catra up inside.

“Catra…it’s ok…we got through this…right…” She affirmed, letting go of Catra’s hand and wrapping her arm around the feline's shoulder instead. Needing a firmer grip on her true love, to anchor her and keep her grounded. Catra sniffed and nodded, shifting her weight to adjust her stance closer to Adora. Unconsciously allowing Adora to shield her. Absorbing all the comfort and affirming words like a balm to the wounds of the past. As silent tears began to fall.

“I…It doesn’t matter. I’m She-Ra, this is what I’m supposed to do.” Memory Adora professed, as the vision began to glitch with Prime’s virus. Both Mara and Adora turned to gaze at the now fractured image of Etheria in concern. Then Mara reached out and

took both her hands, knowing she didn't have much time left to talk.

"You are worth more than what you can give to other people. You deserve love too!" Her words were spoken so passionately, that Memory Adora was suddenly overwhelmed by them. Fresh tears formed at the corner of her eyes, as she finally hoped for the first time that she could have what she truly wanted. That she was allowed to be happy…to be loved.

"Adora…" Catra whimpered, spinning and ducking her head into Adora's neck. As more tears fell down her cheeks, feeling absolutely shattered. By the sight of her true love's shifting expressions from fear and despair, to confusion and then eventual surprise. At the revelation, that she was worth something, that she could hope and want and yearn for a love she had yet to receive.

Adora held her tight, tucking her own face into Catra's neck as the painful vision faded around them.

Another vision formed around them, taking shape slowly one object at a time. When Catra uncurled herself from Adora's neck. She was confronted with a rebellion tent, the interior holding only the basic pieces of furniture needed to survive. A cot, a short cabinet of drawers with the shattered sword of protection on top, several large pillows…and this memory of Adora…face down on the rug! In nothing but her underwear, of a grey tank top and shorts.

"What the hell happened to you!" Catra exclaimed, pulling completely out of Adora's embrace. Her voice was high pitched and full of both worry and exasperation. Because she knew Adora, she had been in this very same situation many times growing up back in the Horde. She just needed confirmation, which she received. By Adora's guilty look and then Bow's sudden

appearance. As he pushed the tent flap aside, carrying a tray with a kettle and tea cup.

“Hey sleepyhead, are you hungry?” He gasped in fright and dropped the tray and lifted his arms in the air screaming. At the sight of Adora lying prone on the ground. His first thought immediately went to the worst case scenario…was she dead!

“What happened, are you ok?" he scrambled to her side, crouching down near her head and surveying her for wounds.

“I gotta go….save….Glimmer…” Memory Adora moaned, struggling to pick herself up off the ground. Her arms trembling at bearing even the slightest weight. Her face was twisted into grim determination, eyes firm with resolve. That she was stronger, her will was stronger then the frailty of her body. With a frustrated groan of complete exhaustion she crumpled back onto the ground face first. “My body is betraying me…” She whined.

“No…you're exhausted. That happens to regular people, when they keep throwing themselves into battle and refusing to sleep.” He chastised, his tone was frustrated but not without compassion.

Memory Adora turned and glowered up at him stubbornly. “I hate it!”

“Com’on you just need to rest.” Bow helped her up and got her back into bed with a sweet, caring smile.

Memory Adora flopped back onto her pillow with a resigned groan.

“Now close your eyes…” Bow began to soothe her.

“Is she dead!” Frosta exclaimed from the tent flap.

Bow cried out in surprise and turned to confront her intrusion.

“What…no…”

“Ok, good…cause Adora normally does all the planning and we were wondering if there was a plan. “ Frosta inquired, her voice sounded frantic as if the world was going to end if Adora didn’t get up and fix everything.

“Look, the upgrades to Mara’s ship are done, but we can’t go anywhere until Adora’s back on her feet. ” Bow attempted to placate Frosta, glancing nervously at Adora as she opened eyes. “So go to sleep and everyone…” He continued to coax softly, worried Adora had heard Frosta’s panic and was about to push herself more. Then a tearing sound invaded the tent and a golden horn tore through the fabric followed by a horse's gigantic head.

“Did anyone say Swift…wind.” Bow slapped his hands over the horse's mouth so he couldn’t finish his very loud, very intrusive introduction.

“Is Adora feeling better, did you tell her about Horde Prime’s message last night, does she know he’s looking for her?” Micah exploded into the tent, pushing the flap aside.

“Was that…!” Memory Adora sat bolt upright in bed. Wide eyed with sudden panic, delirious and disorientated. Her arms flailed briefly for a sword that wasn’t there.

“OK! That’s enough! Adora, rest! Swift Wind head!” Bow commanded. Swift Wind complied, pushing Adora’s head back down onto her pillow with his mussel. Adora grunted as he forced her to lay back down.

“Everyone, Shsssssh!” Bow demanded.

“She will be fine soon…right?” Frosta asked quietly, she was worried not only about Adora but about everything and everyone…the war had taken a tragic and very scary turn for her. Since they had to evacuate out of Bright Moon and had been hiding out in the Whispering Woods for the last few weeks.

“Yes….she just needs sleep! “ Bow whispered loudly in exasperation.

The tender look that crossed Bow's face, as he stared down at Adora who was now blissfully unconscious. Was so full of fond affection and relief. It mirrored the tender looks Catra found herself giving Adora many times during their time in Horde. When she was taking care of the stubborn, over achieving, over working girl…who refused to take care of herself ever!

Catra smirked knowingly and bumped her shoulder against Adora's.

"You never change." She sassed, as Entrapta exploded into the tent next.

"Adora sick log, day three!"

"Nope!" Bow promptly picked the scientist up and tossed her back out of the tent.

Catra rolled her eyes and laughed fondly with Adora as the heartwarming vision faded.

It was the heart breaking sound of a toddler wailing, in pain and fear that pulled them both rapidly into the next memory. The stark white walls and large, nearly empty room that formed around them. Held deep feelings for both of them, some happy, some sad…mostly mixing together as their memories here were so intertwined. Metal cribs lined the walls, with a thin mattress inside and a gray or dark blue blanket balled on top. The sharp smell of disinfectant was in the air, burning Catra's nose just as it had done on a daily basis when she had been trapped in this wing of the nursery as a toddler. Fresh to this new, complicated world without her parents to guide her. Having only Adora, who had freed her from her slumber. Whom she had quickly come to depend on for everything… to teach and care for her in all the ways she needed most at the time.

"The nursery…" Adora stated the obvious, turning in an abrupt circle to take in the sterile environment.

Suddenly Catra, as a tiny kitten bolted out of a side room and into the main sleeping area. Her fur was damp and she was bawling, loudly. Tears streaking down her round face, her thick mane looked as if someone had attempted to comb it. But it was still damp and drying, all wild and untamed. Curling and fluffed up around her small shoulders. She wore the tattered remains of a beige jumper. It was clinging to her in all the wrong ways, as her fur was not yet dry enough to put clothes on. Her claws desperately shredded it, as she ran. Needing to be free of its constraining hold upon her tiny body. Her bare feet slapping against the metal floor as she retreated under a crib at the far side of the room.

“That child is a menace... nothing but a feral animal! ” A shrill, frustrated female voice shouted from inside the small room.

“What happened…” Another voice consoled.

“She bit me, when I tried to get her in some clothes!” The woman explained.

“Let me see, you need to go have it treated in case it’s infected.” The other voice sighed in exasperation.

“Why do you still try to care for her?.” Another voice echoed out of the room, sounding bored. “I gave up months ago, I just ignore her now. You should too, it's not like someone isn’t taking care of her.”

“I am the Head Nurse…these children are my responsibility. Besides, Shadow Weaver will have my head if I don’t get that wretched beast to start to behave!” The woman explained, in a fearful whisper.

The hiss of a sliding door announced a new visitor into the sleeping area of the nursery. A goat hybrid ducked into view for a moment from the small room at the end, to see who it was. A knowing smile pulled at his thin lips as he watched Adora walk into the room. The sweet little girl was dressed in a simple white

t-shirt and gray shorts. With only one white sock on her left foot, having fallen and bunched up at her ankle, the toe flopping as she padded softly into the room. Her blonde hair was tied up in a ponytail, with soft wisps of bangs cascading down either side of her face. She was searching for the kitten, who she had heard crying in distress from the play room. It was a siren call that always pulled her away from whatever she was doing. Second nature for her to seek out her kitten and take care of her, protect her, be that person she could always count on. It had been this way since she had found her, all alone. In the cold, damp cave deep in Horror Hall. So Adora had left her friends to console her kitten. As she always did when Catra got upset.

She quickly found her kitten, hiding under a nearby crib by the fluff of dark brown hair exploding from either side of the sleeping mat. Adora jogged up to the crib and knelt down, pressing her ear to the floor so she could see underneath and console her most precious person.

"Catra…what happened? " Memory Adora asked, brow furrowed in concern.

"She…she…she…gave me a bath…" Baby Catra hiccuped, through breathless sobs. Adora's frown turned into a dark scowl. She ducked around the crib and glared threateningly at the goat hybrid staring at her. Then quickly returned to comforting her kitten.

"I'm sorry…I know you hate baths. But it's over now…so come out…it's ok." Memory Adora's sweet voice floated out into the empty room.

The goat hybrid ducked back out of view and then pulled a severe looking, older, human woman with curly, dark hair, dusted with gray into the open doorway.

"Watch!" The goat commanded, folding his arms over his chest smugly.

“I…I…I…She pulled my tail when I wouldn’t get dressed fast enough…It hurt and I got scared and I bit her!” Baby Catra wailed brokenly, hiccupping and sniffling through her tears.

“Who…” Memory Adora moaned, she wished Catra would just obey and get along with the nurses. But she also understood that they didn't try to understand her needs, or be patient with her. They got rough and Catra reacted, violently…all the time.

“Ugly Aggie…” Baby Catra grumbled, bitterly.

Memory Adora laughed, they had come up with that nickname for Nurse Agatha. A few weeks back. She was the oldest, crabbiest nurse on the wing. Also the most stern, and punitive. She was always yelling and demanding and if you didn’t obey fast enough. She would pinch you, or smack your butt to get you to comply.

“Ok…well…you're all cleaned up, now.” Memory Adora smiled softly, encouraging Catra to come out. The reason Catra had been taken this time was because she had eaten her porridge with her hands instead of using the spoon. Getting food all over herself in the process.

“Yes…” Came baby Catra’s small affirmation. Cringing at the horrid memory of her clothes being taken off, then being forced into the tub. The smelly wet rag Nurse Agatha had used to wash her face and chest. The hot beating of the water from the shower head, against her mane and the rough pulling of the comb against the thick strands. That left her head throbbing and sore. Then being hauled back out of the tub, dripping and soaked and cold. Only to get roughly toweled and manhandled for a few moments before being commanded to put on a fresh jumper.

“Good, then let's get you some fresh clothes then we can go play.” Memory Adora reached under the crib and pulled Catra out. The kitten compiled willingly. Allowing Adora to pick her up as soon as she was free of the undercarriage. Adora wrapped her arms under Catra’s arm pits and promptly heaved her up off the ground. Catra tucked her legs up to her chest and latched her arms around

Adora’s upper arms, which were now criss-crossed around her bare stomach. The kitten instantly felt safe and relaxed in Adora’s embrace, as the blonde carried her into the aisle between the cribs. Adora’s blue eyes were fierce, threatening like a storm cloud, as she glowered at the old nurse. Who was watching them from the doorway of the bathroom. Little Adora lifted her chin defiantly, then declared for all to hear.

“MY CATRA!” In an explosive shout of claim. Then turned on her heel and hauled the kitten away, so she could care for her properly. The kitten’s purr of contentment vibrated within the white washed room.

The sweet, nostalgic laughter shared between Catra and Adora. Was the parting farewell for their innocence long destroyed by their military upbringing.

The somber landscape that followed was a peaceful reprieve from the emotional onslaught they had just endured. They sat upon the peak of a grassy hill, leaning against one another, back to back. Lost to their own thoughts as they gazed upward at the endless night sky full of stars. Adora released a heavy sigh and reached up towards the starscape, a deeply concerted expression on her face. Catra turned, acknowledging Adora's brooding scowl, by crawling her hand over top of Adora’s and giving it a reassuring squeeze. Letting her know wordlessly that she was there, that from now on she would always be by her side.

Adora grunted and squeezed her hand back. Falling back into her heavy contemplations for a time. Watching the stars, wondering if they were going to start falling again? When they remained firmly embedded into the black backdrop of the open sky. She finally began to relax….this was not that dream. This was a new one… easing into its conclusion. They remained silently watching the sky, holding hands and enjoying the warmth and strength each other offered.

Until Adora started to laugh anew, the cadence was bright and uplifting as she finally came to understand the last trail the Crystal

Castle put her through. Catra was confused by the sudden joyful sound resounding from the once sullen atmosphere. Turning slightly, greeting Adora with a warm smile, as the blonde moved to kneel before her.

"I get it! I finally got the last piece of my transformation…" Adora declared, her smile was absolutely beaming. Her clear blue eyes sparkling with absolute clarity. Excited by her revelation and finally content that she found all her answers. That she was ready to move forward again.

Catra couldn't help but be infected by her good mood, her smile growing just as gleeful. As a soft purr began to thrum deep in her throat. Then Adora's smile softened, her eyes reflecting a tenderness that Catra had only witnessed a few times over the last few months. The blonde cupped her cheek, her blue eyes dancing with what Catra had come to understand as love…her complete and unrefuted trust and affection for her.

"My…Love…" Adora whispered in a low breathless voice. It was an irreverent endearment as much as it was a statement. Adora studied her gorgeous lips for a moment, her thumb stroking Catra's cheek fondly. Then raised her softly glowing blue eyes back up. Taking in Catra's luminous eyes for a moment, they always shone, warm like firelight when the world got dark. Right now, they were staring back at her with just as much need and affection. Then Adora closed her eyes and leaned in. Capturing Catra's lips in the most profound kiss they had shared to date.

Catra's eyes instantly welled up with tears, as she leaned into Adora's tender caress. Moaning in bliss, and closing her eyes. As Adora's lips pressed so sweetly against hers, they were soft and played gently against her own. The warmth of Adora's larger hand, against her cheek, was so comforting. As the kiss naturally deepened, becoming something more. Catra clung to Adora's arms, needing to ground herself. As Adora tilted her chin, angling her mouth so she could explore it more thoroughly. Her other arm was braced behind Catra's shoulder blades, pulling her flush against her chest. This kiss was the embodiment of

everything….It was tender and passionate. So full of all the pure emotion's Adora wanted Catra to feel.

The confusion mixed with small joys and painful sorrows as they grew up in the Fright Zone. The regret, the yearning, the frustration and anger she had felt as they fought during the war. Then the exhilaration, the discovery and most of all…the love… that they finally shared. It was everything…she was everything…

Most of all she realized that she had come to cherish Sheana, cherish Despara…she accepted and loved her magic.

My Love….

Then Adora focused on that wonderful, all encompassing feeling… Love…her love for Etheria…for everyone that had ever graced her life. That was why her heart was so heavy with guilt, remorse, why she was angry and so burdened by the past. So worried about the future. She allowed herself to feel all the complex emotions that came with loving…and let those emotions pass through her. Letting the pain go, moving on…to bask in her love for Glimmer, for Mara, for Bow…especially for Catra. It was warm and fulfilling…and their love for her…she accepted it, finally believing she was worthy of it. The confidence, the sense of belonging, of being needed, of being wanted, was so powerful. Her whole body was radiating with the incredible magic it manifested.

(You finally found balance….) Sheana and Despara's voice echoed in her mind. As a power, like she had never experienced before. Exploded from deep inside of her. The power quickly increased in strength and brilliance. As it surged from the very core of her heart and soul. Just like before, she radiated like a star with the light exploding outward like a cosmic event. Expanding from her body and increasing at an exponential rate, as it grew to illuminate every realm of existence. Until all there was was the pure, cleansing light of divinity.

-Glimmer-

Perfuma cried out in alarm, backing away from the seal and ducking her eyes behind a raised arm. As a blinding light flashed from within the center of the seal, expanding until the whole room was illuminated.

Glimmer squinted, releasing her focus on the magic and allowing the seal to dissolve. As the most wonderful feeling of cherished love washed over her.

It was familiar and welcomed…it was Adora!

-Beatrix-

The cleansing was as sudden and awe inspiring as it was the first time Adora had healed her. The power of She-Ra was formidable indeed. Beatrix slowly uncurled from her tight ball upon the crystal bridge in the Central Processing Unit. Staring in awe at her solid, flawless body, reformed as it once was before she had been infected by the darkness. Then she slowly took in the vast room, finding it was also pristine, not a hint of infection upon the walls or the diamond spheres hovering around her.

The serene, unburdened smile that graced her elegant face was long overdue. She felt free…the most whole she had felt in years.

[Crystal Castle Facilitator, detected…how may I assist you, Beatrix] The computer operating system echoed out to her. Her smile only grew, as she realized the power and knowledge she now laid claim to.

-Adora-

When the light faded, Catra and Scorpia were now sprawled on the floor before the memory table. With She-Ra standing before

them, tall and formidable. Wearing the same armor as before, but this time the gold accents upon the wings of her boots and the edges of her gauntlets. The trim of the star on her chest armor was lined with silver. The wings on her crown flared more elegantly, with the tips shining with silver. The Rune Stones upon her crown and chest had changed in color, no longer red nor blue. But a glorious sheen of both colors shimmering in the depths of the stones, that made them resemble the tranquil color of twilight. She bore the large white and gold shield, with a blue gemstone in her right hand and the long elegant sword with the silver cross guard with a red gemstone in her left hand.

"Wow…" Glimmer breathed in awe, scrambling to her feet. As She-Ra smiled down at her. Her grin was full of pride, that she was now capable of overcoming anything!

"Ok…well…I think you're taller." Scorpia chuckled as she rose to her feet. Dusting her thighs with her pincers.

"She's definitely brighter…" Perfuma commented with a giggle, dashing to Scorpia's side and embracing her in relief. Scorpia chuckled fondly and quickly hugged her back with as much relief. That this crazy, terrifying crisis was over with, they had won… again!

Catra was spellbound by the gloriously powerful sight standing before her. She just stayed on the floor, gapping up at Adora in complete awe. That this goddess was her girlfriend…Adora loved her, needed her, wanted only her…unable to comprehend it all. Until a very wet tongue, lapped up the side of her cheek waking her up from her stunned stupor.

"Ughhh. Melog!" Catra complained, turning to smirk at her companion who was chuckling at her. As she rubbed their saliva off her cheek fur with a disgusted groan.

"Alright, I think we're ready. Let's go save Max!" Glimmer announced as they all linked arms.

“What’s going on…what happened…how long was I gone?” She-Ra began to sputter out, as Glimmer blinked them all away to the Waste.

Chapter End Notes

Well, that's it. I hope you all enjoyed this arc, please leave your thoughts in the comments. I love to read them. Also stay tuned for the next part.
Kingdom of Tides....ADVENTURE!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!